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MYTH – ARCHETYPE – PROTOTYPE AND THEIR (RE)INTERPRETATION



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Art Academy of Latvia

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Myth – Archetype – Prototype and Their (Re)Interpretation

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MYTH - ARCHETYPE - PROTOTYPE AND THEIR (RE)INTERPRETATION

INTRODUCTION

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The annual International conference organized by the Department of Doctoral Studies of the Art Academy of Latvia was devoted to encourage researchers both in the exact and social sciences and in the humanities to explore the archetype and the myth as sources and catalysts of artistic creativity, paying special attention to the specificities of their form and content in different cultures and in different cultural domains.

In his Language of Post-Modern Architecture (1977), Charles Jencks announces the "death" of modern architecture and celebrates the language of post-modern architecture for its eclectic use of elements borrowed from a variety of architectural styles. Influenced by the imagery of the preceding epochs and including some of it in one's own work has been a widespread artistic practice all along. It was given a great impetus by the development of printing in the second half of the 15th century, which accelerated the dissemination of visual images with far-reaching consequences for all areas of life, including science, religion, art, and design. Images encountered in printed books became a source of inspiration both for architects and for masters of the fine and applied arts, who imitated and reinterpreted them. Needless to say, nowadays the practice of creative borrowing and reinterpretation of visual archetypes has been greatly augmented by the digital media.

The precise meaning of the prototype, or archetype, varies in different theories and domains of knowledge. In the arts and in design, however, these terms mostly derive their meaning from their theorization in psychology, philosophy, and literary studies, where the archetype refers to the original pattern, or model, from which all other things of the same kind are made. It may be rooted in an individual's emotional reactions to those environmental stimuli which are capable of providing a creative impulse. Similarly, a myth, or mythos, regardless of its origin – religion, mythology, folklore, or literature – serves as a structuring force originating in the individual's bodily and sensory interaction with the lived

environment. Both the archetype and the myth are creatively reinterpreted by the artist, who draws upon them for both the form and content of their works. Indeed, the heritability of archetypal and mythical structures is in no small measure due to their creative reinterpretations and transformations by artists working in different artistic styles in different historical periods.

The collection of academic articles is introduced by the publication "Archetypes, Prototypes, Myths, and the Alchemy of Arts-Based Praxis: Reimagining Our World" by Professor Noel B. Salazar of the Royal University of Leuven. It analyses the transfer of myths and stereotypes, entrenched in public consciousness, into works of art, as well as reveals the social and anthropological mechanisms for the practice of creating new myths. We are pleased that with this highly regarded theoretical treatise we can provide a theoretical direction for theoretical discussions in art theory. In the article "When Two Myths Meet: Ovid and Body Politics at Kadriorg Palace", Estonian art researchers Sophie Turner and Kerttu Männiste present the political and cultural-historical connotations of the adaptation of the myths reflected in Ovid's "Metamorphoses" in the iconography of the ceiling paintings of the Russian Tsar's residence – Kadriorg Palace. Representing the Department of Graphic Arts of the Art Museum of Estonia, art historian Elnara Taidre in the article "Myth and Archetype in Artistic and Theoretical Practices of Tõnis Vint" analyses the creative legacy of Estonian graphic artist Tönis Vint in the reconstruction of the global meanings of myths and ornaments.

With the examples from the so-called Third Awakening, political movement of the Baltic peoples, in art from 1986 to 1991, the art historian Helēna Demakova, in her article "Mythology as the source of new artistic expression in the time of the Awakening (Atmoda) in Latvia", reminds us of the creativity of artists who found metaphorical vivid expression for their position that activated public opinion through the means of both ancient culture and Baltic mythology. The publication "AI (Re)imaginings: Frictionless Myths of Past and Future" by Paulius Petraitis, assistant professor at the Faculty of Communication of Vilnius University, allows us to outline the directions of artistic development in which artificial intelligence (AI) will play a decisive role in the artistic creation of collective memory and visions of the future. The common message of this series of the listed articles is a clearly expressed intention to demonstrate a methodological and theoretical approach to both the analysis of classical mythology in works of art related to retrospection, as well as modelling the potential of technological media (AI) in creating new stereotypes of collective consciousness.

Sanita Bitko in her article offerthematic discourses using modern information technology tools – augmented reality (XR), three-dimensional scanning of art objects – obtaining digitally validable results for hypotheses about the authorship of works of art, and transforming traditional myths into immersive art. By delving into the culture of opera and theatre (Kristina Wuss), fashion, applied art and design (Una Pūpola, Neringa Akcijonaityte, Una Valtere), architecture and sculpture (Ojārs Spārītis), landscape and park art (Valda Jēkabsone-Valtere), reflecting on the role of art education (Katrīna Šeikina, Sanita Oše), the articles related to the unique nature of the individual creative process demonstrate both the scientific maturity of the Latvian Academy of Arts in addressing issues of art history and theory as well as its openness to the study of other aspects characteristic of the modern era.

The bright and internationally represented conference section dedicated to the theoretical and social issues of contemporary design is represented by three articles: "A proposed model for evaluating design and innovation capabilities in public institutions", "Designing for equity: blockchain, agriculture, and the Indian farmer's voice", "Pluralising evaluations of design impact: a design culture studies approach". The topicality of the ideas expressed in these articles is introduced by the section chairpersons Liene Jākobsone and Pinar Kaygan.

Nowadays, with various forms of both remote and face-to-face meetings coexisting in academic science and exchange of ideas, our experience to date demonstrates the usefulness of the presence effect. Although the scope of international scientific information exchange can be global, presentations and discussions in front of an audience, individual meetings, establishing contacts between researchers, and maintaining extensive cooperation in the implementation of publications, future conferences, and joint projects are highly valued practices that researchers at the Art Academy of Latvia, in collaboration with partners around the world, wish to carry on successfully.

THEMATIC TRACK AT THE 2025 INTERNATIONAL SCIENTIFIC CONFERENCE OF THE ART ACADEMY OF LATVIA

UNDERSTANDING DESIGN IMPACT: THEORY AND PRACTICE

Track organisers:

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How to assess the impact of design is a long-debated question, further complicated by the expanding scope of design practice. Early efforts in the 1990s to explain the value of design focused on creating more design-aware managers and increasing the employment of designers (see, for example, Gorb 1990; Cooper and Press 1995). Later, as design gained prominence within national and regional economies, the focus gradually shifted from articulating its value to assess its tangible impact, which refers to the measurable effects of design on business performance, economic development, and societal outcomes. Such initiatives have primarily been led by state institutions and independent professional organisations commissioned to act on their behalf, with the aim of informing policymaking (for a review, see Kaygan 2026). While the impact of design was initially examined in terms of business success, today the interventional role of design in addressing environmental, societal, and political challenges is widely acknowledged (Kimbell et al. 2021). The existing tools, however, fall short of fully capturing and accounting for design's contribution to the quality of life within the increasing complexity.

Understanding Design Impact is organised as a thematic track of the 2025 International Scientific Conference of the Art Academy of Latvia, aiming to address this gap and to bring a fresh and inspiring perspective on how to make the impact of design visible and intelligible. The track has invited papers exploring new methods and approaches to enhance our understanding of design's impact on well-being, health, education,

social inclusion, the environment, climate, and innovation. This thematic track was organised within the framework of the project "Cultural and creative ecosystem of Latvia as a resource of resilience and sustainability", project No. VPP-MM-LKRVA-2023/1-0001, funded by the Ministry of Culture of the Republic of Latvia.

This track sought to welcome a wide range of practice- and theory-based contributions from various fields of design. To this end, we invited papers interested in exploring:

- Qualitative and quantitative ways of impact assessment in design
- Tools, techniques and methods of assessment
- Challenges and opportunities for measuring design impact
- Key actors and institutions of design impact assessment
- Design impact in education

Out of the eight papers presented at the conference, three articles by 14 authors were submitted for publication in these proceedings. These three articles approach the theme of this track from complementary perspectives, each addressing how the value of design can be understood and assessed. They offer a range of methodological positions – from empirical, case-based investigations to structured evaluation frameworks and more critical, reflexive approaches – offering a broad view of current discussions on assessing design impact.

Designing for Equity: Blockchain, Agriculture, and the Indian Farmer's Voice contributes a grounded, practice-oriented approach in which evaluation is embedded within the design process. Using a mixed qualitative methodology – combining field immersion, interviews, questionnaires, participatory workshops, and iterative prototyping – the study assesses design's value through observable transformations in stakeholders' practices and relationships. Rather than relying on predefined indicators, it demonstrates how impact can be traced through shifts in trust, behaviour, and agency across a socio-technical system. Evaluation thus emerges as situated and processual, capturing relational and systemic effects such as increased transparency, improved participation, and redistribution of informational power.

A Proposed Model for Evaluating Design Impact in Design and Innovation Capabilities in Public Institutions translates such insights into a structured assessment framework at the organisational level. Developed through literature review and conceptual synthesis, and tested via a case study, the model operationalises design value through measurable dimensions, including design awareness, integration into internal processes, citizen involvement, innovation motivation, and organisational design capabilities. Its contribution lies in formalising evaluation

through scalable indicators that enable comparison and longitudinal analysis, framing design's value in terms of institutional capacity, governance, and innovation performance. While extending evaluation beyond purely economic metrics, it remains situated within a managerial paradigm focused on capability building.

In contrast, *Pluralising Evaluations of Design Impact: A Design Culture Studies Approach* critically expands the scope and epistemology of design evaluation. Based on a mixed qualitative study across multiple stakeholder groups, it identifies the limitations of predominantly quantitative and economistic approaches and proposes a plural, interpretive framework grounded in Design Culture Studies. Emphasising inclusivity, rigour, and reflexivity, the paper reframes evaluation as a cultural and mediatory practice that shapes what counts as design impact. It advocates for context-sensitive, co-created methodologies that account for socio-cultural, political, and experiential dimensions of value, while foregrounding the positionality of the evaluator.

Considered in relation to one another, these papers outline a progression from situated, practice-based evaluation, through structured organisational assessment, to more critical and plural understandings of design impact. This progression highlights the need to combine measurable indicators with context-sensitive and critical methodologies, suggesting that the value of design can only be adequately assessed through a plurality of complementary approaches.

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REIMAGINING "OUR WORLD": FROM ARCHETYPES AND MYTHS TO THE CULTURAL ALCHEMY OF ARTS-BASED PRAXIS

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ABSTRACT

In this article, I explore the potent confluence of arts-based praxis with deep-seated human archetypes and myths. These concepts, rooted in our collective emotional and sensory experience, are dynamic engines that can inspire innovative pathways toward resilience and transformation. Arts-based praxis is the deliberate act of turning these deep-rooted concepts into living, transformative practice. When artists engage with archetypes and myths, they are reconfiguring these foundational elements to address the pressing challenges of our time. Through art, these patterns are translated into new forms, imbuing the work with a resonance that speaks to our shared human experience. Artistic practice, then, becomes a form of embodied knowledge-making. It channels the innate human ability to sense, interpret, and transform our environment. This process is reflective of what Aristotle termed *phronesis*–practical wisdom that emerges through deep reflection and lived experience. Artists, scholars, and practitioners are uniquely positioned to tap into the deep reservoirs of cultural memory. By revisiting and reinterpreting archetypal symbols, we can generate innovative frameworks for addressing issues such as environmental degradation, resource scarcity, and social fragmentation. The creative reappropriation of these symbols nurtures the kind of emotional and intellectual engagement necessary for transformative action. As we navigate the complexities of the current global challenges, we should draw on the profound power of archetypes and myths to inspire, challenge, and transform.

Keywords: archetype, myth, art, anthropology, practical wisdom

INTRODUCTION

This article provides a brief anthropological exploration into the heart of our cultural being, examining how the notions of "archetype" and "myth" function, not only as static templates, but as dynamic, living forces that shape artistic expressions as well as our deeper understanding of Planet Earth. In diverse intellectual traditions – from psychology and philosophy to literary studies and beyond – these concepts have evolved in meaning and significance. Yet, regardless of their disciplinary nuances, they share one common thread: they embody original conceptual patterns or models from which myriad forms and narratives arise. This article, then, not only reflects on the profound legacy of archetypes and myths in human culture but also explores how these enduring symbols can illuminate the path forward in addressing the complex problems currently facing Planet Earth.

Yes, our world is facing a growing list of interconnected 'wicked' problems (Brown et al., 2010). People worldwide have become familiar with concepts such as climate change, biodiversity loss, and pollution, and are experiencing phenomena such as land degradation, water contamination, or resource scarcity, which in turn affect food security and health, and increase inequalities and conflict. These are the lived realities of communities worldwide, the echoes of human actions reverberating through the landscapes we inhabit. If humans are (part of) the problem, to which extent can they be part of the solution? Anthropologists recognize that people are not simply passive observers of the unfolding drama (Salazar, 2022). We are both the authors and the characters, the architects, and the inhabitants of this complex reality. And if we are indeed part of the problem, then we must also be part of the solution.

So far, a lot of time and energy has been invested in searching for scientific solutions and technological fixes, 'innovation' being the mantra of the day. While this is certainly useful, the complexity of wicked problems demands more than one approach. Science and technology alone are unable to solve the many real-life problems at hand, let alone mitigate them (Jasanoff, 2019). Our understanding of the world emerges not only from scientific inquiry but also from the deep, embodied practices of living, feeling, and knowing. People know by way of their practice – through an ongoing engagement with the constituents of their environment rather than merely applying their knowledge in practice. Praxis, then, is not the antithesis of theory or thinking but a thoughtful doing and reflective practice that requires a deep level of comprehension, contextual in-sight, and critical reasoning. The focus here is thus

not so much on knowledge as information but on knowledge as wisdom (Schwartz and Sharpe, 2010).

Aristotle called this phronesis (φρόνησις, practical wisdom) or the ability, developed through personal experience and deep reflection, to make sound judgments and knowing how to (re)act in specific real-world situations (Reeve, 1992). It is not about having all the answers but about asking the right questions (Kristjánsson and Fowers, 2024). Phronesis includes emotional intelligence, virtue, and being open to different perspectives (epistemic humility). If phronesis (linked to values) is the map, praxis (linked to virtues) is the journey, putting phronesis into action, allowing people to make informed (practical) decisions about the world in which they live (Flyvbjerg et al., 2012). Practical wisdom is socially constructed, co-created, and shared by people through relations with their environment (Intezari et al., 2020).

In mythological traditions, wisdom and artistic expression were closely intertwined; for instance, the goddess Athena – later known as Minerva – embodied both wisdom and the arts, serving as a divine patroness of craftsmanship and human creativity. Given this context, I want to pay attention to the relevance of arts-based praxis as a domain of practical wisdom in addressing the global challenges the Earth is currently facing (Cazeaux, 2017). Arts-based praxis is based on experience, intuition, and creativity; often focused on exploring and practising ideas, and including speculative and critical knowledge creation; it can transcend the limitations of language and logic, offering a more holistic and inclusive view of the world (Leavy, 2020). I thus want to explore here how the arts, as a domain of phronesis and praxis, can illuminate our path through global challenges. I do this by delving into the power of archetypes and myths, those foundational patterns and stories that shape our understanding of the world.

ARCHETYPES AND MYTHS

At the heart of artistic creation lie the archetype and the myth. The precise meaning of these terms is fluid, a tapestry woven from threads of anthropology, psychology, philosophy, and literary theory. Yet, within this very fluidity lies their power. More important than imposing a singular definition is to understand how these concepts operate, how they are lived and performed.

Let us begin with the archetype. It is often described as the original pattern, the foundational model. At its essence, an archetype represents a primordial blueprint – a conceptual seed from which all variants of a

particular kind emerge. In psychological terms, figures such as the hero, the mentor, or the trickster have been proposed as recurring motifs embedded in our collective unconscious. However, beyond the theoretical frameworks of Carl Jung (1980) or the narrative structures delineated by Joseph Campbell (1949), the archetype is rooted in the tangible, sensory, and emotional experiences that each of us endures as we navigate our environments. The archetype, in its essence, is a universal symbol, a repository of collective human experience that transcends time and culture. What does this mean in the context of lived experience? It is not merely a static image, a Platonic ideal frozen in time. It is a visceral reaction, rooted in our biological and sensory engagement with the environment, which sparks a creative impulse within the individual. It is the shudder of awe before a storm, the primal comfort of a mother's embrace, the terror of the unknown lurking in the shadows, the wonder inspired by a sunrise, the resonance of ancient landscapes, the quiet power of a whispering forest. Many natural forms – the spiral of a seashell, the fractal branching of trees, or the rhythmic pulse of ocean waves – evoke in us an instinctual sense of order and beauty. These natural patterns are not merely aesthetic; they are imprinted in our neural circuitry and, by extension, in our cultural expressions. Such primordial patterns evoke deep-seated reactions that compel us to create, to reinterpret, and to imagine new possibilities.

Where archetypes provide the raw material, myths offer the narrative frameworks through which societies interpret experiences (Csapo, 2005). Myths have long served as structuring forces that shape both individual and collective identities. Whether drawn from ancient religions, folklore, or literary traditions, these narratives are not simply stories. Rather, they encapsulate the lived experiences of a culture, encoding its values, struggles, and aspirations in symbolic form. They originate in the bodily and sensory interaction with the lived environment, weaving a (hi)story that resonates with the deepest layers of our psyche. They are structuring forces, shaping our understanding of ourselves and our place in the world. They provide a framework for navigating the complexities of human existence, offering explanations for the inexplicable and guidance for the uncertain. They are the vessels of our shared human experience, carrying the weight of our hopes, fears, and aspirations. They are living, breathing stories – constantly reimagined by artists – imbued with the power to inspire change and reconfigure our understanding of the world.

In every culture, myths arise from the interplay between the body and its surroundings – a dynamic process where sensory experiences and embodied memory give birth to stories that, in turn, define the

cultural landscape. For example, Indigenous cultures often interpret the natural world through a lens of animism, where every element of nature is imbued with spirit and agency. In such contexts, the myth is not a distant, abstract narrative; it is a living, ongoing interaction with the world that informs both ritual and artistic creation. Like archetypes, myths are not static entities. They are constantly being reinterpreted and reimagined, adapted to new contexts and new audiences. The archetype, the original model, and the myth, the structuring force, are not simply relics of the past. They are living forces, constantly being reinterpreted and transformed by artists across cultures and time. They are crucial wellsprings of creative impulse, the seeds of innovation.

TRANSDISCIPLINARY AND TRANS-SECTORAL PERSPECTIVES

As we navigate these turbulent times, it is imperative that scholars from both the exact and social sciences, as well as the humanities, join forces (Brown et al., 2010). The archetype and the myth are not the exclusive domains of literary theorists or psychologists; they are the common threads that bind our diverse cultural expressions and intellectual pursuits. Neuroscience, for instance, is beginning to unveil the neural underpinnings of aesthetic experiences and the emotional responses that drive our interactions with archetypal imagery (Skov and Nadal, 2023). Cognitive scientists are exploring how symbolic representations are processed in the brain (Gallagher, 2005), while cultural anthropologists delve into the ways in which these symbols are negotiated within social contexts (Geertz, 1973). We must bridge the gap between empirical observation and phenomenological understanding, between the objective analysis of form and the subjective experience of meaning. By embracing an interdisciplinary approach, we can harness these timeless symbols to foster creative resilience and sustainable practices (Elo et al., 2024). This convergence of disciplines underscores a profound truth: that our understanding of creativity, culture, and meaning is enriched when we traverse traditional academic boundaries. By integrating insights from diverse fields, we can develop a more nuanced comprehension of how archetypes and myths operate across diverse cultures and historical periods. Such an integrated approach encourages us to view these concepts not as static categories but as fluid and evolving constructs that reflect the myriad ways humans interact with the world.

It is essential to recognize that while archetypes and myths may share universal elements, their manifestations are deeply contingent

upon cultural context. The heroic journey, for instance, is a narrative framework that appears in various forms across continents and epochs, yet its nuances are profoundly shaped by local histories, spiritual beliefs, and environmental realities (Campbell, 1949). In Western traditions, the hero might be portrayed as an individualistic conqueror of adversity, whereas in many Eastern cultures, the journey is often portrayed as a collective or cyclical process, emphasizing harmony with nature and community. This diversity calls for an attentive exploration of the specificities of form and content in distinct cultural domains. As researchers and artists, it is incumbent upon us to approach these narratives with sensitivity and openness, acknowledging that the creative reinterpretations of archetypal themes are both a reflection of and a response to the particularities of the lived experience. By engaging with these cultural variations, we enrich our collective understanding of the human condition and open new avenues for artistic innovation. By engaging in this kind of nuanced and culturally sensitive inquiry, we can gain a deeper understanding of the profound role that archetypes and myths play in the genesis of art. We can move beyond the limitations of theoretical abstraction and embrace the richness and complexity of human creativity.

THE ARTIST AS CULTURAL ALCHEMIST

The artist, in their unique sensitivity, becomes a conduit for archetypal experiences (Wood, 2022). The artist, in their role as storyteller, becomes a crucial agent in the process of cultural transmission. They breathe new life into ancient narratives, infusing them with contemporary relevance and personal meaning. They do not merely replicate them; they re-imagine them, filtering them through the lens of their own subjectivity, their cultural context, and their artistic medium. Artists across time have drawn upon organic patterns to forge new narratives, suggesting that our creative impulses are, in many ways, a dialogue with the fundamental structures of the natural world. The sculptor, wrestling with the raw material, seeks to give form to the archetypal figure of power. The painter, capturing the fleeting moment of light, reveals the archetypal beauty of the natural world. The composer, weaving melodies and harmonies, evokes the archetypal emotions of joy and sorrow.

The artist, much like an alchemist, transubstantiates foundational elements into works that speak to contemporary sensibilities while remaining anchored in a deep historical and cultural substrate (Jung, 1968). Alchemy here stands for the magical process of transformation, creation, or combination. Carl Jung famously stated that “Alchemy

describes, not merely in general outline but often in the most astonishing detail, the same psychological phenomenology which can be observed in the analysis of unconscious processes" (Jung, 1968). Historically, alchemists aimed to transmute base metals into gold. In Jungian thought, this process serves as a symbolic metaphor for the psychological transformation of the fragmented or impure unconscious into a state of integrated wholeness – an idea closely associated with the concept of individuation and the pursuit of enlightenment. The Alchemist archetype transforms or creates, often through a magical process. They exist to bring more magic into the world and often have a talent for transforming energy. They also transform lives and stimulate the evolution of human consciousness. The alchemist's physical endeavour to transform base matter into gold serves as a powerful metaphor for the individual's inner journey toward self-discovery and transformation – a process that necessitates the dissolution of the former self to allow for the emergence of a new identity. This metaphorical path of the alchemist is inherently aligned with psychological and existential transformation, emphasizing their inseparability.

In Jungian psychology, the figure of the alchemist stands as a central archetype for understanding the artist. Entering the realm of the unconscious entails a profound risk: there is no guarantee of return or successful reintegration. This existential uncertainty is what renders the alchemist's path one of profound courage. Consequently, the alchemist may be understood as a symbolic precursor to the artist. Just as the alchemist cannot know in advance whether their transmutation will succeed, the artist too engages in a process defined by uncertainty – creating something that does not yet exist in the material world. The emergence of the truly original cannot be assured; its pre-existence in a metaphysical or unconscious realm does not ensure its successful articulation into physical form. The artist must, therefore, undertake the creative act as a leap into the unknown, transforming latent potential into manifested reality. This courageous navigation of uncertainty is a defining feature of genuine creative expression. The alchemical impulse – to elevate the base into something refined – closely parallels the artistic impulse. For example, to describe a painter's work merely as the arrangement of pigments on canvas would be reductive, as it neglects the deeper metaphysical act of creation. The true artistic process involves imbuing material elements with new meaning and expressive form, generating a communicative bridge between the unconscious, the ineffable, and the perceiver. Art thus becomes a liminal space – a threshold between the invisible realm of potential and the visible world of form.

Artists, in their unique capacity to reinterpret and transform archetypal and mythical structures, play a crucial role in their heritability. Through their works, artists breathe new life into these ancient patterns, infusing them with contemporary relevance and personal significance. This creative reinterpretation is not a mere replication but a dynamic process of transformation that reflects the artist's individual vision and the cultural context in which they operate. The heritability of archetypal and mythical structures, as I have noted, is inextricably linked to this process of creative reinterpretation. It is through the artist's transformative power that these primal forces are kept alive, passed down through generations, and adapted to the ever-changing landscape of human experience. Consider the ways in which artists have reimagined the classical hero or reconfigured traditional narratives to comment on contemporary society. In each instance, the artist's creative act is a process of negotiation – a dialogue between the inherited symbolic structures and the individual's lived experience. It is this interplay that not only enriches the work of art but also perpetuates the very mythic qualities that define our cultural heritage. The transformative power of art lies in its ability to take the archetypal, to distil it into its elemental form, and then to reassemble it into new configurations that speak to the current human condition. The heritability of archetypal and mythical structures is, therefore, a testament to the enduring power of human creativity. Artists across different historical periods and cultural domains have drawn upon these universal symbols, reimagining them in ways that speak to their own time and place. This process of creative reinterpretation ensures that archetypes and myths remain vibrant and relevant, continually evolving to reflect the changing contours of human experience.

CHALLENGING THE CHALLENGES

As stated before, our creative impulses are deeply rooted in the interplay between our sensory experiences and our cultural narratives. When we engage with the world as practitioners of both knowledge and wisdom – when we allow our *phronesis* to guide our praxis – we are better equipped to reimagine solutions for a world in constant flux. But how can ancient concepts help us address the contemporary challenges we face (WEF, 2023)?

- Firstly, archetypes and myths provide a framework for understanding human behaviour and motivation. They reveal the deep-seated patterns that drive our actions, both individually and collectively.

By understanding these patterns, we can gain insights into the root causes of our problems and develop more effective solutions.

- Secondly, archetypes and myths can serve as powerful tools for communication and engagement. They speak to us on a visceral level, transcending the limitations of language and logic, offering a holistic and inclusive lens on our shared reality. They can evoke emotions, inspire action, and foster a shared sense of purpose. The archetype of the hero or the myth of rebirth can be reimagined in artistic installations that address environmental degradation. An artist might reinterpret the hero's journey to mirror humanity's struggle against climate change, suggesting that the path to salvation lies not in technological fixes alone but in a reawakening of our collective responsibility and care for the Earth. In this way, arts-based praxis transforms a static template into a dynamic call to action.
- Thirdly, the arts, as a vehicle for archetypal and mythical expression, offer a unique space for knowledge co-production. Artists, through their creative process, can bridge different knowledge systems, integrating scientific data with Indigenous knowledge, artistic intuition with empirical observation. They can embed knowledge into art objects, share knowledge through the language of art, and contribute to monitoring social-ecological change. Consider the power of a sculpture that embodies the fragility of a threatened ecosystem, or a performance that evokes the emotional impact of climate change. These works can communicate complex ideas in a way that resonates with audiences on a personal level, fostering empathy and understanding.
- Lastly, we must recognize that archetypes and myths are not static entities. They are constantly being reinterpreted and transformed by artists, reflecting the changing realities of our world. This process of creative reinterpretation is crucial for ensuring that these foundational patterns remain relevant and meaningful in the face of evolving challenges.

In the context of today's global challenges, arts-based praxis thus emerges as a potent form of practical wisdom. There are multiple ways in which artistic processes can contribute to addressing wicked problems:

- Embedding Knowledge in Art Objects: Art can serve as a vessel for cultural, ecological, and social knowledge, transforming abstract concepts into tangible, evocative experiences. By creating art that reflects the complexities of our world, artists can inspire critical reflection and dialogue.
- Communicating Beyond Words: Art transcends linguistic and cultural barriers, allowing for the sharing of knowledge in ways that

are accessible and engaging. The visual, auditory, and performative languages of art can bridge diverse knowledge systems, enabling to communicate complex ideas and foster a deeper understanding of global challenges, and fostering dialogue among communities that might otherwise remain isolated.

- Cultivating Creative Skills: The practice of making art is itself a form of knowledge-making – a journey that nurtures empathy, critical thinking, and emotional intelligence. By sharing art-making skills, artists can empower communities to engage in creative problem-solving and develop their own responses to local and global issues.
- Monitoring Social-Ecological Change: Art can document, reflect, and even predict shifts in our social and ecological landscapes, acting as a barometer of change. Through artistic practices, we can capture the nuances of environmental and societal transformations, providing valuable insights for policymakers and practitioners.
- Fostering Temporal Continuity: Art has the unique ability to connect past, present, and future. By drawing on archetypes and myths, artists can create works that resonate across generations, fostering a sense of continuity and shared responsibility for the future. Through the reinterpretation of archetypal and mythical forms, art sustains cultural memory and continuity, linking past wisdom to future innovations.
- Co-Producing Knowledge: Art is inherently collaborative and participatory. By engaging diverse stakeholders in the creation of art, we can co-produce knowledge that is contextually relevant and socially inclusive. Art becomes a site where diverse perspectives converge, creating hybrid forms of knowledge that are both context-sensitive and globally relevant.

CONCLUSION: A CALL TO COLLABORATIVE EXPLORATION

The archetype and myth are far more than theoretical constructs; they are the living, breathing substrates of our creative existence. The archetype and the myth are not relics of a bygone era but living, evolving frameworks that continue to inform and inspire our artistic and scientific endeavours. They remind us that the creative act is both a reflection of our inner landscapes and a response to the world around us. The study of the archetype and the myth offers us a powerful lens through which to examine the interplay of nature, culture, and creativity. It challenges us to look beyond rigid disciplinary boundaries and to embrace an integrative approach that honours both the empirical and the experiential.

Whether you are a scientist probing the neural correlates of aesthetic experience, a historian deciphering the evolution of mythic narratives, or an artist reimagining age-old symbols in a contemporary medium, your work contributes to a grand, ongoing dialogue about what it means to be human.

I encourage you to explore these timeless themes – archetypes and myths – as sources of inspiration and catalysts for new creative expressions. Let us work together to map the intricate terrain where our individual experiences intersect with the deep, enduring patterns that have shaped human history. Let us continue to draw upon these ancient patterns, reinterpreting and transforming them in ways that reflect our own unique perspectives and the cultural contexts in which we live. In doing so, we not only pay homage to the past but also chart a course toward a future where art and scholarship continue to illuminate the boundless possibilities of human creativity. In an age marked by complexity and uncertainty, arts-based praxis offers a powerful, integrative approach – one that cultivates practical wisdom and enables us to co-create a more just, resilient, and vibrant future. Arts-based praxis harnesses these elements, converting timeless patterns into vehicles for action and resilience.

As we navigate the complexities of our global landscape, let us draw on the profound power of archetypes and myths to inspire, challenge, and transform. Let us embrace the power of arts-based praxis, recognizing that it is not merely a form of expression, but a vital tool for navigating the complexities of our world. Let us cultivate *phronesis*, wisdom-in-action, and embark on the journey of praxis, transforming knowledge into meaningful change. Let us remember that the responses to our global challenges lie not only in scientific innovation but also in the creative power of the human spirit, in the enduring wisdom of our archetypes and myths, and in the transformative potential of art. Let us, through the alchemy of art and anthropology, forge a path towards a more sustainable and just future.

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WHEN TWO MYTHS MEET: BODY POLITICS AT KADRIORG PALACE

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ABSTRACT

This article investigates the ceiling painting of Diana and Actaeon in the main hall of Kadriorg Palace, Estonia, as a case study in the political uses of Ovidian mythology in early 18th-century Europe. Situating Kadriorg within the wider reception history of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, the study reconstructs the transmission pathways – textual, visual, and material – through which classical imagery travelled from France, Italy, and Germany to the Baltic. By analysing illustrated editions, engravings after Rembrandt, and the Versailles-inspired iconographic programmes adopted across European courts, the article demonstrates how Peter the Great deliberately inserted Russia into a Western European visual and political tradition grounded in classical authority. The Kadriorg ceiling's depiction of Actaeon's metamorphosis, interpreted in the Russian court as an allegory of Sweden's defeat in the Great Northern War, reveals how myths of bodily transformation were mobilised to articulate sovereign power. The article further argues that Kadriorg's emblematic panels – derived from Charles Le Brun's designs for Louis XIV – extend this political messaging by aligning Peter I with an absolutist rhetoric of virtue, abundance, and dynastic legitimacy. Ultimately, the study shows that the Kadriorg programme epitomises the convergence of ancient poetics and imperial self-fashioning, illuminating the mechanisms by which Russia positioned itself within the cultural topography of early modern Europe.

Keywords: Ovid, Kadriorg palace, Peter the Great, Europe

INTRODUCTION

In 2026, the Kadriorg Art Museum will open an exhibition dedicated to the reception of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* at the palace built for Peter the Great in 1718. At the centre of this project stands the palace's painted ceiling, commissioned by Peter, which depicts the myth of Diana and Actaeon (Fig. 1. Kadiorg Palace ceiling painting). The tale, drawn from Ovid's poem written around 8 CE, appears within the larger arc of the *Metamorphoses*, a text that stretches from the creation of the world to



Fig. 1. Kadiorg Palace ceiling painting

the deification of Julius Caesar and the advent of Augustus. Ovid's sequence of myths – each structured around the motif of bodily transformation – became one of the most significant cultural reservoirs for early modern Europe. Long described as the "Bible of artists," the *Metamorphoses* profoundly shaped the visual imagination of painters, sculptors, and architects.

To encounter Ovid, a Roman poet, in the early18th-century court of Peter the Great is, at first glance, surprising. Why this myth, and why here? What does the presence of Diana at Kadriorg tell us – not only about Peter's own image-making, but also about the circulation and reuse of ancient mythology across European courts? This article begins

by tracing the long and complex history of the *Metamorphoses* in early modern Europe, in order to understand the cultural, artistic, and political frameworks within which the Kadriorg ceiling must be situated.

OVID'S JOURNEY TO KADRIORG

Research into the sources of the Kadriorg ceiling has required us to look far beyond Tallinn. The image did not originate in Russia; rather, it reaches the Baltic through the centuries-long transmission of Ovid's text and its illustrations across Europe. Ovid's popularity in "Western" Europe far predates his reception in Russia, where Metamorphoses would not be translated until the early eighteenth century. By that point, in France, Italy, and Germany the poem had already served as an inexhaustible source for poets, dramatists, designers, and – especially – visual artists.

Although medieval readers engaged with Ovid extensively, the 16th and 17th centuries witnessed a dramatic expansion in the poem's influence. Across these centuries, the *Metamorphoses* became one of the most frequently cited ancient works at European courts. A major factor in this acceleration was the proliferation of illustrated editions. As print culture expanded, publishers increasingly paired the Latin or vernacular text with sets of engravings designed to guide readers through Ovid's complex myths. These images were didactic as much as decorative; they provided a visual taxonomy of the ancient world and served as templates for artists working across all media. This raises an important question: how did a pagan poet become so central to Christian Europe? Ovid's acceptance by both Catholic and Protestant traditions was crucial. Early modern interpreters frequently framed him as a morally instructive proto-Christian author whose tales could be read allegorically as lessons in order, hierarchy, and divine justice. Elements deemed too pagan were downplayed; what remained was a reservoir of exemplary narratives well suited to princely courts eager to articulate their own power through classical precedent.

By the 16th century, translations into Italian, French, and German proliferated. But one of the most influential editions appeared in 1676: Isaac de Benserade's French rhymed translation, commissioned by the French King Louis XIV. This luxurious project, richly illustrated, was intended not only for his son, the Dauphin's, education but also as a guide to the iconographic programme of Versailles, where allusions to Ovid permeated virtually every decorative scheme. Versailles itself drew on Book II of the *Metamorphoses* for its conceptual foundations, with Apollo – the Sun – serving as Louis XIV's central emblem.

The Sun King's visual politics were inseparable from classical appropriation. Louis XIV obsessively collected (or replicated) antiquities; he founded the French Academy in Rome in 1666 to train young artists in the study of ancient art, whose forms would be transferred to France in casts and copies. At Versailles, these motifs were not imitations of antiquity but vehicles for a new mythology of kingship. Individual sculptures were erected inside and throughout the gardens of Apollo but also of female goddesses, particularly Diana, the goddess of the hunt. A Roman marble sculpture of Diana, commonly referred to as the Diana of Versailles, was first brought to France from Rome in the 16th century as a gift from Pope Paul IV to the French King Henri II and was installed in the gardens of the Château de Fontainebleau, and later in the Hall of Mirrors at the Château de Versailles. Larger sculptural demonstrations such as the Latona Fountain at Versailles – where the goddess defends her children Apollo and Diana from the insolent Lycians, who are metamorphosed into frogs – embody a political theology, in this case one in which divine protection guarantees order and punishes rebellion. It is a world protected by the Gods, and shows the role of providence. The message here is that Apollo (another name for the Sun King) is accorded divine protection, and that Apollo would be the guarantor of order, a symbol of the sovereign. Those who rebelled or challenged divine order would be appropriately punished. Myth and antiquity join hands; they are both part of the programme of constructing the king's glory. But they are part of the myth of kingship that Louis is creating. The bodies, here, are a tool for conceptualising a different socio-political reality. Myth and antiquity become instruments of sovereign authority, articulated through the metamorphic bodies that populate Ovid's poem.

Versailles' iconographic programme was meant for all of the king's subjects – books were printed with the purposes of guiding the visitor – as well as for posterity and, crucially, for other European courts. Diplomacy in this period was a theatre of display, and royal residencies became stages on which power was visually negotiated. Courts throughout Europe adopted, adapted, and emulated Versailles: from Madrid under Philip V, to the royal palace in Stockholm, to Würzburg's Residenz staircase, to the Habsburg complexes at the Hofburg and Schönbrunn. The stories from Ovid's Metamorphoses were incorporated into the architectural sphere following other monarchs' desires to portray themselves as superior cultural and political powers.

Peter the Great's travels to France in 1717 therefore occurred at a moment when Versailles' classical aesthetic had already begun to reshape court culture across the continent. During this visit Peter toured

Versailles and the Académie des Inscriptions. On his return, he sent the Academy the inscription for his equestrian monument at St Petersburg. He founded institutions modelled on their French counterparts, including a state newspaper, a tapestry manufactory, and the Academy of Sciences. Peterhof, designed by Jean-Baptiste Le Blond – a former student of André Le Nôtre, who had designed the gardens of Versailles – can be understood as a northern response to Versailles, particularly in function and ceremonial culture, and even included apartments dedicated there to teaching Western manners to the Russian nobility. In this context, Peter's commissioning of a ceiling based on Ovid must be read as a deliberate insertion of Russia into a distinctly Western European political and visual tradition.

FROM PRINTED OVID TO PAINTED CEILING: THE DISSEMINATION OF IMAGES

Peter's adoption of Ovid served both international and local purposes. While the political implications for Russia will be analysed in the next section, it is important here to trace the precise visual sources behind the Kadriorg ceiling. Our ongoing research indicates that its imagery belongs to the long history of illustrated book editions of the *Metamorphoses* that circulated between France, Germany, Poland, and Russia.

As noted, the Benserade edition became a key point of reference across Europe. Its engravings influenced subsequent visual cycles, including those produced by Johann Ulrich Kraus in Augsburg in the 1690s. Kraus's edition would later play a central role in early Russian translations, which included extensive engraved material. Parallel to this, a Polish edition produced by Walerian Otwinowski in 1638 became an important intermediary: two Russian translations were made from Otwinowski's work at the end of the 17th and beginning of the 18th century.

The closest analogue to the Kadriorg ceiling, however, appears in a French–Brussels edition associated with Du Ryer, and possibly printed by Foppens, in 1677. Its engraving of the Diana and Actaeon episode by the Dutch engraver, Magdalena van de Passe, closely resembles the composition used at Kadriorg, suggesting a direct or indirect line of transmission.

By mapping these editions – from Benserade in France to Hoffmann and Kraus in Germany, to Otwinowski in Poland, and finally to Russia – we gain an insight into the pathways through which classical visual culture travelled in the early modern period. The Kadriorg ceiling thus emerges

not merely as a decorative adaptation of a classical myth, but as a manifestation of intellectual and artistic networks that linked Paris, Augsburg, Warsaw, and St Petersburg. It participates both in a trans-European language of courtly power and in the specific political conditions of the early Russian Empire.

THE CONSTRUCTION OF KADRIORG PALACE

Kadriorg Palace is the most remarkable building erected in Estonia in the 18th century, both in terms of its ambition and artistic value. The palace was built on the orders of Russian Tsar Peter I and designed by the Italian architect Niccolo Michetti. Niccolo Michetti (1675–1759) was a student of the famous Baroque master Carlo Fontana and one of Rome's leading architects before coming to Russia. Working in Russia from 1718 to 1723, he essentially became the chief architect of St. Petersburg, and his work can still be seen today in Kadriorg Palace in Tallinn and in several fountains in the park of Peterhof Palace.

By 1710, the Great Northern War (1700–1721) had essentially ended for Estonia, and the land had passed from the rule of Swedish King Charles XII to that of Russian Tsar Peter I. As early as 1714, the tsar acquired nearly 100 hectares of coastal land near Tallinn for his personal use. From there, he had a panoramic view of both the Baltic Sea – which was to become Russia's link with Europe, supporting the development of shipping and the economy and ensuring the country's security – and the tower-filled skyline of the Hanseatic city of Tallinn. Planning for the palace complex began in 1718 with the architect Niccolo Michetti and his assistant Gaetano Chiaveri. Together with Tsar Peter I, they marked the location of the palace foundations and the boundaries of the park on July 22, a date that is still considered the birthday of the Kadriorg Palace complex.

The main hall of Kadriorg Palace is an exceptional and beautiful example of Baroque interior design from the time of Peter I, especially since the representative palaces in St. Petersburg, Peterhof, and Strelna have largely lost their original appearance due to later renovations or war damage. In Kadriorg, however, the interior design of the main hall has been preserved in its original form, with Baroque symbolism and lavish displays of power that glorify the monarch's might and virtues.

The design of the main hall was created in the 1720s based on the plans of the palace architect Niccolò Michetti. The work was carried out by a group of international masters at the top of their field: the stucco

decoration on the ceiling was modelled by the Italian master Antonio Quadri, while the golden trumpeting geniuses and stucco ornamentation on the fireplaces were created by the Swedish royal sculptor Salomon Zeltrecht. The four tondo-shaped reliefs were created by Matthias Seidtinger, and the Baroque wave-shaped fireplaces made of dolomite were carved by Heinrich Bergen from Riga.

DIANA AND ACTAEON – SOURCES AND PARALLELS

The central ceiling painting is based on the story of the hunter Actaeon (Greek: Aktaion) and the goddess Diana (Greek: Artemis) from the *Metamorphoses*. While hunting in the forest, Actaeon discovers Diana, the goddess of hunting and nature, bathing among the nymphs. The virgin goddess is enraged that a mere mortal has seen her in such a situation and turns the hunter into a stag. The hunting dogs, no longer recognizing their master and mistaking him for prey, chase the stag and tear him apart. The painting depicts the moment when the nymphs bathing in the water notice Actaeon and try to hide their nakedness from him, but under the influence of the goddess Diana's punishment, horns have already appeared on the hunter's head and his metamorphosis has begun. In the upper right corner of the painting, there is a cave in the forest with two witnesses, a woman and a boy, who will later be able to tell people about the events that took place.

The painting is based on Rembrandt Hermensz van Rijn's painting "Diana Bathing with Nymphs, Actaeon and Callisto". This painting is now in the collection of the Wasserburg Anholt Museum. The engraver and publisher Chrispijn van de Passe II (1594–1670), who worked in Paris, Utrecht, and Amsterdam, created a graphic sheet based on this painting. His sister Magdalena van de Passe's engraving appears as an illustration of the story of Diana and Actaeon in the *Metamorphoses*, published in Brussels in 1677. In addition to the ceiling painting in Kadriorg Palace, another monumental painting based on the same engraving was created. It is located in Güldenstein Castle in Schleswig-Holstein, founded by Heinrich von Thienen. The manor house was built at almost the same time as Kadriorg Palace, between 1726 and 1728. The architect was Rudolph Matthias Dallin (1680–1743) ("Corpus der barocken Deckenmalerei in Deutschland"), who was of German-Swedish origin. Dallin had been a captain of engineers in the Swedish army, and his first architectural project was commissioned by Duke Frederick IV of Schleswig-Holstein-Gottorf, who was a Swedish ally in the Great Northern War.

DATING THE PAINTING AND QUEST FOR AUTHORSHIP

The technical research conducted in March 2024 on the ceiling painting of Kadriorg Palace revealed that, although the work has historically been described as a fresco, close visual examination provides no grounds for assuming that it was executed on wet plaster. Rather, the painting appears to be a form of secco, the analysis of whose original technique is complicated by the extensive restoration works carried out at later dates. An assessment of the painterly manner and stylistic features indicates the frequent use of a combination of glazing and impasto brushwork, characteristic of oil painting. Moreover, the technical quality of execution varies considerably across the surface of the painting.

Two principal hypotheses have circulated regarding the date of the painting's completion (Hiiop, Kröönström, Murre 2025, 77-108). The long-standing theory that the work was executed for the 1746 visit to Tallinn of Peter I's daughter, Empress Elizabeth Petrovna, a view seemingly validated by an invoice documenting the employment of the local master painter Londicer, proves untenable in light of the painting's political programme and more recent archival discoveries. Examination of both the iconographic message of the composition and the documentary evidence increasingly supports an alternative dating to the second half of the 1720s. As the ceiling painting could only have been undertaken after the completion of the stucco work in the main hall in the autumn of 1725, the earliest plausible date of execution may be placed in 1726–1727. The painting's somewhat mediocre and rigid handling suggests that, for whatever reason, a highly accomplished master from abroad was not engaged, and that the author should instead be sought among the painters active in Tallinn during the 1720s.

From 1720 onwards, Carl Gustav Schnettler was a citizen of Tallinn and later became the first Eltermann (alderman) of the painters' guild. His documented works include the painting of the town gymnasium building and, from the mid-18th century, the execution of faux-marbling on the balcony and columns of the hall of the Great Guild Hall. However, no works by Schnettler are known that would approach the scale or artistic ambition of the ceiling painting at Kadriorg Palace.

A somewhat more plausible candidate for the authorship of the main hall ceiling is Johann Heinrich Fick, born in Nuremberg and admitted as a citizen of Tallinn in 1719. Archival sources record that he received payment in 1721 for work carried out at Kadriorg Palace. Considering the construction chronology of the palace complex, this payment has been associated with the ceiling painting of the seaward auxiliary building.

Nevertheless, Fick's authorship of the main hall ceiling is called into question by the fact that the wing's ceiling painting was executed in glue-based tempera, that is, in a technique noticeably different from that employed in the main hall. More precise stylistic comparison is complicated by the condition of the wing's ceiling painting, which survives only fragmentarily, chiefly its lower paint layers.

The third painter active in Tallinn during the years of the completion of Kadriorg Palace was Johann Heinrich Wedekind, a native of Bielefeld. In 1698, while working at the court of the Swedish king, he painted a portrait of Charles XII. Wedekind, who had married the daughter of a Tallinn apothecary, acquired Tallinn citizenship, and resided there until 1714, entered the service of the Swedish Crown again in 1716, remaining in its employment until the death of Charles XII.

From 1720 until artist´s death in 1736, his professional life was associated primarily with St. Petersburg, although through familial and social ties he remained connected to Tallinn, where he executed several portraits that have survived to the present day. Of Wedekind's oeuvre, which includes portraits of members of the local elite as well as portraits and allegorical compositions commissioned by Catherine I, fifteen works are currently known in Russian and Estonian museum collections, ten of them signed.

OVID'S METAMORPHOSES IN THE SERVICE OF PETER I'S POLITICAL PROGRAMME

By choosing a plot from Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, Peter I emphasized his own and Russia's belonging to European culture. When Kadriorg Palace was built at the end of the Great Northern War, Reval (Tallinn) was where Peter's "window on the West" began. Inspired by the allegories and pictorial programmes used to glorify the French King Louis XIV, Peter consciously and systematically employed narratives from classical mythology in the construction of his own cult. In Peter's case, no distinction is made between the mortal human and the political body: in glorifying the sovereign, it is not the state or the nation that are celebrated, but rather the ruler's own deified qualities and achievements. Following the victorious Battle of Poltava in the Great Northern War, the classical deities in artworks unmistakably assume Peter's features; for example, the war god Mars, in "The Triumph of Mars" executed in 1711–1712 at Menshikov's Palace, bears a striking resemblance to Peter himself. The triumphal arches erected in Moscow to celebrate the Battle of Poltava were adorned with mythological scenes. The rector

of the Slavic-Greek-Latin Academy published a booklet explaining the decorations of the triumphal arch and glorifying Peter, thus framing the celebration of the Poltava victory within a context of Ancient Rome and linking Peter I's victories to those of the Romans. Artworks, speeches, and ceremonies presented Peter as the god of war Mars, the all-powerful Jupiter, the ruler of the waters Neptune, and also as the hero-monarch Hercules (Wortman 2006, 21-27).

Ovid's *Metamorphoses* was a very important literary work for Peter I: it was the first work of fiction in Russian, with illustrations, to be published in Russia during Peter I's reign, in 1721 (Клепиков 1964, 159-160). Another of Peter's favourites was Hermanus van den Burg's "Symbola et Emblemata", which was printed for him in Amsterdam in 1705 and republished in Russia in 1719. Detailed verbal explanations of classical and mythological motifs ensured that the associations embedded in the symbols reinforced the sovereign's image. Emblematic art enjoyed exceptional popularity throughout Europe in the 18th century. Emblem paintings, encircling a central ceiling composition, for instance, formed part of the decorative programme of the Spökslottet palace in Stockholm, commissioned in the early years of the 18th century by the merchant Hans Petter Scheffler. In Estonia, emblem paintings were likewise prevalent in manor interiors, where such works featured both familial symbolism and allegorical motifs, as exemplified by the decorative scheme of the Palmse manor house.

Ovid's motifs were used in ceremonies, buildings and individual artworks during the reign of Peter I, carrying strong ideological and propagandistic significance in connection with the Great Northern War and the defeat of Sweden. Reasons for using this myth in the ceiling painting of Kadriorg Palace may have also resulted from Peter I's personal experience. Namely, St. Petersburg historian Nikolai Vertogradski has mentioned a relief depicting St. George slaying the dragon and Peter I as Actaeon, which may have originated from the triumphal arch erected in 1700 in honour of the Battle of Narva, which was victorious for Sweden. Peter I, who conquered Narva in 1704, may have seen this triumphal arch or the aforementioned images himself and decided to depict the defeated Swedish king Charles XII as Actaeon (Вертоградский 1908, 7-23). And thus it came to pass that in the ceiling painting at Kadriorg Palace Actaeon represents Sweden, which lost the Great Northern War, and the hunting dogs represent the allies who turned against Sweden during the war. The punitive Diana symbolizes Russia's victory in the Great Northern War, destroying enemies who cross her boundaries, show disrespect and even as much as gaze upon her unfavourably.

The waterspouting mascaron in the upper right of the painting transforms the forest spring into rather a park basin, thereby further linking the myth to its location since Peter and the architect Michetti had designed the area surrounding Kadriorg Palace as an elaborate garden with canals and water features. The number of nymphs surrounding the goddess represent the number of towns and fortresses that Russian forces captured during the course of the war in the territories of Estonia, Livonia, and Courland.

The myth of Diana and Actaeon assumed a particular prominence in Peter's political propaganda during the final years of the Great Northern War; yet the identification of Russia with the goddess Diana had emerged considerably earlier. As early as 1703, a triumphal arch erected by the Slavic-Greek-Latin Academy to celebrate Russian military victories featured a depiction of Diana rescuing her companions, the nymphs (symbolising territories conquered by Russia), from the jaws of a bloodthirsty lion (Sweden). The Great Cascade in the park of the Peterhof Palace, designed by the architect Niccolo Michetti – who also designed Kadriorg Palace – includes representations of Narcissus, Perseus and Andromeda, the Rape of Proserpina, as well as Diana and Actaeon.

EMBLEMS BORROWED FROM THE FRENCH COURT AS VEHICLES FOR THE AMPLIFICATION OF A POLITICAL MESSAGE

The central ceiling painting in Kadriorg Palace is complemented by four small emblems (Fig. 2. Kadriorg Palace ceiling emblems) that clearly express Peter I's ambition to define himself as an absolutist monarch and a ruler equal to the crowned heads of Europe. The four painted panels depict a sheaf of wheat, a white lily, a rose, and a swallow. The emblems are modelled after the tapestries of French court artist Charles le Brun on the theme of the seasons, allegorical tributes to King Louis XIV. The main hall of Kadriorg Palace, intended as a summer residence, features two spring and two summer emblems. Engravings based on the tapestry designs were published repeatedly and spread throughout Europe. It is not known which edition was used by the creators of the Kadriorg Palace picture programme, but it is known that Peter I stayed in Paris and Versailles in 1717 and saw the season tapestries.

It is significant that the emblems were chosen from the spring and summer tapestries. The central image of the spring tapestry depicts Mars and Venus, the god of war and the goddess of love, and is thus associated



Fig. 2. Kadriorg Palace ceiling emblems

on another level with the victory in the Great Northern War and pays tribute to Catherine I, Peter I's wife whom he loved passionately. The summer tapestry with Minerva and Apollo symbolizes wise rule and the flourishing of the arts. Thus, in the context of Kadriorg Palace, these emblems carry a multi-layered message and Peter I's imperialist ideology.

The sheaf of wheat above the tsar's monogram, together with the Latin motto "*Vitae melioris in usum*" (For a better life), symbolizes the Russian Empire, which during the reign of Peter I incorporated the Baltic provinces and the Caspian Sea region as separate entities. The paintings of the lily and the swallow form a thematic whole. In both Christian art and secular imagery, the lily is a symbol of purity and royalty; in the context of the palace, it refers to the emperor's promise to rule with dignity

and honesty. The motto above the swallow, "*Et tempora laeta reducit*" (And brings back better times), expresses hope for the restoration of peace and prosperity after the Great Northern War. The red rose with the inscription "*Juncta arma decori*" (Arms united in beauty) is an elegant reference to Peter I's wife Catherine, to whom the palace is dedicated; it can also refer to a beautiful goal (the flower) and the difficulties and sacrifices (the thorns) that inevitably accompany the pursuit of that goal.

CONCLUSION

Illustrated editions of Ovid's *Metamorphoses* proliferated across Europe, reaching as far as the Russian court, through the influence of Louis XIV, enabling ancient deities to serve as allegorical figures for the absolutist rulers of Europe. By selecting a narrative from Ovid's poem, Peter I underscored both his own and Russia's integration into European culture. The main ceiling painting in Kadriorg Palace is accompanied by four smaller emblems that plainly articulate Peter I's aspiration to present himself as a major European power on a par with Europe's crowned monarchs. Ultimately, this study demonstrates that the Kadriorg programme embodies the fusion of classical poetics with imperial self-fashioning, thus shedding light on the strategies through which Russia situated itself within the cultural landscape of early modern Europe.

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MYTH AND ARCHETYPE IN ARTISTIC AND THEORETICAL PRACTICES OF TÕNIS VINT

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ABSTRACT

This paper discusses the phenomenon of Tõnis Vint (1942–2019), the artist and artistic thinker, a legendary figure in Estonian art of the second half of the 20th century, whose ideas served as a starting point for many representatives of different generations working in various fields of art. In the centre of the aesthetic ideal of Vint was the field of visual culture to which he ascribed a broader impact, seeing visual sign systems as the most powerful means of transmitting a message. Relying on his erudition in the art and visual culture of different regions and epochs, Vint created a conceptual platform for interpretation and synthesis of various visual phenomena. The artist believed in the possibility of a universal aesthetical-symbolic system generating positive influence both on an individual and processes in society. He was convinced that positive psychological impact of visual images can also function subconsciously. In his conception, Tõnis Vint proceeded significantly from Carl G. Jung's comparative psychoanalysis, developing Jung's ideas on myth, archetype and mandala in his artistic and theoretical practices in the situation of Soviet Estonia.

Keywords: Estonian graphic art, artistic mythology, total work of art, sign system theories, Jungian archetype conception

The purpose of my paper is to outline the mythological aspect as a fundamental experience of artistic practice. As a case study, I will discuss the phenomenon of Tõnis Vint (1942–2019, Latvian name adaptation Tenis Vints) – a legendary figure in Estonian art of the second half of the 20th century. Vint can be considered a teacher of exceptional importance, whose ideas had served, directly and indirectly, as a starting point for many representatives of different generations working in



Fig. 1. Tõnis Vint in 2010. Photograph: Eva Vint

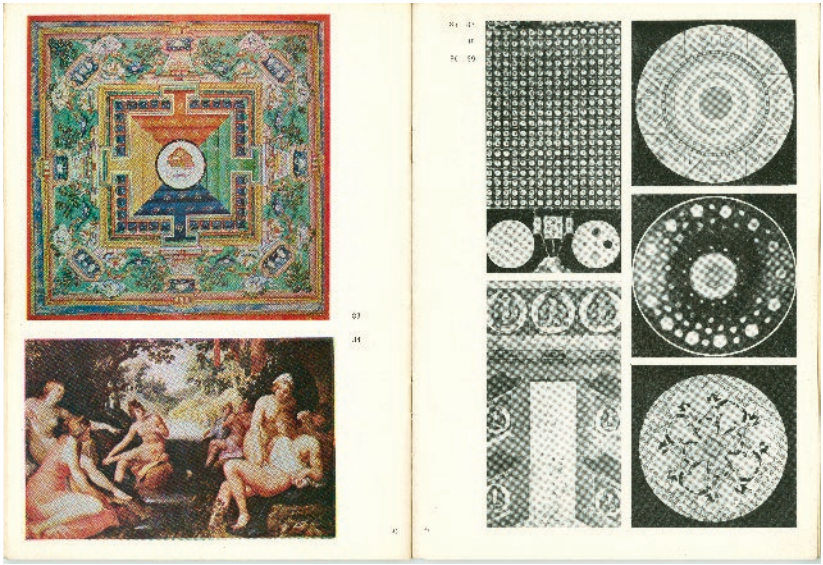


Fig. 2. Illustrations for Tõnis Vint's article "Golden Flower. Tantra. Dao" in *Kunst* almanac [1975/2; destroyed issue] 1975. Private collection

various fields of art – for artists, designers, architects and others. At the centre of aesthetic ideal of Vint was the field of visual culture to which he ascribed a broader impact, seeing visual sign systems as the most powerful means of transmitting a message. The artist believed in the possibility of a universal aesthetical-symbolic system, which would serve as a basis for the interpretation of all kinds of visual phenomena as well as for creation of new (spatial-) visual structures generating positive influence both on an individual and processes in society. Due to its holistic nature, this kind of consistent artistic-philosophical system can be compared to traditional mythological models of the world: still, as it is based primarily on individually-charged concepts and symbols, it should be discussed as an artistic mythology – myth-making in the art practices of an individual author.

Although elements of collective and individual mythmaking are often intertwined, it is possible to distinguish them, moving from older and broader phenomena to more recent and particular cases. Below, as a methodological starting point, I suggest a possibility to map out different levels of myths and mythologies (This question is elaborated in detail in my PhD thesis: Taidre 2016, pp. 48–49).

1. Traditional myths, coining core mythological motifs – or mythologemes – for artistic interpretations or comparative analysis: e.g., the myth of two realities (dualistic cosmology).
2. Modern collective myths dominated by certain social, political or cultural aspects: e.g., the myth of progress, the myth of the perfect language etc.
3. Certain paradigms of art history have their own myths: e.g., the Modernist myth of the artist-creator (demiurge), the myth of the total work of art (*Gesamtkunstwerk*) etc.
4. On the individual level, the autobiographical myth creates heroization and mystification of the artist's life story, e.g. finding inspiration described as comparable to revelation.
5. Individual art conception growing into artist's aesthetic-philosophical system which suggests framing narratives for his or her artworks.
6. Artistic mythology that results in particular artworks, creating symbols and meanings of their own.

All these different levels are present in Tõnis Vint's legacy, but my focus will be mainly on his original input, both in art theory and practice. In this discussion, among other sources, I will also rely on my numerous discussions with Tõnis Vint that took place during the years 2007–2019.

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Acknowledging the context Tõnis Vint was working in, it must be admitted that by the time he joined the art scene of Soviet Estonia the harshest years of Sovietization and Stalinization had come to an end. The so-called Severe style had reformed the canon of ideological Socialist realism, suggesting an alternative Modernist realism: there emerged expressive, poetical and stylised interpretations of reality, but also experiments with the newest art methods. It became possible to get familiar with the geometric Modernist art of the first decades of Estonian Republic, and semi-officially also with the art processes of the West through ordering art journals of the more liberal countries of the Eastern Bloc. Tõnis Vint, then student at the State Art Institute, and a group of other young artists called ANK' 64 (see, for example: Luuk & Trossek 2013) collected art-related information from exchanges of information with unofficial artists in Moscow and Leningrad, where Estonian Ülo Sooster (1924–1970) played an important role, and through the special funds of the State Hermitage Library. Here, Abstraction and Surrealist art became important as a starting point, but soon there was a move further. Vint became a theoretical leader of the new generation of artists, proposing an individual artistic language and wide knowledge of the old and new art as a purpose.

Already in his first theoretical writings published from the end of the 1960s, Tõnis Vint described a synthesis that would unite the values of different art traditions and movements with new elements. He sought models in the early Renaissance and Romanticism, in which art functioned as an integrated whole and provided society with relevant intellectual values and solutions to problems (Vint 1968, pp. 1–5). Vint found the resources for creating an all-encompassing whole in Pop art. In the late 1960s and during the 1970s he was introducing it in articles (Vint 1971, pp. 38–43) and indirectly in artworks, seeking to create on its basis an artistic language both for fine and applied graphic arts. For Vint, Pop art had a different meaning than its Western origins, criticising consumer society. Under Soviet conditions, where a consumer society was basically non-existent and its mediocre objects were made attractive only by the deficits, Pop aesthetics provided a constructive resource for making the environment more pleasant and integrated.

Experiments with Pop art by Tõnis Vint had more in common with the psychedelic subculture of the flower children, which tried to unite aspects of Oriental and Western cultures. Thus, motifs of Oriental symbolism had a Pop-like effect in Vint's works. Stylised images and bright colours on a minimalist background were both decorative and



Fig. 3. Morning. 1970. Ink, gouache. Art Museum of Estonia



Fig. 4. Exhibition poster *Soviet Estonian Painting 1965–1969*. 1970

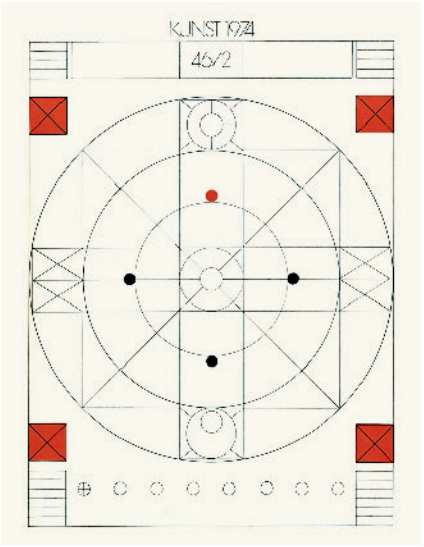


Fig. 5. *Kunst* almanac, cover design from 1974

innovative. Serialised and widely circulated graphic designs gave the opportunity for the aesthetization of the everyday environment through its individual objects, which found a larger audience than artworks at exhibitions. Vint's first programmatic texts already emphasise the need to take the experience of earlier art traditions into account, by putting them into practice at a new level. At the end of the 1960s and in the



Fig. 6–7. Pages from the colouring book *Into the Year 2000* (Tallinn: Kunst, 1972)

1970s, Vint combined Pop art with Rococo, *Art Nouveau*, Art Deco and Oriental aesthetics, as well as minimalist Modernist forms. This blend of traditional and modernist aesthetics was seemingly dealing with purely aesthetical problems (which could still be persecuted), but it was the ideological neutrality that was significant: ignoring the Soviet reality, refusing to participate in propaganda or even smuggling Estonian national colours – blue-black-white – as signs of silent resistance.

Seeking principles valid in both pictorial space and the real environment, Tõnis Vint proposed "Pop Jugendstil" as a new style and used again the smuggling method when the children colouring book *Into the Year 2000* (1973) became his aesthetical manifesto (Vint 1973). The goal was to introduce the ideas of modern aesthetic that could be realised in the home environment, urban and outer space. In cityscapes, Vint depicted buildings inspired by the architecture of Antoni Gaudí and Kenzo Tange, as well as by motifs from the paintings of Hieronymus Bosch. Being up-to-date with the latest developments, Vint

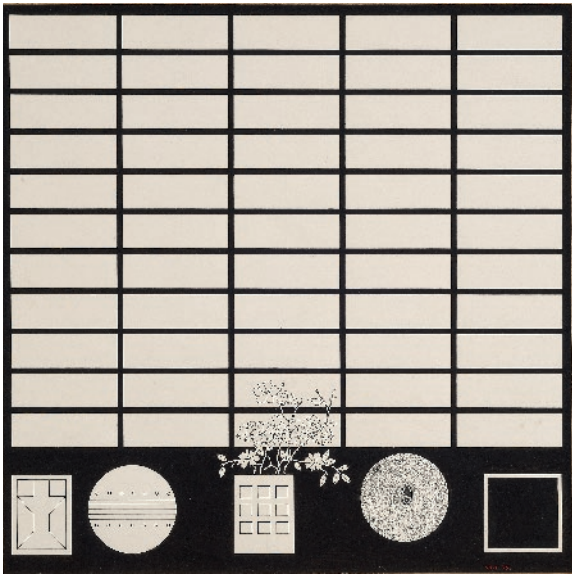


Fig. 8. Japanese Room. Things. 1975. Ink, gouache. Art Museum of Estonia

also took into account earlier development cycles. In the depictions of future interiors, along with the new Japanese-style design introduced by the Eastern German magazine *Schönen Wohnen* (Kaalep 2000), he used *Art Nouveau* and Art Deco elements as well as traditional Japanese aesthetics, creating a multilayered synthesis.



Fig. 9. Interior views of Tõnis and Mare Vint's Mustamäe flat. At the table are Lili Maas and Mare Vint. 1973. Photo: Jaan Klõšeiko

This synthesis has found embodiment in Tõnis and Mare Vints' flat on Sõpruse Blvd. in Mustamäe district of Tallinn. In the late 1960s and early 1970s, the flat was given a total interior design based on the ideal of Japanese living space, which, in Tõnis Vint's view, functioned as an integrated organism – compact and wholesome. In the philosophy of the Orient, the core concept for the artist was empty space or the void: not nothingness, but absolute space and a constructive seed. Vint is considered to be one of the first to deal with the problem of the void in Estonian visual arts and architecture (Lapin 2002, p. 4). His minimalist prints and ink drawings look like models for something larger, which extends beyond the pictorial space to the real environment. In the interiors depicted in Vint's compositions, we see an elegant chandelier or a mirror, which have a symbolic effect, and are familiar from his flat. The artist offers also more general structures for the ordering of space like geometric-shaped shelves. Even his abstract compositions recall the interior views of his home. We see here an aspiration to create universal structures functioning both inside and outside the pictorial space, as a principle of formal and symbolic balance (Fig. 8–9).

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Tõnis Vint believed in a possibility of a universal aesthetic-symbolic system which would serve as a basis for the interpretation of all kinds of visual phenomena as well as for creation of new visual structures with positive influence both on an individual and processes in society. While the first aspect is related to the myth of the perfect language (see, for example: Eco 1997), the second reflects the myths of the total work of art. The latter allows to discuss Vint's art practices in relation to the Wagnerian *Gesamtkunstwerk* in Romanticism and the avant-garde projects of the early 20th century. The belief that a consistent aesthetic environment can positively reshape the society was a part of the avant-garde ideology, with the myth of the artist-demiurge – creator of a new aesthetic universe – as a catalyst. The new aesthetic totalities were to transcend the borderline between art and life – not just to depict the world, but to transform it.

The concept of a total work of art (*Gesamtkunstwerk*, in German) as the synthesis of different art forms was most explicitly formulated by Richard Wagner (1813–1883) in the middle of the 19th century. Wagner's concept was not merely aesthetic, but also social and political. He saw a great revolution and an ideal society coming where, thanks to the new education, everyone would be an artist. But only the total work of art would create the conditions for social transformations, increasing awareness of the need for great changes (Wagner 1848). In his "music dramas," Wagner combined the plots of European myths and legends with innovative musical and technical solutions, sometimes comparable to contemporary multimedia performances. However, he subsequently gave up his revolutionary rhetoric and devoted himself to the creation of total stage mysteries, detached from everyday reality (see, for example: Smith 2007; Koss 2010).

Wagner's ideas had a great influence on German art at the end of the 19th and beginning of the 20th centuries. Thus, the Jugendstil (Art Nouveau) movement involved elements of material culture constituting a uniform aesthetic environment (West 2004, pp. 27–29). The idea of a total work of art, though, grew into a general cultural concept in its time, an aesthetic and often social ideal. Wagner's British contemporary William Morris (1834–1896) represents an independent development of the idea of synthesis in the conception of total design. Inspired by the romanticised vision of mediaeval society and contemporary socialist ideas, Morris elaborated a utopia in which humane production conditions and a harmonious living environment – integrated decorative arts, interior design and

architecture – would stimulate the renewal of society (see, for example: Ormison & Wells 2013). At the beginning of the 20th century, the idea of the total work of art was a catalyst for various Avant-Garde experiments. Transcending borders between different art fields, and between art and life, they were intended to reform society through art.

In Estonian art historical writing, the conception of the total work of art was thematized by Andres Kurg (Kurg 2009) and Mari Laanemets (Laanemets 2010), who associated the ideology of the total work of art primarily with Art Nouveau and the ideas of Morris, and through this prism discussed alternative artistic, design and architectural practices, as well as social interventions in Estonia in the 1970s. These issues are also topical in Tõnis Vint's work, in which social goals are less obvious than the aesthetic ones, but present nevertheless. Here, another distinctive feature evolves not only proceeding from aesthetic or social goals but also relying on an individual symbolic system that can be described as artistic mythology.

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In Vint's aesthetic totality we can see clear influences of Carl G. Jung's archetype theory. A very important agent here is the mandala, which depicts the integrity of both the universe and the individual, and is a device for finding that integrity. The potential of mandala lies in the symmetrical structures with an emphasised central point. In his conceptual project, *Mandala House*, Vint used the symbolic structure of Oriental mandalas for the floor plan. The mandala house was to function three-dimensionally – "moving through it would become a kind of meditation" (Laanemets 2008, p. 95) – as well as two-dimensionally, as an image for meditation. Vint's artworks were devoted to making mandala-like images with a positive effect on the viewer: expressing ideas of concentration, balance and activity. In the stage design for Rabindranath Tagore's play *The Post Office* (1982, fig. 10), the focus was on the lattice structure as a source of concentration, while the warm glowing colours were supposed to "feed" positive energy to the audience.

The social optimism that arose after the restoration of Estonia's independence was followed by Tõnis Vint's more direct and large-scale interventions. In his articles and by participating in architectural competitions, he proposed several projects for reforming the symbols and the urban space related to the new identity of the state. For example, in the first half of the 1990s, Vint introduced his development vision for the Naissaar island (Fig. 11) in the Tallinn Bay, where he suggested to

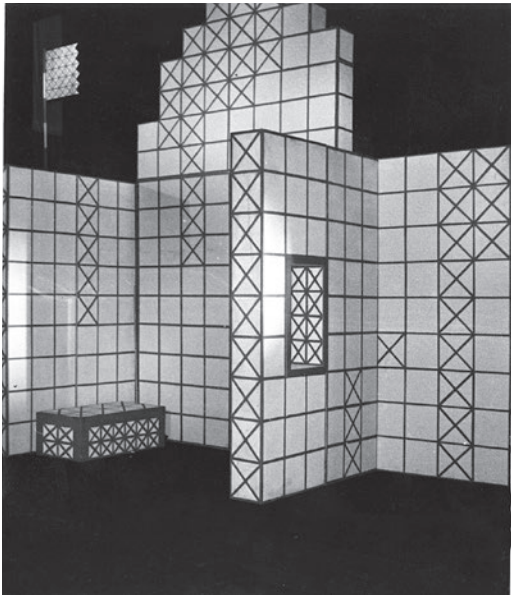


Fig. 10. Stage design for the production of Rabindranath Tagore's *The Post Office* (1983, The Tallinn State Drama Theatre, director Juhan Viiding). 1983. Ink, gouache. Photo: private collection



Fig. 11. Development vision for the Naissaar island from the article "Naissaar. Vision of the Future" (*Ehituskunst* 1995/11, pp. 4–10)

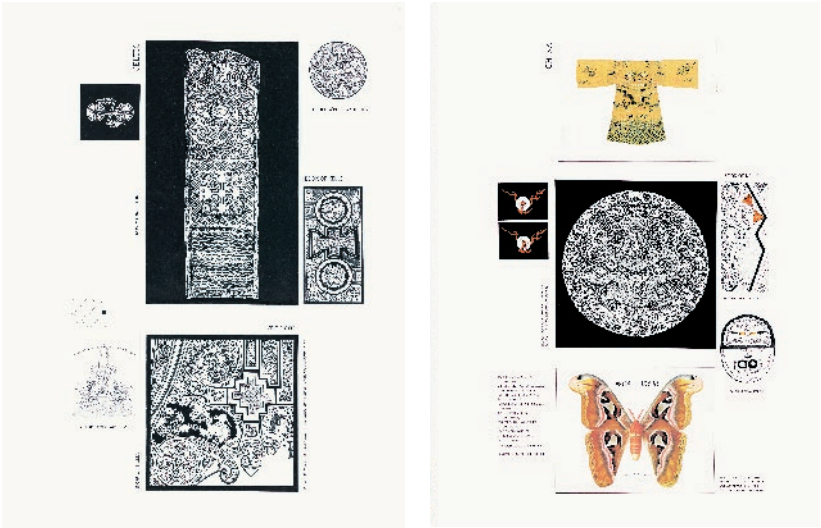


Fig. 12–13. Theoretical charts from the exhibition *Two Realities*. 2007. Private collection

establish an international centre for culture and tourism (Vint 1995). He was relying on his own geomantic analysis of the territory and suggested that skyscrapers would have a good influence, activating the energy of the place. Still, none of Vint's futuristic visions found enough resonance nor was accomplished.

Back to the Soviet period, Vints' home was in sharp contrast to the anonymous environment of Mustamäe district, like a refuge that ignored everything surrounding it. As the art historian Sirje Helme characterised it: "Tõnis Vint's stubborn attempt to create a spiritual atmosphere and physical space around him, which would have nothing to do with the society in which he lived [...], represented a model of an unofficial art lifestyle. [...] Tõnis Vint's high-minded absence, living in his own time, was a form of resistance." (Helme 2000, pp. 262–263). The artist lived in an environment created with the help of his aesthetic system. Vint dealt with problems that transcend history and reality, by creating a hermetic and all-encompassing theory which only he could totally comprehend and manage (Fig. 12–13). Still, he was always eager to share his knowledge, which reveals a certain sense of mission. His home functioned as a platform for the unofficial art life, providing a venue for meetings of the local intelligentsia and hosting foreign visitors for discussions and information exchange. Starting in

the 1960s and basically until the last years of his life, Vint held open lectures which became a source of alternative knowledge for the representatives of several generations.

Since the early 1970s, Vint shared his ideas in publications and graphic designs, introducing for the first time several artists and art phenomena that were not really approved by the official Soviet art doctrine – and sometimes faced elimination by the censorship. Vint's texts and graphic designs functioned as a platform for the introduction of his ideas in theory and practice, testing new aesthetic principles along with the direct and indirect transmission of information. For example, he used mandala-like symbolic structures, thus smuggling alternative knowledge he believed would be perceived subconsciously. This function of a suggestive visual information transmission was also very important in the documentary *Lielvārde Belt* (1980, Riga Film Studio, director Ansis Epners) that introduced Vint's sign system through cinematic language



Fig. 14. Example of Tõnis Vint's comparative sign systems analysis: visual equivalents of the Big Bang in the ornamental systems of the Lielvārde belt and a miniature from The Book of Kells

and montage technique for juxtaposing different images, demonstrating their similarity via allowing them to "grow" one into another. The focus was on the parallels between the Baltic ornamental systems and those in other cultures, stressing the ability of ornament to express universal processes, for example, the Big Bang (Fig. 14).

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So far, mainly geometric artworks by Tõnis Vint have been discussed, but there was another strong line – symbolist figurative compositions. Here, in a dream-like atmosphere a mysterious female figure was ascribed the function of Jungian *anima* – the guide to the collective unconscious and discovery of the Self (Jung 1997a, p. 70). The events depicted are mostly not easy to verbalise, but they are suggestive visually, creating an impression of estrangement and even otherworldliness, where, for instance, a mirror is a symbol of another reality. The philosophical basis for this aspiration can be found in Jung's description of the process of individuation, where, in addition to rational consciousness and reason, a person's goal should find contact with the collective unconscious as the essential human state through which it is possible to know oneself and achieve individual

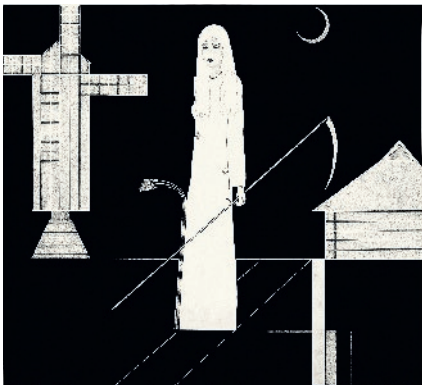


Fig. 15. The Month of Harvest I. 1982. Ink, gouache. Private collection



Fig. 16. The Month of Harvest II. 1982. Ink, gouache. Art Museum of Estonia

integrity. Jung's psychoanalysis considers dreams as one possible process of experiencing the unconscious: the key role here belongs to the suggestive and mysterious feeling of isolation, which creates a resonating psychological mood.

Tõnis Vint seemed to be staging scenes with this mysterious dream-like atmosphere in his works, interweaving here also references to his sign theory. In the two-part graphic work *The Month of Harvest Month* (1982, Fig. 15–16), the symbolism of two worlds is expressed in the structure of both compositions, reflecting Vint's concept of pictorial semantics inspired by Oriental art: "[...] the left part would be the

masculine beginning, the cosmic whole, the Sky, the Sun and the knowledge, the vision preceding reality. The right part of the image, on the other hand, is the feminine element, the Earth, the Water, the Moon, the energy. This is where reality begins, this is where growth and development start." (Vint 1978) In one of the compositions, there is a mill on the left, and in the other – a gate, both symbols related to the otherworld, while the barn on the right in one artwork could refer to our reality. In the middle of both compositions is a figure of a young woman with a small bundle of grain in her hand or beside her; in one of the works she is holding a sickle – a grain-harvesting tool, also associated with the symbolism of death. There is a new moon in the sky above the woman, even two in one of the artworks.

Jung has interpreted the story of the young goddess Persephone in Greek mythology through the symbolism of the grain: just as Persephone is forced to spend one third of the year in the underworld, ruled by her husband Hades, and returns every Spring to the land of the living, which her mother, the goddess of harvest and agriculture Demeter, makes bloom in her honour, so the grain also stays underground to be reborn and arise on the surface as a new plant. The connections between wedding and death, virginity and the moon have played an important role in the cult of Demeter, but the symbolism of fertility, brought to the cosmic principle, dominated here. The images of the mother separated from her daughter and the cut grain are connected by something inexpressibly painful but also bring comfort: the image of the grain contains the idea of beginning and end, moving from non-existence to being and from the individual to the universal. The story of Persephone is also associated with the goddess of Moon, Cybele, and the shape of the sickle cutting the corn also resembles the crescent moon, making the symbolic charge even stronger. (Jung 1997b, pp. 122–149) Probably that's why in Estonian, as in several other languages, there is one word both for "sickle" and "crescent moon".

Motives of waning and waxing of the moon are also connected to the idea of rebirth – alongside the symbols of death discussed above, Tõnis Vint's compositions feature the new moon, a symbol of rebirth. The image of a mill resembling a cross can be interpreted as a symbol of cosmic cyclicity, which has an important place in the author's philosophical system. The young woman's journey from the right part of the composition to the left can be interpreted morbidly as a movement into the otherworld, but parallels can also be found in the Jungian approach to conscious and unconscious – the path shown by the *anima* towards the dark other reality can also be a way for an individual to get to know him/herself. Vint's characters seem to be at a borderline point

in the personal evolution, after which "a break (through) in the path of development, the creation of the individual and growth towards personal illusions" (Vint 1978) can occur. Thus, the works by Vint contain references to both micro- and macrocosmic processes.

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In conclusion, we can trace how, relying on his erudition in the art traditions of various cultures and periods, Vint has created a conceptual platform for the interpretation and synthesis of various visual phenomena. Vint's aesthetic system was based on his research on visual sign systems from America to Australia and from the ancient to the present time. In all cultures, he was interested in proto-images interpreted as universal cosmogonic symbols: elements of a common worldview and a means of shared signification. Vint did not limit himself to art, including ethnographic objects, historical artefacts (e.g., Tarot cards) and visual practices linked to different knowledge systems (the Chinese *Book of Changes* or *I Ching*, geomancy, alchemy, scientific illustrations from different eras and much more). His approach was somewhat similar to the visual culture studies, which emerged as a novel discipline in the West in the 1970s, but in the Soviet context – as an autonomous practice of a non-academician – it was particularly remarkable. Also, it is remarkable how dealing with seemingly neutral, so to say, timeless issues was at the same time evaluating Estonian and Baltic ethnographic heritage that supported the national identity. Thus, Tõnis Vint's ideas contrasted the threat of the Soviet assimilation and were part of the national awakening of the 1980s.

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AI (RE)IMAGININGS: FRICTIONLESS MYTHS OF PAST AND FUTURE

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the epistemic shift produced by the rise of AI-generated "historical" imagery on social media, arguing that generative systems increasingly reconfigure collective memory through the production of what are here termed frictionless myths. Drawing on qualitative visual analysis and critical media theory, the study analyses popular AI-generated history accounts to show how an aesthetic of synthetic realism produces immersive, visually coherent representations that frequently sanitise the past and project speculative futures, downplaying trauma and violence in favour of spectacle and narrative legibility.

To account for this transformation, the paper introduces the concept of operational indexicality, proposing that AI-generated images function not as traces of historical events but as indices of algorithmic processes, training data, and dominant visual conventions. The article concludes by reflecting on the implications of this emergent visual grammar for documentary truth and the reproduction of colonial power relations in the age of synthetic media.

Keywords: operational indexicality, algorithmic memory, generative AI, aesthetic sanitisation, imperial shutter

INTRODUCTION

This article examines the proliferation of AI-generated historical re-enactments circulating on social media. Accounts such as @alookbackintohistory, @historyrevivedofficial, and @salvagedhistoryai have amassed millions of views by posting hyper-realistic simulations of eras from Ancient Rome to the near-present. These short videos and images present immersive encounters with the past – and its speculative reimaginings – rendered through a visual language that heavily

borrows from documentary photography, cinematic realism, and video game aesthetics. The vantage is typically first-person – as if the viewer is walking through a medieval market, lying in a Civil War trench, or standing in a WWII square. This framing invites immediate identification: the viewer is positioned as the protagonist. Unlike the fragmented, complex, and often traumatic nature of the archival record, AI-generated history is smooth, visually coherent, and narratively compressed. Past events are rendered as readily consumable experiences, systematically stripped of the material contingencies that characterise actual historical documentation.

This phenomenon signals the rise of a new form of historical spectacle. The term *frictionless* refers to both the ultra-smooth aesthetic finish of these images and their apparent ease of production – a seeming effortlessness that actively conceals what Kate Crawford terms "systems of extraction" (2021, 18): vast energy use, exploited labour, and rare minerals hidden in data centres and hardware supply chains. I argue that these frictionless myths are not mere entertainment, but active sites of ideological production. They immerse audiences in a past that is systematically sanitised; narrative compression and visual cohesion displace complexity, obscuring the conflicts, traumas, and injustices that infuse lived history.

This trend exemplifies a broader epistemic shift in visual culture. AI-generated images can be understood as part of a move away from the classical regime of photographic meaning-making – where images indexed a reality that once existed – toward a networked regime (Petraitis, 2024, 128) in which images operate as fluid, distributed entities embedded within computational and cultural infrastructures. Within this scheme, images no longer point solely to past referents but circulate as nodes within contemporary visual, cultural, and computational imaginaries.

To explore this reconfiguration, I propose the concept of *operational indexicality*: AI-generated images derive meaning less from contact with profilmic events than from the computational operations, datasets, and visual norms that produce them. This concept builds on C. S. Peirce's semiotics while directly accounting for the uniquely computational character of AI-generated imagery. Read alongside Ariella Azoulay's notion of the imperial shutter – which describes how photographic technologies have historically organised visibility through colonial power – operational indexicality highlights how generative systems simultaneously perform photographic realism and dictate what can be made legible in the first place. Together, these theoretical lenses orient an analysis of how AI-generated historical imagery remakes visual evidence: not as

testimony to events, but as algorithmically plausible narratives. To illustrate these mechanisms, the following sections examine three specific cases: a sequence of United States history, a viral future-historical reimagining of Gaza, and synthetic depictions of Biblical figures. While these examples might initially appear to be somewhat extreme or atypical manifestations of AI-generated history, they are in fact profoundly paradigmatic. They lay bare the deep structural processes through which generative systems flatten historical complexity and fundamentally reconfigure collective memory.

METHODOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK

The study uses a qualitative, critical-media approach grounded in digital ethnography and close visual analysis. The primary corpus consists of AI-generated historical images and videos collected between April and December 2025 from highly visible social media accounts: @alookbackintohistory (over 600,000 Instagram subscribers), @historyrevivedofficial (approximately 2 million Facebook subscribers), @salvagedhistoryai (over 160,000 TikTok subscribers), @temporaltimelens (approximately 80,000 Facebook subscribers), and religiously oriented account @holyvlogsz (over 700,000 subscribers across TikTok and Instagram). These accounts were selected through purposive sampling based on their significant reach, regular posting frequency, explicit engagement with historical reconstruction, and paradigmatic representation of the frictionless aesthetic under analysis.

The analytical framework triangulates formal visual analysis – examining recurring aesthetic features such as composition, lighting, and texture – with a semiotic interrogation of indexicality grounded in an expansive reading of Peirce's theory. This structural reading is complemented by discourse analysis of captions, hashtags, and user framing in order to examine how historical authority and authenticity are rhetorically constructed and negotiated. Selected case studies, including the "Trump Gaza" and "Evolution of the United States" videos, are analysed as exemplary instances of frictionless myth-making, in which narrative compression and affective smoothing transform historically contingent events into visually coherent, ideologically neutralised spectacles.

The proprietary nature of contemporary generative models introduces a methodological constraint. Following Pasquale (2015) and Bridle (2018), this study treats the algorithmic "black box" not merely as an obstacle to analysis, but as a constitutive feature of the medium itself. Because training data and model architectures remain largely

inaccessible, the analysis necessarily adopts an interpretive approach that infers operational logics from visual output. In doing so, it navigates the tension between what is rendered visible in the image and the invisible computational processes that shape its production, treating this opacity as central to understanding how meaning is synthesised.

FROM TRACE TO OPERATION: RECONSIDERING INDEXICALITY

Understanding the epistemic implications of AI-generated historical imagery requires situating it within a longer trajectory of photographic transformation. Classical theories of photography have long understood the photograph as indexical: a trace produced through the supposedly physical registration of light reflected from a referent. Within this framework, photographic meaning derives not only from visual resemblance but from an existential relationship to an event that once occurred. Roland Barthes famously condensed this logic in the formulation *ça a été* (1981) – the photograph as a certificate of presence attesting that "this has been". The epistemic authority of photography rested on its presumed mechanical objectivity and its anchoring in a specific moment in time.

This conception, however, has never been entirely stable. Well before the emergence of generative AI, the transition to digital photography had already unsettled photography's indexical foundations. The conversion of light into data weakened the presumed direct material continuity between image and referent, replacing physical inscription with computational mediation. As digital images became embedded within networked infrastructures, their meaning increasingly depended not only on their relation to a singular moment or event, but on their circulation, recombination, and visibility within broader systems of storage and exchange. Images ceased to function primarily as discrete documents and instead operated as relational entities within expanding visual networks.

It is at this point that AI-generated imagery marks a further and more decisive shift. As Amanda Wasielewski argues, AI images simulate photographic appearance while bypassing photography's ontological foundations. They emerge through statistical inference across large image datasets, producing what she terms "unnatural images" – technically photographic in appearance but fundamentally statistical composites that never existed (2024). Unlike photography, which records light reflected from a specific referent, AI-generated images are produced

through probabilistic synthesis. They appear photographic not because they record the world, but because they successfully reproduce the visual codes through which photography has historically come to signify realism and evidentiary value.

This shift has significant epistemological implications. Whereas photographic images once functioned as evidentiary anchors within historical discourse, AI-generated images sever the link between visual appearance and historical occurrence. Although they conform closely to conventions of photographic realism, they document nothing beyond the computational processes that produced them. Visual plausibility thus replaces historical specificity. What appears as photographic realism is in fact statistical realism – a probabilistic averaging of dominant visual patterns across training data. The image functions less as evidence than as a persuasive surface optimised for what Wasielewski terms "seamless photographic appearance" (2024, 3).

It is within this transformation that operational indexicality becomes a productive analytical tool. The term designates a mode of signification in which images derive meaning not from a referential connection to a profilmic event, but from the operations, datasets, and technical procedures that generate them. Operational indexicality thus aims not at what AI-generated images show, but how meaning is structurally produced when historical representation becomes a function of computation rather than encounter. It is not proposed as a total theory of AI imagery, but as an analytical lens for understanding how such images produce meaning through their conditions of production rather than through evidentiary trace. Rather than strictly pointing to a single past referent, AI images index the operations that produce them: training data, model architectures, statistical correlations, and embedded visual norms.

This operational logic both shapes the visual grammar through which historical scenes are rendered and reconfigures the role of the image-maker. AI-generated imagery consistently favours immersive, first-person perspectives, cinematic lighting, and polished compositional coherence. Visual friction is routinely minimised: the result is a mode of historical visualisation that invites viewer identification, while visually privileging affective immediacy over critical complexity. The image-maker here becomes a co-producer. Following Annet Dekker and Gaia Tedone (2019), the operators of AI-generated visual history accounts can be understood not as autonomous authors but as practitioners of networked co-curation. The image is not produced by a single agent but emerges from an opaque alliance between human intent and a machinic system. The human supplies direction through a prompt, while

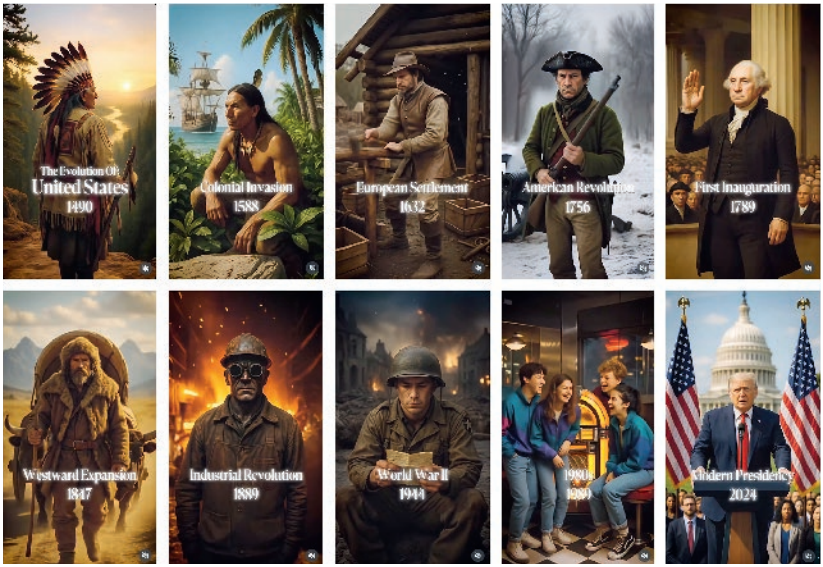


Fig. 1. Screenshots from the Instagram account @alookbackintohistory, post titled "The Evolution of the United States of America" (May 17, 2025).

the machinic agent executes the visualisation according to its own structural dependencies – most notably, the statistical imperative to smooth variation and maximise coherence. The resulting image is co-produced through an asymmetrical relation in which historical representation is shaped as much by algorithmic constraint as by human input.

EXTENDING THE IMPERIAL SHUTTER

At this point, Ariella Azoulay's concept of the imperial shutter helps to clarify the political dimensions of this shift. Azoulay has argued that the photographic apparatus was never a neutral recording device, but an inherently political technology that structured visibility along imperial lines – rendering certain lives visible while excluding others from the field of representation (2019). This exclusion operated not necessarily through explicit censorship, but through habitual visual conventions that normalised imperial perspectives and marginalised colonial violence.

AI-generated imagery automates, rather than merely extends, this logic. The selection and recombination processes embedded in generative systems reproduce dominant visual norms while excluding forms of

representation that fall outside the parameters of statistical regularity. In this sense, the "imperial shutter" no longer resides in a mechanical apparatus or a human editorial decision; it is distributed across datasets, model architectures, and platform infrastructures. What is rendered visible is not merely what is most probable, but what is most compatible with existing visual economies of recognisability, legibility, and appeal.

Seen through this lens, AI-generated historical images represent a shift from trace to operation, and from documentation to simulation. Their authority derives not from having witnessed the past, but from their ability to convincingly perform a specific visual language. The result is an image that appears evidentiary while remaining detached from historical referentiality – a development that fundamentally reconfigures the epistemic status of visual evidence in the age of generative media.

The training data underpinning widely used image-generation models (such as Midjourney, Sora, or Runway) approximate what might be described as an "imperial archive" of the internet. This archive is assembled through large-scale scraping and optimisation processes already shaped by Western, colonial, and capitalist visual regimes. Within this framework, the model operates as a hyper-efficient shutter, systematically privileging images that conform to dominant aesthetic norms of beauty, order, and safety, while excluding and minimising representations associated with disorder, suffering, or political rupture.

Azoulay defines the shutter as drawing three decisive dividing lines: a line in time (separating before from after, relegating violence to a sealed past); a line in space (separating the subject who looks from the object photographed); and a line in the body politic (dividing governors, who possess the "right to look", from the governed, who are looked at) (2019). In AI-generated imagery, these three lines are further entrenched through computational automation.

Consider "The Evolution of United States from 1490 to today" video (see Figure 1) posted by @alookbackintohistory on May 17, 2025. This sequence of AI-generated scenes presents a smooth, visually coherent narrative of national progress, unified by warm, cinematic lighting and seamless temporal transitions. Yet the historical transition from Indigenous societies to European colonisation – labelled simply as "European settlement" – is markedly devoid of conflict, dispossession, or genocide. Slavery constitutes another conspicuous absence. A scene titled "Westward expansion 1847" centres a white male figure heroically framed against a vast, picturesque landscape, reproducing a familiar settler-colonial fantasy while entirely effacing Indigenous struggle.

The sequence concludes with "Modern Presidency", depicting Donald Trump delivering a speech before the US Capitol, surrounded by American flags. This ending positions contemporary state power as the natural culmination of the preceding narrative, effectively validating the erasures that made it possible. Rather than offering a comprehensive account, the sequence enacts all three imperial divisions. Temporally, it seals colonisation as an accomplished fact – the Indigenous displacement appears as a completed historical stage rather than ongoing dispossession. Spatially, the "Westward expansion" scene transforms the occupied land into an extractable resource, allowing the viewer to identify with the sovereign position of the settler. Politically, visibility is allocated asymmetrically: expansionistic settler narratives appear in high-resolution detail, while Indigenous resistance and enslaved lives remain systematically invisible.

SLOPAGANDA AND THE POLITICS OF AESTHETIC DISPLACEMENT

When AI-generated historical imagery enters overtly ideological circulation, its operational logic becomes legible as a direct political strategy. Gareth Watkins's development of the concept of "slopaganda" names the large-scale circulation of mass-produced AI content that overwhelms information environments not through explicit falsehood but through affective saturation (2025). Unlike 20th-century propaganda, which sought to convince through repetitive messaging, slopaganda operates by generating such overwhelming quantities of visually coherent, emotionally satisfying content that critical evaluation becomes cognitively expensive. The frictionless myth succeeds partly because truth-evaluation feels burdensome compared to the ease and allure of visual consumption.

The viral "Trump Gaza" video (see Figure 2) exemplifies this mechanism. First circulated in early 2025 and subsequently amplified by Donald Trump on Truth Social, the video algorithmically reimagines Gaza – a tragic site of displacement, starvation, and mass civilian casualties – as a gleaming hyper-capitalist utopia. Rubble dissolves into pristine beaches; destroyed neighbourhoods transform into luxury hotels; human suffering vanishes beneath gold statues and choreographed abundance. The video deploys affective realism – smooth camera movement, spatial continuity, high-resolution detail – to legitimise a scenario with no basis in present conditions.



Fig. 2. Screenshots from the AI-generated "Trump Gaza" video shared on Donald Trump's Truth Social account (February 2025).

This operates as a form of aesthetic displacement: political violence is not explicitly denied; it is visually substituted. The video does not argue against the existence of humanitarian catastrophe; it simply renders it invisible through visual excess. As Safiya Umoja Noble observes, algorithmic systems systematically privilege commercially viable representations of success over depictions of systemic violence (2018, 26). The logic here is extractive: suffering becomes raw material transformed into consumable fantasy through generative processing.

Read through operational indexicality, the video indexes not a plausible future but a contemporary political imaginary wherein policy solutions are replaced by spectacle. It demonstrates how AI-generated imagery enables political actors to bypass material accountability through aesthetic substitution – a visual resolution to a political crisis that requires no diplomacy, no justice, and no reckoning with actual conditions. This is slopaganda's core mechanism, displacement operating through three simultaneous registers:

temporal displacement: projecting an idealised future to obscure present violence, effectively "solving" the Gaza crisis through algorithmic time-travel that renders current suffering merely transitional.

representational displacement: reframing Gaza from humanitarian crisis to investment opportunity, from a site of occupation to a blank canvas for development – embodying what Azoulay theorises as the imperial gaze that transforms colonised land into exploitable resource (2019).

affective displacement: substituting political-ethical complexity (accountability, justice, historical reckoning) with simple emotional satisfaction (wonder, aspiration, aesthetic pleasure). The video invites viewers not to think critically about Gaza, but to feel good about its imagined transformation.

Crucially, this displacement is not merely the product of deliberate ideological design; it is structurally encoded within the convergence of commercial platform logic (engagement optimisation), Western-centric training data (where luxury aesthetics function as a universal aspiration), and user demand for visually pleasing content. Operational indexicality demonstrates that the frictionless myth emerges systematically from AI's processual conditions, making it simultaneously pervasive and exceedingly difficult to challenge.

THE MEDIATED SACRED

The algorithmic reworking of sacred narratives reveals operational indexicality's infrastructural implications. The popular TikTok and Instagram account @holyvlogsz exemplifies an emerging "Biblical AI" subgenre that recodes scripture through platform aesthetics. The account's tagline announces its intent: "Biblical stories reimagined. Where faith meets cinematic beauty". Generated using Google's Veo 3, videos reimagine Biblical figures as contemporary influencers: "If David went on a Podcast…", "If Moses had an iPhone…", "If Daniel had an iPhone…" (see Figure 3).

The devotional intent of the creators and audience appears sincere. One highly upvoted comment reads: "Jokes aside this is actually teaching me Abt [sic] the Bible" (14,019 likes). Yet this sincere mediation produces what might be termed statistical profanation – not a mockery of the sacred, but its operational equivalence to the mundane. Generative AI models process sacred rituals, traumatic events, and religious icons using the exact same mechanisms applied to images of cats or cars (Wasielewski, 2024). Each image, regardless of theological significance, is processed as numerical tokens, embedded in vector space, made available for statistical recombination. The profanation is infrastructural: model architectures optimised for general-purpose synthesis treat all visual input as ontologically equivalent raw material.

As Gensburger and Clavert argue, generative AI functions less as a medium of memory than as an infrastructure that reorganises the past according to computational principles (2024). Rather than sustaining narrative or theological complexity, such systems reorder historical



Fig. 3. Screenshots from the TikTok account @holyvlogsz. Top row captions: "If the Bible had street interviews…," "If David had an iPhone…," "If Daniel had an iPhone…". Bottom row captions: "If Cain and Abel were influencers…," "If Lot's Wife had an iPhone…," "If Noah went on a Podcast…," and "If Noah had an iPhone…".

material according to statistical logics of optimisation. In this sense, sacred imagery is recalculated – rendered legible only insofar as it conforms to the operational demands of the system.

When a model generates "Moses preaching", it retrieves a statistical composite: the averaged result of all images tagged "Moses" in its training data, which is necessarily weighted toward Western European artistic traditions, Hollywood Biblical epics, and contemporary Christian media. User responses occasionally reveal an acute awareness of this averaging. The video "If the Bible was filmed like TikToks…" prompted a highly upvoted comment: "WHY....WHY...WHY are they all WHITE?!?!" (14,661 likes). This points to both audience recognition of algorithmic bias and the system's structural reproduction of Eurocentric norms. As Crawford argues, training datasets enforce simplified taxonomies upon complex narratives (2021) – in this case, reducing first-century Palestine's ethnic diversity to a statistically dominant whiteness. Similarly, the comment "He turned Australian while crossing! Miraculous!" (37,361 likes on "If Moses had an iPhone…") reveals how AI voice synthesis averages toward dominant linguistic patterns. These are not so much technological failures as the structural consequences of statistical optimisation.

This transformation exceeds individual creative intent. The creators of @holyvlogsz are not attempting to desacralise scripture; their project is framed as reverent. Yet, once sacred narratives enter generative systems, they become subject to operational constraints that reconfigure their meaning regardless of intention. As Dekker and Tedone describe,

networked cultural production unfolds through asymmetric co-curation, in which human (devotional) intent encounters algorithmic imperatives that privilege coherence, recognisability, and circulation over ambiguity or depth. In this context, the sacred becomes legible only insofar as it can be rendered statistically coherent.

This is the core of infrastructural profanation. The divine becomes, as it were, normalised – folded into the same computational logic that governs product advertising, lifestyle content, and political spectacle. What disappears in this process is not belief, but distance. The theological gap that once sustained reverence is flattened by systems that treat the past not as a narrative to be interpreted, but as data to be aligned. Sacred time collapses into platform time, and transcendence becomes scrollable.

Where the "Trump Gaza" video displaced political violence with luxury fantasy, and the "Evolution of United States" video displaced genocide with heroic settlement, @holyvlogsz displaces theological transcendence with influencer accessibility. In each case, the frictionless myth succeeds through aesthetic substitution: what cannot be smoothly rendered becomes systematically invisible. Recognising this also clarifies what is at stake. If AI-generated sacred imagery indexes the platform present – optimisation functions, engagement metrics, and composite datasets – rather than the sacred past, critical analysis must insist on exposing what these systems structurally mask, even while acknowledging the real affective power these images hold for audiences.

CONCLUSIONS

This article has argued that AI-generated historical imagery marks a decisive epistemic shift in the visual mediation of collective memory. Through the concept of operational indexicality, it has shown that such images do not index past events but rather the algorithmic operations, training datasets, and visual conventions that structure their production. What these images reveal, therefore, is less the past itself than the contemporary regimes of visibility through which the past is rendered intelligible.

By privileging recognisability and circulation over ambiguity or depth, AI-generated histories systematically sanitise conflict and compress complexity, transforming history into a frictionless and readily consumable spectacle. In doing so, they reconfigure the conditions under which historical knowledge is produced and authorised. As generative

systems increasingly automate the creation of persuasive historical imagery at scale, they risk displacing human interpretive labour with algorithmic plausibility, substituting rigorous historical inquiry with mere aesthetic legibility.

In this context, AI-generated historical images must be approached not as transparent reconstructions but as operational artefacts. Attending to their smoothness, coherence, and anachronistic clarity allows them to be read not as neutral representations of the past, but as symptoms of a broader epistemic transformation in which visual credibility competes with historical truth. As James Bridle warns, such systems risk ushering in a "new dark age" in which computational representations supersede evidence and interpretation, rendering the past increasingly opaque to human critique.

The task of critical scholarship, then, is not simply to expose factual inaccuracies, but to reintroduce friction into an increasingly seamless visual economy: to insist on the material, political, and epistemic complexities that algorithmic systems are structurally inclined to erase. Only by recognising AI-generated historical imagery as operational rather than evidentiary can we begin to successfully contest the frictionless myths it produces – and the colonial, extractive logics it continues to reproduce.

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MYTHOLOGY AS THE SOURCE OF NEW ARTISTIC EXPRESSION AT THE TIME OF THE AWAKENING (ATMODA) IN LATVIA

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ABSTRACT

The time of the national Awakening, or Atmoda, (1986–1991) caused great changes in art in Latvia. Some of the most visible artists around the age of thirty were driven by new ideas and implemented them on a large scale and in new forms.

From the mid-80s censorship weakened until it disappeared completely by the end of the 80s. At the same time the ideas of postmodern thinking (theories) were gradually introduced into the Latvian cultural scene.

The typical layers of European and Latvian culture were embodied in well recognizable images taking into account the new sociopolitical situation. Mythology as a source of new expression to some extent shaped the imagery of several important contemporary artists. (Importance here and further will be derived from the interest of international scholars and not-for-profit curators in those artists).

The complex reasons of this particular poetics are the theme of this research, as well as its connection to the "mythology" that was never accepted by the Latvian society at large. The latest mentioned was the so-called Soviet mythology, whose critical processing was another cornerstone of contemporary artists' creativity. The tension between the affirmative use of myths and the postmodern critical distance is one of the most visible features of this period in Latvian contemporary art and it is the main subject of this article. No monograph has been published on the subject matter until now.

The mostly valuable tools to approach the subject matter have been the iconographic and iconological methods, as well as the historical perspective since the theme relates to the past of almost 40 years. The limited amount of text does not allow elaboration on the sociological approach.

Keywords: Latvia, Awakening, art, myth, postmodernism

INTRODUCTION

This article aims to show how myths and archetypes have formed the visible part of the contemporary artistic production of the period in question, approximately from 1987 till 1991.

This period was a time of great and radical changes, which in the Latvian language is known as *Atmoda* or Awakening. The reforms by Mikhail Gorbachev began in the Soviet Union in 1985 gradually went out of control of the ruling Communist Party. In the Baltic republics, the huge mass movements, the Popular Fronts, developed rapidly and led to the restoration of Latvia's statehood in 1991. The process came to the same outcome as in the neighbouring Baltic countries Estonia and Lithuania. It is clear that the Awakening influenced all aspects of society, including art and culture.

During these epic changes, it is evident that artists' attitudes centred around many generalized and powerful topics. The mythological motifs thus appear to be a logical outcome. The changes brought with them not only new attitudes within the new context, but they also caused the re-evaluation of former social ties, including Soviet ideology, mythology and visuality. This double take of the Soviet heritage rapidly became a part of Latvian contemporary art.

1. SOURCES OF RESEARCH

Before expanding on the subject matter preferred by artists, we need to make a brief introduction into the research in this field. Although there are some monographs written in the 21st century which are dedicated to individual artists, there is none on the contemporary art scene of this period, This, however, was compensated by two important shows.

In 2005, the art exhibition *Tresspassers. Contemporary Art. The 80s* (curators Solvita Krese and Māra Traumane) was organized by the Latvian Centre for Contemporary Art (LCCA) in the art museum *Arsenāls* in Riga. Part of it dealt with topics related to mythology. The show included 26 artists and artists' groups. Unfortunately, all the information, images and texts were published in a format that is no longer accessible to the average visitor to the Latvian National Library without the assistance of a qualified specialist. No texts about the exhibition are to be found on the website of the LCCA. Visitors to the *Tresspassers* exhibition will recall installations, huge silkscreens, paintings, documentation of performances in different forms – video, architectural, design as well as sound projects. Photography as an autonomous medium was not included.

The choice of artists was clearly connected with the international context or the interest those artists stirred in the period from 1988 till 1991 among the Western curators and critics.

The second important show *Dismantling the Wall. Latvian Art 1985 – 1991* (curators Līna Birzaka-Priekule, Arta Vārpa, Agnese Zviedre) was organized by the Latvian National Art Museum and it was on display from 2023 till today (2026). This show also devoid of any catalogue or scientific explanation. The exhibition features 29 Latvian artists in all media. The approach is more local since many of the participating artists were of no interest to international exhibition makers of the period in question. No work of the most internationally visible artist of the 90s, Oļegs Tillbergs, is present in this exhibition, unlike *Tresspassers* at which he had a prominent place. On the other hand, photography was largely represented.

The exhibition in the Latvian National Art Museum contained explanatory texts on its website (www.lnmm.lv), emphasizing the view that art itself was at the avant-garde of the Awakening and largely influenced it. To some extent, this may also apply to literature (poetry) and its authors.

This is not true regarding visual arts, the theme of the mentioned exhibition. Before dealing with the interpretation of classical and situational myths as part of the artistic praxis during the Awakening, it is necessary to dispel one popular myth among the younger generation of Latvian art practitioners. This is the myth about the crucial role of artists in the period of historical events.

No artist, no person from the sphere of culture took part in the first open manifestation of civic bravery in the summer of 1987 when a handful of workers from the Latvian city of Liepāja placed flowers at the Freedom Monument to commemorate the 14th of June, the day of mass deportations (by the occupational forces of Soviets) from Latvia to Siberia in 1940. This Liepāja group of human rights defenders gave itself the name of Helsinki 86.

The art historian Sandra Kalniete, outstanding politician of the Awakening and now an active Member of the European Parliament, wrote the following in her memoirs: “How many are those who raised their voice before 1988? Not me. I did not have the courage. I sympathized silently. Like the majority.” (Kalniete 2000, 9)

In 1988, during the Creative Unions Plenary, the only two visual artists who spoke out were the Head of the Artists Union of the Latvian Soviet Socialist Republic Džemma Skulme and her son, artist Juris Dimiters. The Creative Unions Plenary was a gathering of the prominent

members of all the artistic unions and beyond, talking in the spirit of the Awakening about the necessity for change.

Juris Dimiters was one of the socially active poster artists and a stage designer. He could afford the venture since his mother was an essential member of the Soviet elite. Art historian Ramona Umblija wrote about his work decades later: "..Juris Dimiters, with frankly-expressed enthusiasm, took on all the ills tormenting Latvian society: the inhuman and destructive attitude towards nature and the pinheads who were its official advocates; alcoholism, the spoiler of our nation; the gigantic bureaucratic apparatus and its unlimited scope to become the weather-vane for all the winds of governance, and so on." (Umblija 2008, 17)

The above was about the truth that everyone knew and understood. For their part, artists, who began to work in parallel to the Western tendencies, did what they were supposed to do – they created. From the point of view of the observer of the events, it was clear that this oeuvre of theirs was not relevant to the absolute majority of people. It should be underlined that the oeuvre in question was something completely new and even alien to the still Soviet society.

Let us say that their political influence on the larger scale was marginal. New art was to some extent visible, but art did not cause changes. The real changes were achieved by the mass Popular Front (*Tautas Fronte*) movement, its leaders and the organizations of the Baltic diaspora, especially in the United States. By applying the historical method to this particular research, it is necessary to study the numerous memoirs, monographs and compilations about the sociopolitical situation and the political actions during the Awakening.

There is a paradox of history and art history which is undeniable. The person who has found his place in art history books as the utmost reactionary censor of contemporary art, Republican senator of the USA Jesse Helms (Doss 2002, 224), played an absolutely crucial role in the acknowledgment of the rights of the Balts to their free and independent states in the 1980s. The verification of the negative part of this statement is to be found in numerous contemporary art history books, but the positive side of the senator as a civic freedom fighter was witnessed by the author of this article several times in the US Senate at the beginning of the 21st century.

Returning to the exhibitions mentioned above, the first one, *Trespassers* in 2005, comprised art which in 1988 was labelled by West Berlin curators as *Lettische Avantgarde*. The selection by German scholars for the important exhibition *Riga – lettische Avantgarde*, which was on show in West Berlin in 1988, Kiel and Bremen in 1989, underlined

the very contemporary character of artistic production. It was art that developed according to Western trends, mostly with a delay of a decade or even two. The catalogue of the exhibition *Riga – lettische Avantgarde* is one of the rare reliable sources about contemporary Latvian art of the period since it highlights the clear difference between the new tendences and the traditional ones developed during the Soviet era.

The other two group shows of contemporary art to mention have been the historic ones, and both took place in Riga in 1990 in the major *Exhibition Hall Latvija*.

The exhibition *Latvia. 20th century Somersault. 1940–1990* (curator Helēna Demakova) for the first time in Latvia showed installations, and installations only, in a large-scale art manifestation. The exhibition had only a catalogue of sketches.

In the exhibition *Gentle Fluctuations* (curator Ivars Runkovskis), the participants were six painters (friends) who created their works over a whole month in front of the visitors' eyes. In terms of documentation, most important has been the book *Gentle Fluctuations that was* published in 2023.

2. CLASSICAL MYTHOLOGICAL MOTIFS AND THE REWORKING OF SOVIET MYTHOLOGY INTO ART

The important Latvian painter Aija Zariņa (1954–2025) dealt greatly with classical myths, especially with the familiar story about the *Rape of Europa* (Fig. 1). This motif is well known from Greek mythology. The images connected with this theme are repeated many times in the artist's paintings and objects during the period of the Awakening. There is a huge temptation to apply the current understanding of feminist thought in reading these works. Another temptation is to interpret the fate of the occupied Latvia as that of one who has been raped by an overwhelming force.



Fig. 1. Aija Zariņa, *The Rape of Europe*, 1989. Oil on cardboard, 240 x 428 cm. Courtesy: Latvian National Art Museum (LNMM)

A painter as great as Aija Zariņa did not deal exclusively with local stories or local problems, or local histories. Hers were universal attitudes and the problems of painting as such. Art historian Ivars Runkovskis wrote about her *Rape of Europa Nr. 6*: "There is a free narrative here. Flow, playful musicality" (Runkovskis 1989, 47)

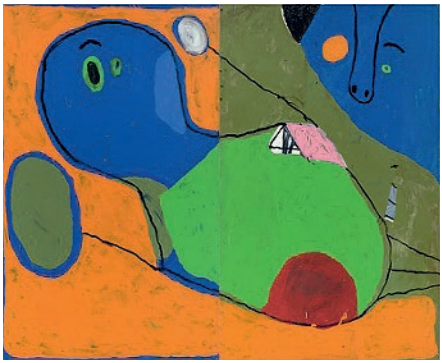


Fig. 2. Aija Zariņa, *The Rape of Europe*, 1989. Oil on cardboard, 240 x 428 cm. Courtesy: LNMM

Aija Zariņa used not only *Rape of Europa* as the mythological motif at the beginning of her career or later. Hers was a vast field of inspiration. Already early on she created *Angel's Conversation with God* (Fig. 2).

We should consider the broader international context where figurative painting came to be *en vogue* since the mid-70s. Latvian artists around 30 years of age, who worked since the 1980s, were very well aware of it, even if they did not use the terms Neo-expressionism, Transavanguardia, or Postmodernism. They converted the energy of change into powerful images, but the themes, motifs and formats were very much influenced by their Western colleagues. The holes in the Iron curtain were large enough for some flow of information from the West.

In 1982, the German scholars Wolfgang Max Faust and Gerd de Vries named this phenomenon of new painting *Hunger nach Bilder* (*Thirst for Paintings* or *Thirst for Images*). Art historian Stephan Schmidt-Wulffen wrote about *Mythologisch malen* (to paint mythologically) (Schmidt-Wulffen, 1987, 49) and about the necessary seduction as the central aesthetic motif as opposed to the art of Enlightenment.

The readings of art occur and continue to take place in the local context and there are some local characteristics which differ from the original motifs or themes. Locally, the outspoken inclination towards metaphors developed during the 1970s. Using all kinds of metaphors, Latvian artists, poets, writers, and filmmakers would employ the so-called Aesopian language to help them avoid Soviet censorship. When

this new trend of painting started to flourish internationally, Latvians were more than receptive.

Another characteristic trait was the previously mentioned energy of change. The author of this article proposes the thesis that the feeling of an unavoidable somersault in society was nourishing artists much more than they influenced the society.

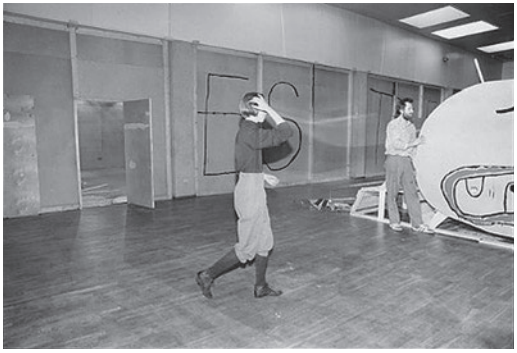


Fig. 3. Aija Zariņa, *The Rape of Europe,* the group show *Latvia. 20th Century's Somersault. Years 1940–1990,* Exhibition Hall *Latvia*, Riga, 1990. Photographer unknown

The energizing atmosphere encouraged artists to adopt a certain naivety and even exaltation. The *Rape of Europa* by Aija Zariņa was made three dimensional in 1990 in the form of a large wooden object of the fallen Bull or Zeus (Fig. 3). This myth was used in the work of the comprehensive group show *Latvia. 20th century Somersault. 1940–1990.* Aija Zariņa's artwork was the centrepiece in the exhibition hall whose walls bore the artist's huge inscription *I LOVE YOU LATVIA!* all around the space.

The mythological motif of the *Rape of Europa* permeated not only the oeuvre of Aija Zariņa*. Rape of Europa* by another avant-gardist (to use the terminology of German curators) Kirils Šmeļkovs (Fig. 4) had

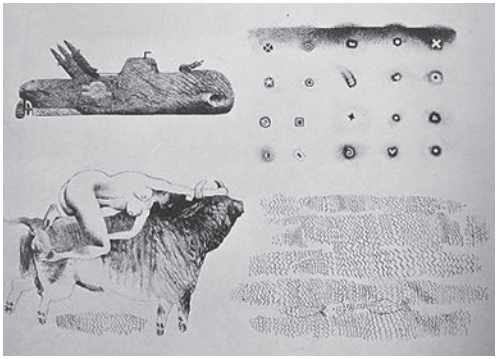


Fig. 4. Kirils Šmeļkovs, *The Rape of Europe*, 1980. Lithography, 30 x 50 cm

erotic undertones and certain graffiti paying tribute to the *Zeitgeist* in art (Straka, Sonneschein, 1988, 62).

The imagery related to mythology showed a variety of artists' attitudes. Andris Breže has been and still is a master of ironic paradoxes as poignant as the poems he writes. For his attitude he may be compared to the branch of Russian postmodernism known as *sotsart*.



Fig. 5. Andris Breže, *Icarus*, 1987. Paper, silk screen print, 125 x 90 cm



Fig. 6. Ojārs Pētersons, from the series *Endless Choice*. 1988. Silk screen print, each 200 x 155 cm

One might wonder how many falling Icaruses (Fig. 5) (Hirša, 2020, 45) can appear in a relatively small art scene in a relatively short period of time. Andris Breže was one of the masters who cherished this image to express his attitude towards the general feeling in society. Art historian Santa Hirša has highlighted his usage of mythological themes: "Breže differs from the other super-graphics artists with a powerful degree of narrative. By playing on cultural references, his composition interpreted the details of various myths, so they are more than just emotional outbursts or experiments with new, large-scale formats." (Hirša, 2020, 45) We should add in a somewhat contradictory tone that in their huge silkscreens, all of the so-called Latvian avant-gardists had only socially relevant narratives.

The most powerful images of a falling man not concealed behind the metaphors, myths and allegories of Icarus are the large silk screens by artist Ojārs Pētersons (Fig. 6). (Straka, Sonneschein, 1988, 54)

His graphic work tells the story. The seemingly archetypical horror of death is a generalization only partly. The real-life event happened on February 5, 1987.

The 29-years-young poet Klāvs Elsbergs, the most talented and charismatic of his generation, was thrown out of a window of the Writers House in the Latvian coastal town of Jūrmala. It was never discovered how this had happened. All we know is that there were some young Russian writers with him at the time.

This tragic crime left a great impact on many artists, including the young artist Kristaps Ģelzis. He made a very explicit homage to the killed poet in an impressive installation *Washing-Day* (Fig. 7) which depicted a naked man upside down on a glass plate. (Demakova, 2012, 44)

At the end of the 1980s a very active group of young artists – Ojārs Pētersons, Juris Putrāms and Andris Breže – were the first to create huge silkscreen prints. In a way, their works embodied archetypical masculinity and archetypical situations in which men are due to get engaged again and again.



Fig. 7. Kristaps Ģelzis, *The Washing-Day (Fragment)*, 1990. Multimedia installation in the group show *Latvia. 20th Century's Somersault. Years 1940–1990,* Exhibition Hall *Latvia*, Riga, 1990. Courtesy: LNMM, collection of Future Latvian Museum of Contemporary Art (LLMM)

Men would jump, bring light into darkness, plant a tree, as in the work by Ojārs Pētersons. The initially ecological themes of the late 70s and early 80s gradually gained a more general, existential character.

New was a certain playfulness around the myth, hints at the gone-by society, something unthinkable in a totalitarian society.

Let us remember how Mark Rothko with a sense of superiority expressed his beliefs about his closest surroundings, his fellow abstract expressionist friends in a well-known quote: "We are a small band of myth makers".

Latvians would never make such claims. Once, in an interview, artist Andris Breže put it like this: "Some time ago, when we had graduated from the art school and were discussing conceptual and contextual matters with Ojārs Pētersons, I remember us saying: "You always have to add the *manikin*..."

It is not easy to draw an abstract picture. The "manikin" is the measure of all things. Back then our attitude was ironic. The manikin, i.e. the human aspect, is part of the Latvian mindset." (Astahovska, Breže 2010, 393)



Fig. 8. Oļegs Tillbergs, *Joining the Universe*, 1990. Multimedia installation in the group show *Latvia. 20th Century's Somersault. Years 1940–1990,* Exhibition Hall *Latvia*, Riga, 1990. Courtesy: LNMM, collection of Future LLMM

One of the greatest mysteries evidently is the birth of a child. At the time of great changes, in 1990, artist Oļegs Tillbergs in the previously mentioned exhibition *Latvia. 20th century Somersault. 1940–1990* created an installation around that mystery. (Fig. 8)

He himself filmed the video with a real childbirth, and the crib-like situation which we know from Bethlehem was confronted with the wrecks of a crumbling empire, its once mighty engineering achievements (embodied in a Soviet aircraft engine in his installation). This was really not art about art, personal matters or personal memories, or

tensions of forms. The very time, when Tillbergs created his epic work, required an epic attitude.

Among historically well-known characters and mythological themes there were also some of Latvian origin.

Kristaps Ģelzis, who was in his 20s during the time of the Awakening, turned to Latvian legends and stories time and again. His father, the well-known architect Modris Ģelzis, was involved in the initial competition for the new National Library building in Riga. Kristaps Ģelzis metaphorically expressed the whole miserable situation in the old building and the importance of knowledge in his 1988 installation *Burtnieki Castle* (Fig. 9). (Iltnere, 2010, 27) This popular Latvian legend tells the story of a sunken castle where a vicious ruler had once lived. In fine weather the castle might be seen in the clear waters of Burtnieki lake. Ģelzis' installation was made like a pyramid of dusty old newspapers indicating bygone times.



Fig. 9. Kristaps Ģelzis, *Burtnieki Castle*, 1988. Group show at the Theatre Museum, Riga, 1988. Photographer unknown

Ģelzis' silkscreen prints *Sunset Madonnas* (Fig. 9) constitute a large series of similar works dedicated to the well-known religious symbol. (Straka, Sonneschein, 1988, 40) Our artist's Madonna at the beginning of the Awakening appears from the darkness into light; she emerges from the shadows like an incarnation of the Latvian nation. Keith Haring likes to link the graffiti on her body to contemporaneity and to the new situation in art. For foreigners, this young woman would not mean anything, but many Latvians recognise her immediately. She, Inta Grīnberga, for many years was a model at the drawing classes in the Latvian Academy of Art, and was the wife of the important Latvian performance artist Andris Grīnbergs.

Another contemporary artist who worked with folklore and Latvian ornaments as motifs is Indulis Gailāns (1962–2012). For the exhibition

Latvia. 20th century Somersault. 1940–1990 he organized pantomime dancers for the whole duration of the show who staged Latvian ornaments in their performances. Unfortunately, no pictures have survived.

There have been two visible trends in dealing with mythological material.

One expresses no irony at all. Iconic examples are the works of Ilmārs Blumbergs (1943–2016). His whole life and art were dedicated to the teachings that have come from the deepest layers of human cultures. Ancient Greece and the Vedas, and later India were his favourites. Epics and sacred writings accompanied him daily. He tried to embody his metaphysical convictions in his art. This attitude was very understandable since in the Soviet atmosphere of constant lies one had to find some anchors. Let us recall what Ilya Kabakov wrote about the 1970s Moscow in his memoirs *60–70s... Notes about the unofficial life in Moscow* (Kabakov, 2008). He stated that he could survive to a large extent thanks to metaphysics.

Ilmārs Blumbergs was not only a stage designer, poster artist, graphic artist and book illustrator. He was also a sensitive painter. His series of paintings dedicated to Hesiod's *Theogony* (Fig. 10) is an important testimony to the presence of depicting myths in Latvian contemporary art. (Straka, Sonneschein, 1988, 37)

Another non-ironic, less expressive but subtle in its form and content, was the art of Ieva Iltnere. Her ornament-like creations contained some deeper knowledge about the possible roles of women, which were



Fig. 10. Kristaps Ģelzis, *Sunset Madonna*, 1988. Multi-colour silk screen print on canvas, 100 x 85 cm. Courtesy: Private property

still connected to the big stories of Western culture. One of the jewels connected with classical Greek past is her painting *Danaë* (Fig. 11)

Another trend was critical contemplation involving Soviet myths, symbols and signs. Resigned irony was the common undertone of those works.

Andris Breže, whose graphic works have already been mentioned, has been interested in memories of the recent past. The viewers of the



Fig. 11. Ieva Iltnere, *Danaë*, 1987. Oil on canvas, 131 x 180 cm. Courtesy: LNMM

last 30 years will recall his prolific work which mostly consisted of large and small objects.

Like the remarkable Russian *sotsart* artists, he alienated the recognizable signs of what Latvian art historian Elita Ansone had named the *Mythology of Soviet Land* (Ansone, 2010). He reversed the meaning of these signs to reveal the real essence of the empire of evil.



Fig. 12. Leonards Laganovskis, *The End*, 1987. Oil on canvas, 154 x 190 cm. Courtesy: LNMM, collection of Future LLMM

During the Awakening, the master of conceptual thinking, Leonards Laganovskis, adopted a similar approach. His oeuvre centred around the everyday Soviet signs saturated with ideological meanings. His work "End of the Film" (Fig. 12) shows a painted film still from Soviet black-and-white television featuring the centre of power of the Soviet empire – Red Square in Moscow. In the eyes of the artist the whole former glory has ended like every horror film once ends.

CONCLUSION

Mythological motifs within the newly acquired postmodern paradigm rapidly entered Latvian contemporary art during the time of the Awakening (1987–1991). *Sotsart* as part of the critical side of East European postmodernism was not so widespread as in Russia. Affirmative use of myths and archetypes as a sign of belonging to the European culture was widespread. Both trends did not conflict but co-existed in exhibition spaces. No critical reflection on the tension between these two attitudes to myths was visibly present in art criticism of the period.

Although the themes that have been dealt with in this article were not the dominant ones, nevertheless they were very important as the characteristic features of the development of art and culture at large.

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UNUSUAL ARCHETYPES IN OPERA AND THEIR ECHOES IN DESIGN

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ABSTRACT

The study focuses on the staging of archetypes in various operas, primarily in German-speaking countries and Latvia. The often extremely contradictory interpretations of a specific archetype in contemporary opera direction eloquently testify to the complexity of today's society, even if opera may appear at first glance to be an "ivory tower of art".

Interestingly, a few opera titles with high global recognition inspire a multitude of design decisions. These decisions affect products in the food, fashion, and furniture industries, as well as city marketing campaigns and, not least, scenography.

It is noteworthy that some title characters from operas of the 19th and early 20th centuries continue to inspire products that evoke synesthetic experiences (e.g., through taste design), whereas similar works from the later 20th century and even contemporary works no longer trigger such responses. Regardless of this, there is growing, often unspoken pressure on production teams to continually find new interpretations for operas that have become archetypes, some of which are now 150 or even 250 years old. How do you keep the narrative fresh?

Keywords: popular operas and everyday life, taste, furniture, fashion, stage design in his shadow, very different archetypal visions (in international / Latvian history), director, master of prototypes, unexpected opera solutions

METHODS AND MATERIALS

Based on C.G. Jung's definition of archetypes, "The collective unconscious does not develop individually, but is inherited. It consists of preexisting forms, archetypes, which can only become consciously aware of themselves secondarily and give the contents of consciousness a clearly

defined form." (Jung, 1990, 46) Dramaturgs , psychologists, historians, and stage directors have repeatedly explored theater-specific manifestations.

Opera occupies a special position in the structure of the performing arts and surprises us as it presents archetypes in ever-new combinations. I work primarily as a stage director — immersed in the "art of the fleeting moment" — across three countries. I stand before you as a practitioner who is deeply engaged with that most artistic of all art forms: opera.

The often given definition of opera is "a drama set to music and made up of vocal pieces with orchestral accompaniment and orchestral overtures and interludes" can be helpful to connect concrete operas with selected archetypes. (https://www.merriamwebster.com/dictionary/opera)

But not every opera work can be framed in this definition.

Especially since the essence of Oscar Bie's opera was already described as an "impossible work of art" in 1913 (Bie, 1983, 9) and characterized by the writer and director Alexander Kluge in 1983 in his film as follows: "Opera is a powerhouse of emotions and, as such, should not be subject to fashion."

The archetypal connections are also examined from very different perspectives.

There is a focus on reception research and audience behaviour, whereby there is definitely a direct connection between fulfilled expectations of archetypes in particular and classical music in general: "It can serve a function in that it allows as many people as possible to go home happy in the evening." (Hornberger, 2015, 26)

The formats of heroic journeys deserve special attention in operas. A direct comparison with spoken theatre is not always appropriate: "Opera is a *theatre of voices*, in which the voice type and the position of a role in the hierarchy of an ensemble represent an important marker of the hero's rank." (Seedorf, 2019, 3)

What applies to improvisational theatre also applies to everyday life and can also be illuminating with regard to protagonists from several centuries of opera repertoire: "The world doesn't need off-the-shelf heroes, but individuals who face personal challenges in order to grow." (Lösel, 2019, 16)

Especially in the study of female heroines, there is currently a diverse interest in scientific interpretation and also in new readings, often triggered by unusual or controversial directorial approaches. The focus is on the trichotomy of *femme fatale*, *femme fragile*, *femme enfant*. (Schumann, 2024, 21)

I was born in Germany, but my inspiration for this research was sparked in Latvia, by a glass showcase installed by the architect Zaiga

Gaile in the foyer of the New Riga Theatre, rebuilt in December 2023. Inside, she displayed candy wrappers discovered beneath the stage floorboards – discards transformed, by virtue of their display, into artifacts.

The New Riga Theatre was the first theatre outside Germany where I staged my international experiences, also in theatre studies. In the neighbourhood you find the chocolate factory *Laima*.



Fig. 1. Sweet Cio-Cio-San *Laima Chocolate Museum.* Photo: Elīna Zīle

More specifically, I was inspired by the vintage design of the "Cio-Cio-San" wrappers from the *Laima* factory – sweets that guests from Latvia used to bring me during my childhood. While the sweets are no longer in production, the *Laima Chocolate Museum* archives preserve three examples of its wrapper designs from the 20th century. The third design is familiar to me. The sweet's "flavour design", its intense sweetness, remains unforgettable, even though the years of its popularity have long since passed.

The opera production itself remains current and well-attended today. The *Madama Butterfly* at the Latvian National Opera and Ballet in Riga is possibly the oldest production still in repertoire worldwide, dating back to 1925. Just last Saturday, I attended the performance dedicated to its centenary at the Latvian National Opera and Ballet. In this specific staging, the scenographic interplay between the painted backdrops and the physical space prompted my reflection on classical values. But let us return to design, specifically the "flavor design". Cio-Cio-San, the titular character of Puccini's *Madama Butterfly*, is one of the most tragic heroines in all of opera. How does she pair with such exaggerated sweetness?

The story tells of the love and fidelity of Cio-Cio-San, a Japanese Geisha only fifteen years of age, toward the American Captain Pinkerton. Upon returning to the US, he marries an American woman and views his marriage to Cio-Cio-San very differently.

Only when he revisits Japan three years later – accompanied by his new American wife – does he discover their son. The eighteen-year-old Geisha Cio-Cio-San dies. The son remains.

If the "Cio-Cio-San" sweet were a direct reference to the plot, it should taste bitter. Yet the flavour designers of that era chose to dedicate the recipe to transcendence, to love.

It is fascinating, however, to wonder why this specific candy design was not carried over into the modern *Laima* assortment, as was the case with several others.

It serves little purpose to discuss vintage sweets and their operatic references here under the difficult topic of "cross-cultural misunderstandings". I will simply note that currently, the Finnish confectionery *Fazer* has assumed responsibility for the Japanese Geisha theme, producing a sweet that is more fragile, more expensive, and l e s s sugary.

When it comes to my own engagement with the opera *Madama Butterfly*, I have staged fragments of *Madama Butterfly* in non-traditional settings, such as the German Hunting and Fishing Museum in Munich, 2024. This was a context less "sweet" than a classical opera house, but one surrounded by museum exhibits, including numerous cases of pinned butterflies.

Times change; tastes change. In German, the word "*Geschmack*" covers both "flavour" and "taste". And there is no accounting for taste.



Fig. 2.
Madame Butterfly.
LNOB Riga.
Photo:
Evelina Vītola

RESULTS

I turn now to the question of the collective memory surrounding other operatic archetypes, though I will touch upon them only selectively.



Fig. 3. *Madame Butterfly.* Munich, 2024. Seung-Hee Jang, Alexandros Tsilogiannis. Photo: Burak Kücük

This list includes *The Flying Dutchman*, *Don Giovanni*, *Rusalka*, *Siegfried*, and his (perhaps) somewhat similar counterpart *Lāčplēsis* from Jānis Mediņš's opera *Fire and Night* (*Uguns un nakts)* and, finally, *Carmen*.

It is certainly not the case that *everyon*e – either in Latvia or abroad – has attended the operas named after these characters. Yet, whether they intend to or not, people will inevitably have heard or seen traces of them in their daily lives outside the Opera house. For this reason, I designate these characters as archetypes.

All of the operas mentioned have been staged in Latvia. Here, we can begin to analyze how specific character interpretations emerged during specific eras. A director and their team always construct a unique reading – a treatment one might even call a "prototype".

In Germany, the word "prototype" immediately triggers an association with the automotive industry. A successful prototype guarantees a long life for the product (that is, the car). The automotive industry forms the backbone of the German economy. Opera interpretations, arguably, do not quite reach that level of significance. However, the "reinterpretation" of operatic works can tell us a great deal about the so-called "Zeitgeist" – the spirit of the times.

Take, for instance, *The Flying Dutchman*. For many, Richard Wagner's opera is inextricably linked to Latvia. It was after serving two years as Kapellmeister at the Riga City Theatre (1837–1839) that the composer fled the city aboard the ship *Thetis*. The voyage led him to a Norwegian fjord, where he caught the echoes of sailors' and fishermen's songs.

While in Riga, Wagner had already read Heinrich Heine's tale of the Flying Dutchman – the wanderer who comes ashore once every seven years, hoping for a faithful woman to redeem his soul and end his roaming.

Heine's story appears in the collection *The Memoirs of Mister von Schnabelewopski*. The Flying Dutchman became a symbol for the seeker, driven by spiritual unrest. The interpretation of this opera character invites methods that are already commonplace in film psychology: "I wish to argue that the dream-like images, gestures and scenes can help the viewer in



Fig. 4.
The Flying Dutchman.
Oper Leipzig.
Photo: Tom Schulze

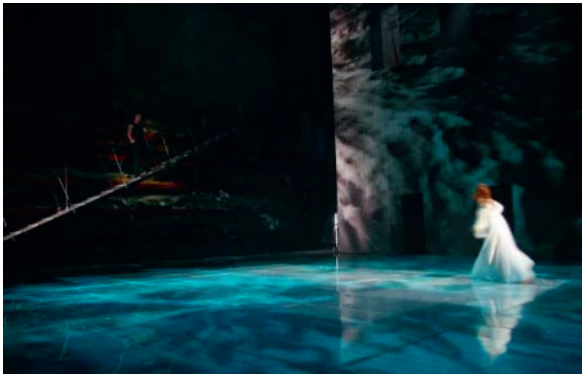


Fig. 5.
The Flying Dutchman
LNOB Riga.
Photo: Gunārs Janaitis

their process of becoming aware, in that they reactivate their knowledge, values and emotions through their partial status as cinematic stereotypes or, following Jung, so called `archetypes´". (Wuss, 2009, 218)

The former Riga City Theatre – located at Riharda Vāgnera Street 4 – is currently being restored as the Gesamtkunstwerk21 project by architect Zaiga Gaile and her office. They have woven *The Flying Dutchman* intensely into the crafting of their public narrative. Consequently, the Dutchman's ship serves as the logo for the Riga Wagner Society.

It was here in Old Riga, in the 19th century, that the actor and singer Karl Wilhelm Günther portrayed the first Dutchman. (His image is still

used today in the Riga Wagner Society's print publications, for example, in connection with the Venice Architecture Biennale.)

But what interpretation of this archetype awaits us today in Wagner's birthplace – Leipzig, Germany – a city far from the sea? Director Michiel Dijkema adheres to the 17th-century setting specified in Wagner's stage directions, yet with deviations and by placing the action amidst dying whales. Suddenly, the 21st century intrudes into this context, even though whales have certainly been washed ashore in previous centuries as well. Today, however, this reads as a reference to an ecological crisis.

And what of the interpretations created in Riga this century? Director Andrejs Žagars, with scenography by Andris Freibergs, devoted ample space to sails, canvas, water, and the footbridge, evoking the Latvian folk song about "bridges thrown by fathers' fathers..."

Director Viesturs Kairišs, meanwhile, transposes the world of sailors into that of astronauts, or into the world of "former cosmonauts". Here, the Dutchman constitutes a prototype; the numerous "Doppelgängers" create a distinct visual pattern, a choreography.

Both of these vastly different interpretations of the "Eternal Wanderer" archetype were portrayed in Riga by bass-baritone Egils Siliņš, who has also sung this role in international productions, including in England, Germany, France, and Turkey.

Does the Dutchman reveal himself to the same degree in every interpretation, given that the music remains the same? Is it "merely" the conductors' tempi that fluctuate, or "merely" the scenographers' concepts that differ? That is likely a subject worth a separate study.

The use of "Doppelgängers" – like those in the aforementioned Wagner opera regarding the "Eternal Wanderer" archetype – was also characteristic of my own production in Riga concerning another archetype: Mozart's *Don Giovanni*. He is a man who flees responsibility, savouring the moment. I compared him to a dark butterfly.

Don Giovanni, too, is a "wandering" figure, yet in a completely different context. In the production running at the LNOB from 1998 to 2006, Andris Freibergs' scenography anchored an interpretation that resonated indirectly with the sensibilities of the 18th century. It was set amidst shifting golden walls and thousands of rose petals – red and black fabrics of varying weights – raining down from the flies at different tempos.

Gunārs Janaitis's photographs reveal that "Doppelgängers" are active even in scenes where Don Giovanni's physical presence is not called for by the score.

During Don Giovanni's ball – situated at the Golden Section of the opera's timeline – the activity of these "Doppelgängers" reaches its peak.

In the finale, Don Giovanni meets the Commendatore, Donna Anna's father, whom he had unwittingly killed in the heat of the moment at the opera's opening, and whose statue in the graveyard he had "spontaneously" invited to dinner. With the arrival of the Stone Guest, the Commendatore, at the banquet, a clash of principles ensues. Yet this time, Don Giovanni is threatened not by Hell, but by a rain of ashen rose petals, or perhaps hail. There is a strong possibility that, like a butterfly, he might simply fly on after the opera concludes.

Only a few years later – in 2009 – the scenographer Andris Freibergs, together with the director Andrejs Žagars, transposed the very same Mozart opera onto that same Riga stage. This time, however, the setting was a white ship in the present day, utilizing a simultaneous set. It would be rather difficult for a butterfly to fly away from the deck of a ship in the middle of the ocean.

And yet, the digital age had dawned, an era where everything is accessible, where everything can be ordered and paid for at (almost) any time – with the possible exception of the soul. Mozart's *Don Giovanni*, while an archetype, nevertheless belonged to a specific social milieu: the aristocracy. On the deck of that white ship, he occasionally found himself exposed to a much brighter light; in place of candlelight, the technical glare of modern international standards prevailed.

This is surely speculation, but perhaps the darker, modern version running on the Riga stage since 2022 is a response to that white ship from the turn of the century.

Director Marcelo Lombardero and scenographer Diego Siliano also utilize a simultaneous set in this version.

The scene in the opera's finale is particularly rich in meaning; it opens onto a fourth dimension, onto a highway-bridge that perhaps leads to eternity.

Again, the bridge returns as a theme. A specific urban bridge, reproduced in its actual dimensions, is found in Poland, at Opera Nova Bydgoszcz, within Mariusz Napierała's scenography for Czech composer Antonín Dvořák's opera *Rusalka* (Baliński, 2016, 8).

Mermaids – aquatic beings yearning to become human and possess a soul – appear in the folklore and literature of many nations, including Andersen's fairy tale. Very often, this transformation is tragic.

This interpretation, featuring a 27-meter-long replica of the old theatre bridge, was conceived specifically for this city. It is dedicated to its German-Polish history – a history that is itself steeped in entanglements and ambivalences.



Fig. 6.
Don Giovanni
LNOB 1999
Photo: Gunārs Janaitis



Fig. 7.
Don Giovanni
LNOB 2022
Photo: Agnese Zeltiņa

In my narrative for *Rusalka,* the mermaids – the heroine's sisters – adapt to the city, even ride the trams manufactured in this very place and which were once exported to many countries.

For this production, the technical craftsmen at Opera Nova constructed a tram prototype designed specifically for mermaids. It glided across the stage without rails, operated by a small remote control. Its true "keeper", however, was the prop designer as it was, after all, a movable prop. When the curtain rose on Act II to reveal Route 8, the tram consistently drew applause from the surprised audience. On its return journey, however – now laden with water – it travelled with its number 8 rotated to form the sign of infinity.

In other opera houses, *Rusalka* does not feature trams, but aquariums. An aquarium, much like the water-tram, is essentially a box with water, only smaller and without wheels.

In Johannes Gleim's Riga production, several aquariums were mere part of the decor. At the Bavarian State Opera in Munich (Schmitt, 2010,

18), however, the aquarium was charged with a profound, immense significance. Austrian director Martin Kušej severed Rusalka from the realm of fairy tales, transplanting it into a contemporary Austrian crime saga – a scandal that, in 2010, had shaken the entire society and neighbouring Germany alike.



Fig. 8
Rusalka Opera Nova Bydgoszcz. Photo: Marek Chełminiak



Fig. 9 A. Kristīne Opolais. Photo: Bayerische Staatsoper



9 B. Magdalena Polkowska. Photo: DUX

The image of Kristīne Opolais within the aquarium – featured on the cover of the Bavarian State Opera DVD – remains vividly imprinted on the memory. It has arguably become the defining symbol of Rusalka for the early 21st century. This status persists despite the emergence of many captivating interpretations in opera houses worldwide, and

despite the fact that a personality as luminous as Asmik Grigorian has also played the role in Munich.

The *Rusalka* at Opera Nova Bydgoszcz is memorable for yet another reason: released in 2019, it was the first opera Blu-ray ever produced in Poland. The DVD edition is already in its second pressing. Remarkably, fresh reviews continue to arrive from abroad, from countries where the specific historical context remains undeciphered, yet where the fairy-tale aesthetic speaks directly to the viewer.

The most surprising interpretation of Rusalka emerged quite recently, in 2024, at the Berlin State Opera, under the direction of Kornél Mundruczó. Latvian scenographer and costume designer Monika Korpa, together with the video artist Rūdolfs Baltiņš, transposed the action to a contemporary Berlin "Wohngemeinschaft" (WG). This shared apartment offers a view of the city's iconic Eastern silhouette – the TV Tower – and the famous "Berlin sky".

The Waterman and the nymphs inhabit the kitchen-apartment, complete with a walk-through bathroom. The Prince resides in the elegant penthouse terrace above.

The Witch, meanwhile, occupies the concierge's flat in the stairwell to the right – a space defined solely by its closed door. The Witch-Concierge "throws" an eel into the action. In Berlin, eels are primarily considered a delicacy as well as creatures that are notoriously difficult to track. The cultural contexts that exist in Latvia do not apply in Berlin.

It is entirely unforeseen that Rusalka, after her ordeals in the human world, would begin to transform so radically into an eel – after all, she loves the Prince. This transformation, which begins with Rusalka in the bathroom and ends in the building's basement, provoked discussions specifically among Berlin's youth even a year after the premiere.

Dealing with the figure of Siegfried – the "hero" – is far simpler than with Rusalka, even if his historical-political baggage is quite heavy; one need only recall the specific eras in the 20th century when parents chose this name for their sons. Yet the myth of the strong boy who vanquished the dragon and bathed in its blood existed many centuries earlier.

As early as the 19th century, Richard Wagner had named his own son Siegfried. Yet, within the composer's tetralogy, *The Ring of the Nibelung*, a significant detail stands out: the linden leaf that falls upon the hero's back as he bathes is not granted an aria. The Forest Bird, by contrast, is endowed with actual words, not merely vocalizations.

When we consider a definitive interpretation of this hero, the Heldentenor Wolfgang Windgassen comes to mind. Collaborating with the composer's grandson – director and scenographer Wieland Wagner –



Fig. 10. *Rusalka* Berlin Photo: Monika Korpa



Fig. 11. *Siegfried* Bayreuth. Photo: The History of The Tenor; Sydney Rhys Barker. 1988



Fig. 12. *Fire and night* Riga. 1987. Photo: Eiženija Freimane / LNOB

he was able, beginning in 1951, to conceptually revolutionize not only the production of Siegfried but the entire Bayreuth Festival.

To grind the old, shattered sword into dust so that a new weapon might be forged from the filings: this metaphor resonates not only with the opera but with many sectors of the divided Germany of the 1950s.

Almost 75 years later, the hero Siegfried appears at the Berlin State Opera in track pants featuring three white stripes down the side – branded designer gear, in other words.

The Heldentenor Andreas Schager operates within a scientific environment; one will not find a forest on this stage. Director Dmitri Tcherniakov's choice of costume was not accidental: in this Siegfried, the image of the hero is far less legible than in any previous interpretation.

Matters are somewhat clearer regarding the figure of Lāčplēsis in Jānis Mediņš's opera *Uguns un nakts*. Lāčplēsis, like Siegfried, also must

battle a bear. But unlike Siegfried, he is able to fight the dark power, here named the Black Knight, openly. In *The Ring of the Nibelung*, Hagen, clad in the armour of an equally dark knight, orders his subordinates to stab Siegfried in the back, with cowardice and without warning.

Yet, even when crafting the operatic image of Lāčplēsis, one can seek and find layers of complexity. It is no coincidence that the Latvian National Opera and Ballet reopened after renovations in 1995 with *Uguns un nakts*. Director Alvis Hermanis successfully fused contradictions and Latvian phenomena from various eras into his interpretation. Transforming the opera's dramaturgy into a live performance was far more complex than the hero's simple white costume – designed by Večella Varslavāne – might have implied. Yet the production succeeded, and it lives on in our collective memory.

In Latvian everyday life, Lāčplēsis appears not as a confectionery, but as a beer, and can be found in almost any shop.

Bizet's opera *Carmen* is perhaps the "most universal" archetype. The opera differs starkly from Prosper de Mérimée's novella about the Gypsy. The Carmen of the opera is painted in different hues than the one in the novella. Yet the name "Carmen" signifies an oracle. Moreover, a tobacco factory worker actually lived in Spain, with whom a certain Count Montijo fell in love. In Riga, director Andrejs Žagars transposed this narrative to Cuba. It was within this production that Latvian world-wide famous mezzo-soprano Elīna Garanča made her debut in the title role. Currently, an interpretation by French director Marie-Eve Signeyrole is on view in Riga – set in a modern suburb, teeming with diverse social groups, including hip-hop dancers.

Since its premiere in the 19th century, Carmen has inspired the manufacturing of both food and durable goods. Here, we see butter biscuits produced in Germany.

Here are chairs currently manufactured by the Swedish firm ROWICO, available in two colours.

In Bregenz, a lakeside city in Austria, Carmen's hands playing the fateful game of cards (director Kasper Bech Holten) became part of the city's architecture in 2017 and 2018, as the opera was in the repertoire of the Bregenz Festival.

In the German city of Magdeburg, where a memorial erected in 1988 to the Roma victims of 1933–1945 stands beside the Cathedral, my scenographer Lukas Noll and I incorporated another archetype into this card scene: the Madonna, using a fragment from an El Greco painting.

Among depictions of the Mother of God, there is a specific type: the Black Madonna. In the Bavarian town of Altötting, Germany, one finds



Fig. 13. Cookies *Carmen.* Photo: Archiv SAGEN.at



Fig. 14. Chair *Carmen.* Photo: ROWICO



Fig. 15. Bregenzer Festspiele *Carmen.* Photo: Wolfgang Morscher

the most powerful wooden sculpture of this kind in the country. She possesses twelve mantles, sewn from the wedding dresses of princesses. A copy of this Black Madonna appeared quite recently in the production of *Hamlet* (composer Jānis Kalniņš) at the Latvian National Opera and Ballet (scenographer Andris Eglītis).

Let us return to Latvia: The image of the Gypsy continues to captivate not only opera lovers but actors as well. The day before yesterday (27.5.2025), at the age of 105, the actress Elvīra Baldiņa passed away. She, too, played the role of the Gypsy – the "White Gypsy" – in the 1948 production of *The Bear of Happiness* (*Laimes lācis*), as I discovered in an exhibition by the Madona Local History Museum.

Let us return to sweets: What kind of confectionery was inspired by the opera *Carmen*? By no means anything excessively sweet, as we see, for instance, in this sample from Turkey. Since we are currently in the season of full bloom, it is worth asking precisely which flower did Carmen fatefully cast toward the soldier Don José? It was an acacia blossom. Its meaning varies from one setting and country to another. Deciphering the language of flowers, it seems, is even more complex than addressing archetypes.



Fig. 16.
Carmen in
Magdeburg.
Photo: Nilz Böhme



Fig. 17. *Altötting* Madonna in
Hamlet LNOB Riga.
Photo: Kristaps Kalns



Fig. 18. *White Gypsy*
actress Elvīra Baldiņa.
Photo: Madona LH Museum

DISCUSSION

The selected operas make it clear that there are works that lend themselves to diverse "exploitation" in design and merchandising. However, the number of possible interpretations for directors remains limited. The names of these opera characters, often the title characters, have a signal effect even outside the theatre. Even people who are not interested in classical music believe they can give a precise assessment. They, just like opera lovers and experts, have expectations.

Among these works there are also those that have inspired the visual arts for decades, even centuries. This engagement can take place directly through "illustrations" with a high degree of recognizability, but also as abstraction.



Fig. 19. Chocolate *Carmen*
Photo: Şok Marketler Ticaret A.Ş.





Fig. 20. Acacia blossom in *Carmen* scenography
Photo: Scenographer Lukas Noll

Other works, on the other hand, invite the production teams to create new interpretations, which sometimes spark heated discussions about the concept of "faithfulness to the original." These discussions can arise among the performing artists in theatres and opera houses, then among the audience and in the trade press.

Even if the term "archetype" is not used, there is still a certain expectation. Almost everyone has a concrete idea of heroism and the hero's journey. Deviations are perceived as provocation.

This has led to vehement reactions from audiences, which in Germany have been expressed loudly as immediate protests rather than shouts of "Bravo" after the performance. The specialist forums on the internet provide a very wide-ranging echo chamber, as do audience opinions following reviews in the specialist and daily press.

The vehemence of some reactions can be explained by the fact that a deviation from one's own ideas and expectations is perceived as a personal affront. It is an attack on something "inherently one's own." Live broadcasts of operas on big screens (e.g., in Berlin, Munich, Bayreuth) and in cinemas also increase the number of people passing judgment. "Every child" now knows what a "real" Carmen or a "real" Siegfried should look like. The pressure on the prototype producers, the directing teams, grows with every production commission they receive for the so-called "archetypical" opera titles.

Could there also be "acoustic archetypes"? These, incidentally, may well have influenced the destinies of nations. The chorus "Va, Pensiero" from Verdi's opera *Nabucco*, for instance, helped forge a united Italy. On the final day of May 2025, this production returns to the repertoire at the Latvian National Opera and Ballet. It might be worthwhile to listen to that chorus with fresh ears. To evaluate and address such sonic archetypes would be a new topic entirely – one, perhaps, to be explored during the upcoming *School Youth Song Festival* in Summer 2025.

CONCLUSION

There is currently an apparent dilemma facing those involved in opera "in front of the stage" – directors, set designers, and costume designers: for some popular operas, it no longer seems so easy to tell the archetypal stories in a plausible way and at the same time create a completely new "prototype" with the interpretation.

The opera creators working "on stage", on the other hand, can always add new facets to their interpretation with one and the same popular opera role in different constellations of stages, orchestras, and colleagues, since the musical component and their psychophysical form on the day account for the lion's share of their work.

On the one hand, this means that their artistic performance is always open to challenge but, on the other hand, it also gives them room for "new opportunities and new luck."

For program planners and theatre managers, however, it means anticipating today the popular opera titles of "the day after tomorrow." In the best-case scenario, they can successfully direct their audience's curiosity toward previously "overlooked" works in the repertoire and promising contemporary creations. In an art form that, in its European form, will soon be half a millennium old, that shouldn't be too difficult.

Even if there seems to be a general consensus, as in this internationally popular reference work on OPERA: "It is a pleasure to see the

same opera in different interpretations. This explains why an entire art form is based on a core repertoire of around 150 operas. However, it remains unclear why many thousands of operas have fallen into oblivion." (Riding & Dunton-Downer, 2007, 15)

I would venture to suggest an explanation: it is due to the more or less skilful handling of archetypes by opera makers. However, the situation is not quite so hopeless for operas "beyond the canon of 150." Over the past 20 years, the lesser-known works have repeatedly made their way into the repertoires of German-speaking opera houses in waves. New heroic journeys could begin.

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UNCONTROLLABILITY IN THE CREATION OF ART

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ABSTRACT

In the creation of art, it is prevalent to derive inspiration from already existing artworks and ideas. In this paper the catalyst of artistic creativity is the uncontrollable creation process itself.

The aim of this artistic research is to find new art forms and to create artworks in the field of ceramics using exact science. In this paper the focal point is the electroformation process itself. By manipulating how strong the electrical current is the notation of the different crystalline structure formations are made. Additionally, the mandrel types are being switched to observe how copper particles would grow on them – from a copper wire to a larger surface copper plate with the goal to create durable and intriguing volumetric copper objects. Furthermore, the connection with ceramic work is explored by the inclusion of conductive materials to the clay body.

With the help of this research the exploration of artistic creation using techniques that are chaotic and not fully controllable is carried out. As electroformation yields results that are predictable by experience yet it cannot be fully controlled by the researcher. There is no way to regulate how the structure of the crystal will lie down on the mandrel. The notion of leaving the illusion of control behind and trusting the process itself is being examined as a main driving force of artwork creation. And the road to mixed media artwork is laid down.

In order to create unique art using exact science and to explore release of the full control in the creation process, copper crystals resembling corals are grown using electroformation. This process works by taking some electrically conductive object – it can be copper wire, plate or something covered with conductive paint or copper foil – and a thick copper metal part and connecting them to electricity. Both of them are placed in electrolytic liquid. This creates a circuit and particle transfer can begin enabling the growth of copper structures and a slow decay of

the metal part. With inclusion of conductive materials and fluxes, the clay modification is made to support copper growth from within the sculpture, enabling the creation of peculiar artworks.

This paper's exploration of the clash of two worlds – strict and calculated scientific approach of technological research and that of expressive creation – and the seamless combination of them enables the unique methods of ceramic art creation.

Keywords: uncontrollability, process, electroformation, ceramics, copper crystals

INTRODUCTION

Uncontrollable creation process

When creating art, the process itself can be as important as the results, especially if the chosen field has a lot of technological nuances. In this paper the presented interdisciplinary research is viewed through the perspective of an artist based in the field of ceramics. Because of that, examples given are from a technological standpoint and acquired empirical knowledge of a researcher. The importance of the creation process is analyzed through practical tests and the road needed to walk to achieve the desired results. In addition, trust in the process as the main inspiration and fueling force for artistic creation is considered. The chaotic and uncontrollable art practices discussed here are set in a strict and calculated scientific research field. The main objective is to create artworks using exact science as well as to search and create new methods of combining it with art in the field of ceramics.

While creating ceramic art, one must have prior experience in technological aspects of it. In this art field it is important to have fundamentals of chemistry and physics, material design and technical work process are. They become a base language of creation that enables the artists to express themselves without limitation of technique. Of course, it is possible to create art without deep fundamental knowledge of ceramic technologies yet having a broad toolset helps to gain rich expression.

Even though on the surface it looks like an artist has full control of their art creation, in the ceramics field it is rarely so. At least not full control over every aspect of the process. Some techniques are thriving on a chaotic means of creation. As an example, let us take mocha diffusion – ceramics decorating technique that works momentarily using chemical reactions. To grow dendritic patterns, one must put coloured acidic liquid on wet slip-covered clay work, and in seconds intricate

lines grow (Hopper, 2016, 116). This expressive process with practice can be managed and influenced and the results can be anticipated. However, to fully control how the branches will grow is impossible. Artists are left to experiment and to create patterns embracing lack of control.

In this art research, electrochemical forming (or electroformation) technique is explored. Even though it is more commonly used in jewellery and is not associated with ceramics, its potential in art creation is vast. This process bears similarity to the previously mentioned mocha diffusion technique in that the process happens without intervention of the artist's full control . To grow coral-like formations with metal, the researcher has to provide an appropriate environment for it. He can choose salinity of the liquid and strength of the electrical current, thus influencing how fast and what kind of crystals will grow. Nonetheless, the researcher cannot control exactly where the structure will land on the model under electroformation. He must trust the process and experience in working with it. And be willing to create without full control of the results.

Both the examples given are specific and they are driven by their chaotic nature. Even though it is paradoxical that for both of them precision and scientific approach is needed to start unrestrained creation. But even taking fundamental ceramics technology full control by an artist is an illusion. Theoretically, composition of materials such as clay and glazes can be calculated and prepared precisely though in practice it is looser and variable. Lack of control begins with the building process of an art-piece regardless of the technique chosen. Even when using slip casting or clay 3D printing – technology used for repetition of the same form – full control is not present. Clay and porcelain are wet and unpredictable, causing a variety of deviations from the model form. The drying process can also reveal that clay has a mind of its own, bending and twisting even when the environment is fully monitored. As for firing of the piece, the artist can set the temperature, steps and duration of the process, but still the nuances of the kiln specifics influence how the work will eventually be and cannot be fully controlled. The ceramist as an artist can take pride in his skills and precision of his work yet still leave full control behind. Acknowledging this can liberate and provoke use of expressive creation.

Electroformation process as a tool for creation

Electroformation is a great technique to achieve precision results when replicating intricate forms. Used in a laboratory setting, it can be controlled completely although it requires scientific knowledge and specialized tools. Electrodeposition can be scaled from micro size to impressively large forms. It is also a reliable way to make difficult forms

precisely and to multiply them. In regard to that, it is well employed in multiple industries (Wu et al. 2019). One way of utilizing electroformation is to ma,ke copies of metal parts by using conductive mandrel and forming thin metal sheets on it. The electroformed metal is then removed and the process can be replicated again (Hamed et al., 2024). This technique is used in such industries as automotive, aeronautical and other that require large scale electrodeposition or nickel mold-making. For such industries as electronics, medicine and spacecraft component making, electroformation reaches micro scale where highest precision is required and most likely dissolvable mandrel is being utilized. Even though for electrodeposition different metals can be used, it is worth noting that in the industrial settings nickel is more common (Parkinson, 1998). Applying electrochemical deposition techniques, large and small parts can be manufactured economically and easily, triumphing over such processes as milling. And because of that it is well used for industrial purposes (Hernández-Pérez et al. 2025). In jewellery, similar principles like those in an industrial sphere are used. An adornment can be electroplated by depositing a thin layer of gold or silver onto it, engulfing it forever (Ramya, Krupanidhi, 2019). In a way, it is like covering it with a layer of paint. Electroforming is also used to build a metal body on a disposable, other material model to minimize the use of precious metal compared to casting full-bodied pieces (Curtis, 2013). These examples show that in jewelry the approach to electroformation is almost the same as in the factories. Artists are making their jewellery with precision to the smallest detail so it makes sense that they would use electrodeposition with intention to fully control it. However, in other artistic practices electroformation can be used without an intention to fully control it. May it be coral like ceramic sculptures of Sabri Ben-Achour or copper crystal engulfed circuit board studies of Ludwig Stalla. And, of course, electroformation can be a catalyst for curiosity that fuels experimentations with growing metal crystals without any intention to control the process or ideas of end results. This shows the versatility of this technology and nudges for further exploration of it as a method to initiate an uncontrollable creation process.

Before starting to employ electrochemical forming as a technique of uncontrollable creation process one must learn how it works. To begin the electroformation process there need to be several things at hand. The first and most important component is an electrically conductive model (or the mandrel) that is the object desired to electroform with metal (also called a cathode); in other words, soon to turn into the result of the process. Second, it is cardinal to have some metal

that will become the source of the particles that will be deposited on the object to be electroformed (also called an anode). As mentioned before, any metals can be used –gold, titanium, nickel and others, depending on the demands for the finished product (Costa et al. 2022). Although different metals may require heat and poisonous chemical compounds to kick-start particle transfer (Kawase, 2005). Third, to have a successful process an electrolytic liquid needs to be used that is made from the same metal salt that is being used for the particle deposition. This chemical mixture creates an environment in which metal molecules can be transferred. Last, but incredibly important - to kick-start everything, the source of electricity is needed, best provided by precision laboratory-grade power supply. Without a well-measured and constant electrical current this technique would not work (Andreou, Roy, 2022). The electroformation process begins by putting electrolytic liquid in the container and then dunking into it the model that will be electroformed and the metal that will provide some distance between them. They both are connected to the power supply that passes a direct current through them. Even though they are not touching, with the help of metal salt solution the circuit is created and particle transfer can begin (Curtis, 2013), thus starting the process of form creation without the intervention of researchers' hands.

Having in mind different uses for electroformation and technical aspects of the process, practical testing can be started to answer questions and help find efficient ways to apply this technique for art creation.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

Sculpting with electricity

Creating sculptures, where the process is as important as the results, electroformation emerges as a great technique to use. While researching how to modify and use this process as well as what conditions could be changed to influence the growth, one of the additional tasks was to find a way to create artistic objects. And the starting point – the first part of the research – was to learn how to sculpt with metal crystals standing behind the container in which the creation process took place.

In this art research, copper metal was chosen. In all the tests made the copper pipe was used as the source of the metal for particle transfer. It was cut into pieces that would fit into the container that were switched out when one part had decayed almost completely. Because the chosen metal was copper, copper sulfate pentahydrate was used for the electrolytic liquid to make a salt solution of 50g/l proportion.

To observe how different forms of the copper object that was being electroformed affected crystal growth, experiments were carried out by switching shapes of the mandrel. Starting from a simple copper wire, then using smaller and larger copper plates, part of the copper pipe. Then starting to get creative with what shape and copper material to use – crocheting very thin copper wire to create a form and bending the shape with copper foil as if it was origami. Because the important part of these tests was to learn how model forms influence copper structure growth, other variables were set unchanged – electrical current was always set to be 0,05A, varying only when the anode would decay too much. Also, the duration of the process was observed, noting crystalline structures after one week of growing.

While using copper wire it was very conspicuous that larger crystal clusters would form on the tip of it. And the closer the tip to the anode the bigger the growth (Fig. 1). When switching to copper plate, crystal formations lay differently. On the plate itself a straight-line pattern grew that showed how the electrical current travelled through the surface of it and larger clusters of copper crystals formed on the edges, being thicker and longer when closer to the copper pipe (Fig. 2). With a larger copper plate the results were different – even though the straight-line pattern was visible, it was not as pronounced as on the smaller surface. Furthermore, there were no spiky crystals on the edges, making coating with copper crystals more uniform than before (Fig. 3). Testing electro-deposition on the volumetric object – copper pipe elbow part – a few points stood out. The surface was covered with a very fine and even layer of small crystals with the back-end edge holding a larger cluster ring. And the front part that was closer to the anode grew longer crystal spikes (Fig. 4).

To sculpt the model object before electroformation process, crocheting technique was chosen. The small volumetric form was made with a very thin and malleable copper wire. It was then electroformed to cover it with copper crystals setting and toughening its form. Some sharper spikes also grew on it, giving it fragility (Fig. 5).

Another technique to make the shape of an object before the copper crystal growing was forming shapes with thicker copper foil. Those tests showed promising results as the shape could be manipulated into form relatively easily and the electroformation made unique copper growth patterns and clusters. As in the previous tests with copper plates, the lines where electricity had been going were visible. However, because of the folds in the foil the lines obtained curved patterns too, which gave it more unique character (Fig. 6).

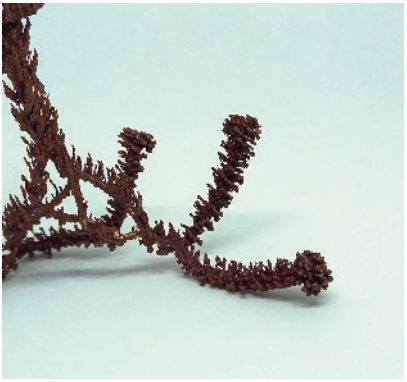


Fig. 1

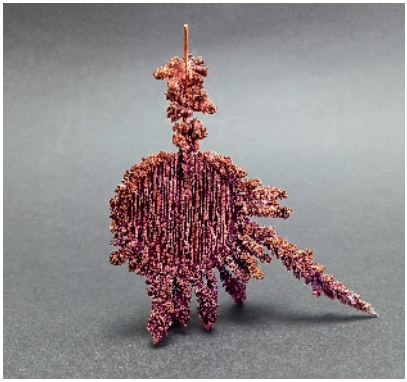


Fig. 2

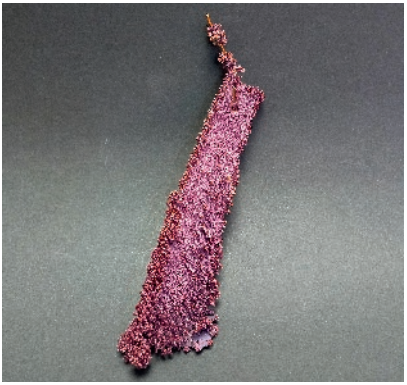


Fig. 3

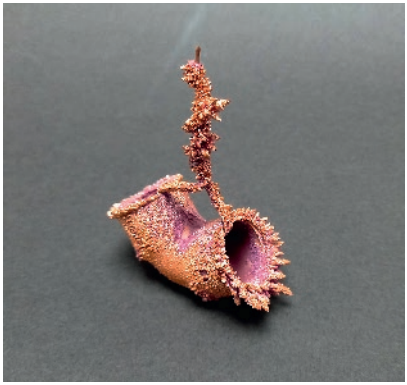


Fig. 4

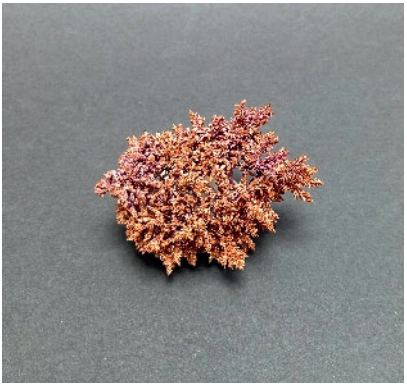


Fig. 5

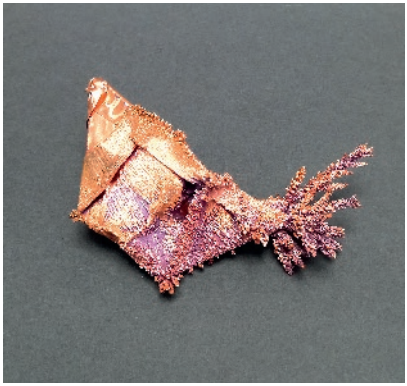


Fig. 6

Influencing copper crystalline growths did give the possibility to create textures and forms on the surface of the object being electroformed. Yet, it raises the question: what makes the metal growths an art object and not a byproduct of an experiment? And does shaping copper metal into preferred forms and then growing crystals on top of them count as using electroformation as a sculptural tool? These questions remain unanswered, but experiments did confirm the importance of the creation process as equal as the results it gave.

Merging copper crystals with ceramics

Continuing the thought of creation with limited control and the importance of the process as well as the results, the second part of the research was carried out. The focus was on the testing of different ways to combine ceramic artwork with copper crystals and searching the ways to merge them organically and not in the form of inclusion after the fact. The problem of how electroformation could influence the form of the sculpture was also tackled.

Growing copper crystals is an interesting process on its own that can give unexpected and fascinating results. But combining it with ceramics also opens doors for other different possibilities. In regard to that, testing how to merge electroforming with ceramics takes precedence and several branches of experiments were explored. First - covering porcelain models with conductive materials such as copper products and conductive paint. Second – modifying the clay body with fluxes and adding conductive materials to it.

To start the experimentation with simple inclusion of copper on an already finished ceramic piece, a porcelain sphere was crocheted around, enclosing it with thin wire mesh. When electroforming onto it, after a week small copper crystals covered the wire with slightly larger spikes on the side closer to the pipe. With the hope of covering the gaps where the porcelain was still visible, this test was left in the copper sulfate solution for an additional week. Despite that, the gaps remained as copper crystals formed larger and longer on the spikier side (Fig. 7).

Another test included use of adhesive copper foil to show that it is feasible to use it for the electroformation process. It does conduct electricity well, providing a surface for a good coat of small copper crystals with larger clusters on the sides. Furthermore, the foil stuck well to the porcelain disc and the adhesive did not dissolve in the electrolytic liquid. But it should be noted that if the foil fails, crystals would fall off completely as they are not touching porcelain itself (Fig. 8).

While testing conductive paint, some problems arose. The porcelain part was covered with paint, and it did help to close the electrical circuit as it was conductive. Despite that, the paint started reacting with copper sulfate and coming off the model. Electrodeposition still took place to create pronounced spiky copper crystals that were very fragile. However, this experiment polluted copper sulfate solution and it was no longer usable, which begs either a different mix of conductive paint or the use of separate containers just for the painted models (Fig. 9).

To step away from combining ceramics with metal electroformation through simple inclusion after the object was already made, tests were carried out to bind conductive materials to the clay body. Considering that most additives may change or burn off during the firing process, a low-fire clay body was chosen. Furthermore, tests were made to lower the temperature even more than needed for clay to transform into a strong-bodied ceramic work by adding different chemical compounds.

Starting experimentation with adding fluxes to low-fire white clay to make it strong even when fired at 800°C, different materials were chosen. Calcium carbonate (chalk), potassium feldspar, talcum, dolomite and iron oxides (Fe3O4 and Fe2O3) were added in different weight percentages. All these materials are used as fluxes in the ceramics field, and when added, they did strengthen the fired clay objects more. Although the finished results lacked the look of glossy ceramics and still needed a glaze layer, the experiment showed promising results.

Another step was to combine clay with conductive material and fire it at a low temperature of 800°C. One of the most commonly used bases for conductive paint is graphite, but in an oxidation environment it combusts at 800°C and cannot be used for this part of the research. Thus, tests with adding copper metal were carried out. To start, different copper products were fired in temperatures used for ceramics. After firing thin materials such as wire and foil they burned through completely, leaving behind copper oxide. When testing a thicker metal disc, only the surface layer burned off, leaving the inside intact that could later be used for electroformation. This showed that copper metal could be combined with a clay object if it was chunky enough to not burn off completely.

This opened the door to a way to influence the shape of artworks before the electrofomation process without immersive control on the part of the artist. Adding copper metal to soft clay made it a part of the object. When drying, clay shrinks and cracks if something prevents it to move coherently. So, if there is metal in it, the surface breaks revealing it in the inside. This alien material deformed and damaged ceramic objects before firing, thus becoming a tool to influence its shape during

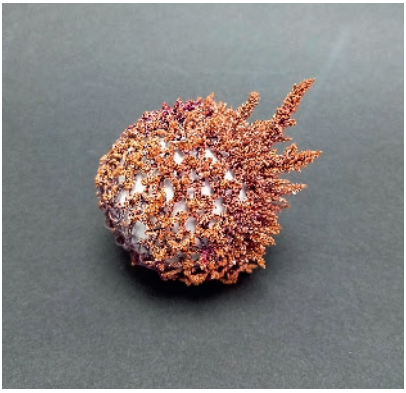


Fig. 7

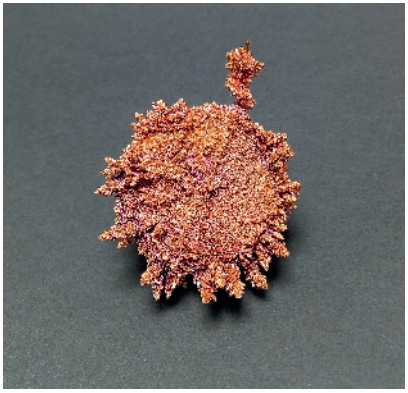


Fig. 8



Fig. 9



Fig. 10

an uncontrollable process. Later, these objects of the experiments were submerged in copper sulfate and left to electroform for two weeks each. Copper formations grew through the cracks in ceramic works, enclosing them and becoming an organic part of them (Fig. 10).

Combining crystalline growths with ceramics confirmed that there are different ways to include them after the object form has been already made, thus making it a decorative part of it. Furthermore, tests with clay body composition and mechanical insertion of copper revealed that there is a possibility to influence the shape of the object before it is fixed with fire. However, more experimentation would be needed to perfect methods of this destructive and hardly controllable creation process.

RESULTS

On completion of this art research, the following results were achieved:

The hypothesis that art creation under uncontrollable processes can provide unique results and fuel artists' expressiveness was confirmed.

The methodology of combining scientific practice of metal electrochemical forming with artistic praxis of ceramics was created and tested.

The development of methods that implement combination of art and science through uncontrollable creation yielded a starting point for the exploration and construction of new interdisciplinary artworks (Fig. 11) (Fig. 12) (Fig. 13) (Fig. 14).



Fig. 11



Fig. 12



Fig. 13



Fig. 14

DISCUSSION

It is paradoxical to intend using procedures and ideas of not being in full control of the process in art creation yet choosing scientific methods as measures that need laboratory precision. When considering the scientific approach to research, it seems vastly different from creative practices. The world of science is methodical, strict and calculated, with clear guidelines as to how to do tests. Technological research in the ceramics field, usually in the field of material design, is also grounded in tests and calculations, although this process displays more lenience to interpretations and playfulness. The creative process is mostly loose and expressive. It is based on experience and intuition. Yet the combination of such different worlds as shown through this artistic research simply works.

Exploration of the electroformation process showed that it is set in a calculated and well-monitored environment where a scientific method is used to measure conditions of the copper crystal growth. Without careful approach it can be dangerous as chemicals and electricity are used. In a way, it needs a laboratory setting. However, experimentation with different possibilities to use electrodeposition with artistic intentions confirmed that copper electroformation can be applied as a tool in the expressive and uncontrollable process to create objects of art. Furthermore, tests with clay and raw copper inclusion into it revealed new transformative methods to influence the shape of a sculpture as well as a technique to organically merge crystalline structures with the said object. This shows a blueprint for creation of unique artworks without immersive control of either process or end results. However, more research should be made into adaptation of this method in practice.

Another aspect that should be mentioned and explored further is the role of the artist in the creation of art when working with uncontrollable processes as well as employing scientific methods. As in the case of electroformation, the researcher is the initiator as well as a spectator of the shaping process of the artwork. He supervises conditions, manages and influences the course of creation, but not the results of it all. Control is only present in the preparation stage and is removed when the object is being made. At that point the artist becomes a collaborator with the materials, trusts the process and waits. This raises the question of the role of the artist in the creation of artwork and if the term ‘researcher’, which implies a managerial position, is more appropriate. This shows the need for further discussion and exploration of the topic.

CONCLUSION

Researching electrochemical deposition of copper metal allowed to confirm that artists can employ scientific practices and merge them with art in an organic way, thus making art and science equal in the creation process as well as complimentary to each other. Empirical knowledge that was provided by practical tests during this research paved the way to composing new artistic methodology of uncontrollable art creation using science. It encourages artists to relax a little and trust the process. Furthermore, technical testing of the materials and mechanical merging of copper into clay provided proof that electrodeposition is an acceptable tool to use for ceramic art creation when the intention is to release full control of the process and face the results it gives. Moreover, during this research the search of the methods to further copper crystal growths as a surface decoration technique or simple inclusion of décor to already pre-existing artwork was successful. Nevertheless, the method of combining copper with wet clay during building the form needs further research to investigate how the shape would deform and crack during drying and firing processes as well as what difficulties would have to be faced when scaling the work up. In conclusion, uncontrollability in art creation is fruitful with technical practices in the field of ceramics that provide a welcome addition to empower creativity, even when the chosen techniques come from another, seemingly opposite paradigm.

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REINTERPRETING THE AGENCY OF THE "POWER SUIT" IN FASHION COMMUNICATION: QUESTIONING EMPOWERMENT IN WOMEN'S CORPORATE LEADERSHIP

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ABSTRACT

This paper examines the ambivalent agency of the "power suit" in the visual self-presentation of women leaders in corporate and political environments. Emerging in late-twentieth-century Western corporate culture, the power suit has been understood as a sartorial tool of empowerment, signalling competence and authority. Drawing on fashion studies, social theory, and qualitative interviews with nineteen senior women leaders in Latvia, the paper argues that the power suit both empowers and renders women's bodies subject to gendered scrutiny. It operates as a visual technology that aligns women with masculinised norms of leadership while simultaneously activating latent regimes of sexualisation and objectification. Situated within broader debates on gendered credibility and body-based evaluation in contemporary public discourse, the study identifies tensions in how women negotiate dress codes, bodily management and expectations of "appropriate" femininity. Reinterpreting the power suit through fashion as communication and the notion of "absence-presence," the paper suggests that it functions as a paradoxical medium that both conceals and foregrounds the sexualised female body. It concludes that reliance on masculinised sartorial codes in women's leadership dress reflects a persistent authority gap and the enduring cultural expectation that women navigate the symbolic divide between "productivity" and "reproductivity".

Keywords: power suit, fashion as communication, women leaders, gendered credibility, objectification

INTRODUCTION

In August 2023 the leading political party alliance in Latvia nominated Evika Siliņa as candidate for the position of Prime Minister (Fig. 1). Almost immediately, public debate turned from her policy agenda to her appearance, generating humiliating and explicitly sexist commentary on her body and clothing. She was described in derogatory terms, including comparisons to a "bunny" and a former porn actress, while the then Estonian Prime Minister Kaja Kallas was labelled an even "cooler bunny". The episode triggered responses from prominent women leaders and even from the Ombudsman (Jansons, 2023), and opinion pieces in mass media addressed the objectification of women and the role of appearance in evaluating professional competence.



Fig. 1. Evika Siliņa, Prime Minister of Latvia (2023–2026)

This context foregrounds a broader research problem: the ways in which women leaders' bodies and dress are still central to their social legibility and political credibility. Fashion scholar Joanne Entwistle argues that women's identity has historically been tied to a culturally entrenched understanding of the female body as "naturally" sexualised and reproductive, in contrast to the supposedly rational, disembodied male subject (Entwistle, 2015, 207). In corporate settings where overt sexuality is coded as inappropriate, women must learn to manage and mute bodily "signals" in order to gain and maintain authority and trust. The professional outfit is therefore not only a means of self-expression but also an instrument of bodily governance.

Within this regime, the power suit has become a key sartorial code. As a self-presentation discourse, the power suit symbolises women's formal business dress in corporate and institutional environments. Its contemporary form emerged in late twentieth-century Western corporate culture, alongside women's rising participation in managerial and political roles. The power suit has been linked to women's emancipation and to the discourse of empowerment: by visually approximating the suit-wearing male colleague, women were advised to signal equivalent professionalism and leadership capacity (Fig. 2) (e.g., Entwistle, 2015; Molloy, 1975).

At the same time, the power suit sits atop a much longer history of the suit as a masculine uniform of authority. Since the so-called "Great Masculine Renunciation" at the turn of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, Western men's tailored suit has functioned as a visual embodiment of a sober, rational, serious masculinity and as a marker of bourgeois respectability (Kuchta 2002, 130–131). Femininity, by contrast, was relegated to the realm of appearance and frivolity. Thus, when women enter the suit, they step into a historically gendered sartorial code constructed around male bodies and male power, visually aligning themselves with masculine templates of authority.



Fig. 2. Promotional imagery from the back cover of John T. Molloy's *Dress for Success*, 1975

The present paper, developed within a practice-driven professional doctorate in fashion design, explores how the power suit operates as a communicative medium in the construction of women leaders' professional identities and how its agency can be critically reinterpreted. It examines the ambivalence of the power suit as both a tool of empowerment and a vehicle of conformity and asks how this ambivalence is negotiated in everyday dressing practices by women in senior leadership roles in Latvia.

The paper situates the power suit historically and theoretically within fashion sociology studies. It outlines the methodological approach of a qualitative, interview-based study. The empirical sections present key themes from the interviews, highlighting how respondents describe their relationship with the power suit, the management of the body, and the negotiation between femininity and unwanted sexuality. The discussion brings these insights into dialogue with theories of fashion as communication and medium (Barnard, 1996; McLuhan, 1994), and gender performativity (Butler, 1988), reconsidering the power suit's agency as a paradoxical absence-presence of the sexualised female body. The conclusion reflects on implications for fashion design and for future research on gendered credibility in corporate dress codes.

MATERIALS AND METHODS: RESEARCHING EMPOWERMENT TROUGH THEORY AND LIVED EXPERIENCE

This paper forms part of a broader practice-led and practice-based doctoral research project through which the Art.D. degree was awarded at the Art Academy of Latvia, focusing on the power suit as a phenomenon at the intersection of fashion design, communication, and gendered leadership cultures. The research combines historical-theoretical analysis with empirical qualitative inquiry and design experimentation.

The empirical component discussed here is based on semi-structured, in-depth interviews with nineteen senior women leaders in Latvia. The respondents occupy top-level or upper-middle management positions in corporate and public sectors, as well as non-governmental organisations, including CEOs, board members, partners, and high-ranking public officials. All participants have long-term experience in representing their organisations in formal public and media contexts.

The interviews were designed as narrative conversations that invited participants to reflect on their personal trajectories, their experiences

of entering and inhabiting leadership roles, and their everyday practices of professional dressing. Particular attention was given to self-descriptions of everyday and "high-stakes" outfits (meetings, media appearances, negotiations), perceptions of the power suit and of suits more broadly, experiences of body-based judgement, objectification, or sexualisation in professional contexts, perceived "rules" and "lines" regarding acceptable or unacceptable femininity, and reflections on agency, comfort, discipline, and authenticity in dress choices.

Interviews were conducted in spring 2024. The interviews lasted approximately 60 minutes on average. With participants' consent, all interviews were audio-recorded and later transcribed verbatim. Transcripts were anonymized. Data were analysed using qualitative thematic analysis, combining inductive coding with theoretically informed sensitising concepts drawn from fashion studies and social theories. Initial coding focused on recurring words and phrases used by respondents to describe clothing, the body, and professional situations (e.g., "grown together with the suit", "comfort", "discipline"). In a second step, codes were grouped into broader themes such as the power suit as uniform and protective armour; the power suit as discipline and self-control; asymmetrical sanctions and gendered double standards in dress; negotiating visibility and sexualisation; gendered expectations; and the symbolic economy of trust and credibility.

The empirical findings are augmented by a historical-theoretical examination of the power suit, engaging scholarship on Western fashion history, sartorial cultures, and feminist critiques of expected female roles and their representation, including in the media (e.g., Entwistle, 2015; Church Gibson, 2001). Statistical data on women's representation in corporate leadership and heads-of-state roles in Europe and the United States are used illustratively to contextualise current developments[1].

In parallel with the analytical process, the practice-based fashion collection "What is Wrong with This Woman?" was developed as a research artefact. The collection functioned as a material and conceptual extension of the empirical findings, translating interview insights (codes) into sartorial forms that interrogate the tensions between discipline, visibility, embodiment, and the politics of professional self-presentation. Its creation provided an additional layer of practice-led inquiry, enabling

1 Women occupy 23.3% of management and 8.5% of top management positions in EU-27 companies as of 1 January 2025 (up from 12.4% and 3.4% in 2015). In the United States, women hold 29% of management roles and lead 11.6% of companies in 2024 (up from 17% and 4.8% in 2015). Globally, 25 countries have women heads of state in 2025, compared to 18 a decade earlier (European Institute for Gender Equality, 2024; McKinsey *Women in the Workplace,* 2024; Fortune, *Fortune 500 List,* 2025; UN Women, *Women in Politics Map, 2025*).

the research to explore how these themes manifest, resist, or transform when articulated through design.

RESULTS: WHAT EMERGES WHEN WOMEN ENTER THE SUIT

Historically, the emergence of the power suit for women is intertwined with broader struggles for political and economic citizenship. The late nineteenth-century suffrage movement not only fought for women's political rights but also reconfigured sartorial codes by incorporating trousers – a key element later associated with the power suit – as a symbolic instrument of emancipation (Young, 2011, 16–17). By adopting garments previously reserved for men, suffragists challenged the strict gender coding of dress and its role in maintaining social hierarchies.

In Latvia, similar dynamics unfolded in the interwar period. Cultural historian Ineta Lipša notes that public figures such as writer Jānis Akuraters described a "masculinisation" of women's appearance in the 1920s, commenting on "boyish" hairstyles, suits, ties, and even top hats as attempts by women to move closer to their "idol" – the man (Lipša, 2014, 200-215). Such commentary reveals both fascination and anxiety about shifting gender norms, already framing women's appropriation of masculine dress as symbolically loaded rather than merely practical (Fig. 3). The two World Wars functioned as catalysts for new images of



Fig. 3. Caricaturist Augusts Kalniņš's depiction of inverted gender roles in interwar Latvian visual culture, Sikspārnis, 1930

working women. While women were later pushed "back to the kitchen", their proven capacity to replace men in civilian jobs fostered both social reflection on gender equality and the emergence of the figure of the independent, working woman.

In the Soviet context, the power suit did not develop as a Western corporate symbol. Its form was shaped by controlled emancipation discourse, the state-constructed ideal of the socialist super-woman, the rejection of Western fashion as bourgeois, and strong pressure toward sartorial unification through centrally designed prototypes (e.g., Bartlett, 2010; Smeltere, 2019; Zitmane, 2016). Consequently, the Soviet woman's suit expressed collectivist, state-regulated identities rather than individual authority or corporate ambition.

The empirical material confirms that clothing and the body function as powerful communicative media. McLuhan's concept of clothing as an extension of the skin and the statement that "the medium is the message" suggest that the mere presence of a medium – its form and sensory organisation – has a stronger impact on human perception than its overt content (McLuhan, 1994, 7–21, 119). In this sense, the suit is not a neutral container for professional identity but an active medium that structures interaction and pre-configures interpretations of the wearer.

From Barnard's perspective, fashion and clothing can be understood as protheses: extensions or tools that are not "us" but which we attach to ourselves in order to perform social tasks (Barnard, 1996, 38-40). The "clothing prosthesis" helps produce microsocial order; it signals roles, hierarchies, and expectations. The interviews confirm this: respondents repeatedly describe the suit as a "uniform" that allows them to enter particular spaces, be taken seriously, and maintain control.

All nineteen interviewed leaders recognised the power suit as central to their professional wardrobe. Many described themselves as having "grown together" with the suit and could not imagine their everyday leadership without it. Respondents frequently described the suit as simultaneously comfortable and disciplining. It provides psychological security – "I know I look appropriate" – and bodily structure: "I hold myself differently in a suit". One leader called the suit "a door through which you enter the world of power built by men", highlighting both its facilitating and excluding dimensions.

Many respondents emphasised that the corporate environment is a "playing field in which you dress for what you are supposed to be". The suit is used to signal belonging to a specific leadership culture and to minimise the risk of being judged as unprofessional or "too feminine". As one interviewee put it, "It is clear they will take me more seriously if I

come to the meeting in a suit and not in a feminine dress. It is hypocrisy to say otherwise."

Participants described a persistent asymmetry in how men's and women's dress deviations are sanctioned. A male leader appearing in a T-shirt in a formal context would, in their view, be accepted more easily than a woman of the same hierarchical level making a similar choice. "He has to do much more stupid things to be criticised," one respondent observed. By contrast, women are subjected to a "mystical, undefined demand for being interesting" and to expectations of permanent youthfulness ("it feels like a woman must always be minus 15 years").

Almost all interviewees mentioned the challenge of navigating a sensitive, invisible boundary between acceptable femininity and "undesirable" sexuality in professional dress. This is policed not only in terms of visible body parts such as breasts but also through accessories, hairstyle, colour, and fit. As one respondent noted, "Clothing is a social contract not only about what we show but also about what we do not show." The responsibility for not "distracting the business partner, who in most cases is a man," is placed on women.

Some participants reflected on the risk that the multi-role woman – leader, mother, partner, "doing everything" – leaves her own body in neglect. Bodily care is framed as another task to be managed and controlled, risking both over-discipline (constant self-monitoring) and under-investment (exhaustion, burnout). The power suit can both mask and accentuate these tensions.



Fig. 4. Collage of media objectifications of women political leaders

The interviews resonate with media representations of prominent women politicians internationally. Geraldine Ferraro, the first woman nominated for US vice president in 1984, was famously described as a "size 6" candidate; Margaret Thatcher was characterised as a "low-heeled nanny"; Angela Merkel as a "German granny in baggy clothes"; Theresa May as the "best of Breastminster". More extreme cases include the inflatable rubber doll modelled on US vice-presidential candidate Sarah Palin in a "sexy" suit, or caricatures of Scottish First Minister Nicola Sturgeon focusing on her cleavage and literally inserting male politicians between her breasts (Fig. 4). These examples illustrate how body, age, and clothing become primary markers through which political subjectivity is negotiated. The Latvian case of Evika Siliņa confirms that sexualised and humiliating commentary can be mobilised rapidly in public discourse, reactivating latent patterns of gendered objectification to question women's political legitimacy.

DISCUSSION: THE AMBIVALENT AGENCY OF THE POWER SUIT

The findings support an interpretation of the power suit as a fundamentally ambivalent medium. On the one hand, it enables women to access spaces of authority and power that have been historically designed for suit-wearing men. It offers a recognisable code through which to signal seriousness, competence, and managerial readiness. Many respondents stress that women feel more confident and are taken more seriously when wearing a suit. In this sense, the power suit functions as a tool of empowerment and a practical strategy of survival in gendered institutions.

On the other hand, this empowerment is conditional and constrained. By putting on the suit, women conform to a masculine sartorial regime instead of reshaping it. The power suit expresses aspiration to power and authority while simultaneously affirming the norm that "the leader equals the man". It thus acts as a vehicle of conformity, masking the female body in a masculinised code to approximate a male template of credibility.

Butler's argument that those who fail to "do" their gender correctly are subject to regular punishment and sanction (Butler, 1988, 522) helps explain the fear of transgressing the "thin line" between acceptable and unacceptable femininity. The power suit offers a way to perform professionalism in a recognisable, low-risk manner. Yet the very need for such protective armour demonstrates that femininity remains

suspect in the field of power, and that the female body is always already a potential site of inappropriate sexuality.

From the perspective of social anthropology's interest in absence as a mode of agency (Frers, 2013), the power suit can be understood as a marker of the absent-present sexualised female body. The suit attempts to neutralise or conceal the body's "excess", but in doing so it paradoxically calls attention to the very sexuality it tries to erase. It signals that there is something underneath which must be controlled and kept out of sight; it becomes a sign of suppressed sexuality rather than its disappearance.

If we return to McLuhan's "medium is the message", the objectified female body emerges as a medium with stronger social resonance than the supposedly empowering suit. In essence, societal focus on women leaders' bodies overwrites the communicative intent of the power suit, replacing it with a message of sexualised embodiment. What takes place is a collision of two powerful media: the empowering suit and the objectified female body. In this collision, the latter often dominates public perception.

The interviews show that women leaders are acutely aware of this tension. They invest considerable cognitive and emotional effort in calibrating their outfits so as not to "provoke" misinterpretation, while also striving to maintain a sense of individuality and authenticity. This effort – largely invisible and unremunerated – is an additional tax on women's participation in leadership.

The concept of "gendered credibility" captures how trust and authority are unevenly distributed across genders. Women must often prove competence and loyalty more intensively than male colleagues, and their sartorial and bodily choices are more closely monitored and sanctioned. The preference of respondents' stakeholders for women in suits over women in dresses – particularly in high-stakes financial or political contexts – indicates that masculine-coded dress still functions as a shorthand for reliability.

In this sense, the power suit illuminates a deeper dilemma: the persistent demand that women choose between "productivity" (professional, public, rational) and "reproductivity" (bodily, maternal, sexual). Church Gibson argues that, in postmodernity, even when women sought to avoid self-exploitation and to contest dominant economic, social, and sexual orders, they often built their new values on old patriarchal constructions instead of creating entirely new ones (Gibson, 2001, 351-354). The adoption of the power suit can be read as such a move: an attempt to inhabit patriarchal codes more advantageously rather than to design alternative codes of authority.

The Latvian and international examples of sexist attacks on women politicians show how easily the figure of the "strong woman" is treated as an anomaly that can be ridiculed, sexualised, or delegitimised. The power suit alone cannot shield women from such attacks; indeed, it can be reinterpreted as evidence of "unnatural" ambition or as a garment that hides alleged bodily flaws. The medium remains vulnerable to hostile re-signification.

CONCLUSION

This paper has reinterpreted the agency of the power suit in the context of fashion communication and women's leadership, using a combination of theoretical analysis and empirical insights from interviews with nineteen senior women leaders in Latvia.

First, the historical overview demonstrated that the power suit is rooted in both women's struggles for political and economic rights.

Second, the study confirmed that clothing and the body are not neutral coverings but active media that structure social interaction, shape perceptions, and create microsocial order. The power suit is a particularly charged medium because it combines a masculinised form with a female body that is culturally constructed as sexualised.

Third, the empirical material revealed how women leaders experience the power suit as both comfort and discipline, as a "door" into male-constructed worlds of power and as a constraint that demands conformity and constant self-monitoring. Respondents described asymmetrical sanctions for dress deviations, which translate into intensified expectations placed on their bodies and the additional burden of regulating male desire through careful calibration of appearance.

Fourth, the analysis argued that the power suit functions as a paradoxical absence-presence of the sexualised female body. By attempting to neutralise sexuality, it simultaneously signals its potential and activates latent objectification. In collisions between the empowering message of the suit and the persistent cultural medium of the objectified female body, the latter often dominates, as illustrated by sexist media treatment of women politicians in Latvia and globally.

Overall, the power suit emerges as an ambivalent sartorial technology: it empowers women to enter and navigate spaces of authority while also reproducing gendered hierarchies and credibility gaps. Rather than resolving tensions between femininity and power, it makes visible



Fig. 5. From the "Male Gaze" section of the collection "What Is Wrong With This Woman"? illustrating the unsuccessful attempts to conceal the female body within the suit

the unresolved demand that women choose between "productivity" and "reproductivity".

To foreground these tensions in a material, practice-based form, the fashion collection "What Is Wrong With This Woman?", developed as part of the doctoral research, exposes the disciplinary structures embedded in the power suit and visualises the contradictions women navigate between visibility, credibility, and bodily regulation. (Fig. 5)

Future research could further explore how alternative sartorial codes – beyond the masculinised suit – might be designed and legitimised as credible forms of femininity in leadership. Practice-driven fashion research and collaboration with women leaders could help prototype new visual languages of authority that neither deny the female body nor submit it to renewed regimes of control. Additionally, comparative studies between different cultural and organisational contexts could illuminate how local histories and norms shape the meanings and uses of the power suit, and how transnational discourses of empowerment interact with enduring structures of gendered credibility.

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ARTIST OR TEACHER? THE ART ACADEMY OF LATVIA AND DRAWING PEDAGOGY IN THE 1920s AND 1930s

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ABSTRACT

Since its founding in 1919 and opening in 1921, the Art Academy of Latvia has played a significant role not only in the academic education of artists, but also in the training and accreditation of drawing teachers in general education schools. The creation and implementation of the teaching programme was entrusted to the sculptor and teacher Gustavs Šķilters, who taught it from 1923 to 1932.

The myth of artists driven by inspiration, of creative personalities detached from the problems of real life, often clashed with the need for financial stability during the interwar period, so many of those academy diplomas read "artist painter" worked as teachers in Riga and elsewhere in Latvia. At the end of the 1930s, as the economic situation stabilized, the view began to prevail that working in a school stifled creativity and was therefore not a suitable occupation for an artist. The period from the founding of the academy was also marked by discussions about the need for an art academy and its role in the professional training of not only artists but also drawing teachers.

Keywords: education, drawing education, Latvian Academy of Art. Latvia, interwar period

INTRODUCTION

Art education encompasses both theoretical and practical knowledge – this is an axiom. However, what qualities and skills should drawing teachers possess when their pupils are students of general education schools? Are pedagogical competencies more important than artistic skills and education, or vice versa? Should a drawing teacher also be an artist? These seemingly simple questions reveal a broad range of issues which, when examined within the period addressed in this study, make

it impossible to ignore the contribution of the Art Academy of Latvia to the training of drawing teachers.

From its founding, one of the Academy's objectives was not only to provide artists with academic education but also to equip graduates with pedagogical skills and knowledge enabling them to work in general education schools and teach art-related subjects, including drawing. Alongside the public debates of the 1920s concerning the necessity and usefulness of an art academy as a forge for professional artists, efforts were underway to formalise the certification of art teachers and to establish a pedagogical programme within the Academy as part of its theoretical curriculum. (See: Pelše, 2023)

DRAWING TEACHERS AND THE ART ACADEMY: CROSSFIRE OF OPINIONS

The issue of training drawing teachers had already become topical in the mid-19th century when drawing was introduced as a foundational subject in the real schools of the Russian Empire. At the institutional level, this process was overseen by the Imperial Academy of Arts in St. Petersburg, which certified candidates' eligibility to hold teaching positions at various levels of educational institutions. In Latvia, two art education institutions functioned as intermediaries between the Academy and the profession, both operating under statutes approved by higher authorities: the private drawing school opened in 1873 by Elise von Jung-Stilling (1829–1904), and the drawing and painting school founded in 1895 by Weniamin Bluhm (1861–1920). In 1906, the drawing school founded by Elise von Jung-Stilling was taken over by the City of Riga and, with the permission of the Imperial Academy of Arts in St. Petersburg, reorganised as the Riga City Art School. (see: Ābele 2014, 35–41) After the initial years marked by stagnation and decline, the leadership of the school was assumed in 1909 by the painter Vilhelms Purvītis (1872–1945). Within a few years, art critics and observers of local cultural life expressed admiration in the press for the works produced by students at the school's annual exhibitions. Even more encouraging were the successes achieved at exhibitions organised by the Imperial Academy of Arts in St. Petersburg. (Rīgas mākslas skolas (V. Purvīša direkcija) skolnieku darbi 1911) Purvītis' decision to invite Jānis Roberts Tillbergs (1880–1972) to join the teaching staff ensured a further rise in the level of students' artistic mastery, and tangible results followed quickly: in 1914, works submitted by the Riga City Art School were recognised as the best among those exhibited in St. Petersburg Academy. (R 1914)

As the institution's activities became more firmly established, plans emerged to transform it into an art academy that would also oversee all matters related to art education. Although the city authorities allocated substantial financial resources for this purpose, including funds for the construction of a new building suitable for a higher art education institution, the outbreak of the First World War interrupted these plans and the preparatory work already underway. (see: Ābele 2014, 121)

Upon the end of the war, the subsequent two years were marked by political instability during which power changed hands repeatedly and several governments succeeded one another. Despite these circumstances, the establishment of an art academy remained on the political agenda. Attention was directed not only to the training of professional artists but also towards the development of art pedagogy. Once the political situation stabilised, efforts were put in to construct an education system encompassing all levels, from pre-school education to higher education. (Institūta gaitas 1928, 3) In the early 1920s, discussions concerning the necessity of establishing a higher art education institution in Latvia intensified and often took on a polemical character. Artists themselves actively participated in these debates, expressing sharply divergent views. Critics reproached the haste with which decisions were being made and voiced suspicions that bureaucracy and the institutionalisation of art would stifle creativity. (Ministru prezidentam, Izglītības un Rūpniecības ministru kungiem 1921) Notably, several figures who later became lecturers at the Art Academy of Latvia initially doubted the need for such an institution. Among them were Kārlis Miesnieks (1887–1977), Kārlis Brencēns (1879–1951), Burkards Dzenis (1879–1966), and Ludolfs Liberts (1895–1959). The most vocal opponent in later years was Romans Suta (1896–1944) who, despite his scepticism, acknowledged in a January 1920 meeting of the Graphic Subsection of the Art Section of the Pedagogical Committee of the Ministry of Education that provision should be made for the establishment of a specialised department of art pedagogy within the envisaged State Art Academy. (LNA_LVVA_6637_1_457. l, 1-2)

Already the following year, however, Suta adopted a more radical stance, declaring that Latvia had no need for an academy and that the younger generation should be trained in private or state workshops, following the model of Renaissance-era art education. (Sutta 1921) In the second half of the 1920s, the economic crisis reignited doubts regarding the Academy's existence, with drawing teachers frequently invoked as a central argument in these discussions. Suta repeatedly articulated his views in the newspaper *Pēdējā Brīdī*, asserting that the Academy's artistic and educational significance was minimal, as evidenced by student

exhibitions. He argued that Academy instructors were artists rather than trained pedagogues, each approaching teaching according to their personal temperaments. In his view, the Academy merely produced educated unemployed individuals who burdened state institutions and society, as only a small minority could secure positions as drawing teachers, while the majority earned less than the support provided to the unemployed. (Suta 1929a) Suta further claimed that, given school curricula and requirements, academic education was not necessary for drawing teachers and that a small specialised school of two to three classes would suffice to train such professionals. His proposals included abolishing the Academy idea altogether and replacing it with a more modest institution, where the most talented would become artists and the less gifted, teachers. (Suta 1929b) The articles published by Suta provoked a broad public debate that extended over several issues of the newspaper and attracted responses from other prominent artists. Niklāvs Strunke (1894–1966) supported the claim that Latvia had an excessive number of painters, sculptors, and drawing teachers, while professionals in applied arts were in short supply. (Vaj mākslas akadēmija 1929) Although some of the opinions expressed were coloured by professional rivalry, the discussion also revealed well-founded criticisms that had previously circulated primarily in private conversations among artists and educators. The debate highlighted the place of drawing within the school curriculum and exposed problems related both to teacher training and availability. Arguments concerning the overproduction of drawing teachers were applicable mainly to Riga and other major cities. In rural areas, by contrast, schools often struggled to recruit specialised drawing teachers. During the 1921/1922 academic year, there were still 318 rural schools staffed by a single teacher and 923 with only two teachers. (Broka 1922) Despite efforts to avoid combined classes, such arrangements persisted, particularly in Latgale, due to a lack of facilities and the small number of pupils. The shortage of qualified art teachers meant that drawing and music were frequently omitted from school curricula altogether. (Plotnieks 1929)

In defending the Art Academy, its proponents increasingly emphasised the preparation of teachers as employment in schools provided a vital source of income for many artists during periods of rising unemployment. At a session of the Saeima's budget commission, the educator and politician Kārlis Dēķens (1866–1942) fiercly opposed proposals to close the Academy, arguing that the Academy's mission was to train drawing teachers and thereby alleviate artists' economic insecurity. (Viens jauns 1929)

The debate also brought to light several thematic areas that had previously received little public attention. One of these concerned the

significance of drawing as a school subject within the broader educational process. In public opinion, drawing was still often regarded as a non-essential subject, not necessarily to be included among compulsory courses, and its advocates seldom emphasised its role in the aesthetic education of pupils. The question why, in many schools where drawing teachers with academic training were employed, drawing and painting were not utilised as means of aesthetic education, was directed primarily at the Art Academy of Latvia, even though its first graduates received their diplomas only in 1925. (Mīlgrāvis 1934) The assertion that it was insufficient for a drawing teacher merely to master their craft, and that as an artist they must also be a genuine pedagogue capable of employing art as an instrument of aesthetic education, retained its relevance in subsequent years. This issue remained topical as pedagogical subjects continued to be taught at the Academy and the training of drawing teachers persisted throughout the interwar period. The debate thus reinforced the view that artistic competence alone was inadequate without pedagogical awareness and commitment to educational objectives.

THEORETICAL PEDAGOGICAL COURSES AT THE ART ACADEMY OF LATVIA

Systematic and purposeful work toward the establishment of the Art Academy of Latvia began in the mid-1920s. This process involved the search for suitable premises, the identification and recruitment of teaching staff – including the artists who had remained in Russia – the planning of the study process, and the drafting of curricula. Taking into account Latvia's specific circumstances, it was decided that applied arts should also be taught at the Academy, that instruction should take place both in master workshops and in general drawing and painting classes, and that a separate course for the training of teachers should be established. (LNA_LVA_485_2_215, 37–38) The curriculum was designed to encompass both practical subjects and theoretical knowledge. The theoretical courses, referred to at the time as the 'scientific courses', included anatomy, art history, theory of styles, cultural and literary history, colour theory and painting techniques, general technology, physics, chemistry, mathematics, and foreign languages (German and French), alongside the pedagogical subjects. (LNA_LVA_485_2_44, 38–42) The first cohort of applicants was admitted in the autumn of 1921. Owing to the post-war situation, the student body was highly heterogeneous, comprising both young people who had only recently completed primary school and

individuals with prior experience gained in Russian art schools. Studies could be pursued either as full-time students or as auditors.

By the summer of 1925, the Art Academy of Latvia was preparing to graduate its first cohort of students, many of whom had already possessed prior artistic training upon admission. Consequently, the issue of graduates' professional rights became increasingly pressing. At a meeting of the Academy Council on 20 June 1924, it was decided that graduates of the Academy would, in addition to the professional qualifications of painter, sculptor, or applied arts specialist, be entitled to teach visual and applied arts subjects at educational institutions of all levels. Furthermore, graduates were permitted to teach other principal specialised subjects included in the Academy's curriculum at secondary and vocational schools. Students in the lower courses who had completed life drawing classes and passed the required specialised and compulsory subjects, together with the pedagogical course, were granted the right to teach visual and applied arts subjects at secondary and vocational schools without holding a higher education degree. (LNA_LVA_485_2_44, 38–42) Third-year students who had completed the relevant specialised and compulsory subjects were authorised to teach art subjects in primary schools. In order to be recognised as fully qualified drawing teachers, Academy graduates were additionally required to complete one year of practice in evening drawing courses, as well as one year of successful teaching practice in a school environment. (LNA_LVVA_6637_1_21, 15)

In 1928, the 'Regulations on the Rights of Graduates of the Art Academy' were published in the official gazette *Valdības Vēstnesis*. These regulations formally confirmed the rights of Academy graduates who had completed their studies and received diplomas to serve as teaching staff in visual and applied arts subjects at educational institutions of all levels. In secondary and vocational schools, graduates were also entitled to teach other specialised subjects included in the Academy's disciplinary programmemes. Graduates who sought to obtain the status of fully qualified teachers in secondary, vocational, or primary schools were required to complete the compulsory pedagogical subjects prescribed by the Academy. Upon fulfilling these requirements, they were recognised as fully qualified teachers with higher education in their respective specialisations. Students of the master workshops who had completed all compulsory and specialised subjects, as well as life drawing classes in painting and drawing, were granted the right to teach visual and applied arts subjects at all educational institutions without holding a higher education degree. Those who had completed the Academy's plaster and live model drawing classes, head painting classes, and all specialised and

compulsory subjects – including pedagogical courses – were authorised to teach visual and applied arts subjects in primary schools. (Noteikumi 1928) These regulations increasingly consolidated the role of professional artists in drawing pedagogy within general education schools. Contemporary policy statements emphasised that, in both urban and rural primary schools, art subjects should gradually be entrusted to specialists – artists trained for pedagogical work – whose employment conditions would be aligned with those of teachers of other subjects, including a standardised number of teaching hours in drawing, calligraphy, handicrafts, and class supervision. (LNA_LVA_485_2_378, 122)

In 1924, the Art Academy of Latvia invited the artist Gustavs Šķilters (1874–1954), who had recently returned from Soviet Russia, to develop the programme of pedagogical subjects. Since 1905, Šķilters had taught at the Stieglitz Central School of Technical Drawing in St. Petersburg. Alongside his creative work, Šķilters became the principal author and lecturer of the Academy's art pedagogy programme, including drawing methodology, a position he held until 1932. [Fig. 1] From 1926 to 1929,

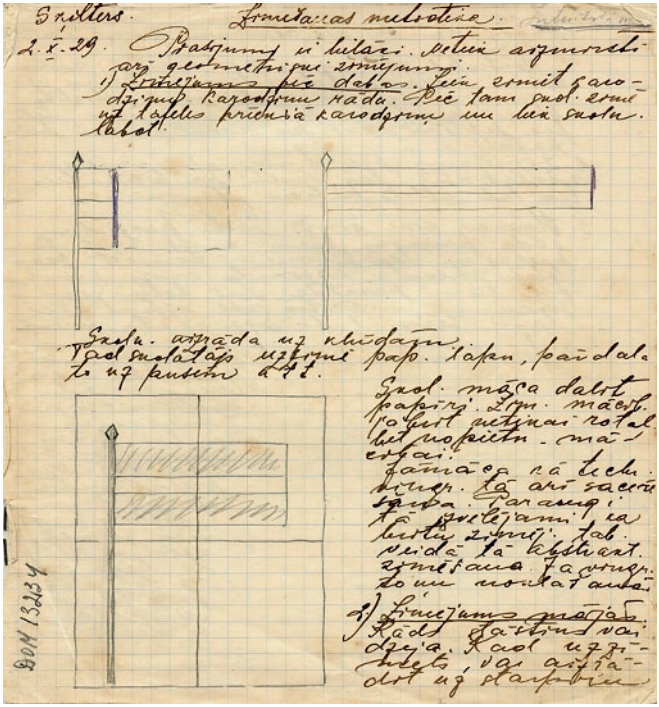


Fig. 1. Page from the manuscript Drawing Methodology by Gustavs Šķilters. Daugava Museum

he also taught drawing methodology at the Jelgava Teachers' Institute, and after 1937 at the Latvian People's University.

In the early 1920s, drawing methodology was the sole pedagogical subject taught at the Academy and comprised two lectures and twelve practical sessions delivered by a single lecturer. Over time, the curriculum expanded, and by 1925 it included child-and-adolescent psychology, aesthetics, and pedagogy. These subjects continued to be taught exclusively by Šķilters. In 1929, the Ministry of Education mandated that the history of pedagogy, general pedagogy, the psychology of adolescents and youth, and general aesthetics be compulsory subjects at the Academy. Following the introduction of these requirements, the Academy received numerous applications from former students seeking re-enrolment in order to complete pedagogical subjects that had not been offered during their initial period of study but had since become necessary for obtaining teaching certification. In 1931, Šķilters proposed the establishment of an evening school affiliated with the Academy, where Academy students who were preparing to become drawing teachers could practise teaching and observe classes. His own pedagogical experience underscored the necessity of practical training, and a few years later the Ministry of Education made a two-year pedagogical practice a mandatory requirement for obtaining full teaching rights. In 1936, in response to the Ministry's regulations, the Academy resolved that, upon completion of the theoretical pedagogical courses, graduates would be permitted to undertake one year of teaching practice in evening drawing courses. This opportunity was also extended to graduates of higher education institutions who had previously completed courses in drawing methodology. The Art Academy of Latvia petitioned the Ministry of Education to recognise its pedagogical courses as equivalent to the years of work completed by teacher-trainees and to take these courses into account when assessing candidates for positions as drawing and art history teachers. (LNA_LVA_485_2_433, 25–74)

From the late 1920s onward, particularly during periods of economic crisis and discussions of higher education budgets, the question of the Academy's purposefulness was repeatedly raised. At a January 1932 meeting, the senior lecturer Gustavs Šķilters was informed that, due to budgetary reductions, his position would be abolished in the forthcoming fiscal year. Šķilters declined the offer of a lower-paid lecturer position, after which a public competition for the vacant post was announced. (LNA_LVA_485_2_324, 13) The true reasons for Šķilters' dismissal require further research. Soon thereafter, the Academy acknowledged that it was not feasible for a single lecturer to teach all pedagogical subjects,

necessitating the appointment of several specialist lecturers responsible for related groups of subjects. (LNA_LVA_485_2_324, 13) Following the reorganisation of the pedagogical programme, three lecturers were appointed to replace Šķilters. Courses in aesthetics and pedagogical psychology were entrusted to Jānis Siliņš (1896–1991), while the history of pedagogy and general pedagogy were assigned to Milda Liepiņa (1902–1991). Drawing methodology was taught by Kārlis Brencēns. (LNA_LVA_485_2_378, 163) In 1936, the artist Jānis Aleksandrs Ērglis (1891–1964) was appointed as an external lecturer in place of Brencēns. A graduate of the Stieglitz School, Ērglis had worked as a teacher of drawing, art history, and technical drawing at Riga Second State Gymnasium and at the Riga Teachers' Institute, where he also taught drawing methodology. (LNA_LVA_485_2_433, 25–74)

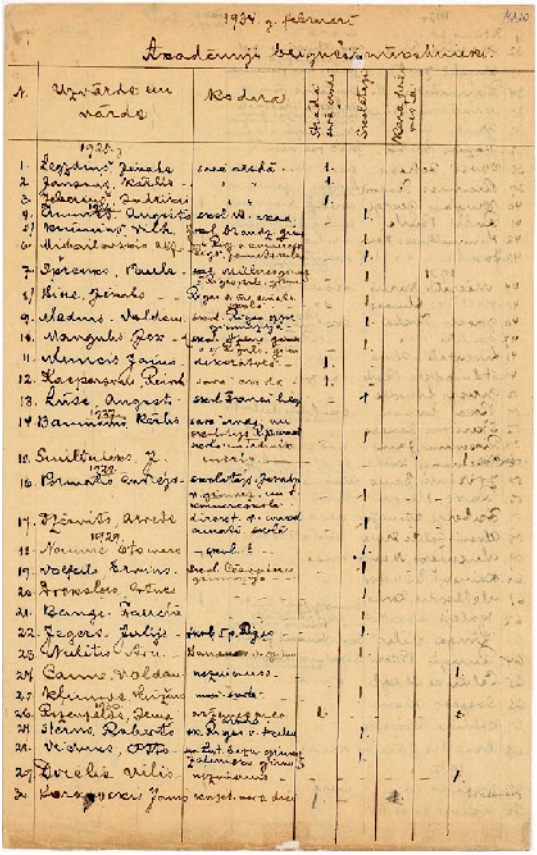


Fig. 2. Artists Graduated from the Art Academy of Latvia. Page from a list. LNMM ZDC

The interwar myth of the artist as a figure guided solely by inspiration and detached from the practical concerns of everyday life, frequently collided with the need for financial security. Consequently, many graduates whose Academy certificates designated them as 'painter-artists' or 'sculptor-artists' found employment as teachers in Riga and elsewhere in Latvia. In 1934, after several graduating classes had already completed their studies, and as debates concerning the place of art in schools once again intensified, an attempt was made to compile data on graduates' professional trajectories. Of 132 graduates, 13 were serving in the military, 14 had not yet begun professional employment, and 55 were working as teachers. [Fig. 2.] Thirty-two graduates were employed in their artistic professions, working in painting, as theatre decorators or scenographers, or in industrial enterprises. (LNA_LNMM ZDC-MP_178, 1–23) This overview of graduates' employment led to the conclusion that, aside from the widespread positions of drawing and art history teachers, sculptors were those most consistently able to find work within their professional field. (Jūrasteters 1939)

By the late 1930s, as the economic situation gradually stabilised, an increasingly prevalent view held that employment in schools stifled artistic creativity and was therefore an unsuitable occupation for artists. (Bērziņš 1944) This shift in attitude marked a significant change compared to that of earlier years when teaching had often been regarded as a vital means of financial survival for artists.

ACCREDITATION OF DRAWING TEACHERS

Following the establishment of the Republic of Latvia, a broader range of individuals became involved in art pedagogy. This included those who had obtained the right to teach drawing during the previous political period, as well as individuals who had acquired practical skills through school-based experience or independent study. The Ministry of Education emerged as the central state authority responsible for the administration and supervision of education and science. In order to involve professionals from the field, the Ministry established a system of hierarchically subordinate committees and boards responsible for specific areas. In January 1920, the Graphic Subsection of the Art Section of the Pedagogical Committee was formed under the auspices of the Ministry of Education, with the task of developing art curricula and defining educational objectives for schools. Its membership included both artists and educators. (LNA_LVVA_6637_1_457, 1–2) In 1921, the Ministry of Education established a commission for the certification of secondary

school teachers. The commission was authorised to grant full teaching rights to individuals holding higher education and possessing theoretical and practical knowledge of pedagogy, as well as to those who had obtained teaching qualifications in pedagogical institutions of Imperial Russia or who had completed specialised teacher-training courses and demonstrated several years of successful teaching experience. (Staris, Ūsiņš 2000, 145) Although the Art Academy of Latvia was not the only institution responsible for training drawing teachers for general education schools, the Ministry of Education delegated to it a supervisory role in this process. It was stipulated that, should other educational institutions be granted similar rights to certify their graduates, such certification could be issued only with the consent of the Art Academy as the Academy imposed particularly high standards on its students. (LNA_LVA_485_2_44, 38–42)

The Ministry of Education also coordinated the development of curricula, designating drawing as a compulsory subject. It repeatedly emphasised the need to ensure high-quality instruction, noting that art occupied a marginal position in schools due to the limited number of drawing lessons, inconsistencies in teaching methods, and shortcomings in teacher preparation. (Dombrovskis 1924) In the early years of the Republic, the rapid growth in the number of general secondary schools created an urgent demand for appropriately trained teachers. In the absence of a fully developed system for preparing secondary school teachers, these institutions initially employed students or graduates of seminars, institutes, and other secondary educational establishments. From its earliest years, the Art Academy also assumed responsibility for the accreditation of drawing teachers.

In addition to certifying the equivalence of prior education, the Academy was entrusted with administering examinations for secondary school teachers seeking certification in drawing. These examinations included drawing and painting still-life compositions and drawing from the live model and were conducted over three days with six hours allotted each day. An examination commission was established at the Art Academy under the chairmanship of Jānis Roberts Tillbergs, with its members including Rihards Zariņš (1869–1939), Gustavs Šķilters, and Kārlis Miesnieks (1887–1977). Candidates were required to supply their own paper, paints, and drawing materials and to cover the costs of the model. In the late 1920s, the Ministry assumed responsibility for these expenses, and the commission was chaired by Jānis Kuga (1878–1969), joined by Šķilters, Miesnieks, and Eduards Kalniņš (1904–1988). (LNA_LVA_485_2_244, 49)

The Academy's intention to strengthen its position in the field of drawing pedagogy was further evidenced by its appeal to the Minister of Education to establish the post of inspector for aesthetic education within the field of visual arts. This official would be responsible for overseeing the teaching of art subjects and the instruction of drawing in all schools. The Academy proposed that candidates for this post be selected by the Art Academy in consultation with the Ministry of Education. It was also suggested that the Academy host annual exhibitions of the best pupils' works from schools throughout the country, thereby enabling systematic evaluation of students' achievements in drawing and visual arts. In addition, the Academy Council resolved to petition the Minister of Education to regulate the teaching of art subjects in rural primary schools. According to the Council, such subjects should be taught exclusively by specialists trained in the field, thereby ensuring a consistent level of professional competence in art education across the country. (Dibinās 1934)

CONCLUSION

Following the establishment of the Republic of Latvia, art subjects, including drawing, were assigned a defined place within the curricula of general education schools. However, a persistent shortage of qualified teachers significantly affected the quality and scope of instruction. In the early 1920s, the professional preparation of drawing teachers took place in various institutes and courses, but , by the mid-1930s, with the development of higher education and the consolidation of the Art Academy of Latvia, only individuals with higher education were permitted to work as fully qualified drawing teachers.

The notion of an art academy as merely an incubator of creative personalities who would pursue exclusively artistic self-expression fails to capture the full range of opportunities offered by the Academy during the interwar period. From its inception, the Academy's statutes defined the training of drawing teachers for general education schools as one of its core missions.

Pedagogical subjects constituted an integral part of the Academy's theoretical curriculum, and, when combined with supervised teaching practice, conferred the right to teach art subjects in schools. Gustavs Šķilters' contribution to the development and implementation of the pedagogical programmeme was particularly significant as he laid the foundations for art pedagogy at an academic level. Despite various challenges, the Art Academy consistently trained drawing teachers throughout the entire interwar period.

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HISTORY AS MYTH AND MYTH AS HISTORY. IDEOLOGICAL ASPECTS OF DEBATES REGARDING LATVIAN ART HISTORY CURRICULA IN THE 1950S

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the impact of Soviet ideology on the development of Latvian visual art history curricula during the 1950s. The paper is based on the premise that myths in Soviet culture served not only as a propaganda tool but also as a way to structure knowledge, defining the interpretive boundaries of art history. Through a comparative analysis of two curricula developed at the Art Academy of Latvia, one from 1953 and another from 1957, the paper assesses the scholarly output of the Department of Art History for whom these programmemes represented a primary research objective. Drawing on primary sources from the National Archives of Latvia, specifically from the protocols of the Academy Council and the Department of Art History meetings, the paper explores the ideological influence on both programmes and whether discursive changes were observed following the end of the Stalinist ideology. Myth is seen to act as a structural framework that shapes historical narratives to legitimize and justify different ideological interpretations while marginalizing others.

Keywords: Art history curriculum, Marxism-Leninism, Art Academy of Latvia, 1950s

INTRODUCTION

The writing of art history cannot be considered a completely neutral or objective process. It is inevitably linked to certain political, institutional, and cultural developments that determine both the direction of research and the dominant interpretive paradigms. In the context of totalitarian regimes, this interaction becomes particularly noticeable,

as education is subjected to ideological control and used as means to spread a certain worldview among the general public.

In the Soviet Union, art was given a specific role from the very start of the Bolshevik Revolution. It was highlighted that art had the ability to influence collective consciousness, design a "new type of human", and consequently reconstruct societal thought patterns (Undusk, 2016, 39). Art was used as an ideological weapon in the struggle for the "correct" reality. Therefore, art history was also subjected to stern control; its objective was not to record the art of the past chronologically, but to compose a specific view that fit with the Marxist-Leninist doctrine. The dominant belief system of the time had a significant influence on the formation of the art history narrative, where artistic values had to be consistent with ideology.

This paper aims to evaluate how Soviet ideological beliefs influenced the development of Latvian visual art history curricula during the 1950s, exploring how myths were used in the interpretation of history and at the Art Academy, an institution of higher education for artists. The theoretical basis of the research emphasizes the role of myth and ideology, while the subsequent analysis introduces a comparative approach for determining textual inconsistencies between the 1953 and 1957 curricula.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

The empirical basis of this paper is Fund 442 of the Art Academy of Latvia, which is housed at the Latvian State Archives. This fund consists of the protocols of the Academy Council and the Department of Art History. These materials reveal the discussions surrounding the creation and alterations of the Latvian visual art history curricula.

The research employs qualitative document analysis, combining historical, discursive, and comparative methods of study. The focal point of analysis is the use of ideological forms and approaches, the periodization of history, the construction of narratives, the rules applicable in the selection of empirical material, and the methods of criticism and self-censorship in academic discourse. To interpret the collected data, the concept of myth is utilized as a theoretical instrument, recognized as a structure that organizes the understanding of reality and frames collective understanding of the past.

RESULTS

In the Art Academy's research plan for the academic year 1950/1951, the creation of a study course for Latvian visual art history was already

designated as the main research work (LNA-LVA, 442–3–56, 1). However, the implementation of this assignment had several disadvantages. The lack of an officially accepted periodization of Latvian history was a significant challenge. Until 1952, there was no unified or ideologically accepted historical framework within which a timeline for Latvian art history could be created (LNA-LVA, 442–3–59, 2). The development of the historical timeline allowed for the systematization of the curriculum in accordance with the Marxist-Leninist understanding of history. Additionally, the situation was complicated by the frequent turnover of staff in the Department of Art History. The department consisted of only two permanent staff positions (LNA-LVA, 442–3–66, 27), while other lecturers were working on an hourly rate and, as a result, were not officially obligated to participate in the development of the Latvian visual art history curriculum.

The Council of the Art Academy acknowledged that creating the visual art history programme would be a thorough and time-consuming process (LNA-LVA, 442–3–66, 61), and that it needed a systematic way of research and a broad source base. Yet, the work continued to be mandatory, the deadlines were set, disregarding the fact that they rarely aligned with the actual pace of research. However, some practical ideas were offered, for example, it was suggested that initial findings could be published as individual articles or brochures (LNA-LVA, 442–3–66, 61), and thus slowly setting groundwork for a more extensive and detailed history of Latvian art.

DISCUSSIONS REGARDING THE 1953 CURRICULUM

During the debates on the content of the curriculum created by the art historian Miķelis Ivanovs in 1953, there was a conceptually significant issue regarding the determination of the starting point for the story of Latvian art history and whether it should include Latvian folk art. There was a unanimous consensus to exclude the Mesolithic and Neolithic periods from the curriculum because of the argument that an insufficient number of artistic artifacts had survived from these periods (LNA-LVA, 442–3–79, 39). One proposal suggested starting the programme with the period of Latvian tribe formation, from which more tangible examples of cultural and folk art remained and, therefore, the research of folk art should extend into the feudal period (LNA-LVA, 442–3–79, 39).

However, the feudal era proved to be one of the most problematic sections of the programmeme, both in terms of structure and interpretation. Critics noted that the description of this period was one-sided,

viewed mostly through the lens of German cultural dominance (LNA-LVA, 442–3–79, 39). It was related to the assumption that Latvian folk culture had been suppressed by the Germans, and this resulted in limited opportunities for full artistic expression. Because of that, the primary manifestations of folk art were associated with craftsmanship and the applied decorative arts. This emphasis on foreign art raised objections about the structural balance of the curriculum: if Romanesque, Gothic, and Baroque art were analysed in sufficient detail, then folk art deserved equally thorough coverage in the programme.

Other proposals included integrating the feudal period with the capitalism development stage as it was the time when the first professional Latvian artists emerged. In addition, those who contributed to the discussion argued that such consolidation would allow the curriculum to cover a broader horizon in its overview of Latvian artists and mitigate an excessive focus on German culture (LNA-LVA, 442–3–79, 39).

Initially, the excessive amount of historical material dominated in the programmeme. In this way, the curriculum was predominantly historical in nature, which prevented in-depth analysis of art processes. The participants of the discussion agreed that the art history programme should mainly focus on the 19th century, as this period was considered particularly significant in the development of Latvian national art (LNA-LVA, 442–3–79, 40). Regarding Soviet-era art, the necessity of focusing on the "unmasking of reactionary ideas" and the analysis of socialist realism as the only "correct" path for artistic development was underscored (Konstante, 2017, 326). The content of the curriculum played a significant role in the creation and consolidation of an ideologically correct methodology. Associate Professor Brodsky from Moscow pointed out that by reducing the general historical overview, the programme could expand its coverage of Marxism-Leninism and emphasize the role of art criticism as a tool for ideological education (LNA-LVA, 442–3–79, 40). He cited Joseph Stalin's work "Marxism and Problems of Linguistics" as a methodologically and politically significant example, underlining its importance in forming a correct ideological interpretation. There was a general consensus to avoid excessive generalization and base the curriculum on specific examples of artists and works of art because this would allow for a more effective control over the direction of art interpretation.

Soviet cultural policy used criticism to teach and shape the ideological worldview of young artists. The goal was to create a unified value system that conformed to the state ideology, using criticism and self-criticism to monitor the creative process and identify any deviations from the

doctrine of socialist realism (Konstante, 2017, 289). In this setting, criticism was not used as a means of improving artistic quality or promoting professional discussion, but as a political tool to ensure that education itself and the way people interpret art were in line with Soviet ideology.

The discussion of the curriculum also revealed specific boundaries when it came to the selection of artists. The main goal was to dismiss those artists who had emigrated or whose artworks did not align with Marxist-Leninist ideology. This is clearly illustrated by the question posed by Professor Kārlis Zemdega: should artists such as Jānis Kuga, Eduards Dzenis, or Sigismunds Vidbergs be mentioned in the Latvian art history curriculum, given that they lived outside the Soviet Union? (LNA-LVA, 442–3–79, 40) This issue was not resolved immediately but was postponed, indicating the need to consult with political leadership.

DISCUSSIONS REGARDING THE 1957 CURRICULUM

The development of the curriculum illustrates an institution-related problem of the period. One person could not compile such an extensive and ideologically complicated programme by themselves. Miķelis Ivanovs, the author of the first draft, had constantly underlined the excessive scope and methodological complexity of the task. At first, the plan was to involve a broader collective of authors in drafting the programme, including practising artists (LNA-LVA, 442–3–66, 61). However, this plan was only partially realized. Primarily, the responsibility fell on the Department of Art History, but their resources were already limited to do the task. Shortly after the first discussions, Miķelis Ivanovs himself was barely involved in refining the programme.

This task was taken up by the new head of the Department of Art History, Rasma Lāce (LNA-LVA, 442–3–128, 41), who accurately took into account the criticism that had emerged in previous discussions and created a new programme. The development of the curriculum took a long time, and it culminated in a more manageable task in terms of its methodologies, as it would focus on a study of 19th-century Latvian art history. Miķelis Ivanovs noted that this was both necessary and, at the same time, highly problematic, but Rasma Lāce, on the other hand, emphasized that the late 19th century represented a very promising area of research (LNA-LVA, 442–3–81, 3). The establishment of the Latvian professional school of art was particularly accentuated here.

The draft for the new curriculum identified the need to avoid a fragmented view of individual educational institutions and instead created a structure based on progressive stages of historical development. This

allowed for a better connection between artistic processes and broader socio-political frameworks. This also led to the establishment of a foundation consisting of three consecutive stages of artistic evolution.

The first stage (c. 1850–1870) was characterized as a period of formation of the Latvian people and national culture (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 6). In this framework, the curriculum focused on the social and historical circumstances that influenced the development of Latvian fine arts, positioning the formation of independent national arts as a direct by-product of the national liberation movements of the mid-19th century. Special attention was paid to the significance of St. Petersburg Academy of Arts (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 11). The academy was positioned as the first educational institution for the first Latvian artists; the school's significance in their professional development and creative work was especially highlighted. This narrative aimed to show that these pioneering artists interacted with both the national bourgeois social movement of the 1860s–1870s and progressive Russian culture, which left its mark on their artwork. This stage highlighted artists such as Oto Bērtiņš, Jānis Staņislavs Roze, Kārlis Hūns, and Jūlijs Feders (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 10), while maintaining a clear distinction from the previous period, which was clearly defined in a separate introductory section. The first stage was mainly organized by the genre, with a focus on painting and graphic art as the most significant fields, while noting that sculpture was not yet fully represented in this period.

For the second stage, the focus was on the 1890s (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 8). This period was described as a flourishing time for Latvian realist art. However, this chronological frame carried a distinct ideological stance, emphasizing the emergence of the issues of national identity within the milieu of Latvian groups of artists at the end of the 19th century. One of the essential issues regarding this stage was the role of the Stieglitz Central School of Drawing, which was presented as an important new centre of education for Latvian artists (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 10). The creation of "Rūķis" circle in St. Petersburg, which united this generation of artists, was specifically highlighted. The emergence of this artists' community was presented as the key driving force for their professional development and thematic orientation toward social processes. This chapter examined issues related to nationality and national self-awareness, described with an emphasis on ideological motivation.

The third stage was defined as Latvian fine art on the eve of the 1905 Bourgeois Revolution (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 11). The turn of the century was marked by heightened ideological tension between the socially oriented and formalist art. Thematic emphasis was placed on the division

and regrouping of artists into two opposing camps, which was triggered by a petition submitted to the Tsar in 1905 (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 11). This political event was used as a catalyst to critically evaluate the degree of social engagement among artists. In addition, the curriculum highlighted the participation of progressive artists in satirical journals, emphasizing the importance of political caricatures as a means of revolutionary expression. The programme includes analysis of the works by Aleksandrs Romans, Jānis Roberts Tillbergs, Teodors Ūders, as well as the development of graphic design and the significance of the publication "Svari" (LNA-LVA, 442–3–82, 10).

In methodological terms, the curriculum was organized in a chronological-monographic format, with the avoidance of excessive biographies in favour of the key figures. Applied arts were excluded, despite their cultural relevance, due to resource constraints and methodological difficulties as only occasional references were received.

The revised curriculum of Latvian visual art, proposed by Rasma Lāce, emerged after a lot of discussions and drafts, and eventually it was presented in 1957. It was conceptually based on Miķelis Ivanovs' 1953 programme, but the new proposal introduced several significant structural and methodological changes which have been pointed out earlier. Nevertheless, sharp criticism was accentuated. It was noted that the author relied too literally on the previous curricula and the criticism associated with them (LNA-LVA, 442–3–128, 42). There was a lack of definition for the concept of "Latvian art" and description of national specificity. Even harsher criticism was expressed by Kārlis Ratnieks, head of the Department of Marxism-Leninism, who pointed out the lingering traces of the "cult of personality" in the programme, a "vulgar" approach to characterizing the role of *Peredvizhniki*, as well as a one-sided view on the artistic influence of Western art (LNA-LVA, 442–3–128, 42). For the programme to correspond with ideological changes, formalism in Latvian art needed to be re-evaluated, the content of the curriculum should move away from an overly monographic structure and maintain a more cautious approach to interpreting Soviet-era art (Konstante, 2017, 419).

DISCUSSION

In this paper the author aimed to establish how Soviet ideology influenced the development of Latvian visual art history curricula during the 1950s and how myths were used to shape knowledge in the academic environment. The results of this comparative study confirm the initial hypothesis that art history curricula at that time not only had an

educational function but also sought to reinforce the myths created by Soviet ideology.

A comparison of the 1953 and 1957 curricula shows that their development was closely tied to ideological goals and institutional power. In this context, a myth is not a fictional story but rather a structure that defines the possibility of interpretation. It constructs a "field of vision" in which certain art phenomena, such as 19th-century national awakening, are highlighted, while others, such as the contributions of emigrated artists or the aspects of folk art, are systematically excluded from collective memory. The archival data, primarily consisting of protocols and draft versions, confirm the assumption that the transition from 1953 to 1957 was not a step towards objective scholarship; rather it was a complex restructuring of ideological boundaries. In the 1953 discussions, efforts were made to align the curriculum's structure as closely as possible with the official Stalinist periodization. At this stage, criticism was mainly directed at the lack of Marxist-Leninist methodology in the curriculum and the excessive amount of factual material. Ideology not only determined what was included in the narrative but also how art could be discussed in order to perpetuate the myth of the "correct" Latvian art history in the context of socialism.

These findings are consistent with a broader historiographical research on the "Thaw" period in Latvia. Criticism of the cult of personality characterizes the discursive liberalization (Konstante, 2017, 221), evident in the 1957 programme discussions. This change was reflected in a broader selection of artists to be included in the programme and a more reflective tone regarding Western art. However, this reveals an important nuance, showing that ideological changes did not mean a weakening of power. The diversity of arguments reflected the flexibility of the ideology itself; the ability to rethink the boundaries of acceptable interpretation may have ensured the longevity of Soviet cultural policy.

An unexpected finding in this study was the degree of institutional resistance and the burden of authorship that the creators of the curriculum faced. Although one might expect a totalitarian system to provide clear, monolithic instructions, the archival data reveal methodological uncertainty and the need for the authors to walk a tightrope to avoid misinterpretation. The "failure" of the first collective drafting process shows that the process of myth-making was hindered by the complexity of the ideological requirements that the authors tried to fulfil.

Under Rasma Lāce's leadership, a pragmatic transition was made to a more manageable and comprehensive scope. The basic idea was to create a collective study of 19th-century Latvian art as the basis of the new,

upgraded curricula. By narrowing the chronological range, the narrative of art history became easier to control and understand. Focusing on the 19th century as the period of formation of Latvian national art made it much easier to align the curriculum with the ideas of socialist realism.

Ultimately, the Latvian art history curriculum was developed as a tool for shaping a specific worldview. Regardless of whether it was through the strict factualism of 1953 or the restructured "liberalism" of 1957, the curriculum served to subject artistic interpretations to Soviet ideological requirements (Konstante, 2017, 222). This shows that even seemingly academic works can be ideologically saturated, reflecting a specifically constructed perspective on national identity. The myth of Latvian art history was not a static dogma but rather an artistic "truth" that developed and restructured itself to maintain institutional and ideological hegemony.

CONCLUSION

Archival materials reveal that in the 1950s, Latvian art history curricula were developed to systematically organize historical materials and explain them in line with Marxist-Leninist ideology. This study demonstrates that the narrative of art history was ideologically charged and that artistic processes were influenced by ruling beliefs, and the primary focus was

placed on class conflict as the main driving force of development. Discussions about the two proposed programmes show that art history was essentially constructed from a political perspective. The process of myth-making itself created a sort of artistic hierarchy, and the very process was able to adapt to post-Stalinist changes without losing control over the framework for interpretation (Groys, 2015, 30).

These findings suggest that ideology dominated the programme development process, but this can also be explained by the fact that art historians had to tread carefully when formulating their ideas. It is possible that the rhetoric of class struggle was employed merely to research Latvian art and later it was directed in a way acceptable to the regime, otherwise a large portion of it might not have been researched at all. Future studies should concentrate on a thorough analysis of the internal developments of the Department of Art History, as well as a comparison with art history programmes in other Soviet republics, like Estonia or Lithuania, to gain an additional insight into this politically charged era and the issues surrounding it. A comparative analysis of this kind would determine whether the debates concerning the art history narrative

were specific only to Latvia or if they were an inherent characteristic of Soviet cultural policy in other republics as well.

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BEYOND LOCAL TRADITIONS: MATERIALS, TECHNOLOGIES, AND THE PRODUCTION OF NEEDLEWORK BELTS

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ABSTRACT

The study examines persistent myths surrounding needlework belts in the Baltic region during the second half of the 19th century, particularly the final decades. This transitional period was marked by the transformation of locally rooted ornamental traditions under the combined influence of international printed patterns, the circulation of materials and technologies, and artisan knowledge across the Baltic region and beyond. Drawing on a comparative analysis of 347 objects from 38 museum collections in Latvia, Estonia, and Lithuania, the study demonstrates that needlework belts were shaped primarily by printed embroidery patterns rather than by locally generated iconographic traditions. Recurrent motifs appearing across belts, purses, and decorative panels are understood as modular pattern units within a shared visual repertoire, freely combined and adapted to different object types, reflecting broader processes of transregional standardisation and visual adaptation.

The study adopts an object-oriented approach in which materials, manufacturing techniques, ornamentation, and construction details are analysed as active components within networks of production, circulation, and use, in conjunction with written and iconographic sources. Considered on the scale of the Baltic region, needlework belts are developed as outcomes of interconnected systems involving materials, technologies, printed patterns, craftsmen, and organisational structures operating within the late nineteenth-century Russian Empire. This comparative framework makes it possible to identify transregional patterns of production and ornamentation, while also accounting for locally specific configurations shaped by social relations, craft organisation, and practices of use.

Keywords: Baltic region, material culture, needlework belts, printed embroidery patterns, traditional national dress discourse

In the second half of the 19th century and the early 20th century, urbanisation, industrial development, and expanding trade in the Baltic region increased access to industrially produced and imported materials and reshaped craft practices, making them more closely tied to the circulation of materials, technologies, and printed patterns. The dissemination of embroidery pattern sheets and fashion or mode journals facilitated the spread of ideas about dress and aesthetic frameworks, contributing to a convergence of visual and stylistic expression of clothing across social strata, while maintaining differentiation through the choice of materials and the quality of execution. Research on clothing of this period is significantly shaped by the structure of available evidence, as the dominant body of materials preserved in the collections of Baltic museums consists of items acquired during ethnographic expeditions conducted in the first half of the 20th century. These materials primarily document rural contexts and largely reflect the period up to the mid-19th century. By contrast, the fragmentary preservation of the clothing associated with the nobility and the urban middle classes constrains the reconstruction of clothing use contexts for this period, contributing to the predominance of rural dress in scholarly research. The transitional period may be examined through the case of needlework belts, as material evidence situated at the intersection of craft practices, material circulation, and ethnographic interpretation.

The study is based on a corpus of primary material, written and iconographic sources relating to 347 needlework belts and their fragments preserved in the collections of 38 museums across the Baltic. Although the material is relatively well represented across the region, its scholarly interpretation has developed along differing methodological trajectories shaped by ethnographic research approaches. In the scholarly literature, needlework belts have been addressed within the framework of men's traditional national dress and interpreted as components of festive attire worn by affluent peasants, typically in combination with a long overcoat or a sheepskin coat (Slava 1966, 54; Astel 1998, 179; Kulikauskienė 2018, 251). Their use has commonly been framed as transitional between rural and urban modes of dress. While this interpretative framework has provided a valuable analytical starting point, it also tends to narrow the scope of interpretation and may obscure the broader social circulation and material heterogeneity of these objects. The examined material indicates that needlework belts were incorporated into the dress practices of various social groups, thereby highlighting the coexistence and overlap of "traditional" (rural) and "urban" (fashion-oriented) dress in the Baltic region during the second half of

the 19th century. Research disparities are also influenced by limitations in the quality of available sources. Although many objects have entered museum collections, documentation of their provenance, conditions of use, and modes of wearing are often fragmentary or absent, and iconographic evidence for the use of needlework belts is rare. To address these limitations and to move beyond regionally bounded interpretations, the study adopts an object-oriented approach within the framework of material culture studies. The study argues that needlework belts in the Baltic region during the second half of the 19th century were introduced through the circulation of printed embroidery patterns and the movement of materials, technologies, and artisanal knowledge within interconnected transregional networks, rather than through territorially bounded and locally generated traditions. To support this argument, materials, manufacturing techniques, ornamentation, traces of wear, and quality of execution are examined as evidence, allowing patterns of use and the cultural meanings and functions of these objects to be reconstructed even in the absence of direct documentation. A comparative analysis across Latvian, Estonian, and Lithuanian contexts reveals shared processes, parallel developments, and regional variations that are often overlooked or interpreted as locally unique within nationally oriented frameworks. Technological aspects of production, especially materials and techniques are given particular attention.

RETHINKING REGIONAL FRAMEWORKS

Research on traditional national dress has frequently relied on methodological frameworks that emphasise clearly delineated regional divisions. Within such approaches, garment forms, decorative schemes, and modes of wearing tended to be interpreted as territorially fixed and embedded within locally bounded cultural systems. While this perspective has provided a useful structure for classification, the evidence of needlework belts from the second half of the 19th century points to the limitations of strictly regionalised interpretations. Their geographical distribution, technological characteristics, and ornamental vocabularies do not consistently correspond to clearly defined regional boundaries. Cartographic analysis of needlework belts in the Baltic region reveals broader territorial patterns that cut across conventional regional frameworks, indicating more dynamic processes of material culture circulation. The most concentrated and territorially coherent distribution is observed in Estonia, whereas in Latvia the occurrence of needlework belts is uneven across regions, and in Lithuania such belts

appear only sporadically (Брук et al. 1986). These spatial patterns correspond closely to the administrative divisions of the Russian Empire. In the Provinces of Estonia, Livonia, and Courland, needlework belts are represented in museum collections to a considerably greater extent. By contrast, in Latgale and in Lithuanian territories, administered within the Vitebsk Province and the North-Western Krai, such belts are rare or entirely absent from museum collections. These regional disparities may be associated with broader structural conditions shaped by political governance and economic relations, including differences in the timing of the abolition of serfdom (1816–1819 in the Baltic provinces of Estonia, Livonia, and Courland, and 1861 in Latgale and Lithuanian territories). Administrative frameworks influenced the circulation of materials, access to technologies, supply routes, and the organisation of local craft practices, as these regions were gradually integrated into the trade and production systems of the Russian Empire. At the same time, the uneven distribution of needlework belt evidence in Baltic Museum collections may also be considered in relation to the history of museum formation and the differing practices of ethnographic collecting in the first half of the 20th century.

SOCIAL DIFFERENTIATION AND REPRESENTATIONAL USES OF NEEDLEWORK BELTS

Material analysis indicates that needlework belts, previously associated in scholarship primarily with the dress practices of wealthy peasants, were also part of the dress culture and representational practices of the nobility and affluent urban strata, before gradually spreading to broader segments of society. In this respect, the Baltic material reveals connections with wider 19th-century fashion processes, as comparable belts are preserved not only in the Baltic region but also in museum collections in Russia, Poland, Germany, Sweden, Norway, and Australia. Finely executed needlework belts functioned as representational elements of dress, through which material quality, embroidery techniques, and ornamental language articulated the wearer's social status, lifestyle, and identity. Such belts were incorporated as accessories in hunting attire and sporting dress. Among rural men, needlework belts are documented primarily as gifts, inherited objects, or specially commissioned items linked to significant life events, particularly weddings. They are recorded as elements of festive dress, worn alongside simpler leather belts and broad woven textile belts associated with everyday use. This vertical diffusion across different social strata points to mechanisms of

social imitation and fashion circulation characteristic of 19th-century modernisation processes (Simmel 1904, 541–558). Analysis of materials and manufacturing techniques allows for a more nuanced reconstruction of the circulation pathways of needlework belts and their relationship to diverse social practices.

DISTRIBUTED AUTHORSHIP AND COLLABORATIVE CRAFT IN NEEDLEWORK BELT PRODUCTION

In the 19th century, beadwork was valued primarily in terms of the labour, technical skill, and time invested rather than its market price (Pazaurek 1923, 380). Within museum collections, indications of authorship on needlework belts are rare and, where present, relate only to the embroiderer. This pattern points to a production context shaped by collaborative craft practices involving craftsmen of different specialisations, in which individual authorship was not consistently articulated or documented. These distributed production practices are also reflected in the material and technical diversity of the belts themselves, providing an insight into the processes and decisions that shaped their manufacture.

The material distribution of the belts indicates that approximately 75% are executed entirely in beadwork, 20% in woolwork, while the remaining 5% combine both materials within a single composition. The finishing of the leather components indicates the work of professional leather craftsmen with high technical precision and experience in material processing. Such features include standardised patterns, carefully finished and symmetrical edges, precise stitching, uniform fastening elements, perforated edges, and riveted holes, all pointing to technological standardisation practised in workshops. This suggests that the leather parts of needlework belts were most often produced as ready-made components purchased separately from specialised workshops and adapted to individual belts according to the wearer's needs and body measurements.

The lining material could be identified only in cases where it was visible through loosened seams, exposed embroidery areas, or mechanical damage. Between the leather base and the needlework surface, a structural interlayer was inserted to stabilise the embroidery, maintain the belt's form, and reduce material deformation during prolonged use or bending. This interlayer consisted of firm linen fabric of varying thickness and texture. Of particular interest is an example from the Jelgava district, where a Russian language newspaper was used as lining

material (CVVM 13739), reflecting everyday late nineteenth-century practices of reusing printed paper and illustrating the multilingual informational environment of the region.

Belt fastenings were made of various metals, including iron, brass, and silver. Individually crafted fastenings were often personalised with initials and dates referring to individual ownership or use. In rare cases, these inscriptions also permit attribution, as demonstrated by a belt fastening from the collection of the Estonian National Museum (ERM A 632:220). One plate of the two-part silver fastening bears the engraved



a b

Fig. 1 (a, b) Beadwork belt with a silver fastening. 1850–1875. Estonia, Tallinn. Glass, cotton, leather, silver. Dimensions: 98 × 5.5 cm. Estonian National Museum (Eesti Rahva Muuseum), inv. no. ERM A 632:220. Photo: (a) ERM, http://www.muis.ee/en_GB/museaalview/497603; (b) Una Valtere

initials "PK", while the inner side is marked with three separate marks: the city mark of Reval (now Tallinn) – a small shield with three lions used between 1842 and 1920; the number "84", indicating the Russian Imperial silver standard (84 zolotniks ≈ 875/1000 purity); and the maker's mark "WC" (Fig. 1). According to research conducted by a collective of authors led by Marina Postnikova-Loseva (*Марина Постникова-Лосева*, 1901–1985) on goldsmiths' and silversmiths' workshops and hallmarking systems in the territory of the former USSR, the maker's identity can be attributed to the silversmith *Wilhelm Kordts*, who was active in Reval approximately between 1850 and 1875 (Постникова-Лосева et al. 1995, 134–135). The same study identifies Tallinn as the principal centre of jewellery production in Estonia during the 18th and 19th centuries, where both local and Baltic German craftsmen were active. The use of masters' and city hallmarks in Estonia is documented from the 15th century, with their compulsory introduction formalised by the 1537 statute on jewellers' marks in Tallinn. Although the guild

system effectively lost its practical significance in 1866, it continued to exist formally until 1920. Taken together, the evidence demonstrates that the perceived anonymity of needlework belts does not reflect the absence of authorship, but rather a historically specific organisation of collaborative labour and material specialisation, rather than individual attribution.

ISSUES OF MATERIAL ORIGIN AND PRESERVATION

Museum object descriptions typically record the type of material used (such as leather, glass beads, or wool thread), while information concerning the provenance of these materials and their circulation pathways is generally absent. Nevertheless, the technical characteristics of the glass and its state of preservation have prompted a more focused examination of the provenance of glass beads, their production centres, and the technologies involved in their manufacture. Glass beads are characterised by high resistance to environmental influences and have therefore generally survived better in needlework belts than organic textile materials. However, the state of preservation varies among the beads, with damage most observed in blue glass beads used predominantly for background embroidery on the belts. Compared to beads of other colours, they are more often friable, cracked, or entirely lost, leaving empty areas in the embroidery. These observations suggest a possible relationship between the additives used to achieve colour, specific production technologies, and the long-term stability of the material, while also pointing to technological challenges and quality fluctuations in 19th-century glass bead production.

A possible explanation is offered by the bead classification system developed by Canadian historians and archaeologists *Martha Ann Kidd* (1917–2012) and *Kenneth Kidd* (1906–1994), who emphasise that from the 17th to the 19th century glass production relied largely on craftsmen's practical experience rather than on precise chemical control. Although general recipes for producing glass of different qualities were known, the proportions of ingredients were not accurately regulated, and the raw materials themselves were often chemically impure. As a result, significant variation occurred in the physical and chemical properties of finished glass, with some batches being inherently less stable than others (Kidd and Kidd 2012, 42).

In conservation literature, this phenomenon is explained by the chemical instability of glass, commonly referred to as "glass disease". Under the influence of moisture, such glass cracks and crumbles,

forming a fine network of surface fissures that render it matt and cloudy and ultimately lead to its disintegration (Davison 1989, 319–321). Glass degradation is influenced by both chemical composition and external factors, including the materials of the object's base and threads, as well as storage conditions. Particularly unstable is glass with high alkali content and low stabiliser levels, which deteriorates under conditions of elevated humidity and pollution. As the chemical composition of glass cannot be altered, conservation approaches focus on environmental control, primarily the stabilisation of relative humidity, to slow irreversible deterioration processes (Verhaar 2018, 47–48).

MOTIF REPETITION AND THE MIGRATION OF PRINTED EMBROIDERY PATTERNS

The ornamentation of needlework belts was shaped by Berlin woolwork pattern designs that were widely disseminated across Europe during the nineteenth century and applied to the decoration of various domestic objects, including book covers, boxes, bell straps, and purses. Embroidery patterns were broadly accessible, with the recurrence of identical schemes across neighbouring regions indicating the transcultural migration of printed pattern designs. This international circulation of patterns is exemplified by a beadwork belt from the collection of the National Museum of Lithuania in Vilnius (LNM IM 165). In this object, the beadwork is organised as a continuous figurative frieze, bordered by a narrow ornamental leather edging that visually frames the central imagery and reinforces the belt's elongated format. The composition depicts a pastoral landscape supplemented with rural architecture, trees, animals, and human figures engaged in movement and interaction. The imagery presents an idealised rural landscape composed of individual scenic episodes. Schematic architectural elements structure the composition, while the moving figures and animals introduce visual dynamism within the belt's linear format. From a technical perspective, the embroidery demonstrates a high degree of precision and control. The uniform size of the beads and their dense, even placement create a smooth, tapestry-like surface that visually approximates woven or painted imagery. The stitch structure ensures durability while allowing for detailed figural representation, indicating a maker well acquainted with bead embroidery techniques adapted from broader needlework traditions. The integration of the beaded band into a leather base further suggests a collaborative mode of production involving different craft specialisations. The narrative sequence terminates with a scene depicting a rider

and horse positioned before large masonry gates, visually articulating the end segment of the continuous frieze (Fig. 2).



Fig. 2 (a, b) Beadwork belt. Early 19th century. Lithuania. Glass, cotton, leather, brass. Dimensions: 165 × 7.5 cm. National Museum of Lithuania (Lietuvos nacionalinis muziejus), inv. no. LNM IM 165. Photo: (a) Una Valtere; (b) reprinted from Tradicinės aprangos priedai, ed. Ona Danutė Aleknienė. Vilnius: LNM, 2014, p. 16.

Among the examined examples, this belt is exceptional both in the complexity of its narrative composition and in the high level of detail achieved in the embroidery. The belt base is constructed from thin, light brown leather, machine-stitched and finished with perforated edges, and is fitted with a brass buckle and an adjustable inner strap. Glass beads,, measuring approximately 1 mm in diameter, were employed, allowing the embroidered band to reach a width of up to seventy rows

of beads. Such technical parameters enabled a remarkably dense and nuanced representation of figural and architectural elements. Taken together, the iconography and execution indicate a high level of craftsmanship and suggest that the belt may have been commissioned for a specific recipient or occasion rather than produced as a routine commodity. This



Fig. 3 Fragment of a beadwork handbag. 1800–1850. Estonia. Glass, cotton. Dimensions: 19 × 10.7 cm. Estonian History Museum (Eesti Ajaloo Muuseum SA), inv. no. TAAM 5766 K-679 TE12. Photo: Una Valtere.

technical and compositional complexity is further underscored by the structure of the needlework narrative, which is composed of several separate pattern schemes arranged sequentially along the belt.

A comparable approach to narrative construction and visual vocabulary can be observed in a beadwork purse from the collection of the Estonian History Museum (TAAM S 766 K–679 T), which features figurative scenes in chinoiserie style on both sides *(*Fig. 3). In both objects, the imagery is organised as a self-contained scenic composition with human figures, stylised architecture, and vegetation, rendered against a neutral ground, and framed by a clearly defined border. The beaded purse entered the museum collection in 1870 as part of *Johann Burchard's* (1776–1838) collection *Mon Faible*. These visual and compositional parallels place the belt within a broader decorative tradition shaped by the European fascination with Oriental themes during the late 18th and early 19th centuries, widely reflected in contemporary porcelain, textiles, and embroidery ornamentation. The recurrence of individual narrative motifs across different object types can be traced through printed embroidery patterns. The chinoiserie scene depicted on the beaded purse corresponds to an embroidery pattern scheme originally printed in Berlin around 1810–1820 by the *L. W. Witich* publishing house and later reprinted in a publication of the State Historical Museum in Moscow (Ковенева 2018, 22).

The final scene of the Lithuanian belt depicting a rider and horse before the gates also appears on a beaded purse entitled *Rider and Chinese*

Figures (RP–16253 ARD) from the National Art Museum of Moldova. On this object, one side of the purse depicts a rider and horse, while the reverse shows three music-playing Chinese figures. The coexistence of these two distinct narrative motifs on a single object demonstrates the modular use of independent embroidery pattern schemes, which could be combined freely without forming a shared narrative structure. A further variation of the rider-and-horse motif is preserved within the same museum collection on the beaded decorative panel *Scenes of Folk Life* (RP–16274 ARD). Both objects are dated to the first half of the 19th century and are described by the museum specialists as products of a Russian workshop. The rider-and-horse motif also appears on a beaded purse in the collection of the Sergiev Posad State History and Art Museum-Reserve (Moscow region, Russia), exhibited in the exhibition *Bead by Bead* (*Бусинка к бусинке*) in 2023.

The material shows that the ornamentation of needlework belts was shaped by the circulation of printed embroidery patterns rather than by locally conceived, unified narratives. Recurrent motifs across belts and other objects functioned as modular pattern units that were adapted and recombined according to format and technique, reflecting transregional networks of pattern dissemination and craft production in the 19th century. At the same time, the material reveals a clear shift over the course of the 19th century: belts produced in the first half of the century, often associated with elite contexts, are characterised by complex compositions and the use of fine, high-quality materials, whereas in the second half of the century these gave way to simpler, more standardised arrangements. This transition demonstrates the broader diffusion and adaptation of patterns across social strata, as well as changes in production practices, material availability, and modes of use.

CONCLUSION

The analysis defines needlework belts in the Baltic region as products of transregional systems of production and circulation that developed over the course of the 19th century and became structurally dominant in its second half. Formed within a socioeconomic environment and shaped by urbanisation, industrial expansion, and intensified trade, these objects are constituted through the interaction of printed embroidery patterns, standardised materials, evolving technologies, and specialised forms of labour operating across the Baltic region and the wider Russian Empire. The examined museum corpus is chronologically

concentrated in the second half of the 19th century, while a limited number of earlier examples indicate the initial emergence of these processes in the early decades of the century.

The ornamentation of needlework belts is defined by a modular compositional logic. Recurrent motifs operate as transferable pattern units that are systematically adapted and recombined across object types, materials, and techniques, without forming unified narrative structures. Their recurrence across Baltic and wider European collections, as well as in printed pattern sources, establishes their belonging to a shared visual repertoire shaped by the large-scale dissemination of printed designs.

The observed variation in material quality, execution, and use are defined as an expression of social differentiation rather than of regionally bounded stylistic traditions. The material demonstrates vertical circulation across social strata, encompassing elite, urban, and rural contexts, and indicates the capacity of patterns and techniques to operate across differing economic conditions and levels of technical skill.

The production of needlework belts is defined by distributed authorship and collaborative craft organisation. Their manufacture involves the coordinated interaction of multiple specialised agents, including embroiderers, leatherworkers, and metalworkers, alongside the incorporation of industrially produced components and printed pattern sources. The limited visibility of individual authorship is thus understood as a structural feature of this mode of production.

Taken together, needlework belts are defined as material manifestations of interconnected networks in which patterns, materials, technologies, and makers collectively determine their form. Their structure and ornamentation are governed by processes of circulation, recombination, and standardisation, situating these objects within broader systems of 19th-century cultural exchange and materially mediated interaction.

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MYTHOLOGIZING THE TOPIC OF "MUSCOVITE" IN LATVIAN CULTURAL HERITAGE OF THE LIVONIAN PERIOD

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ABSTRACT

In the territory of modern Latvia, which together with the lands of the present-day Republic of Estonia was called Livonia in medieval and modern history, both tangible and intangible cultural heritage has preserved evidence of the suffering caused by the invasion of the eastern neighbouring country. The rulers of Russia invaded the territory of Livonia with armed troops of ethnically mixed composition, caused both religious and armed conflicts, subjected the territories to their influence, as well as cruelly dealt with the population. The historical memory of the Baltic peoples during the 16th–18th centuries has associated this set of bearers of brutal violence with a negative description coloured in the ethnic semantics of "Muscovite" and "Tatar", which permanently contains an attitude of fear and warning.

The article also outlines the history of military conflicts between Christian and Muslim peoples of Europe, as a result of which the manifestations of ethnic and confessional hatred took the form of Turkophobia and for several centuries, under the influence of the threat of the Ottoman Empire, strengthened the stereotype of the "Turk" as a generalized enemy in the public consciousness. The traumatic experiences of both the invaded Central European lands and the inhabitants of Livonia were sublimated not only in oral folklore, in horror stories of a warning nature, but also materialized in works of applied and stage art.

The geopolitical events of the 21st century have repeatedly updated the archetypes of the hostile stranger – "Tatar", "Turk" or "Muscovite" – stored in historical memory, drawing attention in a new context to the cultural heritage created based on past interethnic conflicts.

Keywords: Livonia, Russia, religion, conflicts, "muscovite", memory, art

AN INTRODUCTORY INSIGHT INTO THE CULTURAL HISTORY

The 6th and 7th centuries of our era mark the beginning of the conquest and redistribution of the world, in which each side, both the followers of the prophet Muhammad and the creators of the Roman papal empire, declaring the ideological goal of their religion and the political protection of symbolic holy places, sought to implement real economic expansion. While Christians tried to spread the idealistic idea of universal salvation in the name of Jesus, Islam was developing into an aggressive religious and political movement to strengthen the national consciousness of the Arab peoples. These differences in the economic goals of Christianity and Islam acquired an ideological form and were canonized as irreconcilable contradictions in culture as well. The antagonistic situation created fertile ground for the genesis of an exaltedly negative image of religious opponents, which materialized in Christian culture in the images of anti-Islamic art. As a result of the experienced military aggression and ideological differences, the art of Christian Europe generated clichés of consciousness identified with the images of the "Turk", "Muslim", "Tatar" and "Muscovite".

The efforts of European Christians to conquer the Holy Land and regain the tomb of Christ were carried out with the help of crusades initiated by the popes and secular rulers. The successes of the first crusade included the conquest of Jerusalem in 1099, as well as the establishment of the crusader states of Syria and Palestine. As a result of the military campaigns of the French, Flemish, Norman and Lorraine knights, several administrative territories were formed on the Mediterranean coast. However, it was impossible to keep these conquests in Christian hands and the Sixth Crusade facing the troops of the Turkish-Seljuk sultans ended in the crusaders' complete defeat in 1254.

The idealized history of the Crusades by European Christians is expressed in a unique way in the Latvian cultural heritage by the altarpiece of St. Louis Church in Krāslava (Fig. 1), work by the Polish historical genre painter Jan Matejko (1838–1893), created in 1884. Painted in the style of late Romanticism and saturated with the pathos of battle, it depicts the French king Louis IX (Louis IX, St. Louis, 1214–1270), boarding a ship to lead the knights in battle during the Sixth Crusade, to recapture Syria and Palestine from the Muslims. However, this last Crusade also ended in failure for the Christians in 1254. However, the political subtext of the painting, created in the 19th century, is different, which is why this painting was placed in the altar of the main church of

Polish *Inflanty Polskie*, ruled by the Counts Platers. Although the painting depicts an episode from the history of the Crusades, its commissioners – the owners of the Krāslava Manor from the Plater family – wanted to honour their own victims and the victims of the Polish nobility and people in the battles against Russia's efforts to subjugate Polish land and destroy Polish statehood from 1772 to 1795.



Fig. 1. Jan Matejko.
Sketch for the painting
"Saint Louis Goes to War",
1884. Oil on canvas, 52 x 26.5 cm.
No. MT/M 258/N.
Photo by the Toruń Regional Museum, 2015

After the losses in the Crusades and the unsuccessful attempts to recapture the Holy Land from the Muslims, the unified term "Turks" for religious and ethnic opponents became even more established in the vocabulary of European Christians. Only after a short time – in the 16th and 17th centuries – when the Ottoman Empire again began to threaten the lands of Western Europe, did the hatred inherited from the Crusades flare up.

While two groups – Catholics and Muslims – fought for the economic redistribution of Europe and the Mediterranean basin, the hordes of the nomadic Mongol Empire, led by Batu Khan (1205–1255), broke through the Slavic-populated territories into Eastern Europe in 1237. By 1241, all of Kievan Rus', Moscow, and the territories on both banks of the Volga, including the cities of Rostov, Tver, Yaroslavl, and Suzdal, had been conquered, creating the so-called "Golden Horde." After conquering Russia,

the Mongol Khan's troops defeated the Teutonic Knights at Legnica in 1241, subjugated Poland, Silesia, Austria, and Hungary, and prepared to conquer Germany and Italy. Only the internal political events of the Mongol Khanate and the death of Ogedei Khan (Ögedei Khan, Ögedei Khagan or Ogodei, 1186–1241) in December 1241 motivated Batu Khan to stop his conquests in Europe and focus on conquering the Urals and Asian territories [Zentner, Chr., 1982, 144–147].

LIVONIAN EXPERIENCE CONTACTING A "FOREIGN" CULTURE

Traumatic experiences were not unfamiliar to the Livonian Confederation of feudal states in the territories inhabited by the Baltic tribes, which in the 13th century were threatened from the Russian side by the raids of the Golden Horde led by the Mongol Batu Khan. A second wave of violence from the east caused the 25-year-long Livonian War (Phase I 1558–1561; Phase II 1561–1566; 1583; Phase III 1569–1577; Phase IV 1578–1583), when an ethnically mixed army, organized by the Russian Tsar Ivan IV, called the Terrible (Ivan IV Vasilyevich, 1530–1584), invaded Vidzeme [Беляков А. В., 2010, 236–238]. A significant part of the Russian army was made up of the troops of the Tatar Khan Shah-Ali ibn Sheikh-Auleear (Shah-Ali Ibn Sheikh-Auleear, 1505–1567), who defeated the troops of the Teutonic Order at Ērģeme (Ermes), occupied Valka (Walk), Viljandi (Fellin), Tartu (Dorpat), and, having captured the fortresses of Rakvere (Wesenberg) and Narva (Narwa), subjugated large territories in the eastern part of modern Estonia.

The interest of Livonia's eastern neighbours – the Russian rulers – in the conquest of Livonian lands was known even before the invasions of Ivan the Terrible's troops. From time to time, Russian princely rallies were launched from the Pskov and Novgorod sides in the eastern territories of the Livonian Order, and these events were emotionally reflected in the consciousness of the threatened peoples. One of the earliest examples is a bell, cast in 1509 and made by the Teutonic Knights' master Walter von Plettenberg (c. 1450–1535) in memory of the victory over the Russian troops at Smolensk near Pskov in September 1502, as well as in honour of the Christian martyr Saint Blaise (Saint Blaise, killed in 316). Initially, the bell was installed in the tower of St. Peter's Church in Riga, but after the Reformation it was moved to St. Jacob's Church and placed in a roofed structure outside the tower.

For several centuries, the bell was considered one of the symbols of Riga's identity, associated both with its unusual location and attributed

to the folkloric story of a "poor sinner" with the bell being rung to pardon him during his execution. According to several eyewitnesses, when the bell was dismantled for evacuation to Russia in July 1915, it bore an inscription that read something like this: "God, protect us from the Russians, the plague and the floods." The text on the bell has not been precisely recorded, but the testimonies of at least four people associated with the removal of the bell from the tower and its evacuation to Russia repeat a similar content in the main points. The most important thing in these testimonies is the fact that they emphasize the fear of Rigans of the "plague and the Russians" [Campe P. 1930/1934, 78]. After World War I, the historic bell was never recovered and is considered lost.

The dangers experienced during the Livonian War are testified by the preserved visual evidence which records observations made in real clashes with the enemy and uses this negative experience as a warning. Using a copy of an illustrated manuscript about the events in Livonia by Johann Schmidt, secretary of the Riga council (in office from 1558 to 1562), found in Tartu, the encyclopaedist Johann Christoph Brotze has redrawn the "Russian horseman" (Eqves Moscoviticus, 1577, Ein Moscowiter zu Ross) from its pages. The text of Johann Schmidt's 1558 manuscript also describes in detail the armament, riding and fighting techniques of the Mongol and Tatar soldiers included in Ivan the Terrible's army (Fig. 2).



Fig. 2. Muscovite horseman in 1577 (1558).
From: Broce, J.K.
Zīmējumi un apraksti.
Riga: Zinātne, 1996, vol. 2, p. 482

Quote: "- - they have no heavy armour, they have no armour or other sewn clothing at all. Their weapons are a bow, which they, along with arrows or darts, tie to their sides while riding a horse and shoot very skilfully with it; also axes with long handles, similar to a battle mace, wrapped in a long strap around their hand, with which they can chop very quickly, - - and they are able to fight deftly with both hands on horseback with such weapons because they have trained their horses so that they can lead them with their feet as well as with their hands" [Broce J.K. 1996, 48–483]. The actually observed and described features of the enemy soldier's clothing and armour, as well as the drawing itself served as information for the Riga City Council. Combined with the news of the cruelty of the "Muscovite" Asian warriors attacking the Livonian cities, the imagination of the frightened society at the level of consciousness could generate both horrifying images and strive to materialize the enemies of Christians in repulsive visual images.

Also, in the information space of the European Lutheran lands and in Vidzeme, indignation at the political aggression of Russia, based solely on ethnic cleansing methods because of confessional antagonism, grew. The propaganda was served by an illustration of the newspaper "Zeyttung" printed in Nuremberg in 1561 which depicted the torture of Christians in Livonia, thus helping to incite anti-Russian sentiment and scaring the peoples of Europe with the cruelty of the Tatars (Fig. 3).


Gehr grewliche/erschröck-
liche/ vor vnerhörte/ warhafftige Newe zeyt-
tung/was für grausame Tyranney der Moskouter/an
den Gefangenen/ hinweggeführten Christen auß Lyfland/ beydes an
Mannen vnd Frawen/ Junckfrawen vnnd kleinen Kindern/ begre-
het/vnd was täglichs schadens er jnen in jrem Land zufüget. Bey-
neben angezeygt/ in was grosser fahr vnd not die Lyflender
stecken. Allen Christen zur warnung/vnd bes-
serung jhres Sündtlichen lebens/auß
Lyfland geschriben/ vnd in
Druck verfertiget.

Zu Nürnberg bey Georg Kreydlein. M. D. L XI.

Fig. 3. Russian dangers in Livonia. Printed in the *Zeyttung*, Nürnberg bey Georg Kreydlein, 1561. From: Pistohlkors, G. von. *Deutsche Geschichte im Osten Europas. Baltische Länder*. Berlin, Siedler Verlag, 1994, p. 178

Such panic was justified because the contents of the threatening letter by Tsar Ivan the Terrible to Sigismund II Augustus (Zygmunt II August, 1520–1572) King of Poland and Lithuania, became known in the royal houses of Christian Europe. In this letter the Russian ruler threatened to destroy the neighbouring land in the most severe way. A quote from the letter: "With this letter we make known our will that with invincible force and fire, we will burn, subdue and destroy all your land, turning it into graves, coffins and blood. And let it be known to you that our power will also lay your head in the same grave. Therefore, [you] know how you must act with your subjects from now on" [Thomae Hiärn's Ehst-, Lyf- und Lettlaendische Geschichte, 1835, 245].

Starting the Livonian War to gain access to the Baltic Sea with the invasion of Russian and Tatar troops on a wide front in Vidzeme and eastern Estonia from Lake Peipus to Narva, the Russian Patriarchate motivated it as a fight against the Reformation movement initiated by Martin Luther (Martin Luther, 1483–1546), equating it with iconoclasm. This is evidenced by a letter written in 1567 by the Patriarch of Moscow (Mitropolit Фили́пп II (in the world Фёдор Степа́нович Колычёв, 1507–1569): "The godless Crimean Khan Devlet Giray (Devlet I Giray, 1512–1577) with the Mamluks and Latinists, as well as the Lithuanian king Sigismund II Augustus (Sigismund II Augustus, 1520–1572) and the disgusting Germans have fallen victim to various heresies, and above all to the errors preached by Luther, which destroy the holy churches and blaspheme the venerable images" [Fechner E. W. 1993, 210].

Since 1578, Ivan the Terrible had agreed with the Danish prince Magnus as his ally on an aggressive policy against the Swedes and Poles; he implemented administrative reforms against the Lutherans in the conquered lands around Lake Peipus and in both Estonia and Vidzeme up to Koknese (Kokenhusen). To prepare the ground for a further conflict, the Russian patriarch founded an Orthodox diocese in Tartu and built several churches on the border. This "orthodoxization" of the border regions was followed by the methodical extermination or deportation of the local German, Estonian, and Latvian populations to central Russia. The devastating conflict left bitter memories of the experienced atrocities for generations.

The Polish king's secretary Reinhold Heidenstein (c. 1553–1620), who during his lifetime was both a diplomat and the author of the historical chronicle "De bello Moscovitico commentariorum" (Notes on the Muscovite War), written in 1584–1585, recorded evidence of the actions of Ivan the Terrible's troops in the conquered Livonian lands. Describing the events of 1577, R. Heidenstein mentions that, taking advantage of the

political duplicity of Duke Magnus, the Moscow Tsar with a large army occupied many Livonian fortresses – Alūksne (Marienburg), Rēzekne (Rositten), Ludza (Ludsen), Dinaburgs (Dünaburg), Koknese (Kokenhusen) – and even went as far as Aizkraukle (Ascheraden). The event itself is most clearly described in the following quote: "A large number of both sexes and all classes of inhabitants had gathered in Aizkraukle, especially many women and maidens. – The Tsar of Moscow killed all those who were able to bear arms, but the representatives of the non-combatant sex – women and maidens – were given to the Tatars to be raped. Then he went straight to Cēsis (Wenden)" [Гейденштейн, Р., 1889, 3–4.].

The siege of Cēsis, which lasted several days in August and September 1577, ended with the capture of the city and an equally cruel massacre of its inhabitants. According to the chronicler R. Heidenstein, even the kneeling of Duke Magnus before Ivan the Terrible with a request to have mercy on the city and its inhabitants did not help, for which the tsar showered his ally with curses and a slap. "Convinced that Magnus' actions could in no way serve to save it, and that he himself was not safe, seeing himself surrounded on all sides by the evil enemy, the inhabitants of Cēsis, overcome by hatred, fear and disappointment, laid gunpowder



Fig. 4. Russian atrocities in Livonia in July and August 1577. Illustration in the Zurich Central Library "Aus Johann Jakob Wicks Sammlung von Nachrichten": https://www.mediastorehouse.com.au/heritage-images/russian-atrocities-livonia-july-august-1577-15016752.html {{NA-70}}

under the castle, and in this explosion almost the entire flower of the Livonian aristocracy perished – a large number of people of both sexes of different ages and classes" [Гейденштейн, Р., 1889, 4].

The atrocities of the Russians and Tatars in Livonia are shown in an illustration from the collection of documents collected by Johann Jacob Wick (1522–1588) on the Reformation in Switzerland, preserved in the collection of the Zurich Central Library. It contains a coloured ink drawing "Russian Atrocities in Livonia in July and August 1577" (Russische Gräueltaten in Livland im Jahr 1577. Aus Johann Jakob Wicks Sammlung von Nachrichten), which realistically depicts murders, innocent people being cut into pieces, impaled, torn to pieces by horses, and taken captive (Fig. 4). A similar fate was chosen for the inhabitants of Cēsis by the defenders of Gulbene (Schwanenburg), who did not surrender, but blew themselves up together with the castle [Гейденштейн, Р., 1889, 4].

The Livonian War ended in 1582 with the Treaty of Yama-Zapolye, in which the Russian Tsar renounced his conquests in Livonia in favour of the Polish-Lithuanian Kingdom. After the invasion of Russian and Tatar troops of Ivan the Terrible, the frightening image of the "Muscovite" or "Tatar" was firmly and for a long time entrenched in the minds of the Livonian population. This is evidenced by several artifacts related to Riga's cultural heritage whose negative symbolic meaning as well as the repulsive iconographic image have been deliberately constructed to maintain the image of a political and confessional enemy in the east in the minds of generations and to warn of its potential aggression.

The collection of the Latvian National History Museum holds a small sandstone sculpture with an Asian type (Fig. 5). A tight-fitting hat, typical of Asian nomadic peoples, covers the head of a moustachioed figure with a long, pointed beard, while the lower part of the body is covered by a Renaissance-style heraldic shield. Behind the heraldic shield, only the left leg, tucked in a boot, is visible. The pose of the covered lower part of the body allows us to conclude that the figure is a seated warrior, possibly a horseman. The raised left hand and a thin stone fragment resembling a sword blade behind the back of the sculpture indicate that the severe warrior gesture carved in stone depicts a sword strike. Unfortunately, the hand with the sword handle has been broken off. The right hand is missing too. Apart from the already mentioned hat, no other features of the warrior's clothing can be identified that would allow us to further investigate its ownership or the context of its creation. The origin of the sculpture and its affiliation with a specific Riga building are



Fig. 5. Warrior sculpture in the Latvian National History Museum. Sandstone, 16th-17th cent., inv. No. CVVM-30399, VL-4568. Photo R. Kaniņš, 2014

unknown, but its formal stylistic features and decoration allow it to be dated to the end of the 16th century or the first half of the 17th century, as well as to speculate about its connection with the sculpture of the facade or portal of a lost house.

Due to the lack of information, in-depth scientific research has also been lacking on two fragments of anthropomorphic sculptures placed in the permanent exhibition of the Museum of the History of Riga and Navigation. The roughly made, but poorly preserved due to numerous damages, sandstone busts show moustachioed "warriors" of an Asian type: one in a nobleman's hat and a stylized caftan with buttons on the chest, and the other – without a hat and with an unidentifiable clothing detail (Figs. 6 and 7). The severed arms and missing lower body parts do not allow to form assumptions about the two figures belonging to a specific social group or type of warrior but undoubtedly point to a stylized personification of an Asian type in the grotesque sculptures that could have been made as elements of a facade, portal, or fireplace addition.

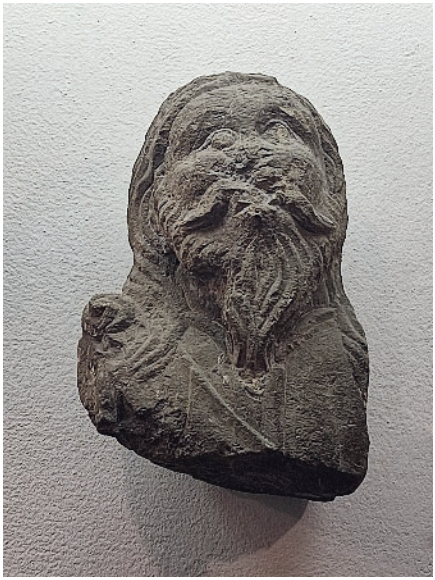



Fig. 6 and 7. Fragments of grotesque sculptures in the Museum of the History of Riga and Navigation. Sandstone, 16th–17th centuries, inv. No. VRVM – 183834; VRVM – 56690. Photo Ojārs Spārītis, 2024

In the middle of the Swedish rule, in the autumn of 1656, the Russian Tsar tried to re-conquer Riga and take the Daugava waterway under his control. Around 30,000 attackers, consisting of Tatar, Kalmyk and Cossack cavalry regiments led by Tsar Alexei Mikhailovich (Алексей Михайлович Романов, 1629–1676), besieged and attempted to conquer Riga from 22 August to 5 October. A copper engraving by the French artist Adam Perelle (1640–1695), included in the book "De Rebus a Carolo Gustavo Sveciae Rege Gestis Commentariorum…" (pp. 182–183) published in Nuremberg in 1696 by the historian and politician Baron Samuel von Pufendorf (1632–1694), depicts the Tsar with his entourage and the deployment of troops during the siege of Riga (Figs. 8 and 9) [Pufendorf, S., M. DC. XCVI, 182–183]. Although the ruler and his entourage are depicted on a very reduced scale in the lower part of the copper carving, their clothing shows elements of Turkish and Persian costumes. They display the fashion for long caftans and high headdresses that dominated the garments of Russian boyars until the reforms of Peter I (Пётр I, 1672–1725). Tsar Alexei Mikhailovich's attack on Riga less than a hundred years after Ivan the Terrible's campaign rekindled memories of the previous Russian invasion of Livonia and strengthened



Fig. 8. Adam Perelle. Copper engraving of the siege of Riga led by Tsar Alexei Mikhailovich in 1656. Pufendorf, S. De Rebus a Carolo Gustavo Sveciae Rege Gestis Commentariorum. [1696], pp. 182–183



Fig. 9. Fragment of the copper engraving with the retinue of Tsar Alexei Mikhailovich

the theme of "Muscovites" and "Tatars" as the personification of mythologized evil at the level of consciousness.

This negative experience after the attack on Riga by the Russian Tsar Alexei Mikhailovich in 1656 was used by the Swedish administration as an ideological weapon to maintain political vigilance in society as well as to fight the opposition. On May 21–22, 1677, a fire broke out in Riga, destroying about 250 houses and also the churches of St. John and St. Peter. Under the politically fabricated pretext that Prince Fyodor Romodanovsky had bribed the tutor Gabriel Franck (–1677), who was staying in Moscow, and Peter Andersson (–1677), who had accidentally arrived in

Riga from Stockholm, to set fire to the city, the court obtained death penalty for both defendants, to be carried out on July 14, 1677. In order to maintain public vigilance against potential Russian threats and fear of imminent punishment, a stone Pillar of Shame was erected outside the city in the present-day Stabu Street area as a reminder of the severe punishment received by Franks and Andersons who were accused of being Russian spies and involved in the burning of Riga (Figs. 10 and 11). After its dismantling in the mid-19th century, a fragment of the Pillar of Shame with a warning inscription is now in the Museum of the History of Riga and Navigation and can be viewed in the Riga Dom Cross Gallery.



Fig. 10. Pillar of Shame [Broce, J.K., 1996, 2., 65]



Fig. 11. Fragment of the Pillar of Shame in the exhibition of the Museum of the History of Riga and Navigation. Photo Ojārs Spārītis, 2007

TURKOPHOBIA IN EUROPE

Since the end of the Crusades, the Ottoman Empire had been a constant threat to the politically fragmented European empire ruled by the Habsburgs from the conquered Balkans and the Mediterranean. In the summer of 1683, the Turkish army advanced towards Vienna from the conquered Hungary and laid siege to the city. The Battle of Vienna lasted from 12 July to 11 September and ended with the victory of the Holy League, a coalition of Christian states of the Holy Roman Empire and the Kingdom of Poland and Lithuania. It marked the end of the Ottoman Empire's expansion in Europe.

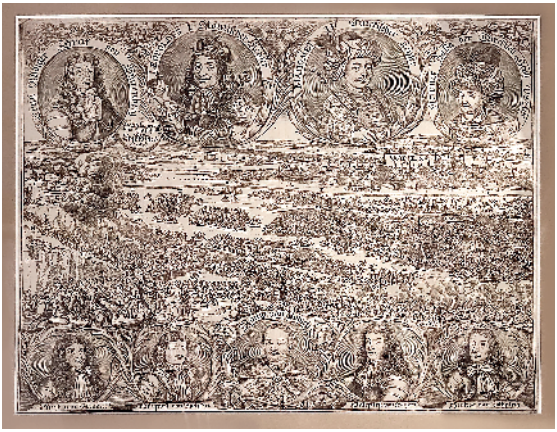


Fig. 12. The March of the Turkish Army of Mehmed IV against Vienna. Published by Giacomo Giovanni de' Rossi (1627–1691), etching on paper, Rome, 1687. Exhibition of the National Museum, Prague. Photo Ojārs Spārītis, 2025

The copper engraving in the Prague National Museum depicts the counterattack of the coalition forces on the besieged Vienna by the Turks and portraits of the commanders of the Holy League armies with the Polish King John III Sobieski in the lower centre of the battle (Fig. 12). Medallions in the form of cartouches entwined with palm trees depict the allies. From the Polish king to the left, the German and Dutch field marshal Prince von Waldeck (Georg Friedrich von Waldeck, 1620–1692) and the Duke of Saxony and Lauenburg, Elector Julius Franz (Julius Franz von Sachsen-Lauenburg, 1641–1689). From the Polish king to the right, the Elector of Bavaria Maximilian II Emanuel (Maximilian II. Emanuel, 1662–1726). The top row, from left to right, depicts the commandant of Vienna and leader of the defence, Ernst Rüdiger Graf von Starhemberg (1638–1701), the Holy Roman Emperor Leopold I (1640–1705), as well as the main commanders of the opposing forces: Ottoman Sultan Mehmed IV (1642–1693) and

Grand Vizier Ahmet Basa (Abdurrahman Abdi Pasha, –1686). The copper engraving by the Italian artist Giacomo Giovanni de Rossi (1687) has the character of an apotheosis as it emphasizes the symbolic significance of the victory of the Christian rulers of Europe for the future history of the continent.





Fig. 13. Decorative sculpture "The Turk". Sculptor Ferdinand Maximilian Brokoff (1688–1731), Prague, 1st quarter of the 18th century, polychrome wood. Exhibition of the National Museum, Prague. Photo Ojārs Spārītis, 2025

Fig. 14. "The Turk's head". Sleigh decoration. Czech Republic, Benešov region, c. 1730, polychrome wood with gilding. Exhibition of the National Museum, Prague. Photo Ojārs Spārītis, 2025

After the victory at Vienna, similar copper engravings recording Christian military triumphs with battle diagrams and allegories praising success adorned books devoted to the history of the Habsburg dynasty and the Holy Roman Empire in large numbers. The European Christians who had reached safety, transformed their previous traumatic experience into politically constructed iconographic works of art. With the help of irony or frightening images, depicting both the defeated Turkish rulers and the defeated soldiers with mocking humour, the Europeans compensated for their collective fear in an imaginative form. In the European culture of the 18th century, the polysemantic concept of "Turks" was associated with clichés of simplified perception and was personified in the clothing characteristic of the Arab peoples, in shoes, hats and headgear that differed from European clothing fashion. Their grotesque and stylized figures *a la Turque*, just like the imitations of Chinese cultural stereotypes (chinoiserie) of the Rococo period, complemented both gardens and parks, as well as interiors, and influenced the design of applied art and household items.

The victory over the Turkish troops at Vienna both raised self-confidence and maintained a sense of insecurity for the ideologists and church circles of European countries, so they deliberately promoted the development of fear and Turkophobia in society. Reproduced images illustrating Eastern tyranny violated the boundaries of applied art saturated with everyday playfulness and were also brought to life in public works of art with a reminder to Christians of the threat of falling into "Turkish" slavery. One of the most impressive sculptural compositions on Charles Bridge in Prague depicts a very broad iconographic programme (Fig. 15). The sculpture on Charles Bridge was created in 1714 by the prominent Czech Baroque sculptor František Maximilian Brokhof



Fig. 15. Group of sculptures on Charles Bridge in Prague. Sculptor (Ferdinand Maxmilián Brokoff, 1688–1731), 1714. Sandstone. Photo Ojārs Spārītis, 2025

(Ferdinand Maxmilián Brokoff, 1688–1731). The mentioned sculptural group has both a complex structure and a complicated thematic content. The lower part depicts three Christians imprisoned in a prison. They are guarded by a "Turk" with a dog, while the Catholic priest Saint John of Matha (1160–1213), the Cistercian hermit and founder of

the Trinitarian Order Felix of Valois (1127–1212), together with Saint Ivan of Rila (1347), founder of Bulgarian monasticism revered by the Western Slavs as spiritual guardians pray for the safety of the prisoners.

To conclude the list of examples, it is worth mentioning the painting of St. Barbara, made at the beginning of the 18th century and exhibited in the National Museum in Prague, which depicts angels honouring her with a martyr's crown (Fig. 16). At her feet is depicted a defeated ruler with a crown over the typical Muslim male headdress, the turban. According to many versions of Christian legends, Barbara, daughter of Dioscurus of Nicomedia, lived in the 3rd century AD and suffered abuse from her father, who imprisoned her in a tower for her loyalty to Christianity. In Catholic lands, the martyr St. Barbara is considered the patron saint of mining and soldiers [Sachs H., Badstübner E., Neumann H., 1996, 51.–52.]. The ruler depicted at St. Barbara's feet in the painting could be interpreted literally as her father –the pagan ruler Dioscurus of Nicomedia. There is one explanation for such semantics – the victory of Christianity over ancient polytheism. However, in the context of the late 17th and early 18th centuries, a defeated and humiliated ruler in Muslim clothing and with a curved sword in his hands, typical of the Turkish soldiers' armament, can be identified as an enemy of European



Fig. 16. Painting of Saint Barbara. Author unknown. Early 18th century. Exhibition of the National Museum, Prague. Photo Ojārs Spārītis, 2025

Christians personified in the appearance of a Turkish ruler. Thus, the painting, which can be compared to a political poster and which before being exhibited in the National Museum in Prague had been in a Czech church, has actively addressed the members of the congregation and mobilized their thoughts for confessional and politically motivated hatred against the "Turk" or "non-believer".



Fig. 17. Sculpture of a killed "Turk" or "non-Christian" fighter personified in the image of a triton. Latvian National History Museum.
Inv. No. CVVM 175848, VS – 200. Early 18th century (?). Polychrome wood.
Photo Roberts Kaniņš, 2012

In searching for analogies with the symbolism generated by the political order of Turkophobia and the fear of Christian society in artistic images, attention is drawn to a sculpture made in the manner of a 17th-century woodcut in the collection of the Latvian National History Museum with a "defeated Turk" depicted in the form of a grotesque triton (Fig. 17). This iconographic interpretation is prompted by a bleeding wound in the chest of a half-animal, half-human figure armed with a curved sword. The hybridity of the image found in the mythology of the ancient world indicates that the creature personified in the sculpture belongs to a foreign culture. The origin and authorship of the polychrome wooden sculpture are unfortunately unknown, but this sculptural addition to the interior portal of a Riga patrician house, perhaps, shows that ideas of Turkophobia dressed in expressive imagery were not foreign to Livonia either. Whether they echoed or overlapped with the much more deeply rooted fear in the consciousness of the Livonian population of the violence of Muslims integrated into the troops of the Orthodox Russian Tsars experienced during the Livonian War, is impossible to answer unequivocally today. However, the undeniable parallelism of the historical threat could also have allowed the image of the "Turk" characteristic of Western European Turkophobia to be identified with the hostile force – the "Muscovites" and "Tatars" in eastern Livonia.

CONCLUSIONS

The territories of the modern Baltic States – Latvia and Estonia – historically known as Livonia and where, with the help of the Teutonic Order and missionaries, Christianity of the Western Roman model was introduced in the Middle Ages, bordering on the Slavic-populated territories in eastern Europe. There, since the baptism of the Kievan Rus' prince Volodymyr Svyatoslavich (Володимир Святославич, c. 960–1015) in 988, Christianity spread according to the rite of the Eastern Roman Church, or the model of Orthodoxy. These differences in religious construction concealed the possibility of potential conflict, which in the 13th, 16th and 17th centuries developed into warfare against Catholic Livonia, motivated by confessional differences.

The perpetrators of the aggression against Catholic Livonia were in alliance with the Khans of the "Golden Horde" and the descendants of their armies, who, together with the Mongol and Tatar units included in the Russian Tsarist vassalage, brought the behaviour characteristic of Muslim military culture. Its consequences stigmatized the consciousness of the Livonian population for several centuries and left traumatic fear of the cruelty of the "Muscovites" and "Tatars".

With an ideological motivation to protect the tomb of Christ and organizing a whole series of unsuccessful crusades against the aggression of the rulers of the Ottoman Empire against the crusader states established in Syria and Palestine, the troops of the Christian lands of Europe were unable to achieve their goals and lost the conquered territories. After the defeat, European Christians interpreted their political failure as a loss to the confessionally "alien" Muslim or "Turkish" empire and created the basis for a long-term ethnically motivated hatred.

After the fall of Byzantium, Muslim conquests were a constant threat to the Christian lands of Europe. By the 17th century, they had already occupied the entire Balkan territory and were moving closer to the Habsburg dynasty's centre of power, Vienna. The military alliance of the Holy League won the Battle of Vienna in the summer of 1683 and drove out the troops of the Islamic state of the Ottoman dynasty. This victory for the Christian lands provided moral revenge for the losses in the Crusades and contributed to the development of pathos, irony and mocking, as well as frightening iconographic motifs in art based on the emotions of the victors.

The Livonian cultural space is unique in that, being located on the border of different cultures, it has historically encountered both of these phobic attitudes: both the aversion to "Turks" as enslavers of Christians,

instigated by the propaganda of the Christian countries of Western Europe, and the fear of the invasion of "Muscovites" and "Tatars" threatening from the east, reproduced in artistic images. Therefore, the "Muscovites", "Tatars" or "Turks" artifacts in the cultural heritage of Latvia preserved the fear of "other believers" and "foreigners" and can be detected as materialized from historical memory into social consciousness.

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STYLISTIC AND ICONOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS OF THE SCULPTURE OF THE ALTAR RETABLE OF LIEPĀJA HOLY TRINITY CATHEDRAL

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ABSTRACT

The interior of Liepāja Holy Trinity Cathedral, created in the second half of the 18th century, has so far been studied mainly from the perspective of architecture and interior quality, while the authorship of the sculptures of the altar retable has not been specified. Documentary sources provide information only about the involvement of the sculptor Jozef Slaviček in the creation of the interior, which does not allow him to be regarded as the sole author of the sculptural programme of the altar retable. Based on stylistic and iconographic analysis, the article examines the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral in an attempt to identify the sources of its artistic influences. In the formal treatment of the sculptures of the altar retable and in the iconographic programme, the influences that can be discerned are associated with the artistic tradition of Andrea Pozzo and Georg Raphael Donner. The results of the stylistic analysis indicate that the possible authors of the altar sculptures of Liepāja Holy Trinity Cathedral may be sought within the sculptural milieu of Kraków, where the closest stylistic parallels can be identified with the works of Johann Georg Lehner, the anonymous Lehner apprentice, and Wojciech Rojowski, including stylistic influences observed in the Moravian region.

Keywords: Liepāja Holy Trinity Cathedral, sculpture, eighteenth-century Central Europe, stylistic influences, Moravian sculptural influence, Krakow sculptors

INTRODUCTION

The Holy Trinity Cathedral of Liepāja (hereafter Liepāja Cathedral) today is distinguished by a richly decorated interior in Rococo style, created in the second half of the 18th century. The church was consecrated

in 1758 (Tetsch 1768, 68). However, detailed information about the group of sculptors involved in the creation of this masterpiece remains unknown. When focusing on identifying the authors of the interior, it must be taken into account that the organ prospect, the altar retable, as well as the pulpit, the ducal loges, and other interior elements may have been produced by different masters' workshops, each involving several sculptors – leaving behind marks of both the shared workshop style and traces of individual authorship.

The central focus of the article is on the sculptures of the altar retable, their possible authors, and their sources of influence. Until now, Imants Lancmanis has devoted more attention to the history and ornamentation of Liepāja Cathedral, whereas within the scope of this paper, the emphasis will be placed on the figural sculpture, in an attempt to identify the paths through which the sources of inspiration for the cathedral's altar retable – and potentially the sculptors themselves – can be traced.

Based on available documentary evidence, only one sculptor's name is known: Jozef Slaviček (also recorded as Slawitzek, Slawitzky, Schlawitzky), who is listed in the expense records of the city of Liepāja and in the account books of the German parish church. In 1757, he was paid for producing the city's coat of arms for the town hall. Between 1757 and 1759, while work on Liepāja Cathedral was in progress, Jozef Slaviček was commissioned to execute the interior of Blīdene Church (now lost). His name is mentioned in connection with Liepāja Cathedral only in 1762 and 1770, when he received small payments for work carried out there, after the majority of the church's interior had already been completed (Lancmanis 1983, 106–107). This information confirms that the sculptor Jozef Slaviček was involved in the woodcarving of Liepāja Cathedral; however, the question remains as to the extent of his involvement and the specific works he executed. In his study, Imants Lancmanis identified stylistic similarities in ornamental carving across several churches in the Duchy of Courland and Semigallia that correspond to the style attributed to Jozef Slaviček – in the interiors of the churches of Cīrava, Lipaiķi, Ēdole and Kuldīga Catholic Church, also in the Zlēkas Church (Lancmanis 1983, 108). The sculptural modelling in the churches of Cīrava and Lipaiķi displays the dramatic expression characteristic of the Baroque; however, the stylistic approach differs significantly from that of the sculptures in Liepāja Cathedral, indicating a different sculptural authorship.

It is plausible that Jozef Slaviček carried out only minor sculptural work in Liepāja Cathedral, as is also indicated by the small sums recorded

for his contribution. This corresponds with the study by Imants Lancmanis, who suggests that Slaviček most likely produced the ornamental carvings of the pulpit, the confessional, and organ balconies (Lancmanis 1983, 109). Moreover, during the same period when the interior of Liepāja Cathedral was under construction, Jozef Slaviček was working on the interior of Blīdene Church, which would have made it impossible for him to have been more extensively involved in the large-scale development of the cathedral interior. As a result, the group of sculptors responsible for the remaining interior and sculptures of Liepāja Cathedral has not yet been identified.

Without naming specific sculptors, several art historians have attempted to propose hypotheses regarding the stylistic spheres of influence on the sculptors responsible for such a lavish and impressive church interior. The art historian Boriss Vipers, in his study on Latvian art of the Baroque period, notes that similar altar retable compositional motifs can be found in the Catholic countries of Southern Europe and emphasises the popularity of such compositions in late Baroque and Rococo art (Vipper 1937, 198). Imants Lancmanis supports a similar



Fig. 1 The altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral. Photo: S. Bitko

view, supplementing this assumption with the etymology of the confirmed sculptor Jozef Slaviček's surname, suggesting that he and the other sculptors may have come from the region of Southern Poland or Bohemia (Lancmanis 1983, 93).

MATERIALS AND METHODS

To determine the circle of possible sculptors and stylistic influences, the sculptures of the altar retable in the Liepāja Cathedral (Fig. 1) were analysed in three groups: (1) the sculptural groups of angels, (2) the sculptural group of holy figures – God the Father, God the Son, and the Evangelists: St Mark, St John, St Luke, and St Matthew, as well as (3) the composition depicting the Holy Trinity. This categorisation method is based on empirical observations made during the course of the research.

[1] Sculptural Groups of Angels

An inattentive observer may overlook the composition with two angels shedding tears located in the lower central part of the altar retable, which is usually obscured by flowers and candlesticks (Fig. 2). This sculptural composition is described by the pastor Karl Ludvig Tetsch (1708–1771) in *Curländischer Kirchen-Geschichte*: "the lowest part of the altar forms a table in the centre, on which the Lord's Supper



Fig. 2. Angels shedding tears of Liepāja Cathedral. Photo: S. Bitko

is celebrated; upon it lies a finely carved serpent, and beside it sit two small angels shedding tears, one representing the Fall of Adam, the other repentance" (Tetsch 1768, 189). This iconographic group visually expresses the principle *Iam sed nondum* – "already, but not yet," or "already accomplished, but not yet fully realised". Christ has conquered sin; nevertheless, humanity continues to live in a world in which the consequences of sin persist. The serpent refers to original sin, while the angels shedding tears point to human awareness of guilt for this reality and to the necessity of repentance. Such a solution does not leave the viewer indifferent, as it recalls what God has done for humankind and encourages a further step – from theoretical faith toward inner, emotional peace.

The choice of this iconographic motif is not characteristic of Lutheran churches and is far more frequently encountered within the Catholic tradition, where, in the late Baroque and Rococo periods, particular emphasis was placed on the affective engagement of the viewer. In the interiors of Catholic churches, dramatic sculptural compositions emphasising mercy and repentance were employed, with the aim not only of illustrating theological themes but also of emotionally affecting the members of the congregation and encouraging personal empathy and spiritual reflection. In Latvia, angels shedding tears are found in two further churches: Pasiene St Lawrence Catholic Church (*Pasienes Svētā Laurencija katoļu baznīca*) and Piedruja Assumption of the Virgin Mary Catholic Church (*Piedrujas Jaunavas Marijas debesīs uzņemšanas katoļu baznīca*). The closest representations of angels shedding tears can be identified at All Saints' Church in Vilnius, Lithuania (*Vilniaus Visų Šventųjų bažnyčia*)(Fig. 3).



Fig. 3. Angels shedding tears. Left: Pasiene Church, Latvia.
Right: All Saints' Church, Vilnius. Photo: S. Bitko

In both angel representations, similarities can be observed in the modelling of the eyelids, hair, handkerchief, and hands. Although the angels shedding tears in Pasiene and Vilnius differ stylistically from the ensemble of Liepāja Cathedral, they are united by a similar emotionally charged theological programme.

The theological message of the altar of Liepāja Cathedral is complemented by the angels placed on the volutes of the entablature of the altar retable (Fig. 4). In comparison with other church interiors in the Duchy of Courland and Semigallia, their anatomy conveys a sense of dynamism, and their expressive gestures heighten the emotional tension.



Fig. 4. Angels on the altar of Liepāja Cathedral. Photo: S. Bitko

The interior of Liepāja Cathedral should be evaluated in the context of the circumstances of its creation. The construction of the church was financed by the townspeople themselves from municipal funds, and sources indicate that "for nine years materials were collected for the construction of a new church, and approximately 20,000 florins had already been gathered" (Šmits 2025, 210). Since the patron was the urban community rather than a specific confessional institution, it may be assumed that sculptors associated with the Catholic milieu were invited to participate in the development of the interior, as they were able to offer an appealing solution within an iconographic framework familiar to them.

Such a situation is not unique. Rūta Kaminska's research on the Pasiene church shows that Polish scholarly studies identify Johann Christoph Glaubitz as the architect – a master of Silesian origin who designed Catholic churches and their interiors in the Grand Duchy of Lithuania. Although he himself was a Lutheran, under his direction both sculptors affiliated with religious orders and secular craftsmen were

employed (Kaminska 1998, 58–59). Similar interconfessional collaboration indicates that in the practice of 18th-century sacred art, style and professional skills often prevailed over confessional divisions, making it possible to realise within a single church iconographic programmes whose roots lay in a different tradition.

[2] Sculptural Group of Holy Figures

The sculptural groups of holy figures on the altar of Liepāja Cathedral require separate consideration – namely, the group of the four Evangelists and the representations of God the Father and God the Son. Pastor Tetsch characterised them as follows: "Between the four columns, on pedestals, the four Evangelists can be seen, who in their excellent execution closely resemble living persons" (Tetsch 1768, 189). When comparing the sculptures of Liepāja Cathedral with those found in other churches of the Duchy of Courland and Semigallia, a significant stylistic difference becomes apparent. In the figural sculpture of Liepāja Cathedral, a more precise correspondence to human anatomy has been achieved, and examples of comparable quality are not encountered in any other church of the Duchy of Courland and Semigallia. This precision in plastic anatomy indicates a highly skilled and, presumably, widely sought–after sculptors' workshop, prompting the search for analogous examples beyond Latvia – specifically in the



Fig. 5. Left: the sculpture of God the Son from the altar of Liepāja Cathedral. Right: the sculpture of St Andrew from the Chapel of John I Albert at Wawel Cathedral. Photo: S. Bitko

major centres of Central and Eastern Europe. A visually comparative analysis of angel sculptures suggests that stylistic parallels should be sought not only in Lutheran but also in Catholic churches. One such possible model has been identified in Kraków, in the chapel of John I Albert (*Jan I Olbracht, 1459–1501*) in Wawel Cathedral (Fig. 5). On the eastern wall of the chapel stands an altar designed in 1758 by the Italian architect and sculptor Francesco Placidi (b. ca. 1710–1715; d. 1782). On either side of the altar are placed the figures of St Andrew and St Stanislaus (Wilk, n.d.). A comparison of the two sculptures reveals similar modelling of the nose, nostrils, lips, eyes, eyelids, and hands (palms). The garments of the figures are modelled with dense drapery, in which features characteristic of the Moravian region can be discerned, along with a sharper treatment of edges typical of sculpture from the Galician region. The plasticity of the drapery is subordinated to the anatomy of the body, while the figures themselves retain a dynamic expressiveness. Such an approach is characteristic of Bohemian sacred sculpture as a whole.

The stylistic similarity is so pronounced that the involvement of the same sculptor or workshop in the execution of both the sculpture of St Andrew and the sculptures of Liepāja Cathedral may be considered plausible. However, although the name of the architect of the altar of the Chapel of John I Albert at Wawel Cathedral has been documented and preserved, information about the sculptors is lacking. In order to determine the possible circle of sculptors in such a situation, it is advisable to apply the method of indirect attribution by analysing known sculptors who collaborated episodically with Francesco Placidi in other joint projects. By reviewing the output of several workshops and analysing the works of individual sculptors, it has been possible to identify the Lehner circle of sculptors, whose work displays the closest stylistic affinity with the sculptures of Liepāja Cathedral. A more in-depth insight into the sculpture of the Lehner circle is provided by the study of Krakow sculpture in the second half of the 18th century conducted by the Polish art historian Anna Dettloff. The collaboration of two sculptors associated with this circle – Wojciech Rojowski (d. 1778) and the anonymous Lehner apprentice – with Francesco Placidi is recognised within Polish art historical scholarship, even though it is not always documentarily confirmed:

(1) At St Andrew's Church in Krakow (*Kościół św. Andrzeja w Krakowie*) (1741–1744), Francesco Placidi is identified as the architect of the high altar, while the sculptor is referred to as the anonymous Lehner apprentice (Fig. 6) (Dettloff 2013, 74).



Fig. 6. The sculpture of St Peter at St Andrew's Church in Kraków. Photo from Dettloff 2013



Fig. 7. The tomb monument of Michał Korybut Wiśniowiecki at Wawel Cathedral. Photo: S. Bitko

(2) At Wawel Cathedral, the sculptor Wojciech Rojowski worked on both the decoration of the altar of the Andrzej Stanisław Załuski Chapel, completed after 1763 (Dettloff 2013, 113–114), and the tomb monument of Michał Korybut Wiśniowiecki (Fig. 7), executed between 1760 and 1761 (Dettloff 2013, 113–116). In both commissions, Francesco Placidi served as the architect.



Fig. 8. Left: a fragment of a sculpture from Liepāja Cathedral. Right: a fragment of the sculpture from the tomb monument of Michał Korybut Wiśniowiecki at Wawel Cathedral. Sculptor: Wojciech Rojowski. Photo: S. Bitko

In the works of both sculptors mentioned above – Wojciech Rojowski and the anonymous Lehner apprentice – namely, in their sculptural creations (Fig. 6, Fig. 7), one can observe the previously identified stylistic similarity in the modelling of drapery folds, comparable to the sculptures of the altar retable in Liepāja Cathedral (see Fig. 5 left, Fig. 8). The form of the drapery reflects a stylistic tendency characteristic of sacred culture in the Bohemian and Moravian regions (Hladik 2021), marked by an unnatural, artificially sharpened rhythm of folds that contrasts with the natural fall of fabric. The sharp edges intensify the artificial tension of the composition – a feature particularly typical of Rococo sculpture.

To gain a more comprehensive understanding of the distribution of stylistic features and their potential connections with the sculptures of Liepāja Cathedral, the analysis must be expanded beyond the previously examined works of sculptors within the Lehner circle. This involves including additional works by the same masters, as well as works by other sculptors belonging to this circle. Among several artists of the Lehner circle, the closest stylistic affinity to the sculptures of Liepāja Cathedral is most clearly evident in the works of the aforementioned sculptors –

Wojciech Rojowski and the anonymous Lehner apprentice – as well as in the oeuvre of the master himself, Johann Georg Lehner (1703–1776), after whom this circle is named in Polish art history scholarship.

A significant point of comparison is the side altar dedicated to Saint John of Nepomuk (Fig. 9), created by the sculptor Johann Georg Lehner in the Church of the Holy Trinity (*Kostel Nejsvětější Trojice*) in Svatoňovice, Czechia (hereafter Czech church), dated to around 1735 (Dettloff 2013, 79–80). A similar architectural structure and arrangement of figures can be observed in the altar of Liepāja Cathedral. The compositional layout of the sculptures in Liepāja Cathedral follows the same model as in the Czech church:

(1) In the lower central section of the altar retable, two childlike angels are placed; the only difference lies in the theological programme. While in Liepāja Cathedral the angels are depicted weeping, in the Czech church they are rendered with a pronounced dynamic of movement.

(2) In both churches, expressively gesturing angels are placed on the entablature volutes of the altar retable.



Fig. 9. Altar of Saint John of Nepomuk, Church of the Holy Trinity (Kostel Nejsvětější Trojice), Svatoňovice, Czechia. Sculptor: Johann Georg Lehner. Photo from Dettloff 2013, 79

(3) Between the four columns of the altar retable, four larger-scale sculptures are placed; although the theological message differs, the figural composition remains unchanged.

(4) At the top of the altar retable, a radiant glory is positioned, behind which a window is built to allow natural light to enter, creating the liturgical light effect characteristic of Catholic Baroque churches.

(5) Both altar retables are painted white with individual gilded elements.

Another comparative example is provided by the sculptures of the altar of Saint John of Nepomuk (1750), created by the workshop of Wojciech Rojowski and located in the Basilica on the Rock (*Bazylika św. Michała Archanioła i św. Stanisława Biskupa w Krakowie* or *Kościół Na Skałce*) in Kraków. When comparing the sculpture of Saint John Cantius from the Basilica on the Rock with the sculpture of the Evangelist John from the altar of Liepāja Cathedral (Fig. 10), both figures display not only similarities in body posture but also a facial type characteristic of the Lehner school style – an upward gaze, pronounced cheekbones, the modelling of curled hair, and a downward-curving shape of the lips.



Fig. 10. On the left: altar sculpture of Saint John Cantius from the Basilica on the Rock (Bazylika na Skałce). Sculptor: Wojciech Rojowski. Photo from Dettloff 2013, 98. On the right: altar sculpture of the Evangelist John from Liepāja Cathedral. Photo: S. Bitko



Fig. 11. Main altar in the Church of Velké Heraltice, Czechia. Photo from Dettloff 2013, 81

The main altar in the Church of Velké Heraltice (Kostel Velké Heraltice), Czechia (Fig. 11), created by the anonymous Lehner apprentice, in this context is considered in relation to similarities in the iconographic programme with the altar in Liepāja Cathedral, rather than in terms of sculptural style or architectural structure.

A similar sculptural arrangement scheme, previously described, is used in the altar (Fig. 11), preserving parallels in the placement of individual figures (see Fig. 9). However, in this case, the depiction of the Holy Trinity becomes the central focus of analysis. As in the altar of Liepāja Cathedral, the altar in the Church of Velké Heraltice also features God the Father with the Son, above whose heads is a gloria with the representation of the Holy Spirit in the form of a dove. Although depictions of the Holy Trinity are diverse in European sacred art, a broad comparative evaluation indicates that the closest parallels to the composition of the Holy Trinity in the altar of Liepāja Cathedral

are found in the works of the sculptors of the Lehner circle. One of the most striking examples is located in the main altar of the Chapel of Our Lady of the Rosary in the Holy Trinity Basilica of the Dominicans (Bazylika Dominikanów pw. Świętej Trójcy) in Krakow (hereafter Krakow Holy Trinity Church) (Fig. 12).

[3] Composition Depicting the Holy Trinity

Both in the altar of Liepāja Cathedral and in that of the Krakow Holy Trinity church, a detailed iconographic depiction of the Holy Trinity is present, with the composition including a globe. The expressive gestures of God the Father and the Son, including the motif of hands extended toward the globe, convey the idea of the created world and divine rule over it (Fig. 12).

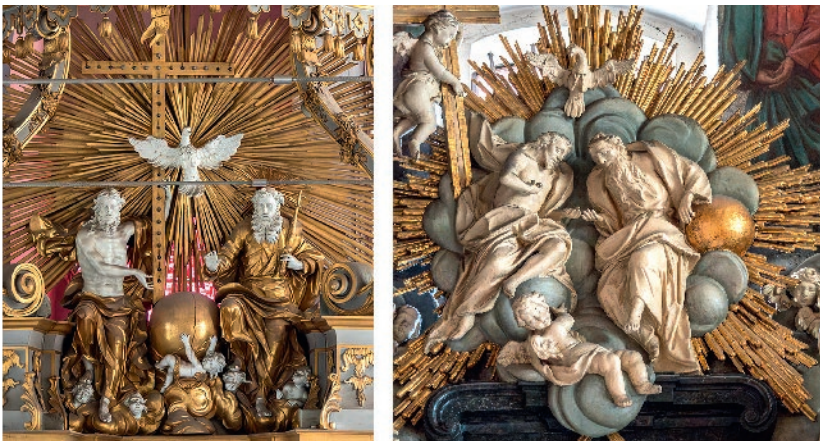


Fig. 12. Composition of the Holy Trinity altarpiece. Left: Liepāja Cathedral. Right: Krakow Holy Trinity Church. Photo: S. Bitko

Art historian Anna Dettloff confirms that the sculptural parts of the altar in the Krakow Holy Trinity Church were created by Wojciech Rojowski (Dettloff 2013, 122). The stucco sculptures in the altar of the Krakow Holy Trinity Church create a noticeably more plastic and dynamic impression than those in the altar of Liepāja Cathedral. However, based on a broad study of sculptural representations of the Holy Trinity – including both in-person surveys of the church interiors and additional analysis of visual materials on digital platforms – it can be concluded that such an iconographic solution is rarely encountered. Based on the study of the stylistics of the Lehner circle sculptors, it

can be assumed that the similarity between the compositions in Liepāja and Krakow did not occur by chance, allowing us to propose the thesis of a possible connection between the sculptors of the two church interiors.

In the second half of the 18th century, the centres of sculpture in Central Europe were in close mutual interaction, and migrating artists often drew inspiration from a variety of sources. During this period, Italian prototypes played a significant role, with their influence reaching different regions through Jesuit commissions, the circulation of engravings, as well as through the migration of apprentices and masters and personal contacts. Particularly important for the development of 18th-century sacred art was the influence of both the theoretical and practical works of Andrea Pozzo (1642–1709). His treatise *Perspectiva pictorum et architectorum* (1693–1698) not only established the principles of illusionistic spatial construction throughout Catholic Europe, but also significantly influenced the creative thinking of artists and sculptors in the development of religious compositions. The treatise gained wide popularity and, until the second half of the 18th century, had been published also in London and Augsburg. Andrea Pozzo's relocation from Rome to Vienna further contributed to the dissemination of his ideas in Central Europe, influencing more than one art centre. His concepts were based on the active involvement of the viewer, achieved through a unified use of architecture, sculpture, and painting to create spatial and visual illusion, thereby enhancing the perception of the Scriptures within the sacred space. As a result, the viewer became not a passive observer, but an active participant in the narrative of the Holy Scriptures (Horn 2016, 1–33).

In his treatise *Perspectiva pictorum et architectorum*, Andrea Pozzo included the altar of St. Ignatius in Rome – designed by himself and realised in 1700 (Pozzo 1693, Fig. 60) – to demonstrate his method of perspective and illusionistic spatial construction in practice. The composition scheme of the Holy Trinity at the top of the altar (Fig. 13), reproduced in the engravings of the treatise, became an easily transferable iconographic model even for artists who had never been to Rome. This may explain the emergence of similar compositional solutions both in Krakow and in Liepāja.

In *Perspectiva pictorum et architectorum*, Andrea Pozzo, in Fig. 74, describes an architectural solution for the altar retable involving openings and windows in the apse wall, intended to admit natural light and enhance visual perception. In practice, this solution is implemented by constructing the altar retable as a spatial structure that does not

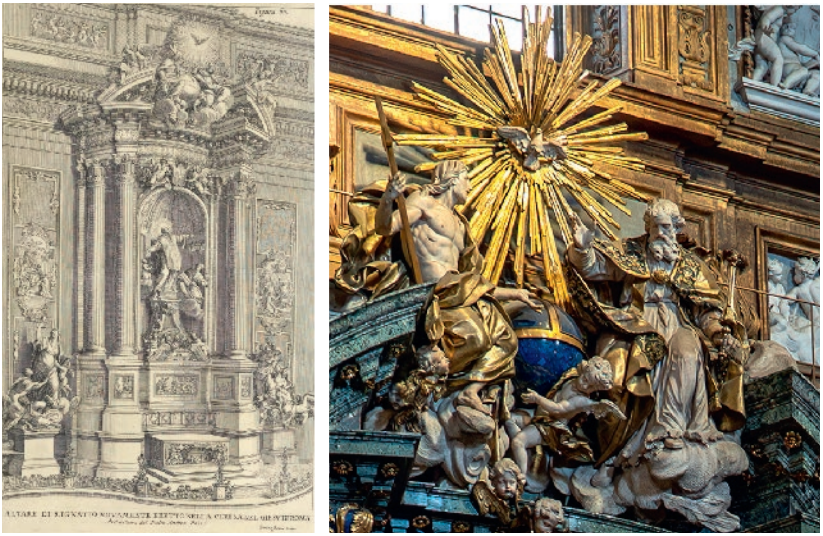


Fig. 13. Left: Engraving of Pozzo's altar. Source: Perspectiva pictorum et architectorum, 1693. Right: Close-up of Pozzo's altar. Photo: S. Bitko

obstruct the light sources embedded in the apse wall (Pozzo 1693, Fig. 74). This idea – the light-entry point serving as a visual accent – corresponds to the solution observed in the altar of Liepāja Cathedral, where a window is positioned behind the radiant glory.

Alongside the influence of Andrea Pozzo, the altar composition of Liepāja Cathedral also shows influences that can be associated with the artistic tradition of the Austrian Baroque sculptor Georg Raphael Donner (1693–1741). In 18th-century Central European sculpture, the artistic environments of Vienna and Bratislava played a significant role, within which Georg Raphael Donner worked as a sculptor. He initially worked in Bratislava, where he faced no competition and therefore received prestigious commissions. Over time, Georg Raphael Donner demonstrated his talent and was also recognised by the artistic circles of Vienna. Sculpture in Central Europe during the 18th century developed under the influence of Georg Raphael Donner, ultimately achieving a decisive victory over Bernini's Baroque (Dettloff 2013, 161). Thanks to his apprentices, who later worked in various Central European centres, Donner's influence spread across a wider region, including Olomouc in Moravia (present-day Czechia), where the sculptor Johann Georg Lehner was also active. While carrying out commissioned works in Krakow, Johann Georg Lehner continued to

apply the compositional schemes and principles of sculptural modelling he had acquired, thereby contributing to the dissemination of Georg Raphael Donner's artistic tradition. In her study, Anna Dettloff notes that Johann Georg Lehner's style should not be regarded as a continuation of a local Krakow artistic tradition, but rather as an interpretation of the classicising Baroque school of Donner adopted in Moravia, which later transformed into the distinctive manner of his own workshop (Dettloff 2013, 160–162).

The sculptors' workshop that created the interior of Liepāja Cathedral introduced into the architectural structure of the altar the compositional principles characteristic of the stylistic tradition of Georg Raphael Donner (Fig. 14). The transmission of these forms may have occurred through the sculptural milieu of Krakow, more specifically through the masters of the Lehner circle of sculptors. The architectural structure of both altars is formed by a vertically organised

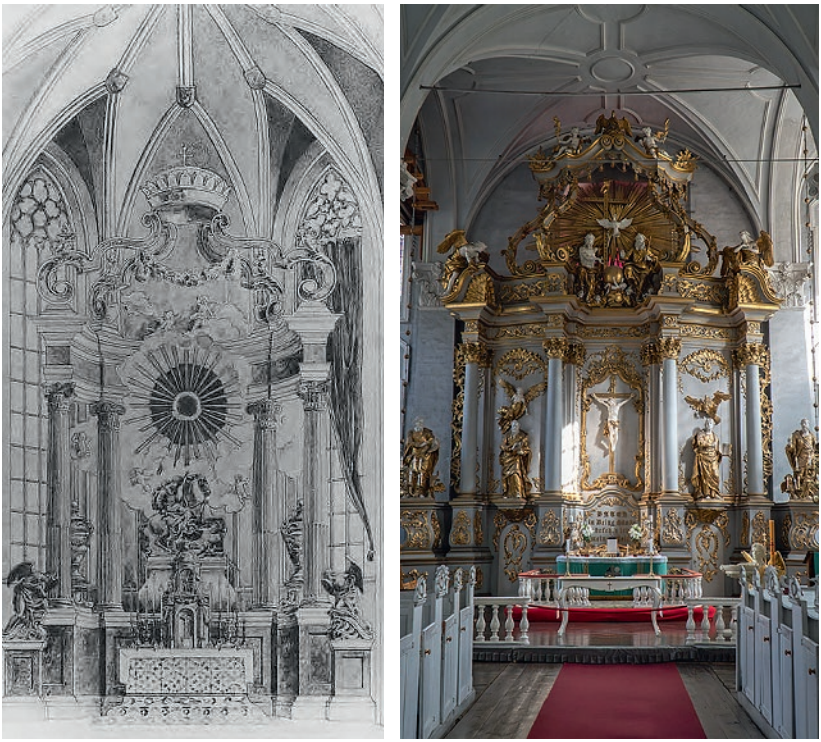


Fig. 14. Left: Drawing of the altar of Bratislava Cathedral. Source: Dettloff 2013, 161. Right: Altar of Liepāja Cathedral. Photo: S. Bitko

system of columns, between which sculptures are positioned. The upper section is crowned by a broken pediment with four volute-shaped consoles, showing a clear similarity to those in Liepāja Cathedral. In the main altar of Bratislava Cathedral created by Georg Raphael Donner, they support a crown, whereas in Liepāja Cathedral they support a baldachin.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Thus far, the article has examined examples in which the work of three sculptors' workshops from the Lehner circle is stylistically closest to the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral. However, at this stage of the research it is not possible to single out only one of them. In comparison with the sculptors' milieu currently identified in Latvia, where church interiors created within a single workshop are often stylistically so close that they produce an almost identical impression, the situation in Krakow is different. This may be explained both by the larger number of sculptors working within a single workshop and by the specificity of the materials employed. The hypothesis of the involvement of a particular Lehner-circle workshop in the creation of the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral cannot be substantiated by stylistic and iconographic analysis alone. Other relevant aspects must also be taken into account. One such aspect is the material of the sculptures. For example, if sculptors specialised exclusively in working with stone, it is unlikely that they would have been involved in the creation of the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral, as it is made of wood. Information on the materials used by the sculptors of the Lehner circle is provided in the study by Anna Dettloff. This study analyses both the materials with which the sculptors worked and the influence of the material on stylistic features and form. It is known that the anonymous Lehner apprentice worked in wood. His works were most often painted white and supplemented with individual gilded elements (Dettloff 2013, 79). Master Johann Georg Lehner worked in stucco but nevertheless gave preference to wood and stone (Dettloff 2013, 67). In the oeuvre of Wojciech Rojowski, the majority of works were executed in stucco, while wood was used by the sculptor less frequently. The master's style was determined by the properties of the sculptural material and the techniques of its processing. The sculptures carved in wood have been assessed by the Polish art historian Anna Dettloff as among the finest works by Wojciech Rojowski. Here, the way in which material determines form and style becomes directly apparent, as the garments

of the wood-carved sculptures are modelled with deeper and sharper folds than those executed in stucco (Dettloff 2013, 148). Archival materials in which the name of Wojciech Rojowski is recorded also refer to him as a "master of woodcarving" (Dettloff 2013, 36). From 1746 onwards, Wojciech Rojowski developed a very active artistic practice, carrying out a large number of commissions. It may be assumed that he established a fairly large sculptural workshop, in which both stucco specialists and woodcarvers were active, as evidenced by the volume, scale, and stylistic diversity of the works produced (Dettloff 2013, 94).

Since the sculptors of all the workshops mentioned above also executed works in wood, the very choice of material does not allow any of these workshops to be excluded. Consequently, all three workshops must still be considered as potential sculptors of the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral.

As a further clarifying criterion, the chronology of the workload of the Krakow workshops during the period of the creation of the interior of Liepāja Cathedral may be considered. It is necessary to determine whether, during the time when the interior of Liepāja Cathedral was being created, the involvement of these sculptors in other large-scale commissions in Krakow or the Krakow region is documented. In such a case, the respective workshop could be excluded from the group of potential creators of the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral.

The time period can be determined based on the year in which the creation of the interior of Liepāja Cathedral was completed. According to Imants Lancmanis – "in 1757, after most of the work in the church had been completed" – it may be assumed that at the time of the consecration in 1758 the altar retable was already finished (Lancmanis 1983, 106). Determining the date when work on the interior began presents difficulties, as no information on this has been preserved. Consequently, the question of when the creation of the interior commenced must be addressed indirectly, by reconstructing the time required to produce the altar. Anton Ulbrich's study of sculpture in East Prussia from the late 16th century to the second half of the 19th century indicates that, if work proceeded without delays, a workshop working on a single commission produced, on average, one altar per year. With due caution, it may therefore be assumed that the time required to produce the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral exceeded one year and most likely encompassed the period from 1755 to 1757/1758. This reconstruction of the timeline makes it possible to determine whether, during the relevant period, the involvement of the aforementioned sculptors in large-scale commissions in Krakow was recorded.

It is known that the sculptor Johann Georg Lehner left Krakow in 1746, and that his work was taken over by Wojciech Rojowski in 1747 (Dettloff 2013, 96). Information on the activity of the sculptor Wojciech Rojowski is available primarily through records of payments for completed commissions. In her archival research, Anna Dettloff has noted that for the period from 1752 to 1763 information about the sculptor is lacking. No archival evidence has been preserved for this period that would allow the sculptor's place of activity to be determined unequivocally (Dettloff 2013, 98). The activity of the sculptor referred to as the anonymous Lehner apprentice in Krakow can be traced until the late 1740s. It is possible that in the early 1750s the sculptor was producing works in Opava (in the Silesian region). The last work currently attributed with caution by Anna Dettloff to the anonymous Lehner apprentice is the main altar of the Church of the Immaculate Conception of the Virgin Mary (Kostel Neposkvrněného početí Panny Marie) in Velké Heraltice, Czechia, which is dated to the second half of the 18th century (Dettloff 2013, 82).

The conducted chronological analysis does not allow any of the workshops examined to be excluded, as during the period from 1755 to 1757/1758, when the altar retable of Liepāja Cathedral was produced, no intensive activity by these workshops in Krakow has been documented.

CONCLUSIONS

The altar of Liepāja Cathedral presents an outstanding example within Latvian sacred art, reflecting a synthesis of international influences in the mid- and second half of the 18th century. The stylistic and iconographic structure of the altar indicates its connection with sacred art processes in Europe in which the principles of spatial composition formulated by Andrea Pozzo, as well as the classicising Baroque formal language of Georg Raphael Donner, played a significant role. These artistic impulses are not to be understood in the altar of Liepāja Cathedral as directly adopted models, but rather as a conceptual and formal framework within which the overall architectural and iconographic structure of the altar was formed.

The author's research makes it possible to establish a more specific connection between the altar of Liepāja Cathedral and parallels in Moravian sacred sculpture, and encourages the altar of Liepāja Cathedral to be viewed not as a general repetition of external stylistic influences, but rather as evidence of the migration and influence of specific Central European workshops and masters.

In the sculptural work of the altar of Liepāja Cathedral, features characteristic of the workshops of the Lehner circle can be identified. These features are very close to the stylistic characteristics and iconographic schemes associated with Johann Georg Lehner himself, the anonymous Lehner apprentice, and Wojciech Rojowski. At present, the sculptors of the Lehner circle may be regarded as the closest group of masters with whom the sculptural work of the Liepāja Cathedral altar can be compared. However, considering the stylistic and iconographic analysis carried out, it is not possible to single out only one workshop. Nor is the range of possible workshops narrowed by the chronological analysis or by the analysis of the materials used.

Further research requires on-site examination of the objects discussed and their comprehensive visual documentation, including the creation of three-dimensional models of the sculptures. In addition to the established stylistic and iconographic analysis, the introduction of a new methodological approach currently under development – based on structured analysis of the facial form in three-dimensional models – offers the potential to support the attribution of the sculptural authorship. Such an approach may enable a more precise and methodologically grounded assessment of the involvement of specific sculptors' workshops in the creation of the altar of Liepāja Cathedral.

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FOUR SOURCES OF MICHAEL JOHANN VON DER BORCH'S POEM "THE SENTIMENTAL GARDEN OF VARAKĻĀNI CASTLE"

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ABSTRACT

Count Michael Johann von der Borch (*Michael Johann Graf von der Borch, Michał Jan Borch,* 1753–1811), naturalist, mineralogist, politician, writer and poet, was one of the most brilliant minds of the Enlightenment in Latvia, and one can assume that the same was true in Europe.

The small book "The Sentimental Garden of Varakļāni Castle", written in French and Latin and printed in Warsaw in 1795 ("*Jardin sentimental du château de Warkland dans la comté de Borch en Russie-Blanche*"), was published in Latvian in 2019 in two translations.

This composition, written alternately in poetry and prose, is considered M.J. Borch's most remarkable known literary work to date, and its interpretation, as well as its connection to the actual grounds of Varakļāni Castle, has been the focus of much research both in Latvia and abroad. This short literary work reveals the multifaceted world of the author's knowledge and values, and also identifies the initiators of the creative process.

At the beginning of the poem, in a section rich in episodes drawn from Greek and Roman myths and interwoven with M.J. Borch's own reflections, it is clear that the author drew inspiration from the works of ancient authors and Renaissance painting. M.J. Borch describes it as "a plan or preface to a sentimental garden," but in the rest of the work, the author does not return to Greek and Roman imagery.

After a poetic introduction, the narrative continues with a stroll through an imaginary, or perhaps semi-real, garden. Here we must mention a second source of inspiration: the motif of the solitary walker in Enlightenment literature. It is highly probable that M.J. Borch, who regularly followed French literary news, had read Jean-Jacques Rousseau's "Reveries of the Solitary Walker" (*"Les les rêveries du promeneur*

solitaire"), written between 1776 and 1778 and published posthumously in 1782 in Geneva.

When creating the Varakļāni Palace garden, M.J. Borch supplemented his library with works on garden art, and a third source of inspiration may have been the publication in German and French of the "*Théorie de l'art des jardins*" by the Enlightenment garden and park theorist Christian Cay Lorenz Hirschfeld.

A fourth source of inspiration for M.J. Borch was his encounter with the French writer and philosopher Voltaire. This is evidenced by his letter to his father, dated January 27, 1775, preserved in the V. Stefanik Scientific Library in Lviv, attached to the Academy of Sciences of Ukraine.

Keywords: Michael Johann von der Borch, Enlightenment, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, K.C.L. Hirschfeld, Voltaire.

INTRODUCTION

Michael Johann von MihalJan Borch's poem "The Sentimental Garden of Warkland Castle" ("*Jardin sentimental du château de Warkland dans la comté de Borch en Russie-Blanche*") (Fig. 1), was privately printed in Warsaw in 1795 as a small, 29 page booklet. This poem is an outstanding example of late 18th century sentimental literature, combining philosophical contemplation, descriptions of nature, and personal reflections. The work focuses on Warkland Castle and its adjacent park, which is portrayed not only as a picturesque and aesthetic object but

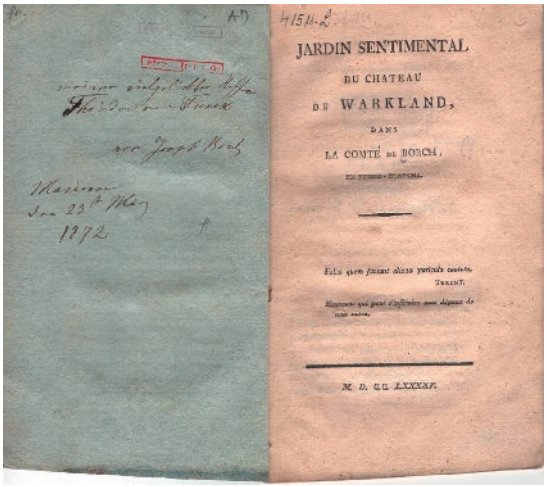

JARDIN SENTIMENTAL
DU CHATEAU
DE WARKLAND,
DANS
LA COMTÉ DE BORCH,

Fig. 1. Borch, M.J. (1795) *Jardin sentimental du château de Warkland dans le Comté de Borch en Russie Blanche*, Warsaw. Cover page. Latvijas Universitātes bibliotēka

also as a spiritual refuge where the author experiences his reflective and intellectual world. The work represents the ideal of the garden, rooted in the Enlightenment view of nature as a source of harmony and virtue. The author discusses the relationship between nature and culture, emphasizing that creating and maintaining a garden is not only an aesthetic task but also a moral and philosophical one. Count Borch's work is distinguished by its sophisticated language and rich style, which resonate with the sentimental literary trends of the period.

GARDEN, MYTH, MORALITY AND SENSIBILITY IN THE ENLIGHTENMENT: BORCH, ROUSSEAU, HIRSCHFELD, VOLTAIRE

In the preface to his poem, M.J. Borch deliberately invokes a series of the most scandalous Greco-Roman myths to denounce the visual arts indulgence in depictions of unbridled passion, incest, and divine deception. This gallery of examples, largely inherited from the Ovidian (Publius Ovidius Naso 20 March 43 BC – AD 17/18), tradition, functions as a moral counter-model intended to be rejected in favour of an aesthetics founded on virtue and the elevation of the soul. The virulence of this denunciation takes on its full meaning when one considers the exceptional iconographic success of these stories in 18th century painting, sculpture, and garden design. The myth of Ixion, deceived by the cloud fashioned in the image of Juno, refers to a theme frequently exploited in history painting, where the ambiguity between sensual illusion and moral punishment allowed for the representation of the female nude under the guise of mythological erudition. Similarly, Bacchic scenes, depicting Bacchantes with thyrsus in their hands, became widespread in decorative painting and the ornamental arts, from compositions inherited from Poussin (Nicolas Poussin, 1594–1665) to the gallant and sometimes overtly erotic variations of the French Rococo. These images, celebrating intoxication, dance, and the loss of modesty, contributed to an aesthetic of sensual excess that Borch explicitly condemns. The incestuous tales of Biblis and Myrrha, although less frequently represented independently, nevertheless permeated the visual culture of the century through abandoned, grieving, or metamorphosed female figures, often associated with melancholic or nocturnal landscapes. These motifs are found in both painting and garden sculpture, where bodies frozen in a moment of despair offered aristocratic strolls an ambiguous, pathetic emotion, oscillating between moral compassion and sensual allure. The

figure of Jupiter occupies a central place in this iconographic repertoire. His successive metamorphoses swan for Leda, bull for Europa, shower of gold for Danaë provide so many visual pretexts for the representation of the female nude, a subject extensively explored by 17th and 18th century painters, from Titian (Tiziano Vecellio, 1506–1576) and Correggio (Antonio Allegri da Correggio, 1589–1534) to Boucher (François Boucher, 1703–1770), Van Loo (Jacob van Loo, 1614–1670), and Lemoyne (François Lemoyne or François Le Moine 1688–1737). These subjects were also transposed into sculpture, in marble or bronze, as well as into garden decorations, in the form of mythological groups arranged along paths, groves, or water features. The episode of Europa being abducted by the bull, in particular, was perfectly integrated into the scenography of landscaped gardens, where movement, flight, and illusion contributed to a visual drama designed to surprise the visitor. The case of Pomona, seduced by Vertumnus disguised as a gardener, is particularly significant in the context of garden art. Widely featured in the decorative programmes of parks and orchards, this myth closely linked discreet eroticism, metamorphosis, and the celebration of cultivated nature. It thus constituted an emblematic model of the "amiable" mythology that Borch seems to be targeting when he denounces the libertine use of classical figures in places of retreat and leisure. By implicitly incorporating these artistic practices into his critique, Borch is not only attacking mythological narratives as such, but also their aesthetic instrumentalization in the arts of his time. Mythology, having become a coded visual language allowing the circumvention of the demands of decency, is thus accused of fostering a culture of the gaze dominated by pleasure, to the detriment of moral education. This position is part of a Neo-Stoic and rationalist critical tradition of the 18th century, which, from the theory of fine arts to reflection on gardens, opposes the art of seduction with an art of instruction, based on virtue, exemplarity and social utility.

The theme of "the figure of the solitary walker" (Fabre 2017, 1) in the Age of Enlightenment is rich and revealing of the tensions between reason, nature, sensitivity and society that mark the 18th century. In this context, we can look at two literary works created by two "walkers" – Jean-Jacques Rousseau and Michael Johann von der Borch.

The last, unfinished prose work of the eminent French Enlightenment philosopher and writer Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712–1778), "Reveries of a Solitary Walker", was published posthumously in 1782. Written between 1776 and 1778, the work comprises ten chapters, each titled "Walks". The final chapter is the shortest, only a few pages, as the author did not have

time to complete it. Toward the end of his life, Rousseau avoided society and retreated to the Château d'Ermenonville, owned by a friend. He spent his days walking and meditating, which he shared with the reader. "Reveries of a Solitary Walker" is a complex and deeply personal text that offers reflections on human nature and the pursuit of happiness. It is considered one of Rousseau's masterpieces and has influenced many subsequent writers and thinkers. What makes this work particularly interesting is the fact that the author never had the opportunity to revise or edit it. This lends "Reveries of a Solitary Walker" an authenticity and spontaneity, and opens a window allowing the reader to delve into the author's world of thought. Each of Rousseau's walks conveys reflections on his life, the meaning of life, society, and humanity. He feels lonely, marginalized, exiled, and the peace and closeness to nature of Ermenonville Park are healing and inspiring for him. Thoughts arise while walking. Although the author considers this work to be a continuation of "Confessions", it is not intended for others, he writes it for himself, because he is a writer, until his last breath. Jean-Jacques Rousseau died at the palace of his friend, the Marquis René Louis de Girardin, and was buried in the park





Fig. 2 and Fig. 3. The tomb of Jean-Jacques Rousseau in the park of the Château de Ermenonville., Photos: Valda Jēkabsone-Valtere, 2025

of Ermenonville on the island. (Fig. 2 and Fig. 3). He was later reburied in the Pantheon in Paris.

"The Sentimental Garden of Warkland Castle" of Michael Johann von der Borch is an atypical 18th century text, straddling several genres: moral allegory, philosophical meditation, didactic poem, and coming-of-age story. Written in verse and prose, it belongs to the tradition of symbolic gardens with an edifying purpose, common in Enlightenment culture, but also draws on the nascent pre-Romantic aesthetic. The text presents a young man confronted with the temptations of the world and invited to use his reason to guide his life choices. Through the allegory of a garden, the text reveals how the author stages a moral meditation on the trials of human existence and the values to be cultivated. At first, the reader thinks that this will be a story about a young man's walk in the park or a journey, but it turns out to be a message about life in its entirety, with choices, doubts, lessons and advice, from early youth, then the years of maturity, to love, responsibility, friend-



Fig. 4. Varakļāni Palace and Park of Count M.J. von der Borch.
Photo: Valda Jēkabsone-Valtere, 2023

ship, death, eternity, also virtue and fame. Borch notes at the very beginning of the poem that it is an Allegory.

But researchers of Borch's life and work are still looking for a connection between the stopping points of in the journey described in this poem and the former real Varakļāni Castle Park (Fig. 4), but the changes that have occurred over the years no longer allow us to perceive almost anything of what could have once been there. Since no real documentary evidence of the plan for the creation of the castle park has been found so far, we can only speculate as to whether the sentimental garden of Varakļāni Castle described in the poem is a creation of the author's fantasy or whether the work is based

on the realities that existed in the park, intertwined with philosophical reflections on the meaning and mission of human life. The ending of the poem sounds like a wish and a kind of testament to future generations, and at the same time also as a hope that Count Borch's life and achievements were had not been in vain, that his works will be read and that they will serve good and noble purposes: "If my sentimental garden can evoke only one of its useful ideas and inclinations, in at least one of those who will visit it, I will bless the moment when I laid it out and I will take this satisfaction, such sweet satisfaction, as a faithful subject, even unto the depths of my tomb. Comte de Borch" ("*Si mon jardin sentimental peut faire naître une seule de ses idées & penchants utiles, au moins dans un de ceux qui le verront, je bénirai le moment où j'ai conçu ce plan; & j'emporterai cette satisfaction si douce pour un sujet fidèle, même dans le sein de mon tombeau Comte de Borch"*) (Borch; Deksnis 2020, 37), (Fig. 5).



Fig. 5. The grave of M.J. von der Borch and his wife Eleonora von der Borch in the family tomb in the Varakļāni S. Victor Chapel – the mausoleum of the Counts Borch family (1814). Photo: Valda Jēkabsone-Valtere, 2023

"The Sentimental Garden at Warkland Castle" (1795), designed by Count Michael Johann Borch, is presented as an allegorical landscape and literary composition, where each element of the garden embodies a

moral or political idea. Jean-Jacques Rousseau's "Reveries of the Solitary Walker" (1776–1778), on the other hand, is an introspective and autobiographical text, written in exile and isolation, where solitary walks in nature become an exercise in consolation, inner truth, and newfound freedom. The two literary works are like two walks in the garden of Enlightenment, so similar and yet so different at the same time. If one (Borch) speaks from the place position of the political subject more or less integrated into the order of the state, and the other (Rousseau) from that of the excluded, wounded, broken subject, both authors use the garden as a sensitive scene of moral meditation, belonging to a pastoral, allegorical and didactic aesthetic, typical of the end of the Enlightenment. But both writers wish for their gardens (real or imagined) to survive as a moral legacy, as a place where a noble sentiment was embodied. We can speak here of two gardens, two philosophies of virtue and time. Both texts feature a walker: a young man guided through the garden in Borch's work, a solitary philosopher in Rousseau's. In both cases, the journey through nature becomes a metaphor for life and the search for truth. "The Reveries of the Solitary Walker" and "The Sentimental Garden" share the same 18th century matrix: that of the moral valorisation of nature, of virtue as the horizon of existence, and of the garden as a space that is both aesthetic and ethical.

What inspiration could M.J. Borch have found for the creation of his castle park and for the writing of his "Sentimental Garden of Warkland Castle" by consulting German Enlightenment gardening theorist's Christian Cay Lorenz Hirschfeld's (1742–1792) "Theory of Garden Art" (Theorie der Gartenkunst, 5 Teile (1779–1785, 1990)? Although it is not known whether this book was actually in M.J. Borch's extensive library, considering its popularity, the count's great interest in botany, nature, garden and park landscaping, philosophy and literature, and also the fact that there is a certain similarity in the depictions of nature found in the works of both Borch and K. Hirschfeld (Spārītis 2020, 243), we can assume that M.J. Borch was not unfamiliar with this five-volume theoretical treatise.

In his "Theory of Garden Art" Hirschfeld advocates a romantic and sensitive landscape garden, one that fosters an affective, emotional, and moral experience of nature rather than a strictly formal or geometric design. He emphasizes the garden's capacity to evoke a sensory impression on the senses and the imagination, to arouse pleasant sensations and an elevation of the soul. This idea aligns with the sentimental literary approach of the 18th century, where the contemplation of nature is linked to interiority, emotion and moral reflection, exactly what Borch

expresses in his "Sentimental Garden", where the landscape becomes a place of philosophical and poetic introspection.

Hirschfeld implicitly criticizes the old model of the Baroque garden (dominant until the mid-18th century), centered on geometry and the mastery of nature, in favour of a "freer and more natural nature" that resembles a picturesque landscape.

For Borch, this innovative approach corresponds to the way he describes his garden: not as a mere assemblage of aristocratic ornaments, but as a living, dynamic space, conducive to sensory experience. His literary writing does not simply enumerate topographical elements, but stages the affective experience of the contemplative walker, an idea that aligns well with Hirschfeld's aesthetic.

Echoing Rousseau, Hirschfeld draws on a philosophical dimension of the garden: it is not only a decorative setting, but also a place of moral elevation, where man approaches an inner truth through contemplative observation.

In "The Sentimental Garden of Warkland Castle", we observe an approach that goes beyond simple landscape description: Borch anthropomorphizes nature, attaches symbolic values to it, and uses the garden space as an allegory for human emotions. This approach reflects the same spirit as Hirschfeld's: nature as a mirror of inner life.

Hirschfeld played a major role in disseminating the ideas of the English landscape garden (although he never traveled to England himself). He synthesized the writings of Joseph Addison (1672–1719), Thomas Whately (1726–1772), and William Chambers (1723–1796) to propose a garden inspired by nature, movement, and the picturesque effect. Although Borch was a learned aristocrat rather than a professional gardener, he was well -versed in European debates on gardens and aesthetics. His choice to title his poem "Sentimental Garden" demonstrates a desire to situate his park within a modern aesthetic movement disseminated by theorists like Hirschfeld, which who valued space as a living, interior stage. Finally, Hirschfeld, while dealing with landscape design, insists on the importance of the emotional effects produced by nature – light, shapes, contrasts, sounds and general impressions, which goes beyond simple technique to touch on an almost poetic aesthetic. There are also poetic interludes in the text of his books. This aesthetic sensitivity is also found in Borch: his "Sentimental Garden" is not a manual of park architecture, but a literary composition where the garden becomes a metaphor, feeling and image, a way of thinking about the garden through emotions, exactly as Hirschfeld invites us to do from the designer's point of view. Borch most likely drew, consciously or unconsciously,

on Hirschfeld's aesthetic and philosophical ideas to design his garden at Warkland Castle and to make it the subject of a literary work in which the landscape becomes a sensitive, emotional , and moral metaphor. "The Theory of Garden Art" provides a coherent intellectual framework for understanding the aesthetics of the "Sentimental Garden", particularly the connection between natural experience and human sensibility.

Within the broader European context of late Enlightenment garden culture, Stowe Landscape Garden in Buckinghamshire - extensively discussed by Christian Cay Lorenz Hirschfeld in his "*Theorie der Gartenkunst*" - offers a revealing comparative model for interpreting Michael Johann von der Borch's "*Jardin sentimental du château de Warkland"* and the historical park of Varakļāni. Hirschfeld presents Stowe not merely as an aesthetic achievement, but as a politically charged landscape in which architectural features, monuments, and spatial sequences articulate the ideological programme of the Whig aristocracy, promoting liberty, virtue, and resistance to absolutist power. The garden thus functions as a coded political text, where nature becomes a medium for expressing constitutional and moral values.

Read in this light, Borch's Sentimental Garden may be understood as participating in a comparable, though more discreet, mode of political expression. While no direct formal imitation of Stowe can be established in the material layout of Varakļāni, the poem itself constructs an allegorical landscape that similarly integrates ethical reflection with implicit political meaning. Through its progression from moral instruction to reflections on virtue, responsibility, and legacy, Borch's text suggests an engagement with the tensions of his time, particularly the reconfiguration of political authority in the wake of the partitions of Poland.

Unlike Stowe, where political ideas are materially inscribed in architectural and spatial forms, Borch's garden operates primarily on the literary and symbolic level. The *Jardin sentimental* encodes its political dimension within an allegorical narrative, allowing for a form of intellectual positioning that remains veiled yet perceptible. In this sense, the relationship between Stowe and Varakļāni is not one of visual or structural correspondence, but of shared ideological function: both articulate, through the medium of the garden, a reflection on power, virtue, and the moral responsibilities of the enlightened individual.

To date, the only evidence of Count Borch's meeting with Voltaire (François-Marie Arouet, 1694–1778, known as Voltaire), the most prominent French philosopher of the Enlightenment, is a letter he wrote to his father on January 27, 1775. This letter, along with other documents from the Borch family archive, is located in the V. Stefanik Lviv Scientific Library of the Ukrainian Academy of Sciences, which was taken to

Ukraine during World War II. This meeting was described in the article by historian and RTU professor Kaspars Kļaviņš (Kļaviņš 2013, 80–97), who traveledtravelled to Ukraine in 2011 to conduct research at the aforementioned library. Currently, due to the long war in Ukraine, such research trips are no longer possible. But, fortunately, thanks to modern technologies, a large part of the documents from the Borch family archive have been digitized and are now available online. It is not possible to claim that all of the Borch family documents and letters have been digitized, but the amount of the digitized items is large enough to provide researchers with a wide field of work and valuable discoveries.

The young Borch wrote to his father very often and documented his travels and daily life in great detail. This meeting is also described in great detail. Borch had arrived in Lyon, and it occurred to him to visit Voltaire, in the castle where he lived at the end of his life, in Ferney (Ferney-Voltaire today), (Fig. 6). The great philosopher was already over 80 at the time, while Borch was just over 20. According to Borch, Voltaire was not immediately ready to receive him because he was feeling unwell. But Voltaire's relative invited Borch anyway, and, after a short time, the meeting took place. They then spent some time talking about history, politics, and, of course, literature, and enjoyed a dinner together to which Voltaire invited him. Borch composed and presented Voltaire with a laudatory letter in verse, which Voltaire was very pleased about. There are no other letters or records of any further correspondence or meeting between Borch and Voltaire. This was probably their only meeting, as Voltaire died on 30 May 1778. This was a very inspiring meeting for Borch, which was reflected both in his literary works and later in the design of his palace and its park. Voltaire's palace, the carefully tended



Fig. 6. Voltaire's Palace, located in Ferney-Voltaire.
Photos: Valda Jēkabsone-Valtere, 2023



Fig. 7. The parish church on the castle grounds, with a pyramid in a recess in the wall. Photo: Valda Jēkabsone-Valtere, 2023

garden with a picturesque view of the mountains, the parish church rebuilt by the entertainer with a pyramid on the wall, these magnificent impressions certainly helped the young traveller many years later to create a plan for his own palace and garden and to realize it with the help of architect and friend Vincenzo Mazotti. Voltaire had created the pyramid near the church with the intention of resting there after death (Fig. 7), but this was not destined to come true, because Voltaire, like Rousseau, was buried in the Pantheon in Paris, far from the peaceful harbour of Ferney, where he felt protected from the hustle and bustle of the capital and spent the productive years of his life.

CONCLUSIONS

This study has sought to identify and articulate four major intellectual and aesthetic sources underlying Michael Johann von der Borch's "The Sentimental Garden of Varakļāni Castle", situating the work within the broader cultural framework of the late Enlightenment. Through a close reading of the poem and its philosophical, literary, and artistic contexts, it becomes clear that Borch's garden is not merely a personal or local creation, but a sophisticated synthesis of European ideas on morality, nature, and sensitivity. Classical mythology, invoked primarily as a negative moral counter-model, provides a critical point of departure that allows Borch to reject the libertine aesthetic prevalent in contemporary visual culture. The figure of the solitary walker, closely aligned with Rousseau's "Reveries", introduces an introspective and experiential dimension in which movement through nature becomes a metaphor for ethical self-formation. Hirschfeld's "Theory of Garden Art" offers a

coherent aesthetic framework that illuminates Borch's conception of the garden as an affective and moral landscape, while the documented encounter with Voltaire reveals a formative personal influence, linking intellectual exchange, political thought, and cultivated space. Taken together, these four sources demonstrate that "The Sentimental Garden" functions as a transnational Enlightenment text, where literature, philosophy, and landscape converge to articulate a moral legacy intended to endure beyond the author's lifetime.

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A PROPOSED MODEL FOR EVALUATING DESIGN AND INNOVATION CAPABILITIES IN PUBLIC INSTITUTIONS

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ABSTRACT

This study presents the development process and introduction of a tool for evaluating design capabilities created as part of a doctoral research project. Numerous models exist for measuring design capabilities within institutions, particularly in the private sector. However, compared to their private-sector counterparts, the public sector's models tend to be less comprehensive. This paper analyzes current methodologies from the private sector and evaluates the operational practices of innovation within public institutions to formulate a comprehensive model for assessing design capabilities in the public sector.

The primary data source of this study is a comprehensive literature review, through which detailed insights into design capability assessment tools, as well as design and innovation in the public sector, were obtained. Using existing models as references, the concept of design capability was redefined in detail, leading to the development of an assessment model for design capability in the public sector. The study can be characterized as qualitative research. Finally, the proposed model is applied and discussed through a case study conducted in collaboration with a municipality and several universities located in the same city, focusing on the transformation of the municipality's design capability over time.

Keywords: design capabilities, public services, design for public sector innovation

INTRODUCTION

The global expansion of design activities within public organizations has prompted collaborations among design agencies, educational

institutions, and public entities such as municipalities and healthcare facilities. This has led to critical questions about the impact of these design initiatives on organizational transformation and service delivery, as well as their role in fostering innovation. While the private sector has seen extensive research in measuring design capabilities in corporations, studies focusing on public organizations remain limited.

This paper introduces a model developed during a doctoral research that examines the collaborations between public institutions and design schools, specifically regarding their influence on design and innovation capabilities. The doctorates' theoretical insights and empirical data draw from frameworks in design management, public sector innovation, and service design.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

The methodological framework of this study is based on a comprehensive and organized literature review of how to measure design capability in public institutes. It relies on the analysis of existing models, frameworks, and theoretical narratives related to design capability and its applications in both the private and public sectors. Key search terms used in the process include "public services and design", "design capability", "design capacity in the public sector", and "design and innovation in the public sector". These keywords were used in various academic databases and institutional archives to ensure a concise and reliable collection of sources. The literature review was conducted in different-systematic stages. In the first stage, established models and assessment tools such as the Danish Design Ladder, European Design Management (DME), and Kotler's Design Sensitivity Audit were analyzed from a design management perspective. This analysis revealed that the existing frameworks are predominantly adapted to private sector dynamics and financing, focusing on commercial competitiveness and profit margins. Consequently, these traditional commercial audits are insufficient to address the complex dynamics of the public sector, which require social value, citizen satisfaction etc. To address this theoretical gap, the concepts of design and innovation in the public sector were examined, focusing on how design practices can be integrated into public services and management structures.

The literature review was systematically synthesized with the findings from interdisciplinary approaches to form the basis for a new public sector design capability assessment model. The framework used was

systematically created during the adaptation of design and innovation in the public sector. It was re-constructed within the context of public service. Areas where incompatibility with public sector design and innovation dynamics was noted were re-examined. This process was supported by a comprehensive review of the existing literature on public sector design and innovation. The proposed model is explained in detail in a case study in the discussion section. To better understand the İzmirDeniz project as a case study, the researcher first conducted a comprehensive review of the relevant official reports. Then, semi-structured interviews were conducted with two representatives from the design department of İzmir Metropolitan Municipality. These interviews focused on the reports of the İzmirDeniz project while also investigated the changes that occurred in the municipality's design capacity. To assess these capacities in the public sector and track their temporal evolution, the proposed model was developed to visualize the development of the municipality's designs.

BACKGROUND STUDY

Design and Public Sector

Designers have viewed service design as a professional discipline since the 1990s (Mager, 2004). Shostack, a researcher in service marketing, initially highlighted the necessity for service design (Shostack, 1982). The service and experience age has prompted designers to integrate services with digitization and contemporary technologies, with service design principles being prevalent in both the private and public sectors for four decades. Manufacturing firms have started to contemplate "servitization" for their goods (Baines et.al., 2017), while service enterprises have begun to characterize themselves as product-service systems to prioritize user experience (Baines et.al., 2009). In conjunction with product-service systems, service-dominant logic is an additional framework for services that enhances both service marketing strategies and service design (Vargo & Lusch, 2007). In service-dominant logic, services are regarded not as supplementary to the product but as a value in their own right. Consequently, their value must be generated collaboratively with all service stakeholders (Chandler & Lusch, 2015). The process simultaneously evolved for public institutions, which are entities centred around delivering services.

Participatory approaches, such as the design thinking process, emerge as solutions to the demands of the public sector, exemplified by

trends like New Public Management and Governance. Governance strategies seek to include involvement in all governmental practices through a citizen-centric framework (Cook, 2013). Therefore, numerous design projects for public service innovation exist worldwide, and the Design Council categorizes these projects into three types: design for discrete problems, development of design skills in public institutions, and design for policy in a hierarchical framework (Design Council, 2013).

Participatory Budgeting, Participatory Decision Making, and Participatory Design methods (Murray et al., 2010) have gained prominence in the agendas of numerous governments and municipalities. These public sector trends augment the demand for design, particularly participatory design methodologies. Consequently, public institutions and their innovation initiatives have started to recognize co-design workshops and participatory design activities. For instance, the Cumulact project emphasizes citizen engagement (Meroni et al., 2017), while the Public Collaboration Lab facilitates "experimentation and experiential learning that unites local government officials, design researchers, and design students with frontline council staff and service users to investigate innovative methodologies for developing and delivering policies and services that could enhance citizen outcomes while minimizing public expenditure" (Thorpe et al., 2016, p. 500). Participation levels in the participatory design process range from citizen-centeredness to creative citizens, as illustrated by Arnstein's participation ladder, which includes citizen control, delegated power, partnership, placation, consultation, informing, therapy, and manipulation (Arnstein, 1969).

Numerous countries now commonly employ service design methodologies and other human-centred design approaches in the public sector. Public sector design projects typically focus on communication, the development of new products and services, innovation processes, and the formulation of policies and strategies. Public entities employ designers through internal, external, or a combination of both methods (Design Council, 2013).

The development and improvement of service design and service-product systems design practices, coupled with the necessity for new techniques prompted by advancements like digitalization in both private and public sectors, alongside the rise of participatory approaches in public institutions, have resulted in a proliferation of design activities within the public sector and a heightened frequency of discourse surrounding them. Part of these talks is about evaluating, assessing, and improving ideas to make these institutions better at design.

Design Capabilities

Understanding the dissemination and integration of design within institutions is crucial for promoting design approaches in the public sector. Consequently, it is essential to examine the design management literature concerning the dynamics of design capabilities within institutions. Numerous authors have examined embedding design in the public sector via the lens of Acklin's absorptive capacity model (Wetter-Edman & Malmberg, 2016; Acklin, 2013).

Alongside absorptive capability, design activities inside public institutions are examined using the Design Ladder, developed by the Design Council for evaluating design in public sector initiatives, which is adapted from the Danish Design Ladder (Kootstra, 2009; Storvang et.al., 2015).

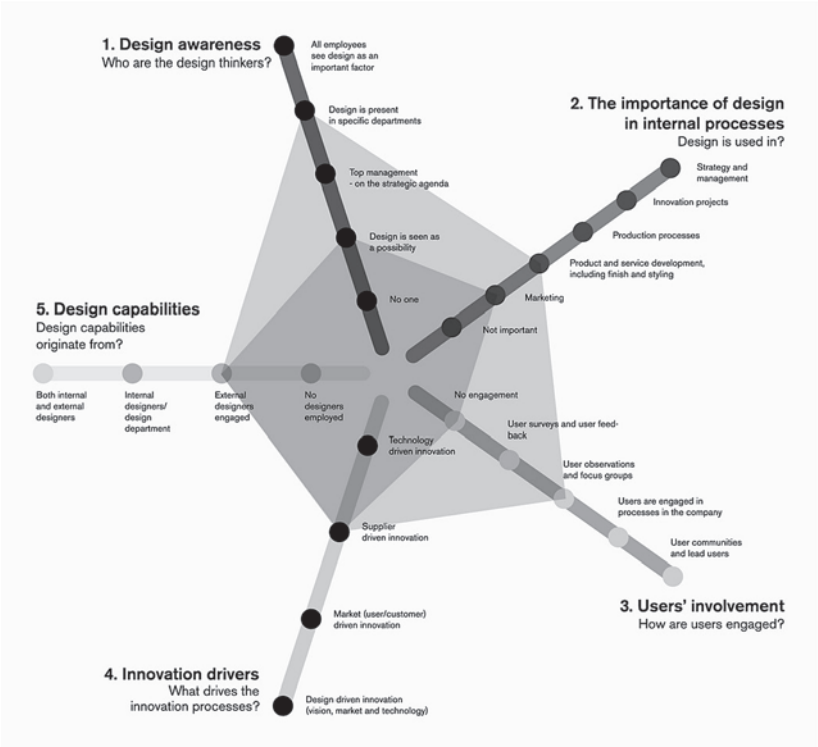


Fig. 1. Framework for design capacity a retail company. The dark area is the current situation, and the lighter area is where the company wants to be in the future. (Storvang, et.al., 2015, p. 19)

Another design management tool for comprehending the design capabilities of an organization is the spider web known as the Danish Innovation Framework, which has been adapted for use in the public sector for this research (Storvang et.al., 2015). (Figure 1) This framework enables the simultaneous visualization of both the design and innovation capabilities of an institution within a single graphical representation.

Its structural configuration allows for the comparative analysis of design and innovation capabilities across different organizations or the longitudinal monitoring of a single institution's evolutionary trajectory in design capabilities over multiple years (Figure 1). Consequently, this model has been employed to identify design and innovation capabilities in the public sector and to conduct the case study analysis presented in this research. It is suitable for assessing the effects of design partnerships in public institutions and comparing several organizations within a single frame.

RESULTS

The framework was developed through a systematic adaptation process to bridge the gap between generic design maturity models and the specific requirements of the public sector. Initially, all dimensions of the existing model were catalogued and critically analysed to determine their applicability to public administration. Following this audit, elements found to be incongruent with the bureaucratic and civic dynamics of public institutions were restructured. This refinement was grounded in established public sector design and innovation literature, ensuring that the indicators reflect the unique constraints and value-creation processes of governmental organizations (Bason, 2017; Junginger, 2017).

Design awareness

As "design awareness", Storvang et al. (2015) use such categories as no one, design is seen as a possibility, top management is on the strategic agenda, design is present in specific departments, and all employees see design as an important factor. This scale is also suitable for public institutions, and therefore it has not been modified for this research.

Table 1. Design awareness

Design Capacity Framework from the Danish perspective	Design for Public Innovation Framework
Design Awareness	Design Awareness
No one	No one
Design is seen as a possibility	Design is seen as a possibility
Top management on the strategic agenda	Top management on the strategic agenda
Design is present in specific departments	Design is present in specific department
All employees see design is an important factor	All employees see design is an important factor

The importance of design in the internal process

While some organizations use design only for marketing, some design-led companies use design to develop strategies (Storvang et al., 2015). For this research, this leg of the chart serves to understand the design goals of the selected projects. This aspect also differs from the corresponding element of the previous framework. Public institutions primarily provide services and product-service systems, with less emphasis on the production process. The OECD report Good Practice Principles for Public Service Design and Delivery in the Digital Age (OECD, 2022) defines innovation in the public sector in a similar way, focusing on improvements in service and communication rather than product or marketing innovation. This report stresses the need for user-centred and process-oriented change. Therefore, public institutions do not require marketing activities, but they try to locate the best way to communicate and create policies and strategies (Design Council, 2013). In conclusion, this scale transforms into a new categorization that encompasses communication design, product and service design, innovation process, and policy design.

Table 2. The importance of design in the internal process

Design Capacity Framework from the Danish perspective	Design for Public Innovation Framework
The importance of design in the internal process	The importance of design in the internal process
Not important	Not important
Marketing	Communication Design
Product and service development, including finishing and styling	Designing product and services
Production processes	Innovation projects
Innovation projects	Strategy and Policy
Strategy and management	

CITIZEN INVOLVEMENT

One of the most crucial characteristics of design-led organizations is their user-centeredness. Likewise, participatory design approaches in the public sector are crucial because of the new public management (NPM) paradigm and governance approach in public administration. Therefore, it is essential to examine the selected design projects in terms of citizen involvement. In this leg of the spiderweb, there are surveys and feedback, observations (field trips, focus groups, etc.), and co-design sessions that are similar to the original innovation framework. However, the last part of the scale is changed from "user communities and lead users" to "creative communities," which means "individuals and communities use existing resources in a creative, original way to bring about system innovation" (Manzini and Meroni, 2007).

Table 3. Citizen involvement

Design Capacity Framework from the Danish perspective	Design for Public Innovation Framework
User Involvement	Citizen Involvement
No engagement	No engagement
Surveys and user feed-back	Surveys and user feed-back
User observation and focus group	Observations (field trips, focus groups)
Users are engaged in processes in the company	Co-design sessions
User communities and lead users	Creative citizens

Innovation motivation

Design-led companies leverage design as a tool for innovation, while the motivations for innovation differ significantly between the public and private sectors. Private sector companies primarily focus on technological advancements, whereas public institutions are often driven by extraordinary conditions (such as pandemics or natural disasters) and political changes (like elections and reforms). For instance, public authorities responded swiftly during the Covid-19 pandemic that resulted in innovations such as illness tracking apps. Additionally, political changes often prompt governments to innovate as they fulfil promises made during elections. Citizen-centred motivations also emerge, particularly following technological advancements. Overall, the key innovation motivations identified include extraordinary conditions, political changes, technology-driven factors, citizen-centred needs, and design-driven approaches.

Table 4. Innovation motivation

Design Capacity Framework from the Danish perspective	Design for Public Innovation Framework
Innovation Motivation	Innovation Motivation
Technology driven	Extraordinary Conditions
Supplier driven	Political Changes
Market (customer/user) driven	Technology driven
Design driven	Citizen-centered
	Design driven

Design capabilities

It is used to understand the design employment dynamics of the public institutions, after the selected design projects in this research. The scale is similar to the original framework. Because of Kang and Prendiville (2018) report that design employment in the public sector has also four ways; no designer, external designer, internal designer, and internal, and external designers.

Table 5. Design Capabilities

Design Capacity Framework from the Danish perspective	Design for Public Innovation Framework
Design Capabilities	Design Capabilities
No designer employed	No designer employed
External designers engaged	External designers engaged
Internal designer/ design departments	Internal designer/ design departments
Both Internal and external designer	Both Internal and external designer

Given below is the final model. A key architectural strength of this framework is its ability to facilitate dual-axis monitoring, encompassing both design and innovation capabilities within a unified visual representation. The structural design allows for two types of high-level analysis: cross-institutional benchmarking and longitudinal tracking, which visualizes the evolutionary trajectory of a specific institution's design maturity over time. Consequently, this model serves not merely as a descriptive tool but as a diagnostic instrument for identifying and analysing shifts in public sector design competencies, as demonstrated in the case study of the İzmirDeniz project.

DISCUSSION

This section aims to discuss the previously introduced model through a case study. The focus is on showing how the proposed framework can be used to evaluate design skills in a public institution by looking at the İzmirDeniz Project. The İzmirdeniz Project is an example of how the İzmir Metropolitan Municipality uses design thinking in the city government as part of the "İzmir Model", suggested by İlhan Tekeli. Launched after the 2009 İzmir Cultural Workshop, the project aims to position İzmir as a City of Design and Innovation, becoming a key player in the Mediterranean Cities Network, and prioritizing participatory governance. The initiative seeks to cultivate a design-conscious urban culture among residents, supported by local businesses, engaging urban planners, designers, and academics through five coordinated design teams focused on İzmir's coastline (Tekeli, 2018).

The IzmirDeniz Project demonstrates a public organization evolving from design awareness to design integration. Design was initially acknowledged as an essential tool and subsequently integrated into municipal frameworks with the creation of the Urban Design and Aesthetics Department, which employed in-house industrial designers. This

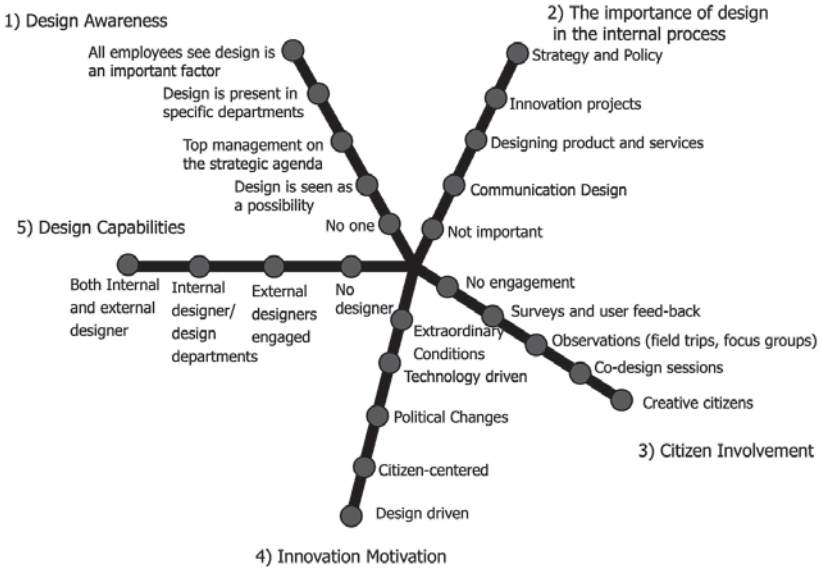


Fig. 3. Design for Public Innovation Framework

initiative is a crucial advancement in establishing design knowledge throughout several departments.

Regarding internal processes from a design perspective, the project transcended visual communication and marketing to include service, urban and policy design in accordance with the public sector's focus on participatory governance and strategic development. The iterative design techniques utilized in the IzmirDeniz Project demonstrate an organization transitioning to leverage design for strategic and policy innovation instead of solely single products.

The IzmirDeniz Project exemplifies an advanced participatory approach to civic engagement. The municipality conducted design forums, work in focus groups, and co-design events with residents and local stakeholders–activities aligned with the higher tiers of the framework ("co-design sessions" and "creative citizens"). These participatory activities exemplify a transition toward governance through design and collaborative sense-making in urban change. In terms of innovative motivation, IzmirDeniz was primarily citizen-focused and design-oriented, addressing local demands for enhanced quality of life and environmental sustainability rather than resorting to market or technology constraints. Political endorsement and institutional leadership, under the

guidance of İlhan Tekeli, established the strategic basis for design-oriented innovation in public administration.

The Izmir Metropolitan Municipality exhibits a hybrid paradigm in its design capabilities, utilizing both internal designers and external design specialists. This hybrid paradigm improves organizational learning, continuity, and cross-disciplinary collaboration. It has progressively enhanced the city's comprehensive design environment through projects such as Good Design İzmir and partnerships with local universities.

This study demonstrates that the İzmir Metropolitan Municipality has attained a level of design competence, marked by integrated design practices, a collaborative culture, and an increasing strategic application of design in urban policy formulation. The IzmirDeniz Project offers empirical evidence of the evolution of design ability inside public institutions via long-term, participatory, and multi-stakeholder design efforts.

CONCLUSION

In many countries, public institutions still have limited design capabilities and evaluating them solely using models developed for the private sector is insufficient. Public institutions operate under distinct motivations, governance structures, and innovation dynamics that require tailored assessment frameworks. The model for measuring design capability developed through this research offers a new perspective for understanding how design is embedded, managed, and evolved within the public sector.

The proposed framework modifies and enhances models initially created for the private sector, facilitating the identification of public institutions' innovation motivations, their ability to recruit and manage design talent, and their strategies for incorporating design into service development and policy-making processes. Through this model, it becomes possible to monitor the utilization of design services, assess the institutional capacity for design over time, and develop strategies to strengthen design-oriented practices within public organizations.

Furthermore, the model allows for the comparison of design capabilities across different public institutions and provides a structured way to trace how design maturity evolves within a single organization over time. Such longitudinal insights can support evidence-based decision-making in developing design and innovation strategies at various governmental levels.

Ultimately, the framework serves as both an analytical and strategic tool that helps policymakers, public managers, and design educators to assess readiness for design integration, foster sustainable collaborations between design schools and public institutions, and guide the formation of design-led innovation ecosystems within the public sector.

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DESIGNING FOR EQUITY: BLOCKCHAIN, AGRICULTURE, AND THE INDIAN FARMER'S VOICE

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ABSTRACT

Discussions on sustainability and equity in agriculture often overlook the everyday struggles of small and marginal Indian farmers. Despite rising interest in certifications and global standards, Indian agriculture continues to face systemic issues such as volatile pricing, information gaps, and a persistent trust deficit between producers and consumers. Much of this stems from limited access to credible production data and low awareness of how transparency can support economic stability.

This research, conducted with Sahyadri Farms, one of India's largest farmer-owned cooperatives, explores how blockchain-enabled QR codes can strengthen traceability across the fruit and vegetable value chain. By scanning these codes, consumers can view verified details such as farm origin, harvest dates, grading, and cold-chain handling, fostering trust and making farmers more visible in the process.

Using a human-centred design approach, the study integrates field observations, questionnaires, participatory workshops, and iterative prototyping. Alongside simplifying data entry in the pack-house, a dedicated farmer dashboard was created to show transparent pricing breakdowns, highlighting the value retained by farmers versus processing, logistics, and retail. This demonstrates how clear information design can shift data from a bureaucratic task to a shared asset that strengthens cooperative participation.

While blockchain alone cannot solve deep-rooted inequities, this research shows its potential to support more transparent, inclusive, and trust-based agricultural systems in India.

Keywords: sustainability, participatory design, fair equity, blockchain, agriculture.

INTRODUCTION

Agriculture in India is more than an economic sector; it is a social fabric that sustains livelihoods, cultures, and communities. Smallholder farmers, who constitute the majority of India's cultivators, face a complex web of structural challenges: fragmented landholdings, precarious market linkages, limited access to reliable information, and persistent vulnerability to climatic and economic shocks. These hardships are worsened by long-standing information gaps in the food and fibre value chains. Consumers lack reliable knowledge about how and where products are produced, and farmers remain largely unaware of consumer demand trends or how prices are determined. The resulting trust deficit undermines equitable value distribution and hampers sustainable agricultural transitions.

Contemporary debates on sustainability, certification, and ethical sourcing often focus on standards, labels, or market mechanisms, but they frequently overlook the lived experiences of Indian smallholder farmers (Dev, 2012). A striking symptom of this neglect is the ongoing crisis of farmer distress in India, reflected in high rates of indebtedness and farmer suicides, which calls for solutions that centre on farmer agency, dignity, and economic resilience. Addressing these problems requires interventions that do not merely impose technological fixes, but that thoughtfully integrate design, local practices, and institutional realities (Dev, 2012).

Blockchain technology, despite occasional hype, offers a pragmatic way to address specific dimensions of the trust problem by creating tamper-evident, verifiable records across supply chains (Demestichas *et al.*, 2020). When combined with accessible interfaces (for example, QR codes on product packaging), blockchain can bridge the gap between producers and consumers by making provenance and production metadata available at the point of purchase. Importantly, such interventions must be framed as socio-technical systems: technology alone will not lead to equity unless it is coupled with inclusive design processes, local capacity-building, and participatory governance (Demestichas *et al.*, 2020).

This paper explores how design practices can enable the effective use of blockchain to support more equitable agricultural systems, using Sahyadri Farms in Nashik, India, as a central case. The project centred on a ''farm-to-fork'' intervention that integrated blockchain-backed QR codes onto food items, enabling instant consumer access to production and provenance information. Over 5.2 million QR codes were produced as part of the initiative, demonstrating the scalability of a low-friction interface for consumers across literacy and digital-skill levels. Beyond

the numbers, our interest lies in how design in communication, user experience, and participatory research can transform complex, technical data into meaningful narratives that empower both consumers and producers (Misra *et al.*, 2023).

Our research approach combined fieldwork, stakeholder consultations, and iterative design exploration. We conducted extensive customer surveys to understand consumer motivations and information needs and; engaged in repeated field visits to document farmer practices and constraints; and as well as facilitated workshops with farmers and supply-chain actors to co-design the ways information is captured and represented. These activities were complemented by expert consultations in agronomy, rural economics, and supply-chain management to ensure that the intervention remained grounded in domain realities.

This paper contributes to design research by positioning blockchain-enabled traceability not merely as a technical infrastructure, but as a socio-technical system shaped through human-centred and participatory design. It demonstrates how design can mediate complex data flows into accessible, meaningful interfaces for farmers, pack-house workers, and consumers. In doing so, the study extends the role of design from interface creation to enabling transparency, trust, and participation within agricultural value chains.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

This study adopts a mixed qualitative design approach grounded in human-centred design and participatory research. The objective was to move beyond merely deploying blockchain and instead examine how transparency tools align with the lived realities of smallholder grape and vegetable farmers in Nashik. The methodology integrates ethnographic immersion, semi-structured interviews, structured questionnaires, participatory workshops, value-chain analysis, and iterative prototyping. Together, these methods ensured that the intervention emerged from farmer narratives, cooperative processes, and the socio-economic conditions that shape agricultural decision-making.

Field Immersion and Primary Observations

Field immersion formed the foundation of the research. Multiple extended visits were conducted to vineyards and vegetable farms across the Nashik district. These visits were not limited to formal data collection; they involved walking through fields with farmers, observing

pruning practices, watching the grading of tomato or okra harvests, and accompanying workers during pack-house operations. These experiences enabled researchers to observe the rhythms of the agricultural cycle and gain firsthand awareness of the pressures farmers face, including unpredictable weather, pesticide management, water shortages, and fluctuating market demand.

Table 1

Stakeholder Group	N	Selection Criteria	Recruitment
Grape farmers	52	Active cooperative members, 2+ seasons	Cooperative referral; stratified by landholding size
Vegetable farmers	33	Active members, diverse crop types	Cooperative referral
Pack-house workers	21	Core staff (14) and seasonal (7)	Direct engagement; shift-stratified
Cooperative directors	10	Decision-making roles	Purposive sampling
Consumers (QR code users)	526	Post-purchase engagement	Anonymous digital tracking

Participants were drawn from multiple stakeholder groups across the cooperative ecosystem, including farmers, pack-house workers, managerial staff, and consumers engaging with QR-based traceability systems (see Table 1). Purposive sampling ensured representation across production scales, roles, and operational contexts, while consumer data was collected through anonymous digital engagement.

Informal conversations during these visits helped build trust and provided contextual grounding. Farmers often described the difference between what they earn and what consumers ultimately pay, expressing frustration over the uncertainty created by intermediaries and the lack of consistent pricing information. These early insights shaped the direction of the study by highlighting the urgency of designing transparency systems that acknowledge market asymmetries and information gaps.

Data collection spanned 18 months (January 2021–June 2022), enabling observation of seasonal agricultural variations and multiple design iteration cycles. Field immersion involved 12 extended visits (approximately 180 hours) across vineyards and vegetable farms. Semi-structured interviews (n=116; 91 hours of recordings) were conducted with farmers,

workers, and cooperative staff. Structured questionnaires (n=85) captured data on digital literacy and pricing confidence. Six participatory workshops (n=126 participants) facilitated co-design iterations, while pack-house observations (18 shifts; 144 hours) documented workflow patterns before and after system deployment. Post-deployment evaluation (July–December 2021) tracked consumer engagement through QR code metrics and follow-up surveys (n=98).

The collected data were analysed using a thematic analysis approach. Interview transcripts, field notes, and open-ended questionnaire responses were coded iteratively to identify recurring patterns related to trust, pricing awareness, and digital interaction. These patterns were refined into broader themes that informed both the design process and interpretation of results. Findings were triangulated across interviews, observations, questionnaires, and participatory workshops to ensure consistency, while quantitative questionnaire data were analysed descriptively to support qualitative insights. This shift from viewing data as surveillance to seeing it as a shared asset reflects a cultural transformation in how transparency systems are understood and valued (Hollan, Hutchins aAnd Kirsh, 2000).

Fieldwork included detailed mapping of the grape and vegetable value chain, from harvesting and sorting to pre-cooling, storage, packaging, and distribution. Observations within pack-house environments revealed that although substantial data is generated during post-harvest handling, much of it becomes fragmented when the produce from multiple farmers is aggregated. This identified the pack-house as a critical intervention point, where produce acquires collective identity through grading and batch creation, making it central to traceability and attribution.

Semi-structured interviews provided insights into farmer experiences of seasonal variability, input costs, and market uncertainty, as well as perceptions of pricing fairness and trust in intermediaries. These accounts helped contextualise operational findings and informed the design of transparency interventions.

Parallel to the interviews, structured questionnaires were administered to capture quantifiable data related to digital literacy, market access, and information usage practices. Conducted during farm visits or cooperative meetings, these questionnaires provided a standardised way to compare responses while still allowing verbal assistance for low-literacy respondents. The findings revealed that although mobile phones are widely used for communication, few farmers engage with digital tools for price discovery or record-keeping. Most relied on

memory or informal notes to track input costs, exposing vulnerabilities in negotiating fair returns.

Farmers Questionnaire

1. How do you usually receive information about the price of your crops?
   (Cooperative / phone from traders / WhatsApp groups / neighbours / own guess / other)
2. Do you track your input costs each season (seeds, fertilisers, labour, transport)?
   (Yes / Sometimes / No)
   If yes, *Howhow do you record these costs?* (Notebook/phone/memory / other)
3. Do you use a smartphone?
   (Yes / No)
   If yes: *Which functions do you feel confident using?* (Calling / WhatsApp / Camera / Apps / Online payments)
4. How confident are you in using digital applications for farming or selling produce?
   (Very confident / Somewhat confident / Not confident)
5. From whom do you feel you receive the most reliable information about pricing and sales?
   (Cooperative / Traders / Government / Other farmers / Online sources)
6. Do you trust that you are paid fairly for your produce?
   (Always / Sometimes / Rarely / Never)
   If not: *What makes you feel unsure?*
7. Do you know the final destination of your produce (retail store, export market, city)?
   (Always / Sometimes / Rarely / Never)
8. Would you like to know how much the consumer pays for your produce and how much the cost is involved during processing and packing?
   (Yes / No)
9. If yes: *How would you like to receive that information?* (QR code / SMS / App / Verbal update)
10. Have you ever used QR codes or scanned product information on packages?
    (Yes / Tried but difficult / No)
11. What does “transparency in agriculture” mean to you personally?
    (Open-ended recorded in the farmer’s own words)

Pack-House Staff Questionnaire –
Workflow, Digital Tools & Traceability

1. How long have you been working in this pack-house or cooperative?
   (Less than 1 year / 1–3 years / More than 3 years)
2. Which activities are you primarily responsible for during your shift?
   (Sorting / Grading / Weighing / Packing / Labelling / Data entry / Cold storage handling)
3. Do you currently use any digital tools as part of your work?
   (Yes / No)
   If yes: *Which ones?* (Barcode scanner / Tablets / Mobile apps / Weighing machine display / Other)
4. How comfortable do you feel using digital systems on the work floor?
   (Very comfortable / Somewhat comfortable / Not comfortable)
5. Do you feel that digital data entry slows down or interrupts your workflow?
   (Always / Sometimes / Rarely / Never)
   If yes: *What difficulties do you usually face?*
6. How do you make sure the data you enter (weight, grade, batch ID) is accurate?
   (Supervisor confirmation / Rechecking by self / Team verification / No process)
7. Have you ever heard about blockchain or traceability systems used for consumers?
   (Yes, clearly understand / Heard of it / Not at all)
   Do you think consumers should know where the produce comes from and how it is handled?
   (Strongly agree / Agree / Neutral / Disagree / Strongly disagree)
8. What kind of improvements would help you enter data faster during busy shifts?
   (Larger buttons / Fewer fields / Voice option / Better network / More training / Other)
9. Do you feel your work becomes more valuable when consumers can trace the produce back to you and the farmer?
   (Yes / No / Unsure) *Why do you feel that way?*

Across both qualitative and quantitative inputs, a key theme emerged: digital systems must fit the rhythms and realities of agricultural work. Any intervention requiring extensive manual data entry or unfamiliar terminology risks rejection. This insight anchored the guiding design principle

for blockchain integration: simplify, visualise, and support rather than burden. Visual communication, local language support, automated data capture, and minimised user steps became core design imperatives.

The iterative integration of value-chain mapping, interviews, and surveys ensured that the technological solution, rather than being imported as a generic blockchain tool, was grounded in the socio-economic conditions of farmers, the workflow of pack-house staff, and the operational model of the cooperative. This approach created a human-centred foundation for traceability, ensuring that the system would not only enhance consumer trust but also produce tangible benefits for the very people who generate ing the value: the farmers.

The field visits provided an ideal setting to incorporate questionnaire-based inquiry into natural conversations. Rather than treating the questionnaire as an isolated research tool, it was woven into the rhythm of farm walkthroughs and pack-house observations. We often began by discussing the current crop cycle, how the vines were performing that season, or what challenges the vegetables were facing at that moment. Once rapport was established, these conversations seamlessly transitioned into the questionnaire prompts.

Farmers often elaborated beyond fixed response options, offering detailed anecdotes about previous interactions with traders, experiences with receiving delayed payments, or difficulties interpreting digital messages. These narrative additions enriched the questionnaire data and offered context that numeric responses alone could not capture. The flexible use of questionnaires ensured that quantitative patterns were supported by lived experiences, creating a layered understanding of farmer needs.

Participatory Workshops

Participatory workshops were conducted with farmers, pack-house workers, and cooperative field officers to facilitate collaborative inquiry and co-design. Rather than functioning as training sessions, these workshops were structured as interactive spaces where participants reflected on their experiences within the agricultural value chain.

Workshops began with guided discussions in which participants described their journeys from production to market, helping surface key challenges related to information gaps, pricing uncertainty, and post-harvest handling. These discussions were followed by collaborative mapping exercises, where participants visually reconstructed the movement of produce across stages such as harvesting, grading, storage, and distribution. This process helped identify breakdowns in information

flow, including inconsistencies in documentation, re-grading practices, and batch aggregation.

In the co-design phase, participants were invited to articulate what information should be visible to consumers. Emphasis was placed on aspects such as harvest timelines, handling practices, and the role of co-operative systems. Prototype QR code interfaces were then introduced, allowing participants to evaluate clarity, accessibility, and representation. Their feedback informed subsequent design iterations, particularly in simplifying visual communication and improving language accessibility.

Workshops also incorporated structured prompts to encourage reflection on transparency, digital familiarity, and perceived value of labour within the supply chain. These discussions revealed shared concerns around the invisibility of agricultural work and informed the narrative framing of the transparency interface.

Technology Development and Blockchain Integration

The insights gathered from interviews, questionnaires, and workshops informed the design of a blockchain-based traceability system tailored to the operational realities of Sahyadri Farms. A permissioned blockchain structure was chosen to allow verified agents, such as field supervisors, agronomists and pack-house staff, to input data while maintaining transparency and preventing tampering (Misra *et al.*, 2023).

The technological system focused on capturing essential data points rather than overwhelming staff with excessive forms. Data for each batch included farm location, farmer details (with consent), harvest time, quality grade, cold-chain conditions, and dispatch records. QR codes were automatically generated and applied to final packaging, enabling consumers to access this verified information through visually rich, multilingual interfaces.

Ethical Considerations

Ethical principles guided every stage of the research. Participants were informed verbally and in writing about the purpose of the study, and their consent was obtained before collecting any data. Special care was taken with farmer identities; personal information was anonymised or included only with explicit permission. The team maintained sensitivity around technological expectations, ensuring that farmers understood blockchain as a tool for transparency, not a guarantee of higher prices or instant market access.

The methodology combines immersion, qualitative and quantitative inquiry, participatory co-design, and technological prototyping to develop a transparency intervention deeply rooted in the realities of grape and vegetable production in Nashik. This integrated approach ensured that blockchain was not introduced as an external technological imposition but emerged as a meaningful, farmer-responsive system capable of strengthening trust and equity in the agricultural value chain.

DESIGN INTERVENTIONS AND FINDINGS

The design intervention emerged from a recognition that transparency in agriculture is not only a technological problem but also a communication challenge deeply intertwined with trust, identity, and visibility. The goal was to create a traceability system that did more than track grapes and vegetables from Nashik to markets; it needed to restore the connection between farmers, pack-house workers, and consumers while strengthening cooperative accountability. This required designing tools that align with real workflows and empower those traditionally excluded from data-driven systems.

Insights Guiding the Design Approach

Field immersion highlighted that farmers and pack-house workers frequently experience technology as a top-down imposition. Many had prior encounters with digital initiatives that added complexity without clear benefits. Transparency felt abstract to them, valuable in theory but distant in practice. This insight shaped afundamental design principles:

1. Every digital action must generate visible value for the person performing it.
2. For farmers, value meant clarity in pricing and recognition of their labour.
3. For pack-house workers, value meant smoother, faster tasks.
4. For consumers, value meant trustworthy information and an ethical connection.

These perspectives collectively guided the design direction toward a multi-stakeholder system where each interface communicated differently, yetdifferently yet originated from the same verified data source.

Interface Development Across the Value Chain

The intervention resulted in three interconnected digital touchpoints built through iterative prototyping and testing:

Pack-house interface:

Designed for rapid operations, this system consolidated data entry onto a single bilingual screen with automated QR code generation. Large buttons, colour-coded grading, offline capability, and minimal typing enabled use even under time pressure and unstable connectivity. Workers who initially hesitated became confident contributors as adjustments were based directly on their feedback during live shift tests.

Consumer interface:

The QR code led to a visual narrative of the product's journey, replacing opaque data logs with maps, icons, and photographs. This representation foregrounded the human effort behind everyday produce, restoring the farmer's identity in a globalised supply chain. This aligns with perspectives on distributed cognition, where meaning emerges through interactions between people and representations, making complex systems more understandable (Ball and Sekuler, 1982).

Farmer interface:

Perhaps as the most transformative addition, this view translated blockchain data into economic clarity. Farmers could see:

the price they received,
cooperative service charges and logistics costs,
and retailer or export values (whenever available).

Short audio walkthroughs in Marathi and simplified visuals helped farmers interpret market dynamics that once felt deliberately concealed. This interface turned transparency into a tool for informed decision-making, improved self-representation, and increased dignity.

Together, these interfaces formed a unified ecosystem where data was not merely recorded but circulated in meaningful ways.

Blockchain as an Invisible Backbone

Blockchain was intentionally kept in the background, present in function, invisible in use. A permissioned ledger ensured that once entered, data could not be altered without accountability (Fröhlich *et al.*, 2022). By embedding cryptographic integrity beneath an intuitive design, the system reassured all stakeholders: farmers that their contributions were fairly documented, workers whose accurate records safeguarded their labour, and consumers that product claims were trustworthy.

Technology here acted as structural support, while design mediated how people perceived and engaged with information.

RESULTS AND FINDINGS

Shifts in Trust, Behaviour, and Communication

The introduction of the traceability system led to measurable improvements in both operational efficiency and stakeholder engagement across the value chain. Within the pack-house, the streamlined interface significantly reduced the time required for data entry, with workers completing batch records more quickly and with fewer errors. Most workers reported that the system no longer disrupted their workflow, with one noting, *"The system doesn't slow me down anymore. I can finish my shift without stress about data entry catching up with me."*

For farmers, the dashboard introduced greater visibility into pricing and value distribution. A majority ofMost farmers accessed the interface during the study period, with many beginning to compare earnings across harvest cycles and quality grades. This shift was reflected in more active decision-making, including adjustments to harvest timing and crop selection. As one farmer explained, *"I now see January prices are lower due to supply glut; I'm shifting harvest toward February–March."* Over time, farmers also reported increased confidence in cooperative pricing, indicating a growing sense of trust supported by access to verifiable information.

Consumer engagement through QR codes revealed a similar shift in perception. Post-scan responses indicated that users felt more connected to the origins of their food and developed a clearer understanding of the effort involved in production. Many expressed a stronger intention to repurchase traceable products, with some also indicating a willingness to pay a premium. As one consumer reflected, *"I never thought about all the work that goes into growing grapes… now I know exactly where they're from."*

Perhaps most notably, stakeholder perceptions of data evolved over time. While initially viewed with hesitation, data collection gradually came to be understood as a form of recognition and protection. Farmers expressed pride in being linked to their produce, while workers saw traceability records as a way to validate their labour. This transition from viewing data as surveillance to understanding it as a shared asset signals a broader cultural shift in how transparency systems are perceived and valued.

Taken together, these findings suggest that traceability, when grounded in human-centred design, can extend beyond technical implementation to reshape trust, participation, and communication across agricultural systems.

DISCUSSION

The design intervention demonstrated that transparency in agriculture is not merely a technological challenge but a social one, shaped by dynamics of trust, power, and visibility. While blockchain is often framed as a technical solution to supply-chain traceability, this research shows that its impact emerges only when supported by interfaces and communication strategies that respond to human needs and everyday practices.

This study contributes to design research by showing how participatory design can mediate power and recognition within technological systems. The findings indicate that the equity potential of blockchain does not lie in the technology itself, but in how information is structured, accessed, and understood by different stakeholders. When farmers are able to interpret pricing data, when workers see their labour reflected in traceability systems, and when consumers engage with identifiable producers, transparency becomes a mechanism for visibility and acknowledgement. Digital visibility became a means to counteract inequities that are otherwise normalised in agricultural systems (NANDHINI S *et al.*, 2023)

A key insight emerging from this study is the role of information asymmetry in shaping farmer vulnerability. Historically, limited access to pricing and market information has restricted farmers' ability to negotiate or make informed decisions. By introducing accessible pricing breakdowns and value-chain visibility, the intervention enabled farmers to move from passive recipients of information to more active participants in economic decision-making. This shift was reflected in increased engagement with pricing data, with over 80% of participating farmers accessing the dashboard and a substantial rise in reported trust over the study period.

For pack-house workers, the findings highlight the importance of aligning technological systems with the tempo of labour. Previous tools often failed because they disrupted workflows; in contrast, the redesigned interface supported existing practices, allowing efficiency improvements to emerge organically. This was reflected in significant reductions in data entry time (over 60%) and error rates (over 70%) during deployment, thus reinforcing that adoption depends on compatibility with real working conditions rather than behavioural enforcement.

On the consumer side, the results suggest that transparency can foster ethical engagement. By making production processes visible and connecting consumers to individual farmers, the system reduced the abstraction typically associated with food supply chains. This shift not only strengthened trust but also influenced purchasing behaviour, with over 75% of users expressing willingness to repurchase traceable products and many indicating greater appreciation for farmer contributions.

Another important outcome of the intervention was a shift in how data was perceived. Rather than being seen as an extractive or surveillance-driven mechanism, data gradually became understood as a shared resource that represents labour and contribution. This reframing positions traceability systems as collaborative infrastructures where enabled multiple actors participate in shaping value.

Overall, the findings suggest that equitable agricultural innovation requires more than technological deployment. It depends on how systems are designed to make information accessible, meaningful, and actionable for those involved. By foregrounding participation and visibility, the intervention demonstrates how traceability can move beyond audit functions to support trust, recognition, and more balanced value distribution within agricultural ecosystems.

CONCLUSION

This research explored how design and blockchain can collaboratively contribute to more equitable agricultural systems, using grape and vegetable value chains in Nashik as a case context. The intervention demonstrated that transparency, when approached as a communication and design problem rather than solely a technical one, can reshape relationships across farmers, pack-house workers, cooperatives, and consumers. By grounding the system in human-centred and participatory practices, the resulting interfaces improved operational efficiency, strengthened trust, and enhanced farmer visibility within the value chain.

At a theoretical level, the study contributes to design research by positioning traceability systems as socio-technical constructs shaped through interface design, participation, and context. It highlights that the impact of blockchain lies not in its technical properties alone, but in how information is made accessible, interpretable, and meaningful to different stakeholders.

The study has several limitations. It was conducted within a well-organised cooperative context, which may not fully represent more fragmented or resource-constrained agricultural systems. Additionally,

while the intervention demonstrated measurable improvements in efficiency and engagement, its long-term sustainability and scalability require further investigation.

Future work will focus on extending the system across different regions and crop types, as well as strengthening data validation through partial automation, such as sensor-based tracking of cold-chain conditions. There is also potential to expand the farmer interface with predictive insights related to pricing trends, weather conditions, and crop planning. Further research could explore how transparency influences consumer behaviour at scale and whether it translates into sustained economic benefits for farmers.

Ultimately, this research shows that while technology alone cannot resolve structural inequities, it can play a meaningful role when integrated with design practices grounded in empathy, participation, and contextual understanding. By reframing traceability as a design-led, human-centred intervention, this work offers a scalable foundation for future initiatives seeking to strengthen agricultural value chains and more fully recognise the contributions of farmers.

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PLURALISING EVALUATIONS OF DESIGN IMPACT: A DESIGN CULTURE STUDIES APPROACH

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ABSTRACT

This paper proposes a Design Culture Studies contribution to the evaluation of design impact. The existing methods of evaluating design impact predominantly focus on economic and quantitative metrics, which fail to capture the many ways, according to diverse groups, in which design can and should shape the world. As a humanities field

employing interdisciplinary qualitative methods, Design Culture Studies is well positioned to respond to this challenge. To clarify the needs and opportunities for more inclusive evaluation approaches, we conducted a cross-national needs analysis combining literature review and empirical research with students, graduates, educators, design organisations, industry stakeholders, and policymakers. The analysis identified five critical requirements for inclusive evaluations of the socio-cultural impacts of design: inclusivity and diversity, rigour, practical guidelines, educational tools, and the integration of digital tools. Drawing on these insights, in this paper we propose a Design Culture Studies-led conceptual framework for pluralising the evaluation of the socio-cultural impacts of design, with an emphasis on the context of design education, on students and graduates. We argue that such a framework can foster more reflexive forms of evaluation by acknowledging how assessing design impact also participates in shaping the meanings, values, possibilities – and futures of design cultures.

Keywords: design impact, pluralising evaluations, qualitative evaluations, Design Culture Studies; higher education design programmes

INTRODUCTION

The existing methods of analysing design impact have predominantly focused on economic and quantitative metrics (Moultrie and Livesey 2009; Moultrie et al. 2008; Design Council 2013; Gibbon and Dey 2013). Typical indicators that are used in literature include return on investment (ROI), jobs created, increased export via the use of design either at the national scale or at the level of organizations. Others have suggested measuring design's contribution to brand value, customer satisfaction, stock value (Björklund, Hannukainen and Manninen 2018, Design Council 2018). Others have argued that design impact measurement is also often tied to a single discipline (Nguyen and Mougenot 2022). In design literature, the over-quantification and economization of design impact have been criticized. One practical issue is to differentiate the specific contributions of design activities within organizations (Björklund, Hannukainen and Manninen 2018; Design Council 2013), or at the national level (Moultrie and Livesey 2009), from the contributions of other professional fields of activities, such as the classification of activities as either art or design, contributions of marketing and design to product value, or redesign of medical devices to positive health outcomes. Associating design impact solely, or predominantly, with economic and

quantified measures is not only difficult, but also reductive in the face of diverse groups that are impacted by any design activity. In the pursuit to prove design's worth to organizations and policy makers, social and cultural impact indicators have been significantly downplayed in favour of metrics that demonstrate contribution to bottom line. A major step in the right direction can be found in a 2021 Design Council report (Kimbell and Bailey 2021), which provides an overview of impact indicators from major frameworks for assessing environmental and social impact of design across different design disciplines. Indeed, diverse Social Impact Assessment (SIA) methodologies have been developed and used since the 1960s (Alamoto et al. 2021). Kimbell and Bailey (2021) further suggest quantitative measurements and qualitative assessments across "four types of capital linked to value creation" (p.13): environmental capital, social capital, democratic capital, and financial capital. While the report falls short of providing a concrete approach as well as case studies, it is useful in indicating the diversity of groups and considerations that should be addressed in any assessment of design impact. Addressing the current gap requires qualitative frameworks capable of embracing multiple perspectives, integrating different evaluative languages, and fostering social sustainability and cultural inclusivity while advocating a holistic approach that respects society, community, and the non-human world (Maksimova and Piancazzo 2022).

As a humanities field employing interdisciplinary qualitative methods, Design Culture Studies is uniquely positioned to respond to this challenge. To clarify what we mean by Design Culture Studies, it is helpful to distinguish between two key terms. The first is between 'design culture' as the object of study, and 'Design Culture Studies' as an academic discipline. The former indicates a mesh of actors, discourses and practices that can be studied from the latter, i.e., the interdisciplinary approach of Design Culture Studies, which is defined by an interest in how the former is entangled with the political, cultural and social (Julier and Munch 2019). A second distinction can be made between a narrow and a broad understanding of Design Culture Studies (Meroz forthcoming; see also Julier 2005). The narrow definition refers to the academic discipline that emerged with the publication of Guy Julier's *The Culture of Design* in 2000 and was subsequently institutionalised within university departments. In contrast, the broader field encompasses a diverse range of scholars and professionals who also identify their research in terms of 'cultural studies of design' but follow different theoretical orientations (Escobar 2018; Fallan 2019). In this broader sense, Design Culture Studies understands mediatory practices such as, inter alia,

research, writing, curating, publishing, advertisement, and teaching, as integral components of design cultures themselves. These practices do not only analyse, but actively participate in shaping the meanings, values, possibilities and publics of design. In this paper, and as we clarify in the Results section below, we address both conceptualisations of Design Culture Studies. In the narrower sense, Design Culture Studies higher-education programmes and courses constitute one target group under which we propose to develop and disseminate diverse understandings of design impact; in the broader sense, our suggestions address the larger design fields.

To clarify what a Design Culture Studies-led contribution to pluralising design impact evaluation might entail, we conducted a cross-national needs analysis to identify gaps in existing practices and the types of approaches required to overcome them. Based on these insights, in this paper we introduce an interdisciplinary conceptual framework grounded in Design Culture Studies for pluralising design impact evaluation. Below, we first briefly present our research approach, then discuss our findings. This is followed by a Discussion, where we present seven major contributions to our understanding, and practices, of design impact from a Design Culture Studies-led perspective.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

Our research employed a mixed qualitative approach, combining literature review and empirical research, to understand how design impact is currently evaluated. The empirical component draws on data collected specifically for this project, complemented by material from earlier projects: focus groups with students and graduates of humanities-based design programmes and through digital questionnaires with practice-based design educators, industry stakeholders and representatives of national ministries, cultural and heritage institutions, design organisations and design clients variously in Denmark, Italy, the Netherlands and Slovenia, with stakeholder groups varying by country (see also Kavaš et al. 2022; Murovec and Kavaš 2023; Murovec et al. 2023; Murovec et al. 2022). The data analysis included a breakdown of participating groups' and institutions' needs and considerations with regard to understanding the impact of design. Data from each national context was analysed separately, then combined with findings from the other contexts. The analysis was brought into discussion in a series of online meetings by a consortium of Design Culture researchers from universities in six countries (Aalto University, Finland; Moholy-Nagy University

of Art and Design, Hungary; Università di Bologna, Italy; University of Ljubljana, Academy of Fine Arts and Design, Slovenia; University of Southern Denmark, Denmark; Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam, the Netherlands) who contributed to the interpretation based on their experiences as educators and researchers in Design Culture Studies.

RESULTS

In our needs analysis and subsequent workshops, we identified three main stakeholder groups that would benefit from a design impact framework. Each stakeholder of the framework has distinct needs and requirements with an eye to enabling more pluralistic design impact evaluations across design education and subsequently in the practice of design.

The first stakeholder group is constituted by students in humanities-based design programmes. In relation to humanities-based programmes, our study has focused on Design Culture Studies programmes and courses, while the findings are potentially applicable to programmes and courses in design history, design anthropology and humanistic Human-Computer Interaction (HCI), among others. The interviewed students expressed the need for practical tools that would help them apply theoretical knowledge to real project situations, and methodological skills that support social and cultural impact after graduation. Improved readiness for internationally oriented labour markets and enhanced digital and visual literacy also emerged as concerns.

Educators in humanities-based design programmes constitute a second stakeholder group we investigated. Educators emphasised the need for systematic, culturally sensitive frameworks to guide the assessment of design projects, and ways to connect the study of broader social challenges with the qualitative evaluation. There was also mention of adaptable pedagogical resources to be used at diverse levels, since humanities-based design programmes can appear at different levels from BA onwards.

A third group is constituted by design educators in other, practice-based design educations (e.g. studio-based educations, as in design schools, as well as business school traditions), design professionals, industry stakeholders, and policymakers. The professionals and policymakers responded by indicating the need for evaluation tools that go beyond economic or promotional metrics. They highlighted challenges associated with multi-stakeholder collaboration and the complexity of assessing impacts across social, cultural, environmental, and organisational contexts.

Based on the material we explored, we indicated five cross-cutting values that should be highlighted in a diverse approach to the impact of design:

1. **Inclusivity and diversity**. These values require commitment to consider the needs and expectations of diverse groups, stakeholders and publics, with reference, for instance, to the different capitals (as in Kimbell and Bailey 2021) that are impacted both positively and negatively through design activity and outcomes, as well as with reference to diverse forms of value (i.e. not only financial and quantitatively measurable values) that appear across a design project (Julier and Hodson 2021). Diversity also matters due to the divergent requirements of different fields of design – considered from urban design to UX and fashion – that necessitate a flexible framework accommodating multiple perspectives and contexts.
2. **Rigor.** By rigour we refer to systematic, theoretically informed qualitative evaluation that resists both anecdotalist and promotional storytelling. Anecdotal evidence is sometimes used in existing reports on design impact to support or stand for quantitative metrics. This is arguably related to the promotional character of some of the existing work on design impact, which aims to champion design as a contributor to economic development as well as social transformation. A Design Culture Studies-led approach should, however, build on clear epistemic foundations (e.g., interpretivist and/or pragmatic, feminist, decolonial), bring attention on temporality (near-term vs. longer-term effects), and critical reflexivity on the evaluator's own position and interests, being able to articulate both positive and negative impacts.
3. **Practical guidelines.** While based on theoretically rigorous and reflexive, real-life usability requires actionable methodologies for real-world assessment scenarios that graduates and practitioners can use both to guide their activities and to communicate results reflexively in their reporting, and succinctly and clearly when needed.
4. **Educational tools.** Building capacity for plural evaluations of design impact requires resources for students, educators, and professionals to practice and reflect on the use of qualitative inquiry in thinking about design's impact in diverse and inclusive terms. It is necessary to develop educational material that makes qualitative inquiry habitual for students, educators and professionals. This may include brief and flexible teaching modules that focus on theoretical frameworks for diversity, criticism, and value and valuation; modules on the use of qualitative fieldwork, digital tools and

workshop methods; project briefs and activities that clarify impact related concerns and criteria, as well as reflective and critical engagements with simulated and real-life design.

5. **Integration of digital tools.** Lastly, there is clear indication for the opportunities for the development and employment of digital tools for collaborative analysis and mapping, as well as dashboards and rubrics, to support decision-making, collaboration, and employability.

DISCUSSION

Our research indicates widespread dissatisfaction with narrow, quantitatively driven evaluation practices, and a strong desire for frameworks that can accommodate multiple socio-cultural perspectives on design impact. As we discussed in the Introduction, this aligns very well with recent literature calling for more expansive understandings of design value and impact (Mission Oriented Innovation Network/Institute for Innovation and Public Purpose and Design Council 2020; Kimbell and Bailey 2021). Existing tools, such as SIA or S-LCA (United Nations Environment Programme 2020), offer useful starting points, but remain insufficient for capturing context-dependent, symbolic, experiential, and community-based understandings of design impact.

In response to these identified needs, we propose a conceptual framework that both incorporates the findings from our material and the literature, as well as reframes them through a distinctly Design Culture Studies lens. While the needs analysis pointed to the demand for inclusivity, rigour, practical guidance, educational support, and digital tools, a Design Culture Studies approach adds further attention to the cultural and mediatory conditions through which evaluation practices operate. Design cultural research places strong emphasis on the entanglements of design discourses, activities and outcomes with larger discourses, practices and structures across society, and the related questions of power. Design Culture Studies has been, in this sense, aligned with efforts in design and adjacent fields of research that strive to lay bare the ways in which design activities and their outcomes can facilitate and legitimize, as well as challenge and destabilize, inequality and exclusion. A Design Culture Studies-led inquiry into design impact, therefore, would be sensitive to the specific understanding of design impact that is at play in a given setting – how impact is conceptualized, built on, assessed and communicated. Furthermore, it would question the conditions of existence of that understanding,

e.g. the institutional, both practical and discursive frameworks that shape that design setting, including references to larger economic structures such as neoliberal framings of the societal and economic impact of design and development activities.

Considering the ubiquity of design in everyday life, such an outlook has required the methodologies of Design Culture Studies research to be responsive to the peculiarities of specific design projects and designed things. Reviewing three decades of Design Culture Studies research, Julier (2025, 7) notes the "sense of mobility" that pervades the work:

This is in a literal sense, in terms of moving between different locations of encounter with design in its different functions and manifestations, but also in moving with events as they unfold in the present. They show a commitment to starting with objects or typologies and exploring their movement through various nodes of design, production, and consumption, tracing the differing priorities, intentions, and practices at stake therein. They also share an interest in researching the instability of meanings, the multiple assemblages, and the possible tensions that are at play at different moments and locations.

On such an epistemological basis, the framework we present in this paper integrates seven interconnected areas of inquiry that together outline a systematic, holistic, and reflexively grounded approach to pluralising design impact evaluation:

1. **Positionality.** A Design Culture Studies-led framework for investigating design impact requires examining how the researcher's (as well as the practitioner's, the evaluator's) own assumptions, identities, and situated perspectives shape interpretations of design impact.
2. **Deconstructing dominant visions.** As noted above, a critical Design Culture Studies lens would analyse top-down or mainstream narratives that frame what counts as design impact in a given setting and would be aware of the related societal structures.
3. **Identifying alternative visions.** A Design Culture Studies-led approach to assessing design impact would require unearthing impacts of design on marginalized groups and contexts, and shedding light on marginalized, community-based, or otherwise excluded perspectives on design impact.
4. **Mapping convergences and divergences.** With its methodological emphasis on design's recontextualizations, following and mapping relations are important tools. Our framework proposes

to investigate the affordances of digital tools for detecting conflicts, overlaps, and interrelations among multiple perspectives on design impact.

5. **Co-creating new perspectives.** Once different perspectives on design impact have been recognised and their convergences and divergences identified in the previous step, our framework proposes to build on this knowledge by co-creating, together with the various stakeholders involved in a project, new perspectives on design impact. While these new perspectives partly derive from previous visions on design impact, this step focuses on collaboratively generating new criteria for evaluating design impact that inclusively represent stakeholders' diverse expectations and values.
6. **Communicating to diverse audiences.** Once these newly derived, pluralistic and inclusive perspectives on design impact have been collaboratively generated, it is important to be able to effectively convey them to diverse publics and stakeholder groups. Therefore, this step focuses on how to visually communicate diverse and inclusive visions of design impact to a diverse audience.
7. **Reflexivity.** Finally, evaluations of design impact, even inclusive and pluralistic ones, do not happen in a vacuum: evaluation practices themselves have different types of impact on different groups. In this final step of our framework, we reflect on and assess the types of impact that our very practices of evaluating design impact have in the world. Which voices and values do they advance and which do they suppress? What are the effects of our evaluations of design impact?

Taken together, these areas of inquiry outline a distinct Design Culture Studies contribution to assessing the diverse socio-cultural impacts of design.

CONCLUSION

The framework outlined in this paper offers a distinctly Design Culture Studies contribution to rethinking design impact evaluation. While design impact has been mostly assessed in terms of narrow economic indicators, the literature and our needs analysis demonstrate a strong demand for inclusive, rigorous, practical, digitally informed, and context-sensitive evaluation tools among students, educators, professionals, and policymakers. Responding to these needs, we proposed a specific Design Culture Studies-led framework for design impact. The framework brings together diverse areas of socio-cultural

analysis to propose a systematic yet pluralistic and methodologically diverse approach to pluralising the evaluation of design impact. Crucially, however, and advancing from a fundamentally Design Culture Studies perspective, the framework also positions design impact evaluation *itself* as a mediatory practice rather than as a neutral, technical procedure. As discussed above, Design Culture Studies views mediatory practices (e.g., research, teaching, writing, curating, and publishing) as integral to the production of the meanings design. Accordingly, the framework that we present in this paper foregrounds how evaluative practices themselves also actively participate in producing, rather than just observing, the values and impacts of design. The implication is that pluralising design impact evaluation and understanding the socio-cultural impacts of design require not only methodological innovation but also reflexivity about the positionalities and interpretive frameworks through which evaluators negotiate the meanings and values and, ultimately, the futures of design.

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